Above the Vaulted Sky

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/30285306.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Huntara (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Slice of Life, Living abroad, Mental Health Issues, Childhood Trauma, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting, Alcohol Abuse/Alcoholism, Implied/Referenced Drug Use, Implied/Referenced Sexual Assault, it's a good mix of cute and sad, finished work, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, POV Adora (She-Ra), POV Catra (She-Ra), Fluff and Angst, Happy Ending, Friends to Lovers

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by egregiousSynonyms

Summary

When Adora had told people that she was quitting her lucrative job at the high-power firm that had plucked her straight out of law school, they had thought she was making a huge mistake.

When Adora had said that she was dumping her whole career in the trash to become a novelist, they had thought she was either possessed by a demon or experiencing an acute mental break.

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Adora Gray quits her dream job and then up and moves half-way across the world to stay with her best friend from high school. There, she meets another woman as dogged by the demons of her past as she. Together, they explore what it means to belong, to be, and to be truly home.

Fic has been completed.

Notes

Welcome! This is a super-niche modern AU taking place in Antalya, a city on the Southwestern coast of Turkey, but I think you'll enjoy it.

This fic tops out a bit over 80k words and consists of 11 chapters plus an epilogue. Chapters alternate between Adora and Catra.

Winter Pt. 1

Chapter Notes

> UPDATE 18/9/2021: I've done some fairly significant rewrites to the first two chapters to make the whole work more narratively sound and 1000% less contrived. The rewrites in the other chapters are there but ultimately inconsequential and exist to make me feel better.
>
> I made a Spotify playlist to go along with the fic. It will be updated as we go along.
> https://open.spotify.com/playlist/6qtrsHXeg7PNa8XqDt7Vkt?si=122768a69b5b4884
>
> All of the Princesses aside from Glimmer are Turkish. Here's a quick guide for the first chapter:
> Perfuma - Perihan
> Mermista - Merve
> Feyza - Frosta

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The first thing that Adora Gray noticed when she disembarked in Antalya, Turkey after a 12 hour flight was how pleasantly warm it was. When she had left JFK, the temperature had been well below zero and the flight had been delayed 3 hours due to ice on the runway. The second thing she noticed was that almost everyone around her was shivering as they all waited for the shuttle. She shrugged off her jacket, happy for the balmy 50 degrees. She followed the crowd off of the shuttle and into the airport, trying to match the Turkish directions posted everywhere with the English translations, worrying not for the first time that she hadn't had enough time to study before this trip.

Adora got her bags and followed the signs out to the pick-up area. She looked at each of the signs scrawled with names in turn, not necessarily expecting to find her own, but irrationally sad not to

nonetheless. She watched as parties embraced and left arm in arm, glancing at her phone periodically as the minutes ticked by. After forty-five minutes, Adora bounced on her heels and considered for the millionth time this week that this might have been a bad idea.

A little over a month ago, Adora had been staring at the blank screen of her laptop desperately willing words to appear when she had received a video call request from her high school best friend. They weren't quite as close anymore, but they had always kept in touch, so Adora had happily answered. They had shot the shit for a while before her friend had casually mentioned that she should come visit her abroad. In what a year prior would have been an uncharacteristic burst of impulsivity, Adora had asked if next month would be a good time. Her friend had screamed her assent and the two had spent the next hour researching and booking a flight.

Adora met Glynnis Bright on the first day of high school. Standing alone in an unfamiliar foyer, she was trying to put on a brave face, but she was in a new city in a new state, packed into a uniform that must be pressed every day, and surrounded by people that could surely smell the stink of poverty on her. She had missed the tour the previous week and was poring over a map, the seconds ticking by in her head until she was inevitably late for second period, the consequences for which would surely involve her finding her head on a pike on the manicured front lawn. "Hey, are you lost?" a short girl asked, appearing out of nowhere and making Adora jump. When Adora said that she couldn't find the Andrews building, the girl declared that she was going that way and looped their arms together. In their shuffle, Adora learned that the girl's name was Glynnis but that she hated it and preferred to be called Glimmer. She also learned that Glimmer had a shock of pink dye on the underside of her light brown hair. When Glimmer conspiratorially put a finger to her lips and grinned, Adora smiled for the first time all day.

Just as Adora was starting to panic, she saw two people sprinting in her direction and shouting her name. The people standing

around turned to stare curiously at the tiny, pink-haired missile as it plowed into the tall blonde woman, knocking them both to the ground.

“Adora! Oh my God! I’m so sorry! We were waiting at the domestic terminal! I forgot you had a direct flight! Are you okay??”

Adora laughed and wrapped her arms around her friend who had not changed a single bit since the day they met. “Glimmer, I’m fine!” The two got up, keeping their hands linked. Realizing the spectacle that they were making, Adora started to get a little uncomfortable.

“Everyone is staring at us.”

“You’ll get used to it,” Glimmer dismissed with a wave, “C’mon!”

Glimmer pulled her towards her companion who wore a grin that could blind the sun itself.

“Adora, hi! It’s so nice to finally meet you in person!”

Adora extended a hand but found herself wrapped in a bone-crushing hug. She also found herself returning it with equal gusto until both of them gasped and pulled away from lack of oxygen.

“You too, Bo!”

“Let’s go before you dumb idiots suffocate each other. Onward!” Glimmer pointed in the direction of the parking lot and started marching. Both Adora and Bo caught up quickly and the three skipped off in a line like they were on their way to The Emerald City.

Adora knew better than to be impressed with anywhere that Glimmer lived at this point in her life, but that didn’t stop her from staring in wonder as she stepped off the elevator and through the front door. The living room was wide and spacious, decorated in brash pinks and purples around sleek, modern furniture. Adora

was led upstairs to her bedroom, one of four, and then given the grand tour which included Glimmer's bedroom, a massive bathroom with both a waterfall shower head and a tub, and two more bedrooms that had been converted into a walk-in closet and a comfy-looking cinema room filled with couches and cushions. Finally, Glimmer led them up another winding set of stairs to the terrace where Adora gaped at the sauna, full bar, and panoramic view of the Mediterranean.

Adora had felt this same awe the first time that she had visited Glimmer's family's home in Boston nearly 15 years before. Most students at the boarding school had family within a couple hours of the school and went home for weekends. Adora, at the time, had had nowhere to go but was perfectly content to stay in her dorm and catch up on homework or run drills with the lacrosse stick they had practically shoved into her hands on the first day. Adora had always been eager to please, especially then with what she viewed as a golden opportunity to claw her way out of the mire of her former life.

After a solid semester of this, Glimmer had realized simultaneously that Adora hadn't once left campus and that she hadn't learned a single thing about the taciturn blonde girl that she had been aggressively befriending. Adora had predictably fought against the notion of joining Glimmer and her family for winter break, but Glimmer had glared at her and said, "You are not spending Christmas alone." And that had been that.

Adora was shaken out of her reverie by Glimmer's whine that it was cold and windy.

"It's 50 degrees."

"But it's humid!"

"It's like -4 in New York right now."

Glimmer mumbled something about *fucking tourists* under her breath and said, "You don't get it!"

Bo clapped his hands. “How about a movie then?”

Enticed by the prospect of the cinema room, Adora relented and headed back in.

--

Both Glimmer and Bo had to work during the day, so Adora was left to her own devices. Bo taught History at the international high school, and Glimmer did, well, *something*. Adora could never quite parse the details of her friend’s employment, but she knew it had something to do with her family’s textile company, just one branch of the sprawling BrightMoon Group. Business had never been Adora’s forte, so she had always chosen the smile and nod route.

Adora puttered around the city with her mornings and afternoons, visiting various landmarks that Bo provided for her. She was particularly enticed by the archaeology museum, staring in awe at both the pre-historic tools and marble statues for hours, feeling for the first time that she was truly among history. That night, Bo promised that they would visit all the nearby ancient cities as soon as winter broke. Adora listened, fascinated, to his ramblings about Perge and Termessos, his personal favorites, and Bo seemed pleased to finally have an audience whose eyes didn’t immediately glaze over the moment he began to speak.

Adora had managed to stay awake through her flight and stave off the worst of her jetlag. Unfortunately, though, she still awoke right before dawn every day and took the time to go running on the pedestrian walkway that wrapped around the sea. This was when she was happiest, when the constant dread coursing through her quieted for a few blessed moments in the face of physical exertion and the beauty of the sunrise. *Everything is going to be okay,* she let herself believe.

--

That Saturday morning, Glimmer and Adora sat together drinking coffee. Adora was chipper and fresh-faced from her morning run

and subsequent shower. Glimmer, leaning heavily on her elbows and slouched over the table, was not a morning person and was trying her hardest to endure her friend's babbling about how beautiful and wonderful the city was and how good of a person Glimmer was for letting her stay there. She wanted to snap at her, but no, Glimmer had grown as a person in the last ten years and Adora was just excited. She remembered her own honeymoon period after moving abroad, how exciting it was to go out and do mundane tasks like grocery shopping or buying a mop or hunting around for a specific shampoo.

Glimmer realized that Adora had finally stopped talking and rubbed her eyes. "Try not to tire yourself out today, champ, `cause we're going out tonight."

"Oh cool! Where?"

"Have you been to Kaleiçi yet?"

"The Old City? Yeah, Bo sent me there to check out the big gate and the broken minaret thing and, oh yeah, the clock tower."

"Well, it's also where all the bars are. The whole gang will be there," Glimmer continued, "and I can't wait for you to meet everyone. They're gonna love you."

Adora grinned a little too big, a tinge of anxiety at meeting new people tightening her chest.

"Besides," Glimmer said, leveling her with a devilish grin softened by her sleepy eyes, "My friend's band is playing and I'd especially love for you to meet her."

Adora blushed a little and tried to hide it behind her coffee mug.

"Cool! Sounds fun!"

--

Around 8, Adora, Glimmer, and Bo – or the Best Friend Squad as Bo insisted on calling them – made their way through the winding streets of Kaleiçi. Adora was amazed that Glimmer knew exactly where to go, having been lost there for hours the other day in full sunlight. They stopped at a dingy-looking bar called The Waste and entered through the saloon doors. Graffiti covered the peeling black walls and there was a distinct odor of stale beer and mildew with just a hint of Febreeze.

Glimmer led them over to a table where a man with a manually curled mustache was waving and shouting with abandon.

"Bo, you absolute madlad, join us!"

"Sea Hawk!"

Fucking Australians, Adora heard Glimmer mutter as they watched the two men embrace and butt their heads together on each side like goats.

"And who's this?" He asked, looking at Adora. This was clearly a rhetorical question as Sea Hawk continued, "Ah! Wait! Glimmer's Yank friend, yes, Bo mentioned you. But I must say that he did not do justice to your radiant beauty!" He beat his breast and grinned.

"Uhh, thank you?"

Easy, eşek[1], leave the poor girl alone and sit down," an unamused-looking woman seated next to Sea Hawk said, pulling at the hem of his blue-leather trenchcoat.

Adora sat down between Glimmer and an empty chair with a black leather jacket draped around the back. The woman from before reached out a hand and Adora took it.

"I'm Merve. Sorry about 'Sea Hawk', he is the worst."

"Dearest, you wound me," Sea Hawk said with the back of his hand to his forehead.

Merve continued, “That’s Perihan,” she said pointing to a tall, willowy woman with blonde dreads pulled into a loose ponytail who smiled gracefully at her, “And the literal child is Feyza.”

Feyza scoffed, “Sıktır git, yaaaa, I’m 21.”

“Yavaş yavaş kızım, that tongue may have no bones, but it can break.”

“Wow, shut up,” Feyza said, biting back laughter.

Bo placed a mug of beer in front of her, and she took a sip. *Gross,* as expected, but she took another big gulp. If she could get a few into her, maybe she wouldn’t be such an awkward mess. She didn’t know what to say to any of these people who seemed to have years of history. She had hurriedly sucked down half of her beer when Perihan leaned over the empty seat and tapped her on the arm.

“How are you?” she asked.

Adora started. “Oh, uh, good, thanks for asking,” after a beat, “How… are you?” It was ridiculous that she had suddenly forgotten her own native language.

Perihan ignored the pause, “I am well. You know, I have trouble with these things. Everyone is so loud. I much prefer a cup of Turkish coffee in my garden with friends.”

Adora relaxed slightly, “I haven’t had Turkish coffee yet. Is it good?” *What a stupid question.*

Perihan hummed, “It’s similar to espresso, but the dirt settles at the bottom. After you finish, an experienced eye can see your fortune in the grounds. I do not have the gift myself, but every time I have Catra over, she gives the most insightful readings.”

Before she could ask who Catra was, the lights lowered and everyone’s attention was drawn to the lackluster stage in the corner. Adora hadn’t even noticed the band setting up. A broad-

shouldered woman with thick black hair pulled back into a ponytail was speaking into the ear of a massive bearded man hulking behind the drum kit. A wiry man with sandy blonde hair falling into his eyes quietly gave his guitar a final tune-up. After a moment, the door that Adora had been told led to the DJ section of the bar opened and out came a slim woman. Adora watched her as she stretched her narrow shoulders and sauntered onstage.

The stagelights came on and Adora took in the mane of curls cascading past the woman's shoulders, the black and red flannel rolled up to her elbows, the black tanktop underneath with a cool design that she couldn't quite make out, and the tight black jeans tucked into leather boots.

The woman stepped forward and grabbed the mic.

"Merhaba arkadaşlar. Hoş geldiniz."[2] She glanced over in the direction of their table and smirked, "Hey everyone." Adora felt her heart beat faster as they made quick eye contact before the woman surveyed the rest of the crowd. "Bu akşam nasılsınız?" The bar cheered and the woman laughed. "Çok güzel, arkadaşlar. Biz The Horde!"

The woman turned toward the band as the woman on bass shouted *La La LaLaLa La La LaLaLa* into her mic and the guitar screamed to life.

The woman turned back to the mic and grabbed the top of it.

I wrote her off for the tenth time today

And practiced all the things I would say

She came over

I lost my nerve

Took her back and made her dessert.

Now I know I'm being used

That’s okay man cause I like the abuse

I know she’s playing with me

That’s okay cause I got no self esteem

Adora thought back to the last time she had heard this song. In a bar much nicer than this, one of her more intoxicated colleagues had hopped up on stage, his suit jacket and tie draped over the chair next to her. She most clearly remembered pitying the sweat-stained armpits of his rolled up shirtsleeves. She hadn’t sang that night.

After the second verse and chorus as well as the bridge, the woman pulled the mic off the stand and went to the front of the stage with a sheepish smile and crouched down to eye level. After the bass solo, she launched into the third verse with her hand behind her head and a conspiratorial look in her eye.

Now I'll relate this little bit

It happens more than I'd like to admit

Late at night, she knocks on my door

She's drunk again and looking to score

Now I know I should say no

But it's kind of hard when she's ready to go

I may be dumb, but I'm not a dweeb

I'm just a sucker with no self-esteem

After the final chorus, everyone cheered and the woman laughed, a low chuckle.

Returning to the mic stand, the woman purred, “Teşekkür ederiz, arkadaşlar.”

The band launched into a Turkish song that Adora didn’t know but seemed to please the crowd. She worked on her third beer, watching the woman with her mouth slightly open until she had the presence of mind to close it. They played a few more songs, all covers, all excellent, until the woman said something in Turkish that Adora took to mean that it was time for a break.

Bo handed her a fresh beer, looking giddy. Before she could inform him that she wasn’t finished with her latest one, the lead singer walked over to the table and plopped down in the saved seat next to her. The table erupted in general praise but was cut off when Sea Hawk slammed a liter mug down in front of the woman.

“Catra! Brilliant effort as usual, but the long-awaited hour is nigh,” Sea Hawk declared. Glimmer whooped and held up her full beer along with everyone else. Adora followed their example, trying not to look too confused.

“Here's to Catra she's True Blue! She's a Piss Pot through and through. She's a Bastard so they say and she's not going to heaven she went the other way! She's going down! down! down! down! down!”

Everyone started chugging their beers, Adora included after a moment’s hesitation. Everyone finished before Catra and her one-liter beer, and as each finished they joined in chanting “Skull! Skull! Skull! Skull!”

Eventually, Catra slammed the empty mug on the table with a gasp and a gasp.

“Fuck you, Hawkins, that was a bavyera! Are you trying to kill me?”

“No challenge for the maddest cunt in Antalya!”

“I still have half a set left, you dick.”

Sea Hawk just grinned at her. “Whatever, I’m going outside.” As she was shrugging on her jacket, Adora saw Glimmer gesturing wildly in silent yet profoundly unsubtle conversation.

Catra rolled her eyes and tapped Adora on the shoulder, “Hey you, wanna come keep me company?”

On any other day, Adora would have questions, but most days did not see her chugging beers in a foreign country and beautiful women requesting her presence in secondary locations. “Sure,” she said, clumsily getting out of her chair and following Catra out of the bar into the blessedly fresh night air. Catra hopped onto a low stone wall and lit a cigarette. Adora followed her up, significantly less gracefully, and kicked her legs. When she snuck a glance at Catra, she nearly fell off the wall when she realized that her eyes were two different colors, one bright blue and the other a smoky hazel. Catra quirked a half smile at that.

After a few more moments of awkward silence, Catra was the first to break, “So you must be Adora.”

“And you’re Catra.”

“Adora. Weird name.”

Adora snorted, “Coming from someone named Catra.”

“It’s short for Ekaterina.”

“Oh. That's pretty.”

Catra smirked, “So I've been told.”

A pause.

“You’re from the States, right?”

“Yeah, from Indiana.” Catra sounded slightly bitter about it.

“My condolences. I get it, though. I’m from Tennessee, a small town near Pigeon Forge.”

“Isn’t that where Dollyworld is?”

“Yeah, outside of Dolly’s jurisdiction, unfortunately.”

“Tragic.”

They lapsed into a slightly more comfortable silence. This time, Adora cracked.

“Soooooooo…..”

Catra raised her eyebrows, waiting.

“Why, uh…. why did you invite me out here?” Adora asked, rushing to add, “Not that I’m not having a good time or anything!”

“I take it Sparkles didn’t let you in on her little plan.”

“What plan?”

Catra lit another cigarette.

“She told me that you were going through a tough time and could use a lay. She said that you were hot,” Catra turned her head, looked her up and down, and shrugged. “For once, she didn’t exaggerate.”

Adora sputtered, feelings of anger at Glimmer for pimping her out and excitement that Catra thought she was hot jockeying for the attention of her single, stalled-out brain cell.

Catra laughed, high-pitched and natural, so unlike the low chuckle she used onstage.

“You okay there, princess?”

“Yes!” Adora cursed the blush she could feel burning her cheeks.

Mind a complete blank on any single coherent thought worth allowing passage through her mouth, Adora spat out, "What's your favorite color?"

Catra laughed again and hopped down off the wall.

"Holy shit, Sparkles didn't tell me you were such a dork!"

Adora numbly took Catra's offered hand, slid off the wall, and let herself be led back into the bar and to their table. Catra shed her jacket and hung it on her chair, pausing briefly to lean close to Adora's ear and whisper *Red* while plucking the collar of her red bomber jacket. With that, she made her way back to the stage where the band was waiting for her while Adora combusted.

They launched into a song and Adora turned to glare at Glimmer, who looked incredibly pleased with herself.

"*Seriously, Glimmer*?" Adora hissed.

Glimmer feigned ignorance, "I have no idea what you're talking about."

"We're talking about this later when it's not so loud. I will wake you up at dawn, I swear to god."

Glimmer nodded seriously, trying and failing to suppress a shit-eating grin.

Adora turned in a huff to watch the rest of the show, or more accurately, stare unabashedly at Catra.

After another song, Catra introduced the band. The woman on bass was Lawan and the man on drums was Rogelio. The guy on guitar had a weird name that she didn't quite catch.

They continued on with a mix of English and Turkish songs until it came time for the finale.

The bass line and guitar sounded familiar, but Adora couldn’t quite place it until Catra began singing.

When you get older, plainer, saner

Will you remember all the danger

We came from?

Burning like embers, falling, tender

Longing for the days of no surrender

Years ago

And will you know

Holy crap, she loved this song. And everyone was singing along. This song hadn’t been popular in the states at all. Did they know how gay it was?

Catra grabbed onto the mic for dear life and furrowed her brow as she launched into the chorus

Let's raise a glass

Or two

To all the things I've lost on you

She wailed through it with devastating emotion.

Before the final chorus, Catra found her eyes and quirked a small smile, keeping eye contact through the rest of the song. Adora was ready to wither away and die, the only logical outcome to having all the air sucked forcibly out of her lungs.

When the song ended, the bar screamed, Adora right along with them. She managed to tear her eyes off of the stage where the band packed up when two shots were placed in front of her.

“What is this?” she asked Sea Hawk.

“Tequila!” he pronounced with glee.

Just looking at them made her queasy, but she put on a brave face, clinked the first one with the mass in the center of the table and knocked it back.

--

Somewhere between her fifth beer and third tequila shot, things began to blur. Adora wouldn’t call herself a lightweight, but she hadn’t been around people that went this hard since college. At some point, Catra had wandered up cozied under the guitarist’s arm and dragged the whole table into the back room. Adora had stared in awe at the ancient stone walls around them, understanding why they called this part of town The Old City. The mix of neon strobes, crappy trance music, and the constant jostle of sweaty dancing bodies all in this millennia-old structure made the experience other-worldly. Adora had given dancing her best go, dancing with Glimmer and Bo and then Feyza for a while. The younger woman had seemed mildly obsessed with her ever since she had shed her jacket and had been left in just a tight white tank.

Of course, she hadn’t been able to keep her eyes off of Catra for longer than a few moments at a time. The woman had spent the whole night dancing with the guitarist who she had been introduced to as Khyle, like Kyle but with a Kh- sound he had said, something Adora was sure had an elaborate backstory like everything else with these people. Their constant closeness had sowed seeds of doubt in Adora, slightly assuaged when Catra had snagged her away from Feyza and had pulled her close for a dance. After two songs, she had slid back to Khyle who had leaned down to shout in her ear after glancing in her direction. Adora had seen the two laugh and had wondered if the nauseous feeling in her stomach was due to the alcohol or how *together* they seemed.

After an indeterminate period of time measured only by the drinks she had consumed, Adora found herself outside again. She was leaned up against the stone wall of the bar, eyes closed, willing the spinning to stop so she wouldn't have to vomit in a strange toilet tonight. Distantly, she registered that someone was speaking to her, so she opened her eyes. It was a man a couple of inches shorter than her, and he had just stopped speaking. As she tried to formulate a response, she realized that she hadn't understood a word of what he had said.

"I'm sorry, I don't speak… whatever language you were speaking. Was that German?"

"Ah, English. Where are you from?"

The man continued in heavily accented, broken English and Adora tried her best to follow along, answering his questions about where she was from and why she was in Turkey. She began to feel a bit boxed in despite their height difference when he started grilling her if she had a husband or a boyfriend. To both questions she answered no and that seemed to galvanize the man to move closer and rest his hand on her sleeve. In the US, Adora would have decked a man if he'd pulled that shit, but she was drunk and unsure of the protocol here, so she pressed herself closer to the wall and reluctantly acquiesced to the increasingly sexual conversation. He had just invited her back to his place with the promise of a bottle of vodka when she felt a hand clamp onto her arm and saw another hand not-so-gently push the man back.

"Ne yapıyon sen yavşak?"[3]

Adora saw that the hands belonged to Catra who regarded the man with open loathing. He said something that made Catra laugh coldly and drop her arm. She stepped forward, glaring upward at the man and hissing something that made him clench his teeth and go red in the face. Adora saw his fist tighten at his side and then loosen as if thinking better of it. Muttering something under his breath, he stalked back into the bar. Catra watched him with her eyes narrowed and turned back to Adora.

“What a fucking prick! Are you okay? He didn’t try anything, did he?”

Adora nodded and then shook her head dumbly and took a seat at the table Catra led them to. Catra stewed for a moment before turning to Adora angrily.

“You can’t let them do that to you! These assholes see a foreign girl and jump on her cause they think she’s gonna put out. You gotta tell them to fuck off, or something really bad could happen. I know they seem harmless, but a lot of these guys are real pieces of shit.”

“I’m sorry… I didn’t know what to do. I just… froze.”

Catra ran a hand through her hair and sighed.

“No, I’m sorry, I shouldn’t be yelling at you. I just really hate seeing this shit happen over and over. It’s just like this specific subset of dudes, but they’re not all terrible. Look, uh, aside from that, are you having a good time?”

Adora had to think for a moment, “I liked watching you guys play, but the club thing is a lot. Also, you guys drink way more than I’m used to.”

Catra hummed. “Yeah, Sea Hawk’s got his droopy-eye thing he gets when he’s way past shit-faced. He’s been trying to drag me into the bathroom all night to do coke, but I’m really not feeling it tonight.”

Adora raised her eyebrows. This crowd was more intense than she thought.

Catra teased, “What, princess, no illicit substances allowed in that temple of yours?”

A few loose memories from millennia ago bubbled to the surface, but Adora quickly shoved them down. She opted instead to shrug with affected carelessness, “Not for a long time.”

Catra didn’t pry.

Adora continued, “Most of you are teachers, right? It’s weird to think of teachers doing lines in a bar bathroom, that’s all.”

“Yeah, that’s fair. You’d be amazed what teachers get up to when they’re not at school.” Catra stretched, fished a pack of cigarettes out of her jacket and lit one, never taking her eyes off of Adora.

Adora wilted a little under the scrutiny but forced herself to rally.

“Hey, can I ask you a question?”

“Shoot, princess.”

“Has something like that ever happened to you? Like you said with the asshole guys?”

Catra laughed mirthlessly and leaned forward, “Plenty of times. This one is kind of a funny story. My third day here, a guy pulled me into a café while I was walking down Işıklar. It was pouring out and like 9:30 at night, almost exactly this time of year now that I think about it. Anyway, he hit on me for an hour and when I went to leave, I couldn’t find my umbrella in the little stand. I look outside, and there’s our dude holding it and grinning like he just won the fucking lottery. Now, I should’ve just told him to fuck off, that’s our moral here, but no, I let this dumbass walk me home and get us spectacularly lost. The whole time he’s talking about how he’s my boyfriend now and he’s gonna come up to my room all while kissing my neck and trying to turn my face to get to my lips. I was in this hotel not far from here and Kaleiçi is pitch black on weeknights so there wasn’t much I could really do but wait it out. We eventually found the hotel, fucking soaked from wandering around for 45 minutes in the rain and I rang the little bell to be let in. The front desk guy opened the door and like looked at me and then the dude critically and I jumped in and he slammed the door in his face. Obviously the only thought on my mind was getting in the shower and washing the slime off of me, so I ran to my room and stripped and got in with the hot water

turned all the way up. I was finally starting to relax when I realized," Catra paused dramatically. Adora leaned forward. "That motherfucker stole my umbrella!"

Catra cackled at her punchline. Adora slumped back, horrified.

"Anyway, that's how it can be here sometimes, so be careful, okay? Think of it as a favor to me." Catra smiled and Adora returned it and nodded.

"Okay, but only cause you asked. Did you ever get your umbrella back?"

Catra laughed again, "Another story for another time."

Adora was about to beg her to tell it when Glimmer burst out of the bar dragging a barely-conscious Bo by the waist.

"There you two are! We're leaving before this drunk asshole pukes on me again."

"One time," Bo muttered.

Glimmer gave him a quick hip-check and he groaned. "Adora, are you coming with us? Now or never, let's go!"

Adora paused and glanced between Glimmer tapping her foot impatiently and Catra looking at her critically.

"Um."

"Jesus Christ. Catra, are you taking her or not?"

Catra leaned back in her chair, lit a fresh cigarette, and exhaled. "Nah. Maybe another time."

Adora visibly deflated. Catra shrugged. "You're looking a little sleepy, princess."

"I'm not sleepy," Adora mumbled and stood up, but Catra grabbed her wrist, "Hey do you have your Turkish sim yet?"

“Yeah. Got it yesterday.”

“Good, gimme your phone.” Adora dutifully handed it over and watched as Catra fiddled with it and handed it back.

“Adora, come *on*! You had your chance, *Ekaterina*.”

“Shut the fuck up, *Glynnis*.”

Unwilling to provoke her friend’s wrath any further, Adora smiled unconvincingly at Catra and paired it with a small wave. “It was nice meeting you.”

Catra smiled back genuinely. "You too, dork."

45 minutes later, long enough for the trio to hail a cab and get home, long enough to shed her clothes and crawl into bed disappointed and alone, Adora’s phone lit up with a text.

Catra (03.25): Goodnight, princess

Adora (03:26): goodnight catra

Chapter End Notes

1. eşek: donkey (it's a term of endearment, sorta)
   Sıktır git: fuck off
   Yavaş yavaş kızım: slow down, my girl [▲]
2. Merhaba arkadaşlar. Hoş geldiniz: Hello, friends. Welcome.
   Bu akşam nasılsınız?: How are we tonight?
   Çok güzel, arkadaşlar. Biz The Horde: Very good, friends. We're The Horde
   Teşekkür ederız: We thank you. [▲]
3. Ne yapıyon sen yavşak?: What are you doing, nit? Nit is the literal translation, but it's a pretty significant insult to be throwing around at a stranger outside a bar. [▲]

Winter pt. 2

Chapter Summary

Khyle drummed his fingers on the arm of the sofa thoughtfully, “Okay, but, are you gonna kiss her?”

“She’s a big girl, she can kiss me.”

--
In which Catra is formally introduced.

Chapter Notes

UPDATE 18/9/2021: More rewrites. Less significant than the first chapter, but important.

I realized that this chapter is a bit short, so I decided to post it in the middle of the week. Chapter 3 will release on Saturday as scheduled.

There have been a few updates to Ch. 1. Instead of being the cagey mess I am, I took my girlfriend up on her offer to proof for me. In short, no more typos and the Turkish is better. I also added a name guide and a Spotify playlist with the Horde's set. The playlist will update as we go.

Content note: This is our first foray into frank depictions of mental illness.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“’*This hobble of being alive is rather serious, don't you think so*?’”

- Angel Clare, *Tess of the d’Urbervilles*, Thomas Hardy, 1891

A little over a month later, Catra sat on her couch smiling blithely at her phone. She had already shed her work clothes in favor of

black thermal leggings and a massive maroon hoodie with the hood pulled up. Despite the fact that she made decent money at the high school, she refused to turn on the heat unless she could see her breath and the last couple of weeks had been uncharacteristically warm. Just as she finished typing out the rousing tale of a fight between two freshman boys she had been made to break up that day, she heard the door open. A few moments later, Khyle vaulted over the couch and squirmed his head onto her lap. Catra, of course, did not spare him a second glance.

"Hey, Bise?" Catra ignored the nickname, a word for 'cat' in his dialect of Arabic.

"Biiiiiiiiiiiseeeeeeeee?"

Catra glanced down at him, unamused.

"What?"

"Who ya textin'?"

"No one."

"Uh huh, yes, very believable."

"Shut up."

"You're smiling."

"Am not."

Khyle gasped, putting his palms on his cheeks in a Home Alone caricature.

"Is it," his voice dropped to a whisper, "…Adora?"

Catra jostled her knee roughly and Khyle sat up laughing. His hand snuck along the back of the couch and pulled her hood down and poked at the slight darkening of her cheeks.

"It is!"

Catra groaned, "Why are you like this?"

"C'mon, I'm just teasing. It's cute. I haven't seen you like someone in forever."

Catra knew exactly how long that forever had lasted, and she didn't appreciate it being brought up even indirectly.

She replied with a little bite, "Okay, one, I am not cute, and two, I don't *like* her, I'm just doing Sparkles a favor."

Khyle ignored it, "Uh huh, wasn't the favor to sleep with her?"

"It was more like I'm supposed to distract her from her shitty life or something."

Frankly, Catra had not been sure what to expect when Glimmer had theatrically dragged her out of a bar a few months back. Once outside, Glimmer had pressed a conciliatory beer into her hands and rattled off a disjointed story about how her friend was coming to visit and that she could use some company. This had been followed up with a heavy wink and a description of how hot this friend was. *You've been such a fucking sadsack since I met you, Catra, but I'm getting you laid cause I'm a good friend. Same with Adora, so two lesbians one genius stone that is me, I am the stone*. After this, Glimmer had puked in some bushes, leaving Catra with the distinct impression that she had just had her time wasted by a drunk girl for the millionth time in her life.

Imagine Catra's surprise when she had received a call a few weeks later from a completely sober Glimmer informing her that the friend was in town and was being bundled up and brought to The Horde's show that Saturday. When Catra had inquired about what exactly it was she was supposed to be doing, Glimmer had brushed her off with a *Just be yourself, but, like, nicer.*

Khyle drummed his fingers on the arm of the sofa thoughtfully, "Okay, but, are you gonna kiss her?"

“She’s a big girl, she can kiss me.”

“True, but what are you waiting for? Cause usually when you’re into a girl and you know she’s gay, you just go for it. We’ve been out with them like ten times since the gig at The Waste, and you always find a way to go be by Adora which means you like her, and yet, and *yet*, you haven’t made a single move. Not to *mention* that first night when you literally saved her life like a knight in shining armor and still sent her home. Basically and in short, you are blowing this very hard.”

“I’m not blowing shit. We’re too old to be bringing random drunk girls home cause Sparkles tells us to.”

“Fair enough, but you two have definitely hung out sober since then, so clearly there’s something different about her, which is…?”

Catra glared into Khyle’s infuriatingly perceptive face for a few moments and then sighed.

“Look, I don’t know how long she’s gonna be here. You know how it is here, people come and go and you can’t get attached.”

“Is she a tourist?” Khyle asked, invoking their hallowed list of types of foreigners in Antalya.

“No. She told me that she cancelled the lease for her apartment in New York and is working online.”

“So she’s a transient?”

“Probably? Who wants to stay here for more than two years besides people who marry in and German pensioners?”

“For one, us.”

“That’s different.”

“Oh I bet. I’m a literal refugee, what’s your excuse?”

Catra finally softened, “I’m a stubborn, self-hating bitch with mommy issues?”

Khyle kicked her lightly in the calf and Catra laughed, kicking him back harder prompting further retaliation. When their little squabble let up, Khyle looked at her thoughtfully.

“You’re allowed to be happy that you’re talking to someone.”

Catra scoffed.

“Especially someone as hot as Adora.”

“I *guess*.”

“Seriously, have you seen her? I bet she could bench me.”

Catra laughed. From there, the conversation shifted into the mundane: work gossip, plans to have dinner at Rogelio and Lawan’s restaurant, band practice.

Eventually, Khyle wandered off to take a shower, and Catra watched her best friend as he went. She knew as much about his past as he’d been willing to tell her over the years, and the same went for him. She knew that his real name was Khalil Alawi and that most of his family was back in Syria. He had fled with his cousins Rogelio and Lawan the year before she had come to Turkey.

Lawan, the oldest and the one with the sturdiest head on her shoulders, had come first. Her mother was Turkish, so she could speak the language, making her the ideal candidate to talk to government officials and find a place that would rent to three Syrians fresh across the border. It hadn’t been easy to find a job and a place, but she had managed.

Rogelio had come straight from Riyadh where he had been working in the kitchen of a 5-star hotel. There had been rumblings of him losing his job because of the political situation, so he had slipped out before that could happen. His significant savings of US

Dollars had tipped the scales for them. Rogelio had made do with menial kitchen jobs while Lawan had hopped around as a waitress. After endless red tape, the two had finally acquired the proper permits to open a restaurant of their own with Rogelio in the kitchen and Lawan running the business. They did well among both the Turkish and foreign crowd, and they were considering opening a second location.

Khalil, the youngest, had been the last to arrive, waiting desperately for a copy of his recently-earned University diploma. After it had arrived, his mother and sister had assured him over and over that they would be fine, and he had hopped on a plane. Not a moment too soon, for shortly after, Turkey had tightened restrictions on Syrians entering the country. Khalil had quickly found a job teaching English at a cram school where he had used the name Kyle. Catra had happened to be working at the same school and when he had introduced himself as both Khalil and Kyle, she had combined them. The nickname had stuck.

The four of them had decided to start a band one night while sitting on the floor of the empty restaurant blackout drunk on bathtub arak. They all played different instruments; they all liked the same music; they had all been in bands before; what was stopping them? They had awoken the next morning with splitting headaches and a piece of paper with a sample set-list on it. No one had had any sober objections, so they had figured why not? Both Khyle and Catra could sing and play guitar, but it had been decided that Catra had the marginally better voice and was a hot girl, so she was put at the front. They practiced in the basement/ store-room of the restaurant and played occasional gigs in Kaleiçi. It was more of a hobby than anything, and the four always had a lot of fun together.

--

Catra moved to the balcony with a blanket draped over her shoulders. She curled up on the cushioned bench and lit a cigarette. Three dots appearing and disappearing on her phone indicated that Adora was typing but seemed to be having a tough

time with it. Catra smiled at the screen again before pocketing the phone and gazing at the sliver of sea-view between two buildings and the massive hotel. So what if she was texting Adora? It wasn't like it was that often (wrong, every day, multiple times a day), it was strictly flirting (wrong, they sent each other pictures of stray cats and talked about their days), and most importantly, Catra could not care less about the woman on the other end (big wrong, she thought about Adora constantly).

If there was one thing that Catra was good at in this world, it was lying to herself. In her younger years, she would have counted lying to other people pretty high up on the list, but she had long since decided to eschew that particular skillset. Moving abroad had forced her to truly consider herself in a way that the US hadn't and evaluate the kind of person she wanted to be. It had also plucked her from one form of mental survival mode and placed her into another one entirely.

Catra was born Ekaterina Primov to Snezhana Primov and an unnamed father on an overcast fall morning in Chicago, Illinois. Despite being heavily pregnant, the mother had walked into the emergency room with an air of regality, placing her Bulgarian passport on the counter and tersely informing the nurse that she was in labor. The way the woman had made no sound throughout the delivery despite denying the offer of pain control, the way she had stared at the freshly wrapped child in her arms with open contempt, and the way that she had leveled a withering glare at any staff member who dared mispronounce her name while also refusing to correct them had ensured that the imposing Bulgarian woman would be spoken of in that ward for years to come.

Catra was unsure what she and her mother had done in the few years after her birth. Her first memory was of her mother cleaning an inflamed wasp sting on her inner arm after she had accidently sat on a nest in their backyard, receiving countless stings before being rescued by a man mowing the neighbor's lawn. *Oh, Ekaterina*, her mother had said in a voice just a hair off of kind as she had gingerly dabbed alcohol on the marks, *such a shame you aren't allergic*.

Her mother had never been forthcoming on details about the present, preferring to test those around her on the unspoken and reveling when they failed. But about the past, she was a vault.

As an adult, Catra found this unimportant, but as a child, she had been obsessed with the forbidden knowledge and its relation to her identity. Fantasies about who she was, who her family was had filled her head, the longest-lasting of which was that her mother was the long-lost Anastasia Romanov and they were on the run from Rasputin the evil wizard. Over the course of her childhood, Catra had come to understand that it would have been far more likely that her mother had been the evil wizard pointing a rifle at a family posed for their own downfall.

Over the years, Catra had managed to scrape together a loose story with the help of her mother in her more intoxicated moments as well as a well-hidden box of important documents. Her grandfather, Parvan Primov was a professor of Russian Literature at Sofia University - St. Kliment Ohridski in Sofia, Bulgaria, her mother's birthplace. From what Catra could tell, he was not a kind man. According to the faculty page at the University, he was still alive and teaching – or at least he had been a few years back. His bio picture showed long white hair pulled back in a ponytail, a lean face with scars around the right eye, and an impressive glare. She had an uncle, a man that her mother had often cursed for his laziness and idiocy but had carefully refrained from naming. A fading polaroid cut neatly in half showed what she guessed was him as a frowning young man in a suit with tails and his black hair slicked back. A third sibling had died shortly after birth, taking Catra's grandmother with him. There was no photo of either.

According to the box of documents, Snezhana had been sent to boarding school in Bucharest at the age of 7 where she had learned Russian, English, Romanian, and French. From there, she had attended Moscow State University, but Catra was unsure what she had studied. After undergrad, her mother had made her way back to Sofia and started a graduate program at Parvan's university. This time period, unfortunately the one that most

directly concerned Catra, was shrouded in mystery. At some point, her mother had found herself pregnant and at some point had fled to the United States. Catra knew nothing about her father except that he was Turkish, the only fact about the man that her mother seemed fond of divulging. When drunk, Snezhana could always be relied upon to curse the son of a bitch who had ruined everything as well as the living, breathing bastard child before her eyes that served as a constant reminder of all that had been taken away from her.

Sometime before Ekaterina started school, the pair had settled in Indianapolis. Snezhana started going by Shannon because she said she couldn't stand the sound of her name in the mouths of the slack-jawed cretins by which she was constantly surrounded. Ekaterina, however, was still required to call her mother by her given name – the woman abhorred being referred to as Mom or Mother and Ekaterina had found out just how much on plenty of occasions. She had memories of sitting in her closet, quietly practicing the pronunciation of her mother's name to avoid her wrath from any slip-up.

To solve the problem of employment, Shannon Primov had walked into St. Matthew's Catholic School and had managed to convince the administration of several unlikely things at once: first, that she was a devout Catholic; second, that she had years of teaching experience; third, that she was excellent with children. The following school year, she was placed in a 1st grade classroom. It hadn't taken long for Miss Shannon to develop a scathing reputation among the students, but Snezhana had managed to find one of the last subsets of American parents in the 90's that preferred a 'stronger', more 'traditional' approach with their children.

When Ekaterina had finally started school, she had learned that her mother's nickname was Miss Shadow and that the children that emerged from her classroom at the end of the year were always changed for the worse. Fear of Miss Shadow had kept the children far away from Ekaterina. It also hadn't helped that while their parents respected Shannon Primov the educator immensely,

they gossiped about her as a single mother mercilessly. Through the children, this had passed on to Ekaterina. Even worse, she was unmistakably foreign with her Tupperware of weird food for lunch and her lack of an Irish or Anglophone name. This had been the last piece in the trifecta of childhood ostracism.

However, the summer after 5th grade, puberty had hit the girl like a train, a year or so before everyone else. On the first day of 6th grade, she had sauntered into the classroom with a bra, flat-ironed hair, and a new name: Catra. After she had fully committed to crafting herself a new identity, things had been different. Catra had taken the years of scorn from both adults and her peers and folded them around herself like armor, for who could dish out malice more efficiently than the outcast? She had learned to reframe that which was so odious to herself and those around her: instead of foreign, she was exotic; instead of weird, she was mysterious; instead of shy, she was untouchable.

Most importantly, though, she had shed any trace of the meek, quiet girl she was made to be at home and replaced it with arrogance and swagger. Her tormentors had quickly learned to leave her alone lest they get ripped to shreds by her acid tongue and notoriously sharp nails. It hadn't taken long for her to carve out her own place within the social rank. Today, Catra looked upon her middle and high school years with horror and shame, remembering the cruelty she had inflicted on those unlucky enough to assume her recently-vacated role of scapegoat. In no time at all, Catra had become a copy of her mother, and worst of all, she had taken to it like a duck to water.

Things had irrevocably changed again a few months after Catra's 17th birthday. The Las Vegas Incident was the first of its kind but certainly not the last.

It took a few days for Catra to notice that something wasn't quite right with her. She had been sleeping worse than usual, so she ascribed the weirdness to that. It was hard to describe, but it was like her thoughts were loose, floaty? Something like that. Concentrating on her classes became impossible when a thick

curtain of dread suddenly settled over her, so she cut the rest of the day. Wandering through the thin strip of woods near her house, the dread morphed into fear as she stared at the various shades of green needles poking out among the bare branches. Something was very wrong, but what? A breeze ruffled the last vestiges of leaves in the trees and Catra heard the thwp-thwp-thwp of helicopter blades. In a panic, she took off running to her house and didn't stop until she reached the narrow window that led into their basement. With a look over her shoulder, she pulled it open and slipped down in a practiced motion. She latched the window and crawled behind some boxes, holding her head between her legs and vibrating with the knowledge that she would soon be killed.

That night, she neither died nor was missed by her mother when she appeared to not come home. The time behind the boxes left her with the resolve that she had no choice but to flee the clandestine forces gunning for her head as well as a vague plan for making that happen. When it was time for school, Catra went upstairs and changed into a clean uniform, careful not to act suspiciously, lest anyone catch on that she too had caught on. Once at school, she cornered a boy that she knew had a crush on her, a home life worse than hers, and, most importantly, a car. "Let's run away together," she said, trying to juggle the panic vibrating her every cell with an attempt to be sexy. He took very little convincing and the two were set to leave the next day, a Friday, directly after school. Until then, Catra managed to keep it together, only slipping once when a friend had asked how she was and Catra had launched into a disjointed diatribe about colors and their hidden meanings. Luckily, this gaff did not result in her swift execution, and the two set off West.

*By this time, Catra's head was filled with boiling lead threatening to slosh out of her ears. The boy hadn't argued when she had insisted on driving. She hadn't slept a second in 5 days and it didn't look like she would need to anytime soon. It was something of an adventure driving across the country in the middle of January. In Iowa, their tire burst and they were helped by a kind couple and their kids. (*Catra would do anything to find their

names and thank them. She still had nerve damage in a couple of toes from the frostbite and things could've been a lot worse if not for them.) *In Colorado, Catra had her first brush with death and the passive desire for it. They pulled into a mostly-deserted rest stop on the Colorado River at around 7 am. Her companion was asleep, so she wandered down the path and then through the snow to the bank of the river. Because it seemed like the right thing to do, she walked across the ice, wondering how far she could go before something happened. As is the nature of ice, it broke. She fell through and found herself desperately pawing at the sheet of ice above her. Eventually, her vision darkened. The next thing she remembered was standing up somewhere downriver with her head above water and coughing. "I'm not dead," she thought calmly and clawed her way onto land. Somewhere between gasping and coughing, she realized that her shoulder was no longer where it was supposed to be. She grabbed her wrist and yanked it up, wrenching it back into place with a sickening pop. She returned to the car a shivering mess and let her friend cuddle her until she was warm again.*

The pair eventually made it to Las Vegas and parked in one of the casino lots. The plan for the most part stalled as the contacts that the boy claimed to have were not panning out. Catra was starting to feel strange again, a voice that sounded like her own cutting through the miasma to question why she was looking over her shoulder every few seconds. They wandered around for the better part of the day before going into a head shop on the strip. It was run by a man and his son who was their age. The father was wary of the obvious runaways, but the son was taken by Catra despite the fact that she probably looked like a goblin that had not showered in a week or slept for longer. The boy she was with was not terribly pleased with this development, especially since he had expected Catra to put out at least once and be at least 20% less crazy. He especially didn't like that he was not allowed to stay the night and had to go back to the car. By some miracle, nothing happened to her that night, the head shop boy had simply pulled her back to his chest and held her close. By another miracle, she slept.

Upon waking, her first thought, loud and bright with blistering clarity, was, "What the fuck am I doing?" Still wrapped in the head shop boy's arms, she worked backwards through the last two weeks, and while she still wasn't quite convinced that she wasn't the target of something sinister, she thought that perhaps her decision-making had been compromised. She had, in fact, fucked the fuck up. Careful not to wake her buddy, she extricated herself from the bed, hissing at the white-hot pain in her shoulder that had thus far been muted. Her head swam and all she wanted to do was lay down and go back to sleep for at least a month. Instead, she forced herself to her feet and stumbled into the front of the shop where the owner frowned at her as she hunched and clutched her burning shoulder. His expression softened significantly when she asked to use his phone.

Catra had spent 3 weeks in in-patient psych. There, she had been diagnosed with Unspecified Psychotic Disorder with Elements of Borderline Personality Disorder and placed on anti-psychotics. It had taken her approximately a week after getting out to stop taking them. Catra had been surprised at her mother's reaction to the whole fiasco. There had been a few instances of wrath at the embarrassment that Catra had become, but it seemed that Snezhana was mostly indifferent, grounding her daughter for the sake of it but turning a mostly-blind eye to sports and extra-curriculars – things that would get Catra to college and out of the house for good. At the hospital, the doctors had asked Snezhana about family history with mental illness, and Catra had gotten the impression that it was around but had always been something to sweep under the rug.

Despite another Incident a year later, though one that was much more subdued and took the form of sleeping with random men off of Craigslist, Catra graduated with her class with a good enough GPA and SAT score to get her a full-ride to a state University. Her time there was mostly uneventful aside from a month that she was so sad that she was thinking concretely about killing herself. When she had told a counselor about it, she had been sent to a psychiatrist and then promptly to in-patient for a 72-hour-hold. After a few days of taking the prescribed anti-depressants, Catra

had flown into an Incident that had almost concluded with her dropping out of school. It had been a less-than-stellar experience. Unsure of how to deal with all of this, her first girlfriend had broken up with her. At the time, Catra had understood, knowing acutely that she was a burden and impossible to be around.

In her last year, Catra had decided that she was going to move overseas and teach English. It had made sense considering her English degree and the fact that her best job prospect upon graduation was Starbucks. She had settled on Turkey mostly as a way to piss her mother off, but a small part of her that she refused to acknowledge had wanted to learn about this forbidden part of her identity. It wasn't as if she could look her father or his family up without so much as a name, but perhaps it would be enough to be in the country and eat the food and learn the language.

It hadn't been enough. Moving abroad had been difficult and terrible, but she was happy now. She had a job, friends, and a decent life. On top of that, a pretty girl was texting her "good night" every night before she fell asleep. So what if she was probably temporary and going to leave like everyone else eventually did? Catra was going to enjoy life while it lasted, and goddammit everyone need to stop giving her shit about it.

Chapter End Notes

Do you like it?
Are you mad that I made Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio cousins?
Let me know in the comments!

A quick note: Snezhana is Shadow Weaver, Parvan is Horde Prime. My naming conventions are somewhat predictable in spite of the hours I spent researching Bulgarian names. For the Princesses, I mostly just followed my heart.

Spring pt. 1

Chapter Summary

> "You're late!" shrieked Glimmer. Adora checked her watch. She had said she would be home at 6 and it was now 6:03.
>
> Adora clutched her chest dramatically and looked at Glimmer with her biggest puppy-dog eyes.
>
> "Oh Glimmer, I'm so sorry, how horrible of me. How can I begin to earn your forgiveness for being 3 whole minutes late?"
>
> --
>
> In which Adora is formally introduced and the story moves forward.

Chapter Notes

> UPDATE 18/09/2021: All rewrites from here on out aren't plot-based.
>
> Update: I figured out linked footnotes. My Eyrie will finally get the page she deserves.
>
> By the way,
> Saliha - Scorpia
> Hanife - Huntara
>
> The playlist gets some new entries for the end:
> https://open.spotify.com/playlist/6qtrsHXeg7PNa8XqDt7Vkt?si=122768a69b5b4884

See the end of the chapter for more notes

For I have known them all already, known them all:

Have known the evenings, mornings, afternoons,

I have measured out my life with coffee spoons;

I know the voices dying with a dying fall

Beneath the music from a farther room.

So how should I presume?

- T.S. Eliot, "The Love Song of J. Alfred Prufrock", 1915

Things were going well for Adora. It had been nearly three months since she had arrived in Turkey. A month ago, Glimmer had caught her scanning a site for apartments and had aggressively reassured her that she didn't need to move out. She had finally been convinced when Glimmer had all but begged her to stay, citing the size of the house and her general loneliness. *I love Bo, don't get me wrong*, she had said, *but you're the closest thing to home here.* Like that first Christmas and the countless other crusades Glimmer had mounted over the years to help her, Adora had relented. The swanky duplex apartment, casually referred to as "Bright Manor" by their friends, was semi-officially hers as well when Glimmer submitted a notarized letter declaring that Adora was living there indefinitely.

A few weeks before, Bo had asked her at dinner when they should start working on getting her a residence permit. Adora had told him not to worry about it and that her appointment was actually in a few days. Glimmer had narrowed her eyes suspiciously. After a bit of prodding, Adora had shyly admitted that Catra had helped her navigate the website and gather the needed documents which were currently stored in a color-coded binder in her room. Bo had grinned like a madman, and Glimmer had looked confused but pleased.

Adora was now the proud owner of a grainy print-out that functioned as her ID until the official pink card arrived in the mail. Catra, on her half-day, had waited with her at her appointment at the Immigration Office. Adora had been glad for the company.

The grey office was bleak, and the two had leaned against each other and made up stories about the people around them. It had done wonders to soothe Adora's nerves. Talking to mid-range government employees in sweat-stained shirtsleeves took her back to unpleasant times.

Her economic situation was even looking up. Just a few days prior, she had submitted her first assignment as a ghost writer, a 200 page romance novel about an unfulfilled vineyard owner in Naples and the lowly seasonal worker that seduced her. There were identical twins, clandestine escapes, and even a gunfight. Catra had, of course, insisted on reading it, and instead of mocking her relentlessly like she had expected, the woman had congratulated her and taken her out for a celebratory drink with no more than a little light teasing.

To her greatest surprise, Adora had even started making friends. Perihan had invited her to have coffee in her garden. While the woman had talked about energy far too much for her liking, Adora had had fun and had even started going once a week for Turkish coffee and yoga. Adora particularly enjoyed when Perihan's friends Saliha and Hanife joined them. Saliha, taller and broader than her with a poof of blonde hair on her head, was infectiously positive, and the two had met to play basketball on several occasions. Hanife from Kars, her height but jacked to the gods with long black hair pulled into a tight ponytail, made Adora feel some kind of way. The woman was a bit gruff at first, dismissing Adora as another one of Perihan's pet projects, but once she had earned the other woman's affection, the two had started going to the gym together.

Adora was unsure about the sexuality of the women in her little group as they carefully avoided talk of relationships. All of the arm-wrestling did seem pretty gay, though.

At least one of her questions was answered one day when she was playing basketball with Saliha. She was checking the ball up when Saliha held onto it and bit her lip.

“You okay?”

“Yes? No? Maybe?”

Adora nodded, unsure what to say and led them off the court to sit against the chain-link fence.

“What’s up? Is this cause I was beating you?” Adora grinned.

Saliha laughed nervously. “No! No, I, şey, can I tell you something?”

“Of course. What’s up?”

As Saliha hesitated, Adora got nervous and chewed at her cuticles. *Ew*, she thought, but her hindbrain did not care and said *Bite*.

“You have to promise not to tell anyone.”

“I promise.”

Saliha took a deep breath. “Okay. Adora. I am a lesbian.”

Adora blinked and saw Saliha’s eyes widen in panic. *React, idiot*.

“Oh, that's cool!”

“That’s… cool?” Saliha cocked her head.

Adora scrambled, “I mean, it isn’t a big deal for me. I’m a lesbian, too.”

Saliha’s eyes widened again, and Adora felt herself begin to panic at her tactlessness. “But, uh, thank you… for telling me? That’s very brave?”

Adora felt herself wrapped into a tight hug that seemed to go on forever. When she was finally released, she found Saliha beaming at her.

“Thank you, Adora.”

“For what?”

“Being nice.”

The two sat against the fence for a long time. Saliha did most of the talking, about the mother that she hadn’t spoken to in the years since coming out, the father that didn’t hate her but was so disappointed, and the younger sister who thought Saliha was being selfish for abandoning her family. That one had hurt the worst. She also talked about her colleague, a beautiful woman with whom she was in love. She suspected that the colleague preferred the company of women, but she didn’t know how to ask.

Adora told her that she wasn’t exactly a font of practical advice. She hadn’t quite grown up in a welcoming environment in Appalachian Tennessee, and her every prior relationship had been initiated by the other party. She talked briefly of her own longing for her own beautiful friend, careful to keep it vague lest Saliha divine who it was in her relatively small social circle.

Eventually, Adora had to go and get ready for the party tonight that Glimmer was hosting. *That we’re hosting*, Glimmer had reminded her, *It’s not every day my best friend gets her residence permit and also this is your house, too, so you’re also a host*. Adora considered taking the bus, but saw that she had plenty of time, and decided to walk since her game had been cut short by confessions.

As usual, she couldn’t take her eyes off of the sea. As a child, she had fantasized about the ocean, how big it must be, how it would feel to get into a submarine and sink deeper and deeper until she was swallowed by the silent blackness.

Adora had woken up with the sun for as long she could remember. Today was no different. She sat up, rubbed her eyes, and checked the clock. It was a little earlier than usual, but instead of trying to

sleep some more, she got out of bed and stretched. She hadn't heard Mom come in last night, so she had either been extra quiet or she was somewhere else. Adora opened her bedroom door and took the two steps into the kitchen and grabbed an almost-empty box of cornflakes. The milk in the mini-fridge was spoiled, so she poured a bowl and ate them dry with her fingers. Mom wasn't in her room, and Adora started to worry. She grabbed the phone off the cradle and dialed her mom's boyfriend. They might still be awake, and Adora was willing to endure a slap or two for a too-early call to quell the bad feeling growing in her belly. No one picked up. They were probably passed out. Even though it was early, Adora took a quick shower, brushed her teeth, and dressed for school. She figured she could look around the park a bit before the bus came. Adora opened the door and gasped. She leapt down the stairs of their trailer and dropped to her knees beside the crumpled body of her mother. "No, no, no," she whispered and checked for a pulse, getting a bit of dried vomit on her hands. She thought she felt something and raced inside, tears streaming down her face, and called 911.

The next few hours were a blur. An ambulance came and took her mother away. One of her neighbors drove her to the hospital and dropped her off. She sat in the waiting room for a million years. A police officer came to talk to her, a nice-seeming woman, but she asked too many questions. "How old are you?" "12." "Do you have any brothers or sisters?" "No." "What's your favorite color?" "Blue." "Has this happened before?" "No." Adora lied. Adora said that she only sometimes saw her mom drink, sometimes wine with dinner, but never drunk, not like drunk people on TV. She said that her mom's boyfriend was a nice man who treated them both well. Adora lied and lied and lied, all the while looking over the officer's shoulder willing her mother to walk out and take her home.

She didn't go to school that day. She went home, briefly, to grab some clothes, before sleeping at her neighbor's. She wanted to sleep on the floor, but her friend Brayden offered to share his bed. They had before. His mom didn't care. When he tried to sneak a hand under her shirt, she elbowed him in the ribs hard enough to bruise. He didn't try again.

She went to school the next day in a haze. At lunch, while she was wandering around aimlessly, used to packing her lunch and not having anything resembling lunch money, she was pulled into her guidance counselor's office. The woman was weird, but Adora liked her well enough even though she always called her by the wrong name. Short and round and with a slight accent when she carried on in her cryptic rants, the other kids made fun of Ms. Razz. "Have you eaten already, Mara dearie?" "Yeah," Adora lied. "You can always eat more. Keep an old woman company. Loo Kee and I are not talking, and I have no other friends." Adora glanced at the broom in the corner that Razz frowned at and reluctantly took the foil-wrapped sandwich held out to her. With great effort, she managed not to inhale it lest Ms. Razz divine that this was the first meal she'd had since yesterday morning. Ms. Razz placed a pack of chips and an apple on her desk with a wink. Adora ate the apple and put the chips in her bag for later.

Adora was to sleep at another neighbor's that night, but her host hadn't protested when she'd left without a word and gone back home. The next day, Ms. Razz pulled her into the office and fed her, relaying the newest chapter in her ongoing feud with what Adora assumed was her broom. And so the next day and the next for a week and then two weeks. Adora's mother came home, and Adora still went to Ms. Razz's office every day for lunch. Ms. Razz never asked about Adora's home life, about the incident that landed her mother in the hospital, or about all the ugly little details that Adora was sure littered her file. After a month, Ms. Razz insisted she drop the Ms.

One day, Razz invited Adora to her house to bake a pie. Adora said she'd think about it but still showed up bright and early Saturday morning. Razz showed her how to roll the dough ("Not so thin, Mara!) and make the filling, how long to set the timer. She even taught Adora how to fix a leaky pipe, claiming that she was too old and feeble to do it herself ("Ach, Mara, that's the wrong wrench. You've done this many times before!"). From then on, Adora went to Razz's house every Saturday. She baked pies and did chores around the house. It was strange, but it was nice, so Adora kept going and kept joining Razz every day for lunch.

One Saturday, Adora didn't show up. When she finally showed up for lunch on Wednesday, Razz didn't say anything, but Adora broke down crying almost immediately. "I missed Saturday baking and didn't call," she said, recalling the pipe held up to her lips. She'd done it before, but she hadn't felt bad because no one cared and there had been no consequences. It didn't even feel that good, but the boys liked it, and it was something to do. It made her heart race like it would beat out of her chest, but it was fun to run into the woods and climb trees and pretend to be wild animals. They'd only done it a couple times, afraid Brayden's brother would notice it missing.

Razz listened, nodding intently. "Mara, dearie?"Adora squeezed her eyes shut and prepared for the tirade. Instead, she felt a bonk on her head. When she opened her eyes, Razz was holding the broom and grinning at her. "Silly girl! Stop your tears, my Mara is very good. Now, Madame Razz has something for you." Adora sniffled and looked at a stack of papers shoved across the desk. She grabbed the neatly stapled bundle and a glossy brochure and her eyes widened as she flipped through. It was an application. "What is this?" Razz smiled and leaned over the desk to bring an acrylic-nail to Adora's forehead. "It is time now for Adora."

Adora hadn't thought about Razz in years. Something about the earnestness of Saliha's confession must have stirred something in her. She unlocked the front gate and rode the elevator up, lost in herself. When she opened the front door, she found Bo and Glimmer hanging streamers. There was also a huge banner spelling out "CONGIRADULAYŞIN ADOĞRA" draped across the living room.

"You're late!" shrieked Glimmer. Adora checked her watch. She had said she would be home at 6 and it was now 6:03.

Adora clutched her chest dramatically and looked at Glimmer with her biggest puppy-dog eyes.

"Oh Glimmer, I'm so sorry, how horrible of me. How can I begin to earn your forgiveness for being 3 whole minutes late?"

"First of all, I can smell you from here, so go take a shower and get ready for *your* party."

Adora made a show of sniffing her pits. "Oh you mean…?" She pointed at her underarm and then at Glimmer, "you don't like it?"

Glimmer eyed her carefully. "Adora…"

Adora launched herself at Glimmer who let out a shriek as the larger woman smothered her in stink. "Breathe it in, Glimmer! This is what peak perfection smells like!"

"Bo! Help!"

Bo regarded them for a moment from the kitchen as he stacked various bottles on the counter. "Sorry, babes, I'm good."

After harassing Glimmer for a few more minutes and earning an elbow to the face, Adora hopped up and headed to her room. Glimmer's cry of "You'll pay for that!" followed her and Adora rubbed at her sore chin.

Totally worth it.

Despite Glimmer's dramatics and overload on food and booze, the party wasn't particularly large. Merve, Feyza, and Sea Hawk arrived a little early to "set up," and Merve and Feyza took the opportunity to dump one bag of chips into a bowl and head up to the sauna. Sea Hawk spirited Bo away from the kitchen, flashing Adora a peek of the bottle of whiskey in his breast pocket and a wink. Adora took his place, reassuring Glimmer that everything was great and amazing and perfect and the best she had ever seen.

Soon after, Perihan arrived with a promise that Saliha would be by later and a pot filled to the brim with lahana sarması.[1] Adora had already shoved 5 into her mouth before Perihan gently warned her to wait until everyone arrived. Adora sulked but complied, sneaking one more when a timer beeped and she turned to pull a tray of little springrolls out of the oven. Suddenly, she felt hot

breath on her ear followed by a quiet, “Hey Adora,” and nearly leapt out of her skin. She whirled around to face Catra, who looked quite pleased with herself.

“That’s it. You’re uninvited. Get out of my party.”

Catra laughed brightly, “Aw, did I scare you, princess?”

“I’ve never been scared of anything in my life.” Adora crossed her arms and fought the grin threatening to crack her face.

“Of course not.” Catra hopped onto the counter. “You’d just punch a shark or public speaking in the face.”

Adora flexedand nodded seriously. "Yes."

“Outta my way, meathead, I need a drink.” Glimmer elbowed Adora out of the way and grabbed a bottle of vodka. “Catra, get the fuck off my counter. Actually, both of you get out of here and go flirt somewhere else.”

“Geez, Sparkles, what crawled up your ass?” Catra responded but slid off the counter. She grabbed two beers out of the fridge and went to sit on one of the couches across from Rogelio, Lawan, and Khyle, Adora on her tail. She cracked open both bottles with a lighter and handed one to Adora.

“We have a bottle opener.”

“Yeah, but admit you’re a little impressed.”

Adora loved when Catra did little things for her like getting her a beer or ordering for her when they were out. So maybe she was a little impressed, but she wasn’t about to say it out loud.

Adora wasn’t sure exactly what was going on between her and Catra. The other woman seemed interested, and Adora felt confident that she was properly broadcasting her feelings, but no one had made a move as of yet. The more she got to know Khyle, the less Adora had worried about him. He seemed cool and,

according to everyone, him and Catra were just kind of like brother and sister or soul-bonded or something bizarre like that. She supposed that she could just kiss Catra or explicitly ask her out, but after getting sent home that first night, it felt impossible. She liked Catra as a friend and didn't want to make anything weird. Besides, what they had now was good and fine.

"Okay, maybe a little," she finally replied. Adora took a deep drink of the beer and squeaked when the rising foam spilled on her chin and neck.

Catra laughed. "Dude, you suck. What are you, 12?"

"Your mom's 12," Adora countered, pulling up the hem of her shirt to dry herself off. Out of the corner of her eye, she caught Catra staring.

Lawan leaned forward and clinked her beer with Adora's.

"Congrats, kid, you're one of us."

"Kid? There's no way you're older than me."

"Lonnie is ancient, older than time, wise the *exact* number of her years," Khyle said, grinning. Rogelio chuckled. Adora had heard him speak approximately twice and even that had been sparse.

Lawan put her hand on Khyle's face and shoved him back into the couch. "Shut the fuck up, Khalil." She suddenly pulled her hand away as if burned. "Did you lick me?" She launched into a rapid string of what Adora assumed were curses from how hard Rogelio was laughing. Even Catra snickered next to her.

"Don't tell me you speak Arabic, too."

"Nah, but they taught me the good stuff and holy shit you do not want to know what she just said about his mom."

--

Adora realized halfway through the night that Glimmer had not, in fact, gone overboard with the alcohol. It had been three months, and Adora was still amazed at just how much this crowd could drink. The party had since moved up to the terrace, leaving the kitchen counter full of empty bottles. While Catra had spent most of the party glued to her side, a fact that Adora found highly gratifying, she was now sitting on the bar with a guitar in her lap that seemed to have appeared out of nowhere and was taking requests.

"Wonderwall!"

"No."

"Toxic!"

"Hard no."

"Freeeeeeebiiiiiiiiird!"

"You guys suck."

"TOXIC!"

"Fuck off, Sparkles, I don't even know it."

"You're a goddamn liar."

"She is. I was there when she learned it."

"Shut up, Khyle."

"Have I ever told you how much I love Britney Spears and also how much this is my party?"

"I expected this from these idiots, but you, princess? You're better than this."

"I promise you that I am not."

"Give the princess her Britney!"

The crowd chorused their assent, breaking into a chant of *Toxic*, *Toxic*, *Toxic*.

“Fucking fine, you animals.”

Rolling her eyes, Catra began to strum a much slower version of the pop song. Adora was entranced. She hadn’t known that Catra played guitar in addition to singing until about ten minutes ago when the group had collectively decided that it needed to be serenaded.

Baby, can't you see I'm calling?

A girl like you should wear a warning

It's dangerous, I'm falling

Adora had heard Catra sing before, that was true, but never like this. Not so close, not outside and not struggling for breath in a crowded bar.

There's no escape, I can't wait

I need a hit, baby, give me it

You're dangerous, I'm loving it

She imagined what it would be like to have Catra sing to her, alone.

Too high, can't come down

Losing my head, spinnin' 'round and 'round

Do you feel me now?

Alone in her room, Catra's hair tousled, her lips plump and flush from –

The chorus interrupted Adora's reverie and she reluctantly joined the group in the singalong. Catra caught her eye and winked before starting on the second verse and Adora's insides flipped, relieved that the low light was kind enough to hide her glaring blush.

Before she knew it, the song was finished, and Catra was beckoning Khyle up to the bar. The latter had an ear-splitting grin on his face. The two launched into a routine that they had clearly done before if the cheers were any indication. Adora vaguely recognized the song from middle school.

8 o'clock, Monday night and I'm waitin'

To finally talk to a girl a little cooler than me

Her name is Nona, she's a rocker with a nose ring

She wears a two way, but I'm not quite sure what that means

And when she walks

All the wind blows and the angels sing

She doesn't notice me

Khyle had a pretty decent voice, actually. Catra leapt off the bar, earning a shriek from Glimmer, and joined Khyle for the chorus.

Cause she's watchin' wrestling

Creamin' over tough guys

Listenin' to rap metal

Turntables in her eyes

It's like a bad movie

She’s lookin' through me

If you were me, then you'd be

Screamin' someone shoot me

As I fail miserably

Tryna get the girl all the bad guys want

The two danced around each other, Khyle theatrically gesturing to Catra the whole time. Eventually, he flopped onto Lawan’s lap as if fainting. She tried to jostle him off, but he stayed firm, and Catra took over singing.

There she goes again

With fishnets on, and dreadlocks in her hair

She broke my heart, I wanna be sedated

All I wanted was to see her naked

Now I’m watchin' wrestling

Tryna be a tough guy

Listenin' to rap metal

Turntables in my eyes

I can't grow a mustache

And I ain't got no season pass

All I got's a moped

Catra finished out the song with a flourish, Lawan finally kicked Khyle onto the floor with a thump, and everyone whooped. Catra laid the guitar back in its case by the bar to a chorus of boos.

“That’s all you drunk assholes get without paying me.”

“Play Freebird!”

“Merve, control your dumbass.”

Catra flopped down next to Adora in a spot on the wicker loveseat recently vacated by Glimmer on the hunt for more drinks with Merve’s dumbass and draped her arm along the back. Adora was acutely aware of their knees touching. Despite pacing herself, her head was swimming from the alcohol, and she marveled how Catra never seemed to get too drunk despite drinking to match everyone else.

Perhaps unnerved by the silence, Catra asked, “’Sup?”

Adora jumped a little, “Oh, uh, hi!”

“You look a little drunk, princess.”

Adora snorted, “Absolutely not. I have never in my life been more sober.”

“Is that a fact?”

“The truest.”

“Okay, then stand up.”

“No. This is a trick. I don’t know how, but you are definitely tricking me.”

Catra rolled her eyes and stood up, offering her hand to Adora. “Shut up, I wanna take a walk and you’re coming with.”

Adora regarded the hand warily for a moment and then took it, allowing herself to be pulled to her feet. When she swayed, Catra wrapped an arm around her waist and steadied her. It turned out their walk was just to the other side of the terrace, an uncovered and unlit area with the clearest view of the sea. The two women leaned against the railing, Adora dismayed as Catra’s hand left her side but mostly assuaged that their forearms and shoulders were touching.

“Do you ever get used to it?” Adora asked, taking a deep breath of salty air.

“Get used to what?” Catra turned slightly and Adora could see her hazel eye.

“The sea. Just being right there and beautiful.”

Catra turned to the sea and thought for a few moments. “Yes and no. I don’t think about it every day, but sometimes when the light dances on the waves just right or I’m swimming late at night, it just hits me. The sea, this country, the fact that I live here, the enormity of it, y’know?”

Adora hummed. “When I was a kid. I used to dream about the sea. I grew up in the mountains and they were beautiful and all, but I felt trapped, hemmed in, I guess. I always thought that if I made it far enough east, I could get in a boat and sail far away. I didn’t know where, maybe France or Australia or the Bermuda Triangle, just anywhere. It sounds dumb now; I definitely would’ve been murdered.”

Catra hadn’t told Adora much about her childhood, but she sensed that the other woman understood when she placed her hand on hers and squeezed.

“It’s not dumb. I wanted to run away, too.”

Catra turned to fully face her and fixed her with a searching look. Adora stared back, her eyes bouncing between the other woman's eyes and lips. Maybe she was drunk, but she decided that it was time to go for it. She leaned closer, and her heart flipped when she saw Catra doing the same. Her eyes had just fluttered shut when she heard a jubilant shout of "Adora!" from across the terrace. Both Catra and Adora turned violently to the source of the noise to see Saliha peering at them through the darkness.

"Adora? Is that you? It is you!" Saliha jogged over and enveloped Adora in a tight hug. Dazed, Adora returned it.

"I'm so sorry I'm late! Your friends are *really* drunk. Hey, who's this?"

She dropped Adora and turned to Catra and gasped.

"Aslancım[2], is that you?"

"Selam, Akrep." Catra did not look particularly pleased to see the woman and looked even less pleased when she was swept up in a hug.

"This is crazy! How do you know Adora?"

"We're yabancıs, we all know each other."

Adora finally managed to shake off the wooden feeling in her limbs and mind and smiled.

"How do you two know each other?"

"Catra and I work at the same school." Saliha clamped an arm onto Catra's shoulders and Catra tolerated it for approximately ten seconds before shrugging it off. "She's always up in her fancy English room while I'm in the gym, but joke's on her cause I get to wear shorts!"

Adora blinked, her brain flashing its hazard lights. Hold on. No. The English teacher from America with black curly hair, the one

that was so cool and always making jokes, the one that Saliha was hopelessly in love with and couldn't bring herself to confess to could not possibly be the same woman that Adora had just been nano-seconds away from kissing. There must be dozens of American high school English teachers in this city. She must be imagining it.

One thing was certain, though, they needed to get back to the light and people before Adora gave herself an aneurism, so she forced a smile onto her face.

"Who wants a drink?"

--

When Adora had told people that she was quitting her lucrative job at the well-known if not necessarily well-respected firm that had plucked her straight out of law school, they had thought she was making a huge mistake. Adora had worked for a highly-successful criminal defense firm in New York City with a history of high-profile clientele that often proved to be of ill-repute. After six years with the firm, she had long since graduated from desk jockey to the courtroom, taking whatever role was thrown her way. She did well with judges, juries loved her, and she got on with the DA's office. Her affability and passion made her an asset, but the work was taxing. She worked long hours in the office and every moment not spent eating, sleeping, or working out was spent glued to her work laptop. She hadn't had many friends before, and even that number had dwindled since starting work. Those that were left were disappointed at the waste of her potential but begrudgingly understood that perhaps a move to a different practice might be better for her. It was clear to anyone that cared to look that while she was excelling at work, her personal life was non-existent and she was miserable.

When Adora had said that she was dumping her whole career in the trash to become a novelist, they had thought she was either possessed by a demon or experiencing an acute mental break. While the second was true in a sense, Adora had never felt so

sure of anything in her life. Sure, she'd spent countless hours striving for that life: a hard-won Valedictorian tassel on her high school graduation cap, a full-ride athletic scholarship to Dartmouth, summa cum laude from Columbia Law. This had been who she was, the model student and then employee, never slowing down to breathe or live. The only real joy she had felt was on the lacrosse field, and that she had given up when she started law school. But how could that life be worth it if she was actively making the world a worse place defending the clearly guilty? And for what? Her fancy apartment with a special spot to park her fancy car? Who was she kidding? She had spent most of life desperately pretending she belonged to this world, and she was sick of it.

Coasting on her decent savings, Adora had set her sights on her new dream and had spent a solid year staring blankly at her laptop willing the Great American Novel to appear. She had, at best, crapped out a couple of loathsome short stories and some unsatisfactory poems. Her friends from law school had not followed her into this new life, and Adora had finally been able to comprehend her total isolation now that she was free from the protective armor of tailored suits and unchecked ambition.

This new life was not working, either, she had realized with bitter disappointment. Ever practical, she had contacted a distant 'friend' from undergrad whom she knew worked in publishing. That friend had put her in touch with an agency that specialized in cheap paperbacks and attaching ghost writers to bigger names. The name she wrote under was Gwendolyn H. LeBlanc. Gwendolyn was a fictional woman with hundreds of romance novels to her name, an amalgamation of faceless and nameless authors to which Adora was the newest addition.

When Adora had made the choice to move to another country, it had been surprisingly easy. The lease on her Manhattan apartment had been due to finish. She had sold all of her furniture to some guy on Craigslist for less than what it was worth, but he had had a truck and had taken everything so Adora hadn't cared. She had sold her nearly new Audi to some rich kid's parents for a

steal. All of her professional clothes and shoes had gone to the women's shelter, and everything else had gone to various charities until she had been down to one suitcase. One suitcase and one small duffel full of books, a few sentimental items, and a folder with all of her papers. That had been her life. That was still her life.

But now there was something else. Hope. Hope that she hadn't wasted her life making a string of laughably bad decisions, hope that the restlessness that screamed *Trailer Trash Failure* within her might finally be calmed, hope that after so many years, everything could finally, *finally* be okay.

And for the first time, as Catra quietly sang to her on the terrace after everyone had gone home or passed out downstairs, Adora let herself truly believe in that hope.

You got a fast car

Is it fast enough so you can fly away?

You gotta make a decision

Leave tonight or live and die this way

Chapter End Notes

1. lahana sarması is rice and tomato paste and spices and sometimes meat wrapped tightly in cabbage leaves and my hot take is that it's better than the version in grape leaves[▲]

•

Aslancım: My lion. The cım is a a particle showing ownership, and when it's put on the end of a name, it's a term of endearment.
Selam, Akrep: Hi, scorpion. Akrep is also the word for the sign Scorpio.
yabancı: This is a word with a loooot of meaning. It directly

translates to stranger or foreigner. In this context, it's used for foreigner from another country. Also, I should note that I am aware that the plural form isn't correct if any Turkish speakers are reading this for some reason. [▲]

Spring pt. 2

Chapter Summary

> In the ruins of the bathhouse, Sea Hawk slipped her a flask of rum and she could've kissed him then and there.
> "You're a good man, Hawkins."
> "Anything for our brave heroine."
> "You gotta lay off the Joseph Campbell, man."
>
> --
>
> The kids go on a field trip.

Chapter Notes

> Update: I changed a piece of Feyza/Merve's exchange in Ch. 1.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Everyone made the most of May and the two weeks of pleasant weather between the driving rain of winter and the choking heat of the summer. One Saturday, Catra was convinced to join an 'expedition' to Termessos, an ancient city on top of a mountain not far from town. It wasn't as if she didn't like the outdoors or history or whatever, but she had been in Antalya for ages and was quite certain she had seen everything there was to see. However, instead of relaying this as per usual, Catra had agreed in less than a heartbeat when Adora had invited her to come with stars in those big blue eyes.

So here she found herself trudging up a never-ending hill of stairs and dirt slope with Adora, Sea Hawk, and Bo. The boys plus Adora took turns racing and climbing up boulders and jumping off, and it was mildly cute, but Catra chose to focus on the actual task of walking and not tumbling off a mountain to her death.

The group eventually reached the summit and entered the ancient city. The views were, of course, breath-taking, verdant green as far as the eye could see until mountains met the cloudless cobalt sky. Catra snapped a few pics of Adora posing and allowed a few to be taken of her in return.

In the ruins of the bathhouse, Sea Hawk slipped her a flask of rum and she could've kissed him then and there.

"You're a good man, Hawkins."

"Anything for our brave heroine."

"You gotta lay off the Joseph Campbell, man."

It was early in the season, so when they made their way to the massive amphitheater, they found they had the place to themselves. Catra took the opportunity to scramble up a few boulders, run up a leaning column, and hoist herself onto the highest wall. She made her way around the ruin until she got to a comfortable spot. The other three had already descended into the orchestra, but when Adora saw Catra, she grinned brightly and scanned around for a way up. Catra was mildly concerned for the integrity of Adora's neck were she to fall, but the other woman was quite athletic if a little unwieldy.

Eventually, Adora made her way over to Catra and plopped down next to her, the little hairs that had escaped her ponytail sticking to her forehead. Catra was suddenly very glad that she had agreed to come.

"Hey, Adora."

"Hey, Catra. Come here often?"

"Oh yeah, I never miss a show. They're doing *Oedipus Rex* tonight. I hear it's a real feel-good, family romp."

Bo looked at them and Catra thought he might have winked, but he was too far away to tell. He raised his arms and grinned.

"Welcome to Termessos, triumph of Bellerophon, tribute to Solymeus, the city in the sky that could not fall, not even to Alexander the Great." Despite being hundreds of meters away, his voice carried up to their lofty perch as if he were just below them.

He launched into a rundown of the city's history, starting from its origins in the *Iliad*, going through the stand-off with Alexander the Great, its independence from Rome, and its eventual abandonment when its system of aqueducts broke down. Sea Hawk stood on the stage behind him and provided dramatic re-enactment, performing exceptionally well when Bo detailed the betrayal of Antigonos.

The group caught the sunset perched on an outcrop of rocks overlooking a vast valley. Catra surreptitiously watched the changing colors reflected on Adora's cheeks from the corner of her eye. The woman looked so peaceful that Catra managed to tamp down the shrieking urge to gently take Adora's chin, tilt it to her, and bring their lips together. There had been so many opportunities for a perfectly cinematic first kiss, but it seemed that this was yet another one that was destined to be forgone. Instead, she allowed herself to be content with the ghost of contact from their thumbs touching where they lay splayed behind them.

The scramble back down the mountain in the last vestiges of light was incrementally more cautious than the ascent, though hopping down the steeper parts like goats was perhaps not the safest. Ankles unsprained and skulls unsplit, the four loaded into Sea Hawk's car and began the drive back into town.

About halfway there, Adora asked if they all wanted to get dinner together. Sea Hawk and Bo exchanged a devious grin in the front, and Catra turned to Adora with a smirk of her own.

"Come on, princess, did you really think we'd bring you all this way without feeding you?"

They drove along the coast until the city disappeared behind them. They eventually settled in what appeared to be a village with a surprising number of cars parked along the dirt road considering all the goats meandering only a few meters away. Adora looked mildly concerned, so Catra looped their arms together and took them down a hill and through the line of trees blocking the coast. When they emerged, they were greeted with a wave of music and laughter as well as the smell of seafood.

Before them stood a small, shack-like building that flanked a large, open seating area under a white tent. The place was packed, but Bo had been sage enough to make a reservation, so they were led to a formica table laminated with a collage of black-and-white pictures of the early days of the Turkish Republic and sat down.

"Any allergies or things you hate?" Catra asked.

"I will eat literally anything," Adora replied with a serious nod.

Catra's smile brightened, "That's my girl," she turned to Bo and Sea Hawk who were already standing again, "Godspeed, gentlemen." They saluted in unison and made their way to the shack.

Adora watched them for a moment and then predictably turned her gaze to the sea. Catra let her watch in silence, content to stare at the back of her head and imagine snapping that stupid hair tie and running her hands through the golden hair that would cascade down her neck like a waterfall. Eventually, Adora turned back, and Catra had to pretend that she was also taking in the scenery and not mentally pressing her lips to the back of the other woman's neck.

Luckily, Adora did not seem to find anything amiss and fixed Catra with an impossibly sweet smile.

"This place is nice. You always take me to such nice places. I don't think I've ever thanked you, so thank you."

Catra nearly choked on her own spit at the earnestness painted all over Adora's features, softened by the fairy lights draped around the tent. She hoped that she managed to smirk effectively around her blush and draped a lazy arm around the back of Adora's chair, "We'll see if you're still thanking me tomorrow."

Before Adora had a chance to answer, the boys reappeared followed by a waiter carrying a large bottle and a bucket of ice.

"Jesus, Hawkins, did you seriously get the 75cl? Are you trying to kill us?"

"I tried to talk him out of it, I swear." Bo held up his hands in defense. "We all know what happened the last time."

Catra leveled him with an earth-splitting glare, but before she could properly threaten his life, Adora popped in with, "What happened last time?"

"Nope."

"Our beloved Catra wounded herself most grievously."

"What?!"

"I did not!"

"Catra, you had a concussion."

"What are you, a doctor?"

"How did you get a concussion?"

"I did not get a concussion."

"Yes you did!"

"Tell me what happened!"

"No!"

“Pleeeeaaaasssssseeeee?”

Catra crossed her arms and glared at the three of them in succession, but when she got to Adora, she lingered on her wide eyes and exaggerated pout. When a hand gently rested on her bicep, Catra rolled her eyes.

“Okay fine. So last summer, Hawkins wanted to have a barbecue on the beach, so Khyle and I brought a big bottle of rakı assuming we were being good, hospitable guests. Nope, turns out everyone wanted beer, so Khyle and I drank the whole thing ourselves.”

“To be fair, no one made you drink the whole thing.”

“Shut up, Bo. I was pretty drunk and Khyle was barely awake, right? We must’ve gone back to Hawk’s place eventually cause at some point I woke up face down in the corner of his bathroom with a headache. Everything was double and spinning and shit. Then I went back out and everything was fine.”

“You skipped some parts.”

“No I didn’t.”

Bo’s grin widened further. The asshole. “What Catra failed to mention is that she came back out white as a ghost and sat in swaying silence for 30 minutes. When she came-to, she stole the remote and made us watch Charlie the Unicorn ten times in a row and ranted about some cartoon until 3 am. Didn’t you also say you fainted again when you were home that night?”

“First of all, *Aqua Teen Hunger Force* is not just some cartoon. Second of all, fuck you.”

“Why didn’t you go to a hospital?” Adora was staring in open-mouthed horror.

Catra shrugged. “Didn’t feel like it. I didn’t die, did I?”

Adora’s eyes narrowed.

“Okay, okay, okay. Who’s pouring?” Bo asked.

Catra perked up, “Me, obviously, you both suck ass at it.” She grabbed the glasses, the rakı, and the ice.

At some point during the story, Sea Hawk had turned around and was currently engaged in a lively conversation with a table of four guys behind them, so he had no objections.

Bo clutched at his chest, “You wound me.”

Catra rolled her eyes and turned to Adora. “Okay, princess, pay attention. There is a right way and a wrong way to do this, and if you’re ever gonna find yourself a respectable husband, you need to do it *right*.” Bo snorted, Catra grinned, and Adora looked confused.

“If you’re so good, where’s your husband, canım?” Bo asked.

“He went to Nicaea to fight the Byzantines, but I think he might have just wanted kebab.”

“Wait, we’re joking now, right?” Adora asked, a trace of panic in her voice.

“Wouldn’t you like to know?” Catra smirked and nudged her leg so that their knees and feet were touching. Adora shot her a tight smile, and when Bo stopped laughing, he smiled soothingly and said, “Yeah, we’re joking.”

“Anyway,” Catra said, “First the rakı.” Catra poured some into each glass.

“C’mon, give her a single.”

“We pour doubles in this house or else it’s like drinking Twizzler water. She’ll be fine, won’t you, Adora?”

“Uh, sure?”

“Attagirl. Now comes the water.” Catra glanced around. “Oi, Hawkins! Leave those people alone and give me the fucking water!” Sea Hawk turned from the table of new friends grinning. Catra noticed them staring openly at her and Adora and bristled.

“Say, I’ve been talking with these lads, and—“

“Absolutely fucking not.”

“But—“

“No.”

“Bo?”

“They look nice enough, I suppose,” Bo said carefully, eyes flicking between Catra and Sea Hawk.

“I said no. I’m not enduring another night with Sean Hawkins strays trying to get into my pants. Tell them no, and hand me the fucking water.” Catra had since leaned forward, positioning herself slightly in front of Adora.

Sea Hawk deflated slightly, turned to his new friends and gave his condolences, but not before collecting their numbers in his phone. Immediately back to himself and with nothing akin to shame, he turned back and handed Catra the massive water bottle. She cracked it open and handed it to Adora.

“All right, princess, your turn. Pour it up to about here. Not too full.” She tapped a nail near the rim of one of the tall, thin glasses. Adora nodded, and as if she were defusing a bomb, she gingerly poured the water, letting out a small squeak of delight when the liquid turned cloudy white. Catra placed a hand between the other woman’s shoulder blades, causing Adora to jump slightly and blush. “You’re a natural.”

Bo placed two ice cubes in each drink and passed them around. Adora sniffed at hers and wrinkled her nose. Everyone raised their glass.

“To Adora’s first meyhane night,” Catra offered.

“May it be one of many,” Bo added.

“Huzzah!” Sea Hawk added.

“Şerefe!” They clinked and Bo and Catra took a small sip each and then a sip of water. Sea Hawk drained his drink, and Adora was about to do the same when Catra stopped her.

“Whoa, slow down. Ignore Hawkins, he’s insane. Here, drink some water.” Adora sipped at the water shoved into her hands, looking as if she were trying to suppress a gag. *Dork,* Catra thought fondly.

As if on cue, two waiters appeared with two trays laden with food and began the tetris game of arranging the small white bowls around the table. Another waiter appeared with a steaming plate of calamari, a huge grilled fish, and a bucket of mussels.

While the boys loaded up their plates, Catra explained to Adora what everything was, Bo interjecting as needed. Adora looked like she was on cloud nine as she sampled the different plates and the perfectly cooked seafood.

As they ate, Catra watched Adora’s increasing excitement out of the corner of her eye. She glanced at Bow who shot her a bright grin and a kissy face. Meanwhile, Sea Hawk regaled them all with a tale of the last time he sailed his boat to Greece. She’d heard it a thousand times before, but Adora seemed interested, so she let him go.

When he finished, he flashed Catra a mischievous grin, and Catra narrowed her eyes.

“You know,” he said with feigned casualness, “Catra has made quite an adventurous first mate in the past.” Catra’s eyes widened and she aimed the hardest kick she could to Sea Hawk’s shins under the table. He made a noise of pain and took in the withering glare from Catra that threatened unspeakable acts.

Luckily, he seemed to ascertain the actual truth of the threat and his eyes left Catra's for a moment to glance at a curious-looking Adora who happily chewed around a too-big bite.

"I, uh," he began carefully as Catra's eyes narrowed until they were nearly closed. If he dared tell *that* story, she would tie rocks to his tacky boots, kick him into the harbor, and watch until the bubbles stopped. Bo stared at his plate. Adora seemed to sense a shift and swallowed her food with a sip of rakı.

"I simply wish to delight us all with the tale of Catra and I's adventure to Cyprus." Catra let her hackles lower and loosened the grip on her fork. Apparently emboldened by the lack of harm to his lower half, Sea Hawk continued, "Weather was fair until we were beset with the mother of all storms."

Adora looked riveted. With considerable effort, Catra continued eating.

"So there we were, buffeted on all sides by wind and sea spray, Poseidon himself rising from the Mediterranean as if it were I who blinded his favorite son!" Sea Hawk's arms flew around wildly. "I called to Catra, ' secure the sails, first mate, have faith! This will not be our final night!' My dutiful mate whipped up the mainsail like a cat and bravely tied down the sails. Yea, without her, I truly would be lost.'" Catra snorted. Sea Hawk clutched his breast. "I clung to the wheel with all my strength, begging Palaemon for the succor of quiet seas, but, alas, my prayers fell on deaf ears and the wrath of Oceanus flung me from my post. When all seemed lost, my mate found me, a blessed vision of Soteria herself, and dragged me back to the wheel."

Adora made a quiet noise and Catra glanced over to see her hiding a laugh behind a fist while she nodded enthusiastically. Catra bit back her own grin, the anger from before melting away.

"With her strength bolstering mine, I held fast. After hours of raging sea where my mate and I said our final prayers and in the same breath cursed the gods we had so enraged, the storm

blessedly broke and we fell to the deck in tearful ecstasy. Never have I felt such joy when my weary legs hit land, the foreign land below me all at once the only home I had ever known." Sea Hawk closed his story with a solemn bow, standing up to avoid the restriction of the table.

Catra saw that Bo was sitting there with a tight smile, his knitted brows making him look constipated.

"Say it, man."

"Oh, it's nothing.

Catra pressed, "Dude, please, for the love of god, say it."

"Oceanus is the god of one specific river! A fresh-water one! He wouldn't be on the Mediterranean!"

Adora broke and let out a peal of hysterical laughter.

"He got Palaemon right," Bo said sheepishly.

Adora just laughed harder, burying her face in her hands and shaking with gasping laughs. Unable to resist, Catra clapped her on the back and joined in. Sea Hawk frowned slightly before laughing boisterously, not quite grasping that it was at his expense.

The rest of the meal was mostly uneventful. Catra quit drinking after her first one, having drawn the short straw on driving. The other three made the most of their freedom and wasted no time getting well and truly shit-faced. Catra attempted to get Adora to pace herself, but the woman was determined to match at least Bo. At least she seemed to understand that attempting to drink with Sea Hawk would result in a trip to the ER. To Catra's dismay, another bottle, albeit smaller, was ordered and consumed with a tray of fresh fruit and cheese.

When Adora started throwing grapes into Bo's mouth, she decided that it was time to leave before they got kicked out, something

she wouldn't usually care about, but she *liked* this place. She managed to pay the bill with an especially clingy Adora in tow. On the way there, they ran into the owner, a bear of a man that pulled Catra into a crushing hug and greeted her in enthusiastic Bulgarian.

When she had first started coming years back, the man had found out about her heritage, and she had never been able to truly convince him that she didn't secretly speak the language. It wasn't her fault that her mother hadn't bothered to teach her. The man eventually released her and Adora had her translate a message in Turkish along the lines that this was the best night of her life and she wished him all the money and fresh fish in the world.

Catra couldn't help but preen a little at the indirect praise as she herded Adora and the boys back to the car. Within moments of motion, Bo and Sea Hawk fell asleep on each other in the backseat. Adora appeared to follow suit, so Catra rolled down the window, plugged her phone into the aux, and settled in for the hour drive.

"Love this song," Catra heard a murmur from the slumped woman beside her. Apparently she wasn't quite alone yet. She smiled and turned it up a bit. Adora hummed contentedly.

With effort, Catra trained her eyes back onto the road. "You don't strike me as a Placebo kinda gal."

"Mm, 'm full of secrets." Catra felt a pressure and looked over to see Adora's hand on top of hers where it rested on the gear shift. Catra raised her eyebrows and glanced at Adora whose eyes were shut.

Adora fell asleep soon after, and Catra was left to panic in peace. About 20 minutes into a fierce debate with herself over what Adora could have possibly meant by secrets and grabbing her hand, it became abundantly clear to Catra that this was absolutely fucking *ridiculous*. They were both grown-ass women and they

were both acting like shy teenagers. It was time for someone to make a move already. Not that night, of course, no, preferably a night where neither of them was blackout drunk.

Eventually, Catra pulled up to Bo's place, woke him up, and shoved him out of the car. On his way out, she demanded that he text her when he got upstairs.

"Catraaaaa? Caaaaaring about meeeeee? More likely than you think!"

"I take it back. I hope you pass out in the elevator."

She still waited until he was inside the building before driving the few blocks to Sea Hawk's building. On the way out of the car, he stumbled and nearly fell on his face.

"Fuck," Catra mumbled and turned to Adora, "Be right back."

She hopped out of the car and positioned herself under Sea Hawks arm. He relaxed into her, and she groaned. "Come on, jackass, let's get you inside." On the way to the door, Catra fished his keys out of his pocket and unlocked the gate. She hauled him up the one flight of stairs and unlocked his apartment.

The door swung open to a surprised Merve who quickly morphed into an irritated Merve.

"Ugh, how much did he drink this time?"

Catra dumped Sea Hawk onto the couch and shrugged. "I dunno. I wasn't counting, but we had a 75 of rakı and he polished off the second 50 pretty much by himself." Merve scoffed.

"He's an idiot when he drinks."

"He's an idiot when he's sober."

"True. Thanks for bringing him up."

Catra shrugged again, “Gotta do what you gotta do.”

“You want tea or something? Feyza's out for the night if you want to stay in her room.” Merve headed to the kitchen and filled up a glass with water.

“Can’t, Mermaid. I’ve got Adora in the car. Also, tell him he can come get his car at my place.”

Merve smirked, “What’s the deal with you and the new girl anyway?” She came to stand over Sea Hawk.

“None of your business, *boss*.”

Catra moved to leave. As she closed the apartment door, she heard a splash and a shriek and smiled.

By the time she got back into the car, Adora seemed to have perked up a bit.

“That was nice of you.”

Catra felt like she had been doing a lot of shrugging lately. She pulled onto the road. “It’s nothing. Hawk’s helped me out when I was drunk a million times.”

“Oh yeah?” Adora cocked her head.

“You may find it hard to believe, princess, but I was not always the suave paragon of maturity you see before you.” Adora snorted. “Shut up. I used to have some trouble with limits, especially when I first got here. I was pretty young, right out of college. Everyone drank constantly and we did whatever we could get our hands on, which is a surprising amount of stuff. Back when I worked at the cram school, I would go in in the morning still drunk or messed up from the night before then go back and join everyone a few hours later and keep partying til my evening classes.”

“Holy shit,” Adora said.

“Yeah, it wasn’t a good look. Back then, it was me and the boys, eventually Sparkles, and a couple others who moved on.”

“Moved on to where?”

“Other countries, back home, wherever. People don’t really stay here. You learn not to get too attached when you like someone,” Catra said with a little bit of bite.

“Oh,” Adora said, looking at her lap.

“Anyway, Sea Hawk carried me home more times than I can count. Bo, too. I’m just trying to return the favor.”

A few minutes later, Adora piped up, “Y’know. I didn’t do anything with my twenties. All I did was study and study so I could get into law school. And then studied some more to get a good job. And then I worked and worked and worked at this awful, soul-sucking job, and for what? I couldn’t stand it anymore and I moved halfway across the world like a rebellious teen with a passport. I mean, look at you, you’ve lived so much life. I just sorta feel like I’ve wasted mine.”

Catra hummed, “I’m not sure about all that.”

“About what?”

“Well, think of it this way. Some of us have shitty pasts – mine’s not exactly the gold standard you seem to think it is – but it has led us to where we are right now. Did you have fun today?”

Adora smiled. “Yeah. I had a lot of fun today.”

“Maybe that’s good enough.”

“Maybe.” Adora gazed out the window, smiling. Catra settled into the companionable silence.

“Do you have plans right now?” Adora asked, an anxious edge to her voice.

Catra laughed, “It’s 2 am. Why, what did you have in mind?”

Adora shrugged. “I dunno.”

“I was probably gonna watch something and go to bed. You’re welcome to join.”

“You sure?” Adora appeared to be second-guessing her own boldness.

“You’re doing me a favor. Now I don’t have to drive you across town and put you to bed in the highest tower of Bright Manor.

Adora huffed. “I could make it inside. I am very sober right now. Sober as a…what is it? A jaybird?”

“Jaybird’s are naked, princess. We’re here.” Catra parked on the street, pulled the brake, and hopped out. She watched as Adora got out too fast and lurched. When she steadied herself and took off in the wrong direction, Catra suppressed a laugh.

“That one,” she said and pointed to a lime green building and then opened the trunk to grab their bags.

“I knew that.”

“Of course you did.”

When they got to the gate, Adora demanded that Catra relinquish the bags to her and pouted when Catra only gave her the lighter one. They made it up the stairs while Adora attempted to convince Catra of her nigh-Herculean strength and how she could easily carry five, *no ten!* bags up any amount of stairs. Catra had seen those arms and shoulders in action and didn’t doubt it for a moment, but she still wasn’t giving up the bag.

The apartment was dark, but Khyle’s shoes were there, so Catra told Adora to be quiet, clicked on a light, and placed her on the couch. She went to her room and dumped their bags and was rummaging around for something for Adora to wear when she

sensed herself being watched. She looked up to see Adora standing awkwardly in the doorframe.

"Has anyone ever told you you're clingy when you're drunk?"

Adora shuffled slightly and frowned. "Sorry."

Catra smiled and tossed her a t-shirt and shorts. Adora flailed a bit but caught them and regarded them with a furrowed brow.

"They're clothes. You wear them."

Adora nodded, entered the room properly and stripped out of her tank top and cargo shorts. *Cargo shorts, honestly*, Catra thought and then had the presence of mind to turn around with a slight blush. She quickly took off her own clothes, hesitating when she got to her sports bra. She peeled it off and swiftly donned a clean tee shirt and a pair of boxers. She turned back to find Adora watching her who immediately turned away with a cough and bright cheeks of her own.

Chivalry is bullshit, she thought, grabbing the pillows and thin blankets off of her bed and stalking into the living room. Adora joined her as she pulled up Netflix. She sat a respectable distance away and Catra was a mix of relieved and inordinately disappointed.

"Any requests?"

"Huh?" Adora was staring down at the logo on her shirt that read 'Cathedral Catholic High School Irish'.

"Movie? TV show? Documentary?"

Adora ignored the question and fingered the material. "It's so soft. Is this from your high school?"

"Sure is."

Adora looked surprised, "You went to Catholic school?"

“What? Can’t imagine me in a plaid skirt?”

“No, I can,” Adora blushed and spluttered, “I mean… I had to wear a uniform in high school, too.”

Catra was highly amused. “Y’know, I’m not even technically Catholic. According to some paper hidden in my mother’s closet, I was baptized Orthodox. Not that it matters, but it’s funny cause when I was little, my mother conned a Catholic school into giving her a job by telling them that she had to flee Bulgaria ‘cause they really hated Catholics there. Fed them this sob story about how her husband was murdered for it and that’s why she was a single mother. It’s not like they could find Bulgaria on a map, and what religious type doesn’t love a good persecution story? So they bought it hook, line, and sinker and didn’t even ask for teaching credentials. Now, I’ve never been to Bulgaria, but I don’t think they’re going around burning Catholics at the stake.”

Adora giggled. Catra was not usually too keen on talking about her mother, but she wasn’t convinced Adora would even remember this in the morning. Besides, the way that Adora always listened so carefully to whatever she had to say like it was the most important thing in the world made her feel all warm and fuzzy. So sue her for monologuing a little.

“She was really dedicated to the bullshit, too. We went to church on Sundays and volunteered all the time. Almost every day after school, we watered the flowers in the church. Or, well, I did. She would do whatever it was she did in the offices. I was expressly forbidden from whatever sinister shit that she was up to, so I took the keys and wandered around. It was nice in its way, a big empty building with stained glass windows. Peaceful. Fun fact, the first time I got drunk was off of communion wine I nicked from the storage room when I was 12.”

Adora barked out a laugh, “You did not.”

“I nabbed it and squirreled it away for a while, and then this girl I was obsessed with started dating this boy in our class, and I was

real pressed ‘cause how dare she date this boy I suddenly decided I had a crush on.”

“The nerve!”

“I know! How dare she not be in love with *me*! So obviously the only solution was cranking up some Evanescence and drowning my sorrows in piss-grade communion wine.”

Adora’s laughter was high and bright and it melted Catra’s heart. Adora shifted so that she was laying with her head next to Catra’s thigh and her legs hanging off the arm of the couch.

“Well, well, look who’s finally laughing at my stories.”

Adora gazed up at her. “I always laugh at your stories. You’re funny.”

Catra flicked Adora’s nose. “No you don’t. You usually just stare like I grew another head.”

“I mean, sometimes you say a story is funny, and the way you tell it is funny, but at the core it’s more, like, concerning.”

Catra’s first instinct was to get annoyed, but she smothered it. Instead she drummed her fingers on Adora’s forehead. “And just how do you suggest I tell my stories, princess?”

Adora frowned. “That’s not what I meant. It’s just that you deal with bad stuff that happened to you in a way I’m not used to. When I hear about it, like the time that guy took your umbrella or when you got roofied by your coworker –“

“Hey, my roofie story is gold.”

“—I know you’re telling a story and you’re laughing and everyone’s laughing and it’s funny, but you shouldn’t be telling it cause it shouldn’t’ve happened in the first place! Not to you, and it makes me so mad that no one was there to help you. Like, you had all these friends, but when it mattered, you were alone. Ugh,

I’m not explaining this well. Just forget it, I’m sorry.” Adora buried her face in her hands.

Catra stared down at her, unsure whether to be offended at the implication that she was helpless or touched that Adora cared that much. What gave her pause and stopped her from saying something nasty was that this little drunken outburst did not seem to come from pity but from something that Catra couldn’t quite identify. She’d received plenty of righteous indignation as a response to her stories before she learned to frame them exclusively as humorous anecdotes. However, people didn’t get embarrassed when they got angry on behalf of what they perceived to be the just cause of her victimhood.

This was something else entirely.

“Adora?”

Adora peeked an eye from between her fingers.

Catra softened her voice as much as possible. “What are you trying to say?”

Adora slowly removed her hands from her face and snuck a glance at Catra before turning her head to stare into the distance. Catra’s hands itched to touch her but were held in her lap patiently. Catra had just started to wonder if Adora had fallen asleep when she began to speak in a soft voice.

“I don’t usually tell people this, but my mom had a drinking problem. When I was a kid, I didn’t really notice it. Most of the adults drank and kids started early where I was, so it seemed normal. She struggled, though. Sometimes it was okay and she would be home. Then sometimes it wasn’t and I wouldn’t see her for days and then I’d find her passed out somewhere. She had this on and off boyfriend who was an asshole, but when they were together, at least I knew where she was. He didn’t like me much.”

Adora paused and took a deep breath. Catra was silent, but she hazarded putting her hand on Adora's shoulder and was not shrugged off.

"One day, I found her on the lawn. She looked dead, so I called 911. She wasn't, but she had to stay in the hospital for a while. I felt so guilty. I should've been able to help her. I wouldn't let my neighbors help as some form of penance I guess, so I wasn't eating much cause there wasn't any food. The school counselor started making lunch for me every day and having me over to her house, making it seem like I was helping her out. How pathetic is that? Meanwhile, my mom was getting worse. She lost her job at the supermarket. She left the stove on once and set the trailer on fire. CPS almost took me away for that one. We managed, though. We always managed."

Catra placed her hand on the side of Adora's head, gently stroking the hair there. Adora paused, reached back, and pulled her hair loose. Catra hesitated for a moment before sliding her fingers into the soft blonde tresses and giving her scalp an experimental scratch. Adora pressed into the touch and continued.

"The counselor knew the headmaster of this fancy prep school in Massachusetts and somehow managed to get me in with a full scholarship. My mom didn't want me to go, and I almost didn't, but I needed to get out of there. I promised that I'd call her every day and come back when I could, but that didn't last long. She stopped picking up and I stopped calling. The next time I talked to her, she told me not to bother coming home for Thanksgiving, and then Christmas break, so I just stayed at the school until Glimmer started bringing me to her family's house for holidays.

One day senior year, I got called to the headmaster's office. I panicked, thinking I was in trouble, that something was wrong with my uniform. I was really obsessed with my uniform. The headmaster was a nice woman, but she looked so uncomfortable. She told me that my mom had been in an accident. I asked if she was okay." Adora's robotic voice broke into irritation. "It was a stupid question. Of course she wasn't. Why would I have been

there if she was okay? I mean, I thought maybe she was in the hospital again, but no, she was dead. They kept using that phrase 'passed on' as if she'd gone somewhere else. Somewhere other than a pine box in the dirt."

Adora scoffed and went silent while Catra played with her hair. After a moment, she rolled onto her back and stared at the ceiling. Catra watched her brow unknit and her expression soften into grief. When those brilliant blue eyes filled with tears, Catra gently clasped the sides of the woman's head and maneuvered it onto her lap. Adora looked up at her and flashed a tired smile.

"You know, I blamed myself for it for years. I wasn't there. I'd left. I could've done something. Made her go to rehab. I mean, we never could've afforded rehab, but you know what I mean. She didn't deserve to die like that. She didn't deserve to live like that. And I abandoned her to go pretend to be something I wasn't with a bunch of rich kids. While I was eating whatever I wanted from Glimmer's family's private chef, she was alone in a trailer with a bottle of whiskey. Left behind by all she had left. Logically, I know you can't blame a 14-year-old for all that, but part of me still believes that if she had had someone to help her, things could've been different."

Adora paused to stare into Catra's eyes and swallowed. She looked terribly earnest.

"Everyone deserves someone to help them. I hate that you didn't have that."

Catra felt herself wilting under Adora's gaze, overwhelmed by the emotion behind her words, overwhelmed by the story, overwhelmed by the eyes boring into hers. Catra felt that she had just born witness to something, had become privy to sacred knowledge, and she had no idea how to respond other than to hold the impenetrable gaze radiating from her lap.

Finally, she willed herself to speak. She placed a hand on Adora's cheek. "I think I understand." Adora closed her eyes and nuzzled

into Catra's palm, pressing a tiny kiss into it.

"Thank you," she breathed.

Catra quirked a brow, her palm burning. "For what?"

"Listening."

"Anytime," she choked out around the fluttering heat expanding her chest. And there it was again, that traitorous urge to lean down and capture Adora's lips in her own, to communicate how much she cared and how honored she felt to be granted access to Adora's inner world. Instead, she smiled, hopefully not too dopily and grabbed the remote.

"Movie, show, or documentary?"

This time, Adora didn't ignore the question. She opened her eyes and smiled a sleepy smile. "I don't care. Something stupid, please."

Catra briefly clicked through titles and settled on a sitcom.

A few minutes in, Adora said. "Could we, uh, feel free to say no…"

"Spit it out, princess."

"Lay down? Both of us? At the same time?"

Catra rolled her eyes but smiled and jostled Adora off her lap. She stretched out and raised her arm in invitation. Adora hesitated.

"I'm taller."

"And?"

"I wanna be the big spoon."

Catra sighed dramatically and scooched forward. Adora hummed happily and wedged herself between Catra and the couch and wrapped an arm around the other woman's waist. Catra used her

feet to pull a sheet over them and relished in the protective warmth enveloping her, though one would be hard pressed to get her to admit it. One would also be hard pressed to get her to admit that she forced her eyes to stay open so she could enjoy the body pressed to her, the steady heartbeat against her ribcage, or the warm breath tickling her neck. She barely made it 20 minutes before she drifted off to sleep.

--

When Catra awoke the next morning, her hazy brain was made to process several things at once. First, she was being held in a death grip. Second, one of the hands of that death grip had migrated north under her shirt and was clutching her ribcage. Third, Khyle's grinning face was mere inches from hers. She chose to focus on the third and fixed Khyle with the hardest glare she could manage with unfocused eyes. He waved from his spot crouched on the floor wearing nothing but his boxers and mouthed *Hi bise*. She countered with a pithy *Fuck off*. Undaunted, Khyle pointed at Adora and made a kissy face plus a scissoring gesture for good measure. Catra felt Adora stir behind her and felt the hand under her shirt graze the bottom of her right breast. Khyle's grin somehow grew when Catra absolutely did not blush at the contact. *So cute* he mouthed and put his hands on his cheeks. *I hate you*, Catra replied, *Go away*. Khyle laughed silently, mouthed *Love you too* and stood up to leave but not before tweaking Catra's nose and leaving her seething.

She settled down a bit when the body behind her mumbled something into her hair and sighed. She even managed to ignore how boiling hot she was and the uncomfortable pressure in her bladder. However, she couldn't ignore nature's call forever, so she carefully attempted to extricate herself from her limbed prison. This was apparently unacceptable to sleeping Adora who yanked her back and squeezed tighter.

Fucking ridiculous, Catra thought fondly and tried again. This time she managed to escape and pad to the bathroom. She passed Khyle in the kitchen making coffee. "Put on some pants, you

fucking animal," she whispered. Khyle blew her a kiss. When she finished in the bathroom, she returned to the living room to find Adora sitting up and looking sheepish.

Catra sat down next to her. "Hey, Adora."

"Hey. I didn't do anything stupid last night, did I?"

Catra laughed, somewhat hollowly, "No more so than usual." She found it difficult to believe that Adora didn't remember their long conversation last night. She had seemed pretty sober by the end. It didn't stop the pang of disappointment.

Before Adora could answer, Khyle appeared with a whole-ass tray and plunked it down on the coffee table. Catra noticed that he had thankfully put on a pair of pajama pants though they were covered in little hearts which Catra took as a dig. He also had not put on a shirt.

"Hi Adora, want some coffee?"

Adora stopped blinking furiously and responded, "Hi Khyle. Yes, coffee would be great."

"Milk? Sugar?"

"Yes and one cube."

Khyle made a show of pouring the coffee into three mugs, adding milk to all three and a cube of sugar to one. He handed the mug to Adora with a flourish and bow. He made to hand one to Catra, but she grabbed the one on the tray before he could have the satisfaction.

"Why are you like this?"

"I'm being hospitable. This is very important to my culture and you are being very insensitive right now. The real question is why are Americans like this?"

Catra rolled her eyes and sipped her coffee. Adora chuckled. *Traitor*.

"Besides," Khyle continued, "Last time I had a guest, you made Turkish coffee for everyone."

"That was different."

"Yeah it was. You put salt in his drink instead of sugar."

"I stand by that. He was gross and needed to leave."

"Can't argue there."

The three chatted as they drank their coffee. Catra had to admit that it was nice that Adora and Khyle got along. Eventually, though, Adora began the awkward dance of leaving. She changed back into her shorts from yesterday and when Catra insisted she just wear her shirt home, Adora promised she would wash it and return it as soon as possible. Catra gave her directions on how to get home and Adora insisted that she didn't need to be walked to the bus stop. Then it was time. They both stood uncomfortably in the doorway, unsure how to proceed. Eventually, Adora wrapped her arms around Catra and whispered *Thank you* in her ear. Catra sputtered and hugged her back. After lingering a few moments too long, Adora pulled away, grabbed her bag, and disappeared down the stairs.

Catra stood stunned for a few moments but eventually returned to the living room where Khyle regarded her with an amused expression.

"So, how was it?"

"How was *what*?" Catra plopped down on the couch with a huff.

"You know. Give your best buddy some details."

Catra rolled her eyes. "Oh fuck off. Nothing happened."

“Whyyyyyyyyyyy?” Khyle whined.

“She was really drunk last night. I was being, you know, classy or whatever.”

“Aw, Bise, that’s sweet. Can I ask you a question?”

“Can I stop you?”

Khyle tapped his chin as if thinking. “Was she touching your boob when you were cuddling this morning?”

Catra groaned loudly. “What are you, 10? Also, what was with the coffee thing?”

Khyle shrugged. “Everyone likes coffee.”

“You have literally never brought coffee for anyone who woke up here ever, including me. Especially not on a fucking tray.” Catra narrowed her eyes.

“I like Adora. She’s the only person you’ve ever brought home that wasn’t terrible.”

“I didn’t ‘bring her home’. She was drunk. We slept. End of story. She’s in the friend group. Friends sleep on our couch all the time.”

Khyle fixed her with an incredulous stare. “Whatever you say, Bise.”

Chapter End Notes

> Howdy. No footnotes today. It took me years to get the hang of drinking rakı without overdoing it and blacking out or getting a concussion or both.
>
> Next week, get ready to sweat because it's finally summer.
>
> As per, let me know what you think. If you have any questions/comments/concerns, head on down to the comments section.

Summer pt. 1

Chapter Summary

"Catra?"
"Hmm?"
"You never told me where we're going."
"We're going camping, dummy."
"I feel like this is an elaborate plot to murder me."
Catra shrugged. "It might be."

--

Some different kids go on a field trip.

Chapter Notes

This week is going to be a double-header. Chapters 5 and 6 were originally supposed to be together, but it ended up at about 15k words, so I split them. Ch. 6 will post on Tuesday.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

O wind, rend open the heat,

cut apart the heat,

rend it to tatters.

Fruit cannot drop

through this thick air —

fruit cannot fall into heat

that presses up and blunts

the points of pears

and rounds the grapes.

Cut the heat —

plough through it,

turning it on either side

of your path.

"Heat", H.D., 1915

Summer descended on Antalya with all the aplomb of a duvet soaked in boiling water. The morning before, Adora had woken up with the sun and had gone on a run as she did every day. She had spent the whole run giddy for the afternoon trip to Termessos. She couldn't have imagined the fun she would have at the meyhane or that she would be spending the night at Catra's. She hadn't imagined how they would laugh and talk 'til nearly dawn, how kind and soft Catra would be as she poured out the carefully-guarded tale of her mother, how wonderful she had felt in her arms.

Today, she wanted to reflect on the unbelievable events of the night prior, but instead, she was melting in the early afternoon sun at a bus stop, sweating through the shirt that Catra had given her. The humidity settled against her chest like an unwelcome hug, pressing the air out of her lungs while sweat stung her eyes. She knew that it was going to be hot, but this was *unreasonable*.

Her bus arrived and Adora peeled herself off of the bench to get on it. Adora took some solace in how miserable everyone else looked in the sudden heat and grabbed the over-hanging bar. Twenty minutes later, she sighed into the air-conditioning of the building. When she entered the apartment, she was greeted by Bo

and Glimmer who attempted to seem casual on the couch but had clearly been waiting for her.

She dropped her bag at the door and nearly ran to the fridge to chug water. She was still hungover, after all.

“Are you okay over there, buddy?” she heard Bo ask. She flashed a thumbs up and continued in her quest to slake her thirst. She finished with a loud *Ah!* and grabbed her bag again. She was on her way upstairs, when she heard Glimmer say, “Hey, Adora? Could you come here for just, like, a second?”

Adora turned around and regarded them warily. They were grinning at her. Adora took a deep breath as if readying herself to face a firing squad and went to sit on the opposite couch.

“What’s up?”

“You know what’s crazy?” Glimmer asked, clearly rhetorically as she continued, “I’ve known you for what, 15 years now? Since the first day of high school. We had a lot of good times, right? All the late nights talking, watching movies and VH1 and sneaking out to the mall. All the laughter and the tears. You know, good times. And you know that I was thinking that since I wasn’t invited to your little meyhane night, I got a great night of sleep. Now that I think about it, I didn’t drink at all last night which means I must be sober. So you have to set me straight here, did we really go to *Cathedral Catholic High School*?”

Bo giggled. Adora sighed.

“Catra loaned it to me cause my clothes were gross from hiking. It’s not a big deal.”

“It’s kind of a big deal.” Glimmer replied.

“I didn’t know Catra went to Catholic school.” Bo mused.

“Really? Haven’t you known her for years?”

"Catra doesn't talk about her life before Turkey much. She's got this whole intriguing and mysterious vibe." Glimmer shrugged. "It's really similar to this other girl I know whose life apparently began in law school even though I have it on good authority that we've known each other for a *decade and a half*."

Adora crossed her arms. "You know I did literally nothing but study and play lacrosse for like 8 years solid."

"I know! And look at you now! Coming home at noon after *finally* getting laid. Like, it is insane how long this took you. I set this up for you. Have I told you that? I set it up. I thought to myself, you know what would get Adora out of her funk? Getting laid. And who better with than the hottest bitch on the Mediterranean, Ekaterina Primov?"

Adora stewed. "We didn't have sex."

"Seriously?!"

"Has it ever occurred to you that maybe Catra and I are just friends that enjoy hanging out together?"

"It has not!"

Bo put his hand on Glimmer's thigh, sensing that this might be getting out of hand.

"What Glimmer means is that she's happy that you made a friend."

"That's not what I mean *at all*!"

"Hush, love. Adora, I think we're all confused because you and Catra seem, well, smitten with each other."

Adora pursed her lips and sunk further into the couch. So what if she was 'smitten' with Catra? What business of that was theirs? All she wanted to do was take a shower, maybe a nap, spend some time rubbing Catra's impossibly soft and comfortable shirt on her

cheek, and get some work done. These were all perfectly normal and acceptable activities for one to do when they were very hungover on a Sunday afternoon, yet here she was getting interrogated on a couch.

"Look," Adora sighed and relaxed a bit, "I like her. A lot. More than I've liked anyone in a long time. We're getting to know each other."

Both Glimmer and Bo softened. Bo said, "Aw, Adora. We were just taking the piss a little. You and Catra can go at whatever pace makes you comfortable. Right, Glim?"

Glimmer harrumphed. "*I guess*." She sighed. "No, he's right. Do what you want, how you want, you're a grown-up. But also, please don't torture yourself? I know that's one of your favorite leisure-time activities, but don't do it just this once, as a favor to me? Your amazing friend who just wants the best for you?"

Adora smiled in spite of herself. "Okay fine." Bo stood up and extended his arms for a hug. Adora and Glimmer joined him and the three hugged it out. Glimmer wrinkled her nose at Adora's odor but opted not to say anything.

They released and Adora went to head upstairs. Before she disappeared, she turned back and said, "Hey, guys? Can I ask something?"

"Yeah?" Bo answered.

"Why is it so hot?"

They both burst out laughing.

--

It got hotter. It was hot at every hour of every day. It was slightly less hot at dawn when she ran, but she still came home winded and drenched as if she had just come in from a downpour. For the

first time, she questioned why exactly she had chosen to move to what was apparently a hellmouth.

When Adora had offhandedly mentioned this to Catra one day while they were getting lunch, she had perked up, grinned, grabbed her phone, and had begun typing furiously. A few days later, Adora had been informed that she was going camping. When she had protested that she didn't have a tent or equipment of any sort, she had been told to shut up and be ready to go at 3 pm that Thursday.

Now that Catra had finished the school year, these kinds of things had become common. The other day, Catra had shown up outside her apartment at 11 at night with a black bag full of beers to inform her that they were going swimming. Adora had been a little reticent at first – it was dark and what if something touched her foot – but she had, of course, relented. They had sat on the sand and drunk until Catra had pulled her into the water. Adora had braced for the cold but instead found the water to be the temperature of a bathtub. They had floated lazily in the salty water for hours talking about nothing, laughing too loud, and getting sloshed. Occasionally, their limbs had brushed together and Adora's stomach had flipped. She felt like a teenager or a heroine in a Romantic novel.

In much the same way, Adora found herself packed into the backseat of a car with Catra and Khyle with Lawan up front and Rogelio driving. Catra was playing with her phone while Lawan and Khyle argued back and forth in Arabic. Adora wasn't even sure where they were going.

"Catra?"

"Hmm?"

"You never told me where we're going."

"We're going camping, dummy."

"I feel like this is an elaborate plot to murder me."

Catra shrugged. “It might be.”

“Why won’t you just tell me?”

“It’s a surprise. You like my surprises.”

“I guess, but—“

Adora was cut off by Lawan’s sudden shout of, “Call me teyze[1] one more time, you piece of shit!”

Adora turned to look at Khyle who looked like a cat about to knock something breakable off the table. “But, Lonnie, how will I tell the other boys at school who rolled all this delicious sarma for me? I can’t lie to them. I have to tell them how much I love my Lonnie teyze.”

Lawan whipped back and slammed a practiced fist on Khyle’s thigh. He howled with pain as the charley horse gripped his leg.

Catra snickered and turned back to her phone. “She warned you, bro.”

Adora blinked and sat back.

The car ride lasted nearly two hours. Adora spent most of the time looking at the glittering sea outside her window. At one point, Catra laid her head on her shoulder and closed her eyes. Adora spent the rest of the ride peeking shyly at her and wondering if she should be making more of an effort to make conversation.

Eventually, they turned into a forested area and drove down a dirt path. They stopped at a small clearing and Rogelio put the car into park. Catra raised her head and blinked.

“Did I fall asleep?”

“Yeah,” Adora answered, “Now where are we?”

“This is stupid, Catra, just tell her,” Lawan said as she climbed out of the car.

“Neverrrr,” Catra asserted as she stretched.

Adora would just open her maps app, but she had realized about an hour into the ride that she had forgotten to re-up her data package. She still wasn’t used to not having an automatic contract.

Once liberated from the car, everyone set to work unpacking and setting up. There were two medium-sized tents for Adora and Catra as well as Khyle and Rogelio. Lawan busied herself fastening a huge, cool-looking hammock between two trees. Adora was a little jealous but was overall content with the sleeping arrangements. Adora finished setting up her tent first and went to see how the boys were doing. Rogelio gave her tent a once-over and nodded approvingly. Adora had to stop herself from preening. From the moment she met him, she found that she desperately craved his approval.

After the tents, Lawan took charge. “Rogelio, light the barbecue and put the wings on. Catra and Khalil, you’re making the salad. You idiots think you can handle that?” Khyle flashed a thumbs up and Catra flipped her off. “Adora, you’re with me on firewood duty.”

She turned on her heel and headed into the woods. Adora glanced at Catra who offered her a small wave and then scurried off after Lawan. The two walked in silence for a while, each noting branches they’d grab on the way back.

Eventually, Lawan broke the silence that Adora was sweating profusely through. “So, Blondie, what’s your story?”

“My story?” Adora saw Lawan grabbing sticks and started picking them up herself. She was grateful for something to busy her hands.

“You know, who are you? What brings you here?”

“Oh. Catra invited me. Hey, where are we, by the way?”

Lawan ignored the question and laughed, “Fuck off with that, you know what I mean.”

“Yeah you’re right, I do.” Adora dropped her pile of sticks and worked to strip a dead tree of its branches. “I’m from the US. I used to be a lawyer. There’s not much to me.”

Lawan snorted, “I doubt that. You’ve got a mysterious past vibe about you.”

Adora frowned, “Why do people keep telling me that?”

“You don’t have to tell me,” Lawan said laughing and bumping their shoulders together, “but I bet it’s interesting.”

Adora loosened up a little. “I promise you it’s not. I grew up in Tennessee, do you know it?”

“That’s where Nashville is, right?”

“Yeah, same state. Kinda middle, kinda south. Then I went to this boarding school up north which was a wild transition. That’s how I know Glimmer, by the way. Then I went to college and then law school and then I was a lawyer. It wasn’t good though. I know it sounds selfish and ungrateful, but I gave it all up and now I’m writing trashy romance novels. Like, the kind you find in airports.” Adora felt a little sheepish telling this to Lawan who she could guess had been through far more than she could imagine.

Lawan hummed, “Yeah, but why here? You don’t seem like one of those Live Laugh Love girls that comes here for adventure and exoticism and ends up married to some Turkish man.”

“I had to get out,” Adora winced at her phrasing, “Sorry.”

“Don’t do that. I know where I come from.”

Adora deflated, “Sorry. I guess I, uh, felt trapped in my life. It wasn’t really a life if I’m honest. Every moment was dedicated to work, and work was mostly keeping bad people out of prison. This guy, my last case, this guy killed a girl. He was driving drunk and she was in the passenger seat and he hit a pole. She wasn’t wearing a seatbelt and flew out and hit it. It—the pole—split her head open, like right in half like a watermelon.” Adora yanked at a dead branch harder than necessary and almost went flying when it snapped off. “We, um, we argued that he wasn’t drunk. The DA ‘lost’ the results of the breathalyzer. The, uh, the worst part was what we did to the girl. Said she had drugged the guy and was taking him somewhere to rob him. A blood test to confirm it appeared out of nowhere, and we spun this really tenuous thread that connected her to this local gang that controlled all the sex work in the area. I didn’t know all of it was a lie outright, and even if it hadn’t been, it didn’t make her guilty or deserving of death, you know? I guess I sort of knew, how could I not with the things I did? It was always obvious, I was just walking around with blinders on. It wasn’t my job to do the worst of the dirty work, so I put on my suit and did my job as the face. He got off, by the way. He’s free now. Not even a fine cause the girl’s family lost the civil suit, too. That girl died, I won a case, and I drank free that night at the bar.”

Lawan whistled low, “Damn, Adora, that’s fucked up. I thought you were gonna tell me about a break-up or something. I didn’t know you were such a scumbag! You look way too nice.”

Adora laughed, just a shade off hysterical. “I know! I look pretty nice but also, like, tall. That’s why they wanted me in the first place, so I could be their, like, sleeper scumbag.”

Lonnie laughed. “So you quit after that?”

Adora forced herself to calm down, “Yeah. I couldn’t take it anymore. I should’ve known earlier. It was right in front of my face, but I was the golden girl and didn’t want to see it.” Adora tried to shrug, but her arms were dangerously full.

“Still. That took guts. Leaving like that.”

Adora sighed, “Maybe.”

They walked in silence, nearing the camp.

“Hey, scumbag, I’ve got a question for you.”

“Yeah?”

“Say I killed a guy. Could you get me out of it?”

Adora hummed, “Depends how you did it.”

“I dunno, stabbed him a bunch of times.”

“Front or back.”

“Front.”

“Hmm. Did you wear gloves?”

“Of course.”

“Did you know him?”

“Yeah.”

“How well?”

“My sister’s irritating husband.”

“Ooh, that’ll be tough if they know it’s you. Especially if there’s any defensive evidence.”

“Aren’t you supposed to be the expert?”

“Gimme a second, I’ve been out of the game for a while, and I mostly did negligent homicide cases, so take it with a grain of salt. Okay, so self-defense is the obvious route. Most importantly, you need an interesting story. Something like he found out your sister

was having an affair and confronted you about it. Things got heated, and you had to stab him with his own knife. We can scrounge up purchase proof for that. Then we say he was on something and owed money all around town and was desperate which was why one or two stabs wasn't enough. If we can spin that he was abusing the sister, we can easily come up with a history of violence from sources we can make credible. Depending on the mother, she can be leaned on to testify, maybe even claim attacks on her. That would rile up the jury."

Lawan laughed loudly and Adora flinched.

"Holy shit, that's awful! I'm impressed."

Adora laughed nervously. The two emerged from the woods and dumped the wood near the firepit. Lawan clapped Adora on the back and wrapped an arm around her back.

"C'mon, scumbag, let's test out those muscles and go get that log."

Adora let Lawan lead her back into the trees but not before glancing over to the picnic table to see Catra grinning at her with, if she weren't mistaken, pride. Adora shot a wan smile back.

--

After dinner – spectacular, of course, whatever Rogelio put on those wings should be illegal – the group set off on a hike. It seemed a little late, but Catra assured her that it was mandatory that they leave after dark. Adora was bored of the whole secret thing, but there was a part of her excited for the grand reveal.

Catra was up talking to Rogelio and Lawan when Khyle sidled up to her. "Hi, Adora."

"Hi."

"How's it going? You having fun?"

Adora thought for a moment. She was feeling less nervous, that was for sure. Lawan and she had spent the next half-hour gathering enough firewood for a week and despite how embarrassed talking about her past had made her feel, it had seemed to earn her some respect, though she wasn't sure how she felt about her new nickname. On the bright side, when they had finished gathering wood, Lawan had pulled her into a headlock, given her a noogie, and told her to call her 'Lonnie' instead of Lawan.

So when Adora smiled at Khyle, it was genuine. "Yeah, I am. I take it you're not here to tell me where we're going."

Khyle shook his head. "I am not. When Bise gets something into her head, best to just let it happen."

Adora snorted. "Sounds dangerous."

"Sometimes!" Khyle said brightly and stretched, "So are you ready for your story tonight?"

"Story?"

"Yeah! It's tradition. Everyone has to tell a story around the fire. Catra and Lonnie always do something scary. I just do whatever feels right. You can tell whatever you want. It's not a big deal."

Adora's anxiety shot up through the roof. Fuck, she had to come up with an impressive story, and she had no idea how long she had left. How long should it be? What should it be about? She had written stories, but what was a single one of them about?

Khyle looked at her curiously, "Are you freaking out? You don't need to freak out. I did not mean to freak you out."

Adora huffed, "I am not freaking out. I can tell a story."

"Of course you can!" Khyle beamed, "Be right back." Khyle bounded up to the group in front of them and leaned in to whisper in Catra's ear. If it were light out, she would've seen

Catra's eyes widen and a blush stain her cheeks. She did see Catra smack Khyle's arm and stalk off in her direction. She fell into step beside her.

"Hey, princess, I heard you missed me."

"You heard wrong because we are fighting." Adora crossed her arms.

Catra laughed. "Are we now?"

Adora nodded. "Yes. You didn't tell me about the campfire story. So if you're planning on murdering me and dumping my body in the woods, please do it before then."

"Oh shit, the story." Catra sucked her teeth and frowned. "Fuck me, I forgot about that. I haven't come up with anything yet either if it makes you feel any better."

Adora shrugged. "Maybe a little." Adora paused and sniffed the air. "Is that sulphur?"

Catra grinned. "Sure is. We're almost there."

The group had been winding their way up a small mountain for the better part of an hour. The higher they got, the stronger the smell became. Eventually, they reached the top and the trail opened up to a rocky plateau. Adora gasped. The rock was dotted with small caves filled with tall flames. Catra wrapped an arm around Adora's waist.

"Cool, huh?"

"Is that coming from under the rock?"

"Yeah. Welcome to Antalya's hellmouth: Mt. Chimaera. This is the Yanartaş. Below us are the ruins of the Temple of Hephaestus. Want some tea?"

Adora nodded dumbly and Catra led them over to a vendor with a samovar positioned over one of the flames. She gave him two coins and handed one of the cups to Adora. Adora sipped at it as she wandered to each of the flame-filled caves and cracks. Other people cooked şiş[2] over the flames, adding the smell of meat and vegetables to the sulphur. Catra returned to her side and linked their arms together. She pointed up and Adora looked to see a brilliant canopy of stars. Any irritation she had felt before melted away as she stared up at the stars and the swath of Milky Way with Catra pressing into her side.

The group settled around a flame and ate some apricots that Rogelio had brought while drinking flame-brewed tea. Khyle passed around a flask of rum. Adora felt herself relaxing and participating in the conversation. It felt good to laugh with everyone. It felt good to belong.

After a while, they left, Adora a bit reluctantly, and made their way back to camp. When they got there, it was slightly chilly, so Adora went into her tent and grabbed a flannel. Without thinking, she went into Catra's backpack and grabbed her jacket, too. When she handed it to Catra, she received a funny look and then, after a beat, a smile and thanks.

After much cursing, Khyle and Rogelio got the fire going and everyone settled around it on the logs that Adora and Lonnie had hauled over earlier. Catra handed out red solo cups filled with something that smelled questionable and tasted even worse.

"Jesus *fuck*, Catra, what is this?" Lonnie snarled but took another sip.

"Rum and pomegranate juice. It's not my fault that no one brought vodka or coke or a single sensible thing. The other option was grapefruit juice and beer." Catra threw her arms up.

"Who had drink duty?" Lonnie demanded.

Catra rolled her eyes. "Take a guess."

Lonnie turned and laid a strong punch on Khyle's bicep. "Fuck you, Khalil." Khyle laughed, rubbed at his arm, and sipped his drink. "I think it's delicious. Great job, Bise."

Regardless, everyone drank the concoction. When the tipsy warmth set in, it was time for stories.

Lonnie went first and told the tale of Aisha the Countess, a shape-shifting jinn that seduced men and then lured them home to eat them alive. One night, she met the most beautiful young man that she had ever seen. They caroused 'til dawn and for the first time in her millennia of existence, she chose to spare the man's life and go home with him. Once there, he revealed himself to be a being of fire. As they made love, Aisha found herself pulled into the flames, losing more of herself at every moment, but she could not bring herself to leave his embrace. By the time the sun was at its highest, she was gone, the fire of her own form one with his. The demon then cloaked himself as a beautiful young maiden and made their way to the Countess's palace.

When Lonnie finished, Catra chuffed out a laugh. "Geez, Lawan."

"What?"

"That's fucked up, man. You doing okay? When's the last time you got laid?"

"Get fucked, Catra. Like you have anything better."

"Damn, right in the pride. I'll blow your mind, o ye of little faith, but Khyle is up."

Khyle perked up. "Yes I am! All right everyone, I've got a good one. So one time this horse-"

"Is this a joke?" Lawan asked, eyes narrowed.

"No! It's a very serious story! Anyway, this horse was watching youtube one day and he stumbled upon a video for Dragonforce's 'Through the Fire and Flames' and he thought to himself that he

needed to learn to play the guitar. So he calls the guitar store and asks if they offer lessons. They say yes, but he says 'there's one problem. I'm a horse.' The guitar guy tells him that it's no problem because they have special lessons for horses. So he gets his guitar and his lessons and he practices and gets really good. One day, his buddy the pig comes over and he shows him the 'Through the Fire and Flames' video and the pig decides right then and there that he needs to learn the drums, so he calls the drum store and asks if they give lessons. The drum store says yes, but the pig says 'there's one problem, I'm a pig.' The guy says it's no problem and that they have lessons for pigs. So the pig gets his drums and lessons and practices a lot and becomes pretty good.

One day, the guys are jamming on their guitar and drums and their friend the goat comes by. He tells them that he watched the 'Through the Fire and Flames' video and got inspired to learn the bass, so he got a bass and special goat lessons and now he's awesome. They all form a band and start looking for a singer. Turns out their friend the rooster sings, so they start playing together and eventually start doing local gigs. They get pretty popular and manage to book a gig at a larger venue. They play the best show of their lives and afterwards, a guy comes to talk to them and introduces himself as a record producer. He offers them a contract and to fly them out to LA the next day. They book their flights, but just before they get on, the horse gets a call that his mother is in the hospital and she doesn't have long left. He tells the band to go ahead and he'll join them soon. The horse goes to his mother and is with her in her last moments.

When she dies, he feels a deep sadness, but it is colored with the hope that he is going to go to LA and make his beloved mother proud. Just then, he looks up to the TV where breaking news reports a plane crash in the middle of the US. No survivors. They say the flight number and the horse realizes in horror that that was his flight. All of his friends are dead as well as his dreams. He stumbles out of the hospital, completely numb, and makes a beeline for the nearest bar. He goes in and sits at the bar. The bartender comes over and asks, 'Hey, buddy, why the long face?'"

There was silence for a few moments after Khyle stopped speaking. Suddenly, Adora exploded into hysterical laughter. She buried her face in her hands and Catra laid a hand on her back and gave a few pats. That just made her laugh harder. Lawan heckled Khyle for telling a long, shitty joke and he howled with laughter. Rogelio tousled his hair fondly and Khyle beamed up at him.

"You ready to go, Ro?"

Rogelio nodded and cleared his throat. Catra poked Adora in the side and she quickly got herself together and sat up.

Rogelio's story was a personal one about his time in Saudi Arabia. He had been seeing a man who worked with him in the kitchen. The two were inseparable but had to be careful about being caught doing anything more than being in the other's proximity. One night, they snuck out of the hotel after their shift and made their way through Riyadh to find a party in one of the expat complexes. They 'borrowed' their boss's motorbike and were on their way. Halfway to the destination, the bike broke down in a billow of white steam. A local approached and offered to look at it and pretended to not understand Rogelio's dialect. Eventually, the bike was running and off the men went. They had to bribe the security guard to let them into the complex, but they finally found the party. Everything was fun until security showed up after a drunk Brit fell out of a second-floor window and broke their leg. Rogelio and the man hid in a closet, holding each other close and fooling around until the cops left. The next morning, they snuck out of the complex and hitch-hiked back to the hotel just in time for the breakfast shift.

After he finished, Rogelio leaned back with a dreamy look in his eye.

"What happened to the man?" Adora asked before she could stop herself.

Rogelio met her eyes and smirked. “Who knows?” It was the first time he had spoken to her directly. Lonnie leaned over and murmured something to him in Arabic and he laughed heartily.

Rogelio clapped his hands and rubbed them together. “Catra?”

Catra hopped up and bowed. “Surely you’ve all heard of the Akdeniz Slasher?”

“No.” Lonnie said sounding bored already.

“I have, probably!” Khyle supplied.

“The Akdeniz Slasher was born a miserable child to a family that hated him. No matter how well he did in school, he was locked in the basement for the slightest infraction and eventually he was chained down there for good. Each morning, his mother would come down and drop his breakfast at his feet with a single, disgusted ‘Good morning.’ All he saw of his father and brothers was their boot in his face or ribs. No one would speak to the child, not his father nor his brothers. It was just that single ‘good morning’ from his mother for years and years. There he stayed for years and years more, enduring indignity after indignity until finally opportunity blessed him and he slipped away in the night with only the clothes on his back and his father’s penknife.”

Catra stalked around the fire.

“He walked day and night until he reached Antalya. Before he had been taken out of school, he had learned that Atatürk had called it the most beautiful city in the world, so where better to begin his new life, he thought. Just as dawn was cresting the sky, he stopped to rest in a village just outside the city. He had just pulled off his shoes when a woman walked by carrying water. ‘Good morning!’ she called and he froze. Images of his mother flashed before his eyes, every sneer, every glare coupled with the chafe of the chain on his wrists, the feel of his bones cracking under his father’s boot.”

Catra slid behind Khyle and ran a finger slowly around his chin, neck, and down to his chest.

"And who could blame him when he took his father's penknife and plunged it into the woman's heart again and again and again?" She thumped Khyle on the chest and he coughed. She slunk back to the fire. "Long after she was dead, he drove the knife into her. Eventually, the men of the village tore him from the woman and pried the knife from his bloody hands. He was thrown into a psychiatric hospital, and for a while, he tried to be good, he really did."

Adora felt Catra's hand drift along her shoulders. "But then the hospital burned down under mysterious circumstances and three more people were found sliced to bits. They hunted, but they could never find him. Eventually, they followed a trail of bodies to Çıralı, to these woods." Adora felt Catra's hand slink up her cheek. "But he was like a ghost. No footprints. No campsites. Nothing. Well, nothing but a trail of blood." Catra's hand drew across her neck and she gasped. Catra's voice went low. "No, they never did find him."

After a beat, Catra laughed brightly. "Did I scare you?

Adora crossed her arms. "No!"

"There's no shame in admitting it, princess. I am a master of story-telling." Catra skipped to the fire and bowed dramatically.

"Master of bullshit, more like it." Lawan jeered.

"Just admit that my serial killer story was better than whatever that horny jinn-fucking thing was supposed to be."

"Hell no."

Catra returned to her spot next to Adora, albeit closer than before, while Khyle got up to make another round of drinks.

Catra turned her head to Adora where they sat shoulder-to-shoulder. “You ready, princess?”

Adora shrugged. “I think so.” She felt ready enough. She had come up with something passable on the way back from the Yanartaş. “It’s not scary, though.”

“Doesn’t have to be. Khyle told a joke. You can’t get worse than that.”

“I liked that joke.”

“You would.”

Khyle handed them both a refill and Adora took a deep breath. Catra scooched away a bit to give her space. Adora closed her eyes and focused on her breathing, a ritual she had once used before entering the courtroom. When she opened her eyes, she was a new person, and everyone seemed to take notice as she stood up and regarded each of them in turn, radiating confidence.

Adora’s tale began long ago, long before this world or the one before it. It was a time when the universe was young and gods roamed the earth. As our powerful forebears were wont to do, war upon war was waged for the sakes of pride and arrogance. Battles stretched across eons in eternal stalemate. That is, until the Weapon was forged. The Weapon was a sword of unimaginable power that could only be wielded by a being of pure light dubbed the Warrior. The Warrior obeyed her masters without question and cleansed the battlefield of those they deemed enemy. In but a moment, the eternal war of the divine was finished and the Warrior was sealed in a cavern deep below the Earth. The Weapon was hidden in the heart of a wood so thick and deep, no life could survive.

Millennia passed. The gods created man and retreated to the stars to fritter away their immortality far from prying eyes. The Warrior rested in her cavern, her home and what she came to realize, her prison. The gods watched the humans live and die with little care

except amusement at their own idolization. They were given pause when a force from beyond the stars landed at their gates and laid waste. The gods were decimated, and their Warrior was entombed in the earth. The gods that were left sent a desperate envoy to the world of man begging them to awaken the Warrior and reunite her with the Weapon. The humans ignored the message, deeming it nonsense. That is, until the alien force landed on earth and asked no questions before blasting with strange but no less deadly weapons. Those that lived were sent as a party into the cursed woods that whispered the destruction of eons past and warnings of even greater horrors to come. They searched for weeks, members falling one-by-one to the unforgiving forest until but three were left. It was the king's daughter that found it, a poor-looking sword wrapped in vines and half-buried in the earth. With a quivering hand, she took the sword.

Deep underground, the Warrior jolted awake and felt herself pulled from her bed. Her body flew through the narrow passages and through the mountain of eternal flames, through the plains and into the Whispering Woods. She crashed into a woman holding what she recognized as the Weapon and desperately tried to wrench her body away. It was no use, the Warrior fused with the woman and both the sword and the woman exploded in white light. Her companions were knocked back, and when they could open their eyes, they beheld their friend, a towering goddess wielding a sword larger than either of them.

The Warrior could say confidently that she preferred this new prison to her subterranean cavern. She enjoyed the woman and her friends. She enjoyed the combat with this new enemy. What she did not enjoy was the sinking feeling that this was no different than the time before, that the woman whose body hosted her was in even less control than she had been. Where she was ordered, she fought. She decimated villages for the sake of destroying a single enemy. Innocent lives piled up alongside the corpses of the enemy.

After a particularly bloody conflict, the woman sat in her tent caring for the Weapon. The Warrior reached out to her. The two communed often and had become as close to friends as person and immortal force of destruction could. The Warrior begged the woman to consider what she was doing, what she was being made to do. The woman argued that this was war and she was only doing what was right. They argued late into the night, but the woman finally relented and let go of her hold on the Warrior. The Warrior slipped from the woman's skin and she shrunk to what she once had been. Horror painted her features as she realized what she had become.

With her friends and the Warrior whispering in her mind, she concocted a plan to end the war. Then and there, they fled to the highest mountain in the kingdom. The Warrior returned to her host and the woman kicked off the peak and leapt towards the massive flagship of the invading force floating in space. It was not a long battle. She tore through the hull with her bare hands and flung herself deeper and deeper into the ship, laying waste as she went. When she met with the alien commander, he seemed almost amused to see her. When he spoke, he addressed the Warrior, believing the woman little more than a shell. The woman drove her sword into his chest and this great commander, conqueror of worlds, scourge of the universe, died unceremoniously and alone in his quarters.

When the woman and the Warrior returned, they found the commanders of their own army that they had spent so long blindly obeying strung up at the front of the camp. The friends had incited a mutiny and now all eyes turned towards the woman for guidance. The woman took a deep breath and at the urging of the Warrior, drove her sword into the ground and shattered it. The Warrior burst from her and began to fade. The woman looked to her beloved friend in despair, but the Warrior assured her that this was for the best, that she would make the best ruler the world had ever seen. And with that, the Warrior slipped from this world into the next, to the only peace she had ever known.

Under the woman, the kingdom of man saw an era of unprecedented peace and prosperity that continued for generations. From this grew a cult that worshipped the Warrior ensuring that her great sacrifice would never be forgotten.

Adora sat down. Everything was silent for a beat, her final words still hanging in the air. Then the group erupted in cheers. Rogelio popped two fingers in his mouth and whistled loudly.

"Adora, that was *amazing*. Did you seriously make that all up today?" Khyle gushed.

Adora blushed and rubbed her neck. "Yeah. On the way back from the Yanartaş."

"That is insane!"

Adora glanced shyly at Catra, dying to know what she thought of it. Catra was beaming at her and the way the firelight reflected on her eyes made her chest constrict.

Lonnie got up and extended her hand. Adora rose and took it.

"I hate to admit it, scumbag, but you win campfire storytime."

"Thanks, Lonnie," Adora laughed, more than a little embarrassed, "I didn't realize it was a competition."

"Whoa whoa, hold the fucking phone," Catra snapped, "Why does she get to call you Lonnie? I've known you 7 years and you still make me call you Lawan."

Lonnie wrapped her arm around Adora's shoulder. "One, cause Adora's not a little bitch and two, cause Scumbag here is gonna get me out of jail when I murder someone."

"*When*?" squeaked Khyle.

"This is some *bullshit*, Lawan, and you know it," Catra grumbled and crossed her arms, but Adora could see her smile when she

turned her head away.

The rest of the night was spent drinking and smoking. Adora was more than a little surprised when Catra wasn't even offered the joint and it skipped over to her. She declined too. Weed made her anxious.

When it was time for bed, both Adora and Catra were good and drunk. They stumbled into their tent and collapsed onto their sleeping bags. Adora listened to someone extinguish the fire and sighed in relief. She turned her head to see Catra staring at her, her eyes faintly glowing in the darkness.

"Hi," she said, mouth dry.

"Hey. Do you think I could… come over there?"

"Of course." She felt more than saw Catra shuffle over and rest her head on her shoulder and press their bodies together. Adora hoped that she couldn't hear her heart threatening to beat out of her chest. *Get a grip*. She positioned her hand on Catra's waist while Catra's arm draped across her stomach. Adora forced herself to relax and speak.

"Can I ask you something?"

"Go for it."

"Was your story true?"

Catra chuckled and angled her head to look at Adora. "Why, princess? You scared?"

Adora huffed and pushed Catra's head back down, "Shut up, no."

"I took some details from a Turkish serial killer I watched a documentary on once, but most of it I just made up on the spot."

"On the spot? Like, just right while you were telling it?"

“Yeah, it’s what I always do. It’s more fun that way.”

Adora squeezed Catra’s hip. “That’s really impressive.”

Catra scoffed, “Seriously? Dude, you made up a whole-ass epic in an hour.”

Adora grinned. “It’s true, I am a very accomplished writer. I am basically James Joyce.”

“Oh my god, shut up, I’m done complimenting you. Can’t inflate that giant head of yours anymore.” Adora swatted away Catra’s hand when it came up to do whatever it was supposed to do to her head.

“Hey! My head is normal-sized!”

Catra’s hand finally made it through to flick her on the forehead.

Adora tried to stifle a giggle. “Why are you so mean to me? I bet Lonnie would be nice to me in her hammock.”

“*Lonnie* is a bitch.”

“Ooh, I’m gonna tell on you. Only cool kids get to call her Lonnie.”

Catra poked her in the side and Adora jolted and laughed. “Shut up. You are not cooler than me. You are, like, queen of the dorks.”

“Yeah, can’t argue with that. You’re very cool,” Adora said through the laughter threatening to choke her.

“Damn straight, princess.”

After a few moments, Adora felt shuffling against her legs and glanced down to see what looked like Catra kicking her shorts off. Adora unbuttoned hers and flailed a bit, but eventually got them off while Catra gave commentary.

They were quiet for a while until a thought managed to make its way through the intoxicated haze of Adora’s brain.

“Catra?”

“Hm?”

“Did you bring me out here cause I told you Antalya is like a hellmouth last week?”

Adora felt Catra smile against her. “Wow, conceited much?”

“Incredibly.”

“I thought you’d have fun. You did, didn’t you?”

“I did.” Adora rested her chin on Catra’s forehead and tightened her hold. “You’re amazing.”

Catra hummed, draped a bare leg over Adora, and snuggled closer into her chest. “Good night, Adora.” Her voice was soft and sleepy.

“Good night, Catra.”

Chapter End Notes

teyze: it literally means aunt, but it's one of those words that acts as a term of respect for older women. This is definitely not the last time I use it.[▲]

şiş: whatever you put on a skewer and grill up[▲]

Tune in Tuesday for Summer pt. 1.5
In the meantime, who had the best story and why was is Khyle?

Summer pt. 1.5

Chapter Summary

> "Catra! There you are! I have a matter of the utmost urgency to discuss with you."
> "Whatever it is, I'm not doing it," Catra deadpanned.
> "You see," Sea Hawk continued as if he hadn't heard her, "There comes a time in every hero's life when he must call upon a fellow lion-hearted soul to join him in the grand adventure of life."
> "Bro, *what*."
>
> --
>
> Karaoke is sung and progress is *finally* made.
>
> For the full karaoke experience, follow along on the playlist

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

As imperceptibly as Grief

The Summer lapsed away –

Too imperceptible at last

To seem like Perfidy –

"As Impeceptibly as Grief", Emily Dickinson, 1865

Summer drifted slowly past. Days were spent hidden within the safety of air conditioning. Nights were spent out, sweating and sticky in the stagnant air. Adora settled into a comfortable routine: run in the early morning, work until mid-afternoon, hit the gym, participate in some sort of social activity. Her birthday passed in a fit of drunken indolence. She continued spending time with

Perihan and her coffee club of questionable sexuality even though every time she saw Saliha, she was filled with an acute sense of dread. Saliha didn't seem to cotton on to her reticence, though, and continued on with her crusade to be her friend. As the summer wore on, Saliha got more and more excited to be reunited with the coworker with whom she was besotted. When asked about her own crush, Adora shrugged and kept it as vague as possible.

She didn't mention the camping trip that had left her heart full to bursting or the days and nights spent in the sea. She didn't mention the bars, the lunches and the dinners, the late nights laughing over terrible movies where they inevitably ended up chastely wrapped in each other's arms on the couch or in one of their beds. She didn't mention the countless moments where they almost kissed, restricted by alcohol or betrayed by their own indecision, the morning cups of coffee with Khyle or Glimmer leering with knowledge they did not really know. She didn't mention the laughter, the too-long gazes, the lingering touches, the way her skin burned against her. Most of all, she didn't mention the pull she felt to bare her soul, to spill all of the secrets she had kept locked inside the vault of her heart for so long, and the unbearable truth that she was falling deeply, irrevocably in love with Catra, and that there was nothing she could do to stop it.

She instead listened to Saliha pine and plan while growing sicker to her stomach with the knowledge that she was betraying a woman who had been nothing but kind to her since the day they met. Still, she could not stem the ever-rising tide of desire within her, yet she remained unable to overcome her own inertia. This was especially jarring because movement was a constant in every other area of her life and had been for as long as she could remember. She finished another book and picked up a couple of editing jobs for the hell of it. With Hanife's help, she pushed herself at the gym more than she had in years. She was learning how to make Turkish food under Perihan's guidance. She was slowly but surely learning Turkish. For the first time in her life, she was actually having fun for the sake of it.

And that's what their friends didn't understand. They just wanted to shove Adora and Catra together because they were both single and they thought it was cute when two girls kissed. What they didn't understand was the tenuousness of it all. Were Adora to take the next step, albeit one she desperately desired, it could be as if touching a bubble floating in the air. In a moment, everything could be gone and she could be back adrift in a sea of her own emotional indolence. No, she couldn't risk something like that, so she would have to be content with what she was given even if she had to slice out her own tongue to keep it from betraying her.

She finally *belonged*. Even if it was thousands of miles away in a country no one in her hometown could find on a map. She had sung sea shanties with Sea Hawk on his boat. She had explored ancient ruins with Bo. She had drunkenly belted out Spice Girls songs with Glimmer in their living room. She had sat in on band practices with The Horde. She had learned to make falafel with Rogelio. She had boxed with Lonnie and gotten a black eye. She had laughed with Khyle until she cried real tears. She had listened to Catra's heartbeat as she fell asleep. Everything in her life, all the pain and the guilt and the wasted effort, had led her here. Catra had tried to tell her that once, but she hadn't really understood. Now, though, now she knew that for once in her life, she was happy.

That was the thing about Catra. She understood. She understood Adora in a way that no one else seemed to. She listened to her and didn't pity her the way the others did. When she told her about her mother, Catra simply played with her hair and understood that often a confession did not want for a reaction. Adora paid her the same courtesy. Under the cover of darkness, Catra told stories of her own mother, a cold woman who despised her daughter for the crime of existing. She told of cruel words and the tapestry of lies and unspoken expectations that left her clutching at driftwood in her own endless sea. She told of the void of her identity, the unknown, unnamed father, the name that did not match the world in which she lived. Adora knew that there were gaps in Catra's narrative, hints of incidents and fiascos, things she seemed to want to share but could not bring herself to,

but Adora took it in stride. They had all the time in the world, it felt, if they were careful.

Adora found herself with a book in her living room when Glimmer burst out of her room holding two dresses.

“Which one?” She demanded, brandishing a sequined pink and purple cocktail dress and then a glittery fuscia short-sleeved number.

“What’s the occasion?” Adora turned back to her book.

Glitter sighed with the weight of nations, “God, Adora, it’s karaoke night. Didn’t you get the facebook invite?”

Adora rolled her eyes. “Who still uses facebook? Further, who dresses up to do karaoke?”

“You don’t understand *anything* sometimes, I swear. Now which one?” Glimmer shook the dresses in Adora’s direction threateningly.

“The second one.”

“Thank you. Now, was that so hard?” Glimmer leveled a glare in Adora’s direction. “You need to get ready, too. I’m not walking in with you in some ratty t-shirt and shorts. I’ll do your make-up.”

Adora groaned, “It’s over a hundred degrees outside, I don’t wanna wear pants and make-up.”

“Then wear that one dress you brought. Come ooooooon, don’t you want Catra to see you looking all pretty and done up?”

Adora huffed, “Catra doesn’t care about that stuff.”

Glimmer scoffed, “Everyone cares about that stuff, Adora, now go get in the shower.”

Grumbling, Adora acquiesced and went to take a shower. She loved Glimmer – she was her oldest and truest friend – but she was a pain in her ass. As she showered, dressed in a flowy white dress adorned with flowers, had her make-up done, and argued with Glimmer over how she should wear her hair, Adora tried to reason herself into getting excited for the night to come.

Bo showed up just as Adora threw her hands up and allowed product to be worked through her hair that she was apparently wearing *fucking down*.

"Ladies!" he called, "how are we this fine evening?"

"Adora is working on my last nerve is how the fuck we are!"

"*Me?!* You're the one losing your shit. It's karaoke, not tea with the queen!"

"Bo, tell her how unreasonable she's being right now!"

Bo stared at them wide-eyed with hands raised in supplication.

"Ooookay, let's everyone pause and take a deep breath, shall we?"

The two women stared him down for a few moments, took a deep breath, and visibly relaxed.

Bo sighed in relief, "Brilliant. Now, first of all, you both look stunning. Absolutely ace. Glimmer, I have never seen such a flawless gradient in my entire life. How could you possibly get the glitter so perfectly symmetrical? Adora, that dress makes you look like a goddess. It should be a capital offense how effortlessly beautiful you are." Glimmer beamed and Adora smiled a little in spite of herself. The two snuck a glance at each other and burst into giggles.

Bo sat down on the couch and the other two joined him. "Okay, now that we're all in better spirits, we must discuss the matter at hand." Glimmer nodded seriously. Adora rolled her eyes.

“Adora,” he continued, “this is your first Antalya karaoke, and you must understand that this is a ritual that we all take very seriously.”

“That’s what I tried to tell her!”

“No you didn’t! You yelled at me until I put on a dress!”

Bo held up a hand for quiet and thankfully received it.

“The rules are as follows: 1, you must sing at least one solo, one duet, and participate in a group sing-a-long. 2, no sappy love songs or whingy breakups songs. 3, if you’re gonna fail, fail to the stars, And 4, have more fun than the person next to you.”

Adora blinked. “But *why* are we dressing up?”

“Rule 5 is make everyone die to either be you or be with you,” Glimmer answered.

Adora narrowed her eyes, “I feel like you guys are making this up. We’re not going to be the only ones dressed up, are we?”

Bo waved her off. “No, everyone gets fancy. Sea Hawk started it years ago. Last year, Catra and Khyle wore full tuxes.”

“They said they were protesting how over-the-top the whole thing was but just looked like sexy groomsmen. I’ve got pictures if you’re interested.” Adora shot Glimmer a look despite very much wanting to see the pictures. She was not going to give her the satisfaction.

“The whole thing is kind of like prom,” Glimmer continued, “Only with less of you chipping a tooth or me crying in the bathroom and Ms. Tossa dragging me out for holding up the line.”

Adora laughed, tonguing the bonding on her front left tooth, “Dear lord, what an awful night.”

Bo’s eyes sparkled, “You have to tell me everything!”

Glimmer winked. “See me in three shots, babe.”

--

These people took karaoke far too seriously. The bar that Sea Hawk had rented out for the night was spacious and covered in shiny walnut from the walls to the bar to the tables and chairs. A mic was set up on a decently-sized stage. Next to the stage was a small table with a sign-up sheet that everyone was crowded around. Adora saw Catra leaning against the bar and made a bee-line. On the way, she took in the form-fitting white button-up undone enough to reveal the hint of a black bra tucked into impossibly tight black dress leggings ending in maroon high-tops, one foot up and resting on the front of the bar. To complete Adora’s immolation, Catra had a maroon blazer slung casually over her shoulder like she hadn’t the faintest care that she was the most beautiful woman in the world.

Adora sidled up to her. “How could you?”

Catra swiveled her head to Adora and a smile slowly spread across her face. “Hey, Adora. Pray tell, how have I offended you today?”

Adora saw her reflection in Catra’s mirrored sunglasses despite the fact that the sun had set hours ago on top of the fact that they were inside. “How could you not have prepared me for all this?” She gestured vaguely to the bar and the over-dressed crowd.

“Couldn’t bear to expose you to this stupidity prematurely.”

“You dressed up,” Adora pointed out. “You look good, by the way.”

“I’d never hear the end of it if I didn’t. And thanks. You, too. I like your hair like this.” Catra reached up and twirled a lock of Adora’s hair, wavy from the humidity, around her finger. It was nothing that Catra hadn’t done before, but Adora still felt heat rise to her cheeks and spill down her neck. Catra’s hair was pulled into an over-flowing ponytail with curls left out to frame her face. It made her look younger.

In a desperate bid to get control of herself, Adora asked if Catra wanted a drink.

Catra hummed and finally took off her sunglasses to regard Adora properly. “Maybe later. I’m not trying to get drunk tonight.” Adora stared into her eyes. There were dark circles under them, but Adora ignored them in favor of searching for confirmation of what she felt she was being told.

She chanced a reply, “If you’re not drinking tonight, then maybe I won’t either.”

Catra shrugged, “Don’t let me ruin your night, but it could be fun to have a buddy to watch these assholes make fools of themselves.” Adora thought she saw a slight smirk ghost across her lips.

All of a sudden, Glimmer appeared and grabbed Adora by the wrist.

“Oh hell no, I am not losing another karaoke night to fucking Catra. C’mon, Adora, we still need to sign you up and keep you away from the competition.” As Glimmer dragged her off, Adora glanced up to see Catra had replaced her sunglasses and was offering her a small wave. Adora beamed at her in response.

Soon enough, everyone was seated in what Glimmer enthusiastically asserted were teams. When Adora had managed to tear herself from Glimmer’s orbit to briefly join Catra outside, she had been assured that the competition aspect was merely a figment of Glimmer’s overactive imagination. Sea Hawk took the stage in what Adora had to admit was a dashing tight-cut sapphire suit.

“Friends, another year has passed, and another glorious summer in this glorious land is coming to a close. It has been an eventful time to say the least. I have sailed the seas on the *Dragon’s Daughter IV* and she has taken me all over the great and perilous seas to Bodrum, Izmir, and Ayvalık in my quest to reach

Çanakkale, the fabled Troy of myth! Like the great Odysseus, the bravest of sailors, I walked the hallowed ruins of the land loved so by Athena and protected so bravely by her champions Hector and Achilles."

Adora felt her phone buzz and pulled it out.

Catra (22.09): ignore him. troy sucks ass. it's like 3 rocks

Adora (22.09) i don't think hes even read the iliad. Bo looks like he's about to pop a blood vessel

Catra (22.10) ive seen the dude fall asleep watching troy no less than three times. don't worry, i give it 30 more seconds max

Sure enough, before Sea Hawk could make it through another unending sentence, a room-filling groan cut him off. Everyone turned to look at Merve, who had leveled a look of pure irritation at him.

He rubbed the back of his neck and grinned. "Yes, my love?"

"Get *on* with it, eşek."

Everyone cheered their assent.

"But I didn't get to the part where I introduce our newest addition Adora and her radiant beauty," Sea Hawk whined.

"We all know Adora, Hawkins. Adora! Wave to the crowd." Adora did as she was told though she shrank a little in her seat. "See? There she is in all her 'radiant beauty'. Now, sing your stupid kick-off song and get off the stage!" Catra heckled.

Adora (22.13): ive always considered my beauty more ethereal than radiant

Catra (22.13): bruh

Sea Hawk wrapped up his speech and launched the party with a rousing rendition of "Born to Run" by Bruce Springsteen. He had a pretty decent voice. When he was finished, everyone clapped and he bowed far too deeply. He called for Feyza from his and Merve's table and hopped off the stage. Adora didn't see Feyza often, and her stick-straight black hair was a fair bit longer than the last she'd seen her. She liked her simple, powder-blue dress. She had a terrible voice, but she nailed "No Scrubs" on attitude alone. In spite of herself, Adora had to admit that this was decently fun.

One thing bothered her, though. She couldn't nail it down, but Catra seemed off. She still hadn't taken her sunglasses off and leaned back in her chair with her arms crossed. Adora also hadn't seen her name on the sign-up sheet. Adora had been keeping an eye on her table, and she wasn't talking to anyone, not even Khyle who seemed to have an animated running commentary that had Lonnie laughing loudly. Catra spared him no more than a wan smile. She had seen Catra's cool act in action many times over the year, but this seemed excessive.

Adora also couldn't help but keep tabs on the argument brewing between Merve and Sea Hawk as he became increasingly intoxicated. Adora had seen a few of these before. From what she had gathered, Merve was not entirely pleased with her boyfriend's drinking habits, and she could hardly blame her. She had never seen Sea Hawk completely sober, and had seen him incoherent and passed out on both her and Catra's couches many times. This fight in particular seemed to be escalating at a dangerous pace.

Sea Hawk called a break and Adora turned her head to catch Catra's eye. Catra inclined her head slightly towards the door, and Adora hopped up. Before she could leave the table, Glimmer grabbed her wrist.

"And just where do you think you're going, missy?"

"Outside?"

"To do what?"

“To… be outside?”

“I will not have you fraternizing with the enemy. You’ll give away all of our secrets. You have no resolve.” Glimmer’s face was grim.

Adora rolled her eyes. “Glimmer, we’re singing Kesha. We wrote it on the sheet. It’s hardly a state secret.”

Glimmer tossed her wrist away in disgust. “Fine, you traitor. Go make out with your girlfriend and ruin my life. See if I care.”

Adora did not even dignify that with a response as she slipped out of the bar with her soda and joined Catra at a table nearby. Catra was about halfway through her cigarette.

“Took you long enough, princess.”

“Glimmer thinks you’re running complex karaoke espionage and I’m just your mindless informant.”

“Well shit, looks like I’ve been made.”

Adora giggled. “What are you singing tonight?”

Catra shrugged, “Gonna see if I can get away without getting up there more than once. Khyle and I always do Arctic Monkeys, so I’m locked in to that, but otherwise I’m not really feeling it today.”

“Are you doing all right?” Adora tried to sound as casual as possible.

Catra rubbed her eyes underneath her sunglasses and offered her a smile. “Yeah, I’m fine. Just a little tired.”

Adora wasn’t necessarily convinced, but she let it go for the time being. The two chatted for a while until they were joined by Sea Hawk. He stood in front of Catra, arms akimbo and feet shoulder-width apart. Adora wondered if he adopted the posture for dramatic effect or to keep himself from swaying.

“Catra! There you are! I have a matter of the utmost urgency to discuss with you.”

“Whatever it is, I’m not doing it,” Catra deadpanned.

“You see,” Sea Hawk continued as if he hadn’t heard her, “There comes a time in every hero’s life when he must call upon a fellow lion-hearted soul to join him in the grand adventure of life.”

“Bro, *what*.”

“This is a Herculean task, but one for which you have the mettle, the utter grit required to press onward. Together, we must press to Tartarus and lull the great three-headed beast to sleep with only the dulcet tones that pass our lips.”

Catra’s eyes narrowed, “Wait a fucking second. This had better not be what I think it is.”

“Illustrious Catra, take up this mantle with me and join me in our destiny!” Adora could swear she saw stars burst from his eyes.

Catra looked thoroughly unimpressed. “I’m not doing ‘Don’t You Want Me’ with you. It’s not my fault you pissed Merve off with your bullshit.”

“But, Catra—“

Catra held up a hand, “’But, Catra’ *what*? One, I hate doing that stupid song with you. Two, I’m going back to work in two weeks and I don’t need the mermaid pissed off at me. She’s my boss, man.”

Sea Hawk raised his hands in supplication, “Think of the memories, the legacy, the glorious return to golden age of yore!”

“Unfortunately for you and also unlike you, I have an ounce more self-respect than when I was 23. Go hassle someone else.” Catra waved him off dismissively.

Sea Hawk visibly drooped. Even his moustache seemed sad. Catra sighed.

"Try Saliha. She'll probably do it. Now get the fuck out of my face, Hawkins."

Sea Hawk grinned. "Ah yes, the enchanting Saliha. Perhaps all is not lost after all!" He offered the pair separate bows and booked it back into the bar.

Adora gave her a curious look. "That was harsh."

Catra lit another cigarette. She was smoking a lot tonight; though, she always smoked more when they were out. "I hate that fucking song. He knows I hate that fucking song. I used to do it with him back in the day. He has this stupid choreography that he made me learn and he always goes way over-the-top with it."

"What's going on with him and Merve?"

"What isn't? It's always a matter of time before she gets sick of his shit and throws a tantrum. He's such a piece of shit when he drinks, which is constantly; I wish she'd just dump him already. She deserves better than that. She's always deserved better than that." The quirk of Catra's mouth suggested that she was furious.

"Do you think they'll break up? They live together, right?"

Catra sighed, "Yeah, they do. Nah, I bet they'll be married by next summer. Her parents love him. She loves him. She's just been waiting five years for him to get his shit together."

"Maybe he will."

"Yeah," Catra replied, sounding unconvinced and stubbed her cigarette out. She stood up and offered her hand to Adora who immediately took it. "Shall we?"

When Adora returned to her table, Glimmer seemed to be in significantly better spirits. This perhaps had something to do with

the two empty shot glasses sitting in front of her. There were two full shots in front of Adora. When prompted to take them, she waved them off.

"C'moooon, Adora, loosen up."

"I'm still hungover as shit from yesterday, Glim," Adora lied.

"It'll make you feel better."

"Don't you want me sharp for singing?"

Glimmer couldn't argue with that and nodded. She took one of the shots and knocked it back. For the sake of compromise, Adora took the other one herself. *Ugh, vodka*. She shuddered around the burn and took a sip of her cola. She turned to see Catra looking in her direction, sipping slowly at the beer she had been nursing for an hour. Adora shrugged.

The singing paused for a moment and Sea Hawk scurried across the stage to set up a little black box at the front. When he was satisfied, he started the track and tapped it on. The stage erupted in beams of light. She heard Merve groan distantly as the synthesizers kicked in on "Don't You Want Me?'. Sea Hawk launched into the first verse with a practiced swagger. He sang the first chorus in Merve's direction. She looked seconds away from murder.

Just when Adora thought he hadn't successfully found a partner, Saliha traipsed onto the stage and blasted out the second verse. She was *good*, holy shit. Adora cringed a bit as Sea Hawk danced around Saliha, and she tried desperately to match his movements while the lights flashed in her eyes. She nailed the rest of the song, though, and everyone applauded. Catra whistled and cheered her name which caused Saliha to go crimson.

Suddenly, Glimmer spun in her chair and smacked her hand on the table.

"It's time," she said gravely, "Are you ready?"

Adora laid her hand on Glimmer's, excitement welling up in her chest in spite of herself. "I've been training my entire life for this moment."

Glimmer nodded, flipped her hand to grasp Adora's, and dragged them to the stage. Adora was slowly getting into the schtick but she still thought this was far too much fuss to be made about TiK ToK. Perhaps it was the perfect amount of fuss, though, Adora thought as the song started and she was transported back to simpler times. Dancing around Glimmer's dorm with a hairbrush microphone when she was 16, sipping at a blue MD 20/20 pilfered from the gas station, Adora had never in her life been happier. She had grinned a blue-stained smile and gathered her friend in her arms and squeezed as tight as she could. As the song ended, she did the same as she did then and Glimmer hugged her back. She poured years of love and appreciation for the woman who had always been her best friend into the embrace. Glimmer had always been there for her in her brightest and darkest times without question. She had opened her heart to Adora when she was a scared girl, and she had later opened her home and her life to Adora when she was a scared adult.

The two hopped off the stage laughing and holding hands.

"You're kind of the worst sometimes, but I love you," Glimmer said.

"You're the worst all the time, but I love you, too," Adora replied, squeezing her best friend's hand. Adora peeked in Catra's direction to see her smiling softly at her. Adora grinned back.

The night continued uneventfully. Adora sang 'Mr. Brightside' for her solo. It wasn't particularly good, but she had fun. She joined Bo and Glimmer for 'Summer Nights' as the chorus which suited her just fine. Catra and Khyle trotted out 'Do I Wanna Know' and it was predictably excellent. Saliha surprised the crowd with a devastatingly emotional 'Jolene'. Bo wailed through 'Where Have All the Cowboys Gone?'. Lonnie and Khyle tore through 'Bring Me to Life' and looked especially dapper in their complimentary

single-breasted burgundy and teal suit jackets. Adora was shocked that Lonnie was a soprano.

At some point, Glimmer stumbled over to Catra's table and pulled up a chair next to her. She had been inhaling drinks for hours and seemed to have completely forgotten her enmity for the other woman. If Catra's body language could be trusted, she did not seem particularly pleased with the social call and ensuing conversation. They continued talking, or most probably arguing, for the next couple of songs.

Bo followed Adora's gaze and leaned across the table.

"I told her not to bother her."

"What are they talking about?"

"Glimmer wants Catra to sing something."

"Ooh, that's not gonna go well."

"That's what I said."

Glimmer pointed aggressively at Adora and Catra crossed her arms and sighed. She said something pointedly to Glimmer and got up. She stalked up to the stage and muttered something into Sea Hawk's ear. A grin split his face and he typed something into the machine. Catra went back to her seat and sat down in a huff. Khyle said something in her ear and she waved him off.

Glimmer returned to the table with a big smile on her face. Bo raised his eyebrows.

"She's actually going to do it?"

"Yup." Glimmer was clearly pleased with herself.

"You know she hates that song."

"Yup."

“You know *why* she hates that song.”

“Bo, I’m not taking criticism right now. I’m doing my best friend a favor here.” She gestured to Adora who looked confused.

Adora was about to send Catra a quick text when she saw the woman stand up, take a deep breath, and put her sunglasses on the table. Khyle gave a whoop and Catra flipped him off as she hopped onto the stage and grabbed the mic. Sea Hawk fiddled with the light and Catra nudged him away with the toe of her shoe.

“Can everyone stop being so extra for one fucking minute?”

Sea Hawk went back to the machine, chastened, and pressed play.

Disjointed yet sultry music spilled out of the speakers and Catra rolled her shoulders and settled into a relaxed stance with her eyes closed.

I've been a bad, bad girl

I've been careless with a delicate man

And it's a sad, sad world

When a girl will break a boy just because she can

She opened her eyes half-way and peered out from between her eyelashes.

Don't you tell me to deny it

I've done wrong and I want to suffer for my sins

I've come to you 'cause I need guidance to be true

And I just don't know where I can begin

Catra turned her gaze on Adora and the corner of her mouth quirked up.

Ooh, what I need is a good defense

'Cause I'm feeling like a criminal

And I need to be redeemed

To the one I've sinned against

Because he's all I ever knew of love

Catra swayed her hips and crooned into the microphone. Adora was feeling uncomfortably warm. Glimmer winked at her over her shoulder. Adora tried to glare back but couldn't tear her eyes off of Catra as she slunk up and down the mic stand. Languidly, she straightened her posture and opened her eyes to bore them into Adora's.

Let me know the way

Before there's hell to pay

Give me room to lay the law and let me go

I've got to make a play

To make my lover stay

So what would an angel say the devil wants to know

She slumped into a more suitably sultry pose through the last two choruses and slipped off the stage before the outro faded out. Everyone cheered because of course they did. At their table, Khyle clapped Catra on the back. She looked miffed as she slid her sunglasses back on but did take a moment to shoot Adora a smile before sinking into her seat.

Before long, Adora found herself getting bored. It was fun to watch everyone sing, but as everyone slid past the point of fun

drunk to sloppy drunk, it had started to devolve. Everyone participated in a disorganized ‘Don’t Stop Believing’ and Glimmer slurred through a questionable ‘Everytime We Touch’. It wasn’t all bad: Merve, in slightly better spirits, did a fine job with ‘Fuck Me Pumps’, and Lonnie killed ‘Take Me to Church’.

When Sea Hawk stumbled onto the stage and jaunty organ music filled the bar, Adora felt her phone buzz.

Catra (02.01): get out quick

Adora (02.01): what’s happening?

Catra (02.02): i’m saving your life. get your stuff

Adora wasted no time fleeing the bar to find Catra waiting for her with her blazer on.

“Where’s the fire?” Adora asked.

“Nowhere yet. I’m saving you from suffering through Hawkins’ sea shanty bullshit.”

Adora laughed, “How kind of you.”

Catra shook a cigarette out of her pack, popped it between her lips, and lit it.

“You wanna get out of here?”

Adora shrugged, “Yeah, kinda. I’m bored. But what about the others?”

“I told Khyle I was dipping out. Just text Sparkles in a bit unless you’re really dying to deal with her right now. We’ve got about 8 minutes until anyone notices we’re gone.”

“Is that how long the song is?” Adora asked in disbelief.

“Oh yeah, that asshole always does Mariner’s Revenge Song when he’s too drunk to remember the words. It’s agonizing.”

“Charming.”

“Very. You have everything?”

Adora nodded and Catra offered her arm. “Then off we go.” Adora took it.

They made their way out of Kaleiçi and down Işıklar. They turned onto Catra’s street and Adora asked, “Are we going to your place?”

“No. I’m taking you somewhere.”

“Where?”

“You’ll see.”

“You know what? That’s my fault for asking.”

Catra laughed and squeezed Adora’s arm a little tighter. After a couple of turns, they made it to a giant stone staircase built into the cliffside. Adora was very glad that Glimmer hadn’t talked her into heels as she hopped more than stepped down the uneven steps with only the full moon to guide her. Catra descended nimbly and effortlessly and Adora tried to keep up but was genuinely concerned about cracking her skull open were she to misstep.

Eventually, they turned a corner and the sea opened up before them, vast and quiet in the still air. No matter how many times she saw it, the sea filled Adora’s heart with joy and she took a moment to fill her lungs with a deep draught of salty air. They descended to a somewhat rickety looking platform and sat down. Heedless of their fancy clothes, they both laid down on their backs and stared up at the hazy sky in comfortable silence. Adora took a moment to send a quick text to Bo announcing that she’d left before turning off her phone.

After a while, Catra handed Adora her tightly folded blazer and Adora took it but was unsure why exactly she was holding it.

“Put it under your head, dummy.”

Adora did as she was told and smiled up at the sky. The silence stretched to the stars, the soft murmur of the sea providing a gentle rhythm to accompany her lilting thoughts. Silence usually unnerved Adora and she was usually desperate to fill it with speech or activity, but it was different with Catra. Their conversations always ebbed and flowed, sometimes hurried dialogue punctuated with laughter until dawn, sometimes this for hours. They often laid in proximity in quiet, more often they wrapped themselves around each other and listened to the other’s soft breathing and calm heartbeat. Just being in Catra’s presence leeched the permanent tension from Adora’s muscles and gave her a sense of peace so rare in her life thus far.

Adora turned her head and spied Catra’s hand resting on the wood next to her. Slowly, she reached her hand over and linked their pinkies. Without looking, Catra turned their hands and entwined their fingers. Adora thought that she heard her let out a soft sigh and her heart skipped a beat. She continued gazing at Catra’s profile made ethereal in the moonlight, her blue eye visible and trained to the sky.

Adora could feel her resolve crumbling. Her mind was consumed with thoughts of Catra: her wry smile, her smooth olive skin, her mismatched eyes, her lips that Adora longed to know against her own, the way her head tilted back when she laughed that high-pitched squeak of a laugh, the way she drew Adora out of her shell, the way she unthinkingly handed her a makeshift pillow in concern for her comfort, her unfathomable loyalty to those she deemed worthy, her strength and fierce independence, the warmth that radiated off of her and sunk into every crevice of Adora’s being.

Adora tried to speak, but her voice came up airy and hoarse. She hadn’t realized that they had been laying there that long. It had been hours if the lightening sky was to be trusted. She cleared her throat.

“Catra?”

“Hmm?”

“What are you thinking about?”

“The vast, empty void of space.”

Adora giggled. “Really?”

Catra smiled. “No.”

After a beat, “So?”

“So what?”

“Tell me what you’re thinking about.”

Catra slowly sat up onto her knees and stretched lazily. Adora mimicked her motions and angled herself to face Catra with their knees touching. Catra held her gaze with a heady intensity that left Adora breathless.

“There’s something that I want to do. Something I’ve wanted to do for a long time.”

Adora saw Catra’s eyes leave hers and flick down slightly. She swallowed and did everything in her power not to stutter as she said, “You know what they say. Follow your dreams.”

Catra took a deep breath and cupped Adora’s face in her hands. Adora’s skin erupted in gooseflesh at the contact and as Catra gently pulled her forward, her heart nearly pounded out of her chest. She kept eye contact until they were mere centimeters apart and then let her eyes close just in time for Catra’s lips to meet hers. The kiss was slow and languid and filled with months of suppressed longing. Adora’s hands reached blindly forward until they found Catra’s hips. She grasped them and pulled the other woman toward her until they were both resting on their shins but otherwise flush together.

Catra entwined a hand in Adora's hair and ghosted her tongue over the other woman's bottom lip. Unthinking, Adora parted them and allowed their tongues to meet. She felt Catra sigh into her mouth and the warmth coursing through her veins grew to an inferno. She wrapped her arms tightly around Catra, hoping to communicate the true depth of her happiness and just exactly how much this meant to her.

Eventually, they broke apart to breathe. Catra pulled them together again and so the cycle continued for either a minute or an infinity. As far as Adora was concerned, it didn't matter. They broke apart and sat cross-legged and shoulder-to-shoulder. Adora took Catra's hand and brought it to her lips briefly. Catra linked their fingers together. They didn't talk about what had just happened, opting instead to enjoy each other's presence.

Adora wasn't sure what to make of the way Catra rubbed at her eyes and frowned. She also didn't know what to make of her clipped responses, the previously absent tension in her shoulders, how slow she was to smile. Still, Catra had kissed her over and over again. Even now, Catra held her hand tightly, strangely tightly, as if she were afraid to let go.

Adora chanced, "Are you okay?"

"Yeah, princess, just a little tired. We were up literally all night."

Adora was unsatisfied, but before she could press, they heard voices coming down the stairs, and the spell of the night was broken. Wordlessly, they got up and gathered their things. As the people, two women and a man, drew closer, they reluctantly dropped their hands and began the climb back to the road. Once there, Catra glanced around before grabbing Adora's hand again.

They walked in silence until they reached Catra's apartment. Adora was unsure why they weren't just heading up – Catra's bed seemed to be the most logical place to continue the night/morning. Catra turned to her and offered a strained smile.

“Think you can make it home okay?”

“I’m going home? What’s wrong? Did I do something wrong?” Panic tinged Adora’s voice.

Catra shook her head vigorously, “No. God no. You’re perfect. It’s just, I don’t think you coming up right now is the best idea.”

Adora cocked her head. “Why?”

“I don’t think I can be, uh, gentlemanly right now with you there.”

Adora wanted to scream in Catra’s face that ‘gentlemanliness’ was the complete opposite of what she wanted. She wanted Catra on top of her. Or to cuddle and sleep. Whichever was on the table. She was stopped from voicing this opinion by the look on Catra’s face. Her lips were contorted into a grimace and she was having trouble meeting her eyes. Her arms were wrapped around herself and she looked, well, *small*.

Adora’s voice softened. “Hey, is everything okay?”

Catra nodded and forced herself to meet Adora’s eyes. Adora’s heart sunk at how sad she looked.

“Don’t worry about me, princess. I’m okay.”

“Okay.” Adora pulled Catra into a tight hug and she felt Catra nuzzle gently into her collarbone which soothed her worries that everything was ruined beyond repair. “Call me later, okay?” Adora felt a nod and heard a muffled ‘okay’ against her chest. They pulled away and Catra leaned up to press the ghost of a kiss to Adora’s cheek.

“Bye, princess.”

“Bye.”

As Adora walked to the bus stop in the gathering morning heat, she tried to suppress the cold dread snaking through her veins.

Something was clearly wrong with Catra, and she hoped beyond hope that it wasn't something she had done. She couldn't pinpoint any behavior of hers that would have been particularly offensive. Besides, Catra had been weird before she even came into the picture last night. Even if it didn't have anything to do with her, Adora was still concerned for her friend or whatever they were now. Friend seemed safest. Should she have forced her way up to Catra's apartment and demanded a heart-to-heart? No. She would've hated that.

Catra would tell her about it when she was ready.

Chapter End Notes

> Haha, look at these useless lesbians finally smashing their faces together.
>
> Tune in Saturday for when the bass drops.

Summer pt. 2

Chapter Summary

"Aslancığım?"
"Hmm?"
Saliha had switched to English, "Are you okay?"
Catra realized that she had allowed herself to stay beneath Saliha's arm for much longer than usual and casually slipped out to stand and light another cigarette. Saliha appeared to be searching her face for something and Catra was glad for the protection of her mirrored aviators.
"Yeah, I'm fine. Just tired, Akrepciğim."

-

In which the inevitable rears its ugly head.

Chapter Notes

Welcome to the second half of Above the Vaulted Sky. Thank you for reading so far.

This chapter is where most of the more unpleasant tags come into play, so here are some content notes:
- frank depiction of mental illness, more specifically cognitive distortion, intrusive thoughts, and suicidal ideation
- reference to and non-graphic recollection of sexual assault, it's the big italic part near the end if you want to avoid it

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Day after day, day after day,

We stuck, nor breath nor motion;

As idle as a painted ship

Upon a painted ocean.

Water, water, every where,

And all the boards did shrink;

Water, water, every where,

Nor any drop to drink.

-"The Rime of the Ancient Mariner" Samuel Taylor Coleridge, 1798

Catra awoke the next afternoon, as she had every day for the last several months, covered in sweat. When confronted with the small slivers of blistering light peeking through her curtains, she slammed her eyes shut. She felt hungover, which was odd considering that she'd only had a single beer the night before. No, something else was wrong. She gave moving her limbs a try but found them more akin to lead and gave up, opting instead to clear the murk from her head.

What she found there was less than pleasant. At the front she found a memory from the previous night, her hands cupping Adora's face as she brought her in for a kiss, the sea murmuring below them. Sometime in the last few hours, however, this memory had become corrupted. The giddiness when Adora had brushed her hand, hooking their pinkies together had been replaced with abject embarrassment. The elated anticipation of watching her lips get closer until she finally closed her eyes was gone, choking dread in its place. Worst of all, the explosion of warmth upon their lips joining, the slight tickle of their hair touching each other's cheeks, the pressure of Adora's hands on her hips, that was dismissed in favor of a thick, impenetrable wall of self-loathing.

Catra found that she had begun pressing the heels of her palms into her eye sockets hard enough that colorful spots danced in the corners of her vision. She removed them with a hiss, and her eyes were able to fly open with a sudden realization: *You stupid bitch, you've ruined everything*. The clarity shocked her, the simple, unarguable truth of it. The voice was an old friend, a biting version of her own overlaid with the smoky, calm and lightly accented tone of her mother. *What the fuck were you thinking? What the fuck did you think you were doing?* She let her arms fall to her sides as she stared at the ceiling, rapidly remembering all of the terrible things about herself that she had so stupidly managed to forget. *You worthless idiot, you tricked that nice girl, tricked her into thinking you're more than sludge wiped off a boot onto a dirty mat, tricked her into believing you're not foul and tainted*. *You're just like them, just like him, just like her. You're a fucking monster.*

Catra dimly wondered when she had ended up on the floor, on her knees in child's pose with her arms wrapped tightly around the back of her head. At some point, she had also started crying, evidenced by the hot tears pooling in her elbows and leaking onto the floor. She stayed like this, unmoving save for the rapid rise and fall of her chest punctuated by racking sobs, for quite some time. Her thoughts remained mostly unchanged, cycling through the same diatribe of worthlessness and accusation, skewing more vitriolic as time crept past.

Somewhere, she heard a knock and Khyle's voice. Rather than give away her compromising position, unsure she could even speak around the fist-sized knot in her throat, she opted to squeeze her head tighter and say nothing. After a few moments, footsteps receded and she heard the TV click on in the next room. This interruption of her meltdown brought her back to reality for a few moments and she realized that she had to go to the bathroom, she needed water, and that her back was killing her. These realizations meant very little to her leaden limbs and raging mind, so she stayed where she was. *Useless*, her brain whispered

over and over, a litany almost calming in its familiarity. *Useless, Useless, Useless.*

Hours passed in this way until Catra heard the door open along with a muffled, "Oh fuck." Khyle knelt down next to her and gently pried her arms off of her head. From deep underwater, she heard, "Bise. Hey, Bise, what happened? What's going on? Hey, could you look at me?" She felt a hand gingerly turn her chin, and she opened her eyes to look at Khyle who gazed at her with a mix of concern and sadness. Guilt washed over her and energized her to move. She attempted to untangle but found that both of her thighs had fallen asleep, so she tumbled onto her side. "It's okay, Bise, I've got you," Khyle said as he scooped her up and pressed her back into his chest, rubbing at her thighs to kickstart the blood flow. Catra groaned as pins and needles filled her legs, but the pain did cut off a new train of thought: *Look what you've done, you've hurt him. He has only ever been kind to you and all you do is destroy him one day at a time. He doesn't love you, he just wants to fuck you, and you're a bitch for not letting him. It's all you've ever been good for you fucking—*

As the pain in her legs ebbed, she managed to choke out,

"Hey."

Khyle smiled at the squeak in her voice and brought up a hand to run through her hair.

"Hey, Bise. What's up?"

Catra pushed her head into the contact when he began to scratch at her scalp.

"Nothing much, how about you?"

"Oh, you know, same ol' same ol', bout to start a crappy anime. Care to join me?"

Catra coughed out a sound similar to a laugh. "Okay, but I need to pee."

Khyle chuckled at that and moved to raise them both to their feet, steadying Catra by her waist when she swayed. Eventually both her legs and vision stilled enough for her to shakily make her way down the hall to the bathroom. She heard Khyle reluctantly wander off as she relieved herself and then gazed at herself in the mirror in horror. She was a mess; her eyes were a puffed up mixture of pink and angry red, her skin was sallow and covered in dried tears and mucous, and her hair was bunched up and frizzed beyond belief. *Ugly* bounced around her head like a pinball as she washed her face and blew her nose.

Ugly, unlovable, only good for one thing and even that followed her out of the bathroom and into the living room where Khyle was waiting for her. He patted the couch next to him and when she sat, he handed her a glass of water. She sucked it down like she had never seen water before, and Khyle took the glass and refilled it from a pitcher on the coffee table. "Slow down a little," he said before putting it in her waiting hands. She nodded and obeyed, taking slow sips until the water was finished. Khyle hummed in satisfaction, took the empty glass and turned towards the TV.

"How do you feel about high school gambling?"

"I'm for it," Catra said with a small nod, bringing her knees to her chest and making herself as small as possible in the corner of the couch.

Khyle turned on the show but paid it little attention. He was more focused on watching Catra from the corner of his eye as she stared blankly at the TV. He knew better than to ask what had happened last night or what was happening now. This was not his first rodeo with what Catra called her Doldrums, a word she had described as the maddening stagnation of the sea around the equator.

He had first noticed that something was off shortly after they had moved in together. Catra had walked around in a daze, barely eating, barely sleeping, going to work and coming home with a look in her eye that reminded him of the one in his sixteen-year-

old sister's after their father had torn her freshly born baby from her arms and sent it off to a distant relative's never to be seen again. This was not right.

This had lasted about three weeks by the time Catra started coming out of her fog. One night she had brought home a bottle of tequila and slammed it down in front of him, a desperate sadness painted on her face. After they had finished the 750cl by themselves, she had slurred out an explanation, a disjointed account of how she got sad sometimes but that it was no big deal because it always went away. It was already starting to go away now, so she could finally be fun again. *I need to be fun*, she had said with a high-pitched laugh, *If I'm not fun, I'm not worth shit to anyone*. She had kissed him them. He had been too drunk and confused at the time to do anything but kiss her back, and when she had pulled away, tears had streamed down her face. They had never discussed it, and it had never happened again.

He learned three years ago that that had been a mild one. He would never forget holding onto her at 3 am as she sobbed into his chest like a scene out of a shitty Turkish drama. One night, he had come home late to a cryptic note on the kitchen counter. His stomach had dropped and he'd taken off running. He had found her at the park near their apartment looking over the edge of a cliff at the churning waves below. Wind had whipped at her hair and she had only worn a tank top and boxer briefs with no shoes despite the winter chill. *Hey*, he had said, trying to keep the tremor out of his voice, *Whatcha doin'?* She had turned around and stared at him wide-eyed, her expression completely empty. Terrified, he had approached until he was close enough to grab her hand and lead them back over the guard rail. The second her feet had touched the pavement, something seemed to crack because her eyes had filled with tears and she had buried herself into his chest, sobbing and shivering with cold. He had wrapped his jacket around the both of them and held her for what had seemed like forever before leading them back to the apartment, putting Catra to bed on the couch and taking the other one for himself.

Bad ones like that didn't happen often, Khyle reminded himself, subtly watching as Catra dragged her nails up and down her upper arms but not hard enough to leave more than small whites lines. The evening before, he had hung out with her in the bathroom while she had clipped them, teasing her about being over-eager. If he had been paying attention, he might have noticed that her grin hadn't quite reached her eyes.

This will be okay, he thought, not feeling convinced.

After four solid hours of watching anime, Catra remembered that she was a person that lived in the world. Silently, she stood up. Shooting Khyle a wan smile, she went to her bedroom and grabbed her phone. When she returned to the living room, she found that the show had been replaced by Spongebob, a gesture that brought a genuine smile to her face. He was a good friend. *You don't deserve this. You're worthless. You destroy everything you* – she tamped down the line of thought long enough to take a steadying breath and unlock her phone. It was long past midnight, so she had plenty to look at. About 60 of the messages were from the English department group chat and instead of opening it, she asked Khyle, "What's all this bullshit?"

"They announced that we're going back a week earlier than usual. Everyone is whining about it."

That meant that she had 8 days to get her shit together enough to go to work. Nothing she hadn't done before.

"Jesus, whose bright idea was that?"

Khyle shrugged, "Maybe if you were nicer to Sinem, she could make the big boss change his mind."

"Fuck no, I hate that bitch."

Khyle laughed at that, relieved that Catra was speaking again and present enough to be salty.

Catra looked at her other missed messages: a couple from the band group chat, something dumb from Sea Hawk about karaoke, a video of her singing the night before from Glimmer, and finally, something that made her heart sink.

Adora Gray (07:16): hey, I just got home. I had a great time tonight. good night/ morning <3

Adora Gray (13:30): good morning/afternoon! what are you up to today?

Look what you've done. Look what you've done to this poor girl. You always do this. You trick people into thinking you're good, that you're anything more than worthless trash, and you hurt them. You goddamn—

"Bise?"

Catra realized that tears had filled her eyes and quickly scraped at them with the back of her hand. She needed to be done with that bullshit.

"Yeah?"

"What are you looking at?"

"Adora messaged me. She said she had a good time last night and then said good morning."

"Oooooh, look at youuuuu," Khyle teased, and then a little more cautiously asked, "So what happened last night?"

"I took her down to the swimming spot and we hung out until the sun rose. And then I kissed her."

"Daaaaaaaamn, Bise, smooth," he replied with a low whistle, "Did any of the morning swim amcas[1] see?"

Catra laughed half-heartedly, "No."

"Too bad, they'd love it," he grinned and then realized that the tears pooling in Catra's eyes were threatening to spill again. "What's wrong? That's good, right?"

Catra stared at him, unable to tell him that she was broken and empty and unworthy despite knowing it to be true. She couldn't find a way to explain that she knew that she should feel happy and hopeful but instead she felt like the fire inside her that had driven her to kiss Adora had sucked up all of the oxygen inside of her and snuffed out, leaving her hollow. How could she tell him how she existed only to take the beautiful and pure in this world and warp it into her own hateful, muddied image?

Jesus, you're dramatic, the inner voice that was solely her own managed to murmur before it was quickly smothered by a torrent of self-loathing. Realizing that she hadn't spoken in a while, Catra shrugged in Khyle's direction.

"I don't know."

Thankfully, Khyle let the conversation drop soon after as he realized that he wasn't going to get any more out of her that night. Without a word, he brought pillows for them to sleep out in the living room. Catra was thankful that he had seen to it that she wasn't alone. *He is a good man*, her inner voice whispered among the din of shame.

Hours later, as dawn began to filter through the drawn curtains, she laid awake, half listening to Spongebob still playing on the TV. Her thoughts had settled a bit but only because they were focused on a single point. She looked over at Khyle snoring softly on the other couch, considered waking him up, telling him about the plan taking form in her mind, telling him about the conviction flowing through her.

No, she thought, *he shouldn't have to deal with this.*

--

Catra spent the next week as if made of stone. She drifted from room to room with glassy eyes and tight lips. Not the strongest sleeper at the best of times, she was barely managing a couple fitful hours each night, deepening the permanent dark circles under her eyes into puffy bruises. She ate when Khyle would put food in her hands and physically watch her eat it. She spoke when spoken to but little otherwise; the rest of the world she mostly ignored. Spurred on by Khyle, she had typed out a couple word reply and a smiley to Adora but had ignored any subsequent messages. When the groupchat had asked her what she was bringing to the welcome back breakfast on Monday, she had confirmed her usual two dozen hard-boiled eggs. When it was appropriate, she had paid the water and electric bills at the shop across the street.

Even at her lowest, Catra was functional. This, she told herself, was why this wasn't a problem. She was aware that the way she was feeling wasn't exactly normal, but she was hardly normal herself. She had been keeping it together for this long – never missing work, always paying rent, keeping up with her obligations. *This is what it means to be an adult*, Catra thought as she climbed onto the toilet to push the tile above it up and to the side. She grabbed hold of a thick pipe and gave it experimental tug. When it didn't budge, she let her legs go slack and held on. Just like the last time she had checked, it groaned and shifted slightly.

So much for that.

--

Catra rose from a sleepless night at 6 am to get ready for her first day back at work after summer break. She paid little attention as she took a cold shower, toweled off, and dressed in a freshly-ironed blue-striped linen button-up and clean skinny jeans. She tucked in the front and rolled up the sleeves. She massaged mousse into her mane of curls and blow-dried it. She flipped her hair back up and immediately loosed a cloud of hair spray. When she eventually looked in the mirror, she knew she would have to do something about her face or she would never hear the end of

it. She picked out a concealer from a small bag by the sink and rubbed the orange-beige liquid into the marks framing her eyes. For good measure, she applied a little eyeliner and mascara. She gazed at herself for a moment longer, hardly recognizing the face gazing back into her. *That must be me.* She blinked slowly and the face blinked back.

Distantly, she heard Khyle moving around his room, so she went to the kitchen to make him coffee. She stared at the kettle as it rumbled to life. *Why do you even bother,* her mind offered as if to keep her company, *you know you're just going to fuck it up. You're going to ruin those kids. They need you and you trick them into trusting you and then you fuck them up. Just like Snezhana.* She poured the boiling water into the waiting French press. *Don't get on the shuttle today. No one would notice. Take the KL08 to the spot in Lara. No one would notice*. She slowly depressed the plunger. Her own voice took over for a moment to whisper, *Adora lives in Lara. She goes running in the mornings. What if she found you? You don't want that.* Catra had to admit that it was a compelling point as she poured the coffee into two carry mugs. Khyle emerged right on time and gratefully took the offered mug. He looked bleary. They gathered their bags and offerings for breakfast and slipped on their shoes at the door. They made their way to the bus stop to wait for the shuttle, leaning on each other's shoulders, already sweating in the early morning sun.

Work was uneventful. When they entered, the English teachers' room was an explosion of chatter: brash declarations of how much everyone was missed, wonder at the tans everyone had gotten from time spent at the seaside, excited recitations of summer adventures, and exaggerated malaise that it was coming to an end. Khyle wandered off towards the primary school teachers. Catra dumped her things at her desk and made her way through the throng to plop down next to Merve who looked unimpressed at the whole display.

"You look like shit, Catra."

"Missed you, too, Mermaid."

The two spent most of the morning together, Merve occasionally breaking off for her duties as High School English Department Head. With Merve off in meetings, Catra endured the same conversation with a colleague more times than she could count: *Did you do anything fun this summer? You always go somewhere interesting. You look tired. I went to my family's summer home in Kaş, it was so relaxing*. When it became too much, Catra escaped outside to the smoking area outside the gate. There she was trapped into small talk with the middle school art teacher, mostly nodding absently until the gym teacher appeared and clapped her on the back.

Catra gazed up at Saliha who had wrapped a tight arm around her shoulders and was rambling at her in rapid-fire Turkish. Catra responded when appropriate, dimly wondering, not for the first time, if the tall, muscular woman had a crush on her. It was common gossip around the school that Saliha was a lesbian with her short poof of white-blonde hair with neatly shaved sides and the fact that she was halfway through her 30's without a husband or boyfriend. In that respect, Catra tended to slide under the radar despite making only a cursory effort to hide herself. Her hair was long and her lack of make-up and propensity to wear men's clothing was dismissed as a foreigner's quirk. When she said that she didn't have a boyfriend, her colleagues were shocked but assumed that she simply didn't care for Turkish men or just hadn't met the right one. She was an enigma to them which allowed her ample space to hide.

"Aslancığım?"

"Hmm?"

Saliha had switched to English, "Are you okay?"

Catra realized that she had allowed herself to stay beneath Saliha's arm for much longer than usual and casually slipped out to stand and light another cigarette. Saliha appeared to be searching her face for something and Catra was glad for the protection of her mirrored aviators.

“Yeah, I’m fine. Just tired, Akrepciğim.” As expected, the use of the nickname put the other woman at ease.

Eventually the day ended and Catra skipped the shuttle in favor of walking. Khyle had gone out for a beer with a couple of the history teachers. He had insisted that he would go home with her when she declined the invite, but she had been just as insistent that he go and have fun. Catra wandered up Işıklar, peering up at the familiar buildings as well as the tourists dumb enough to be out at this hour. The Europeans looked miserable waiting for the tram with their lobster sunburns. She watched a man attempt to communicate with a waiter in a café, desperate for a latte with dairy-free milk. She paused, watching both men get more and more flustered. Eventually, she stepped down and told the waiter what the tourist wanted in Turkish and wordlessly walked away, ignoring the calls of thanks in both English and Turkish. *All that fuss over two words*, she thought.

She made her way into Kaleiçi and down to the harbor, sparing a glance at the shitty after-hours bar where she had watched the sunrise many times before. She could barely remember most of those times, but her brain was kind enough to fill in the blanks and recall every embarrassing memory she ever had even vaguely involving a bar. Reflecting on that, she stared out at the sea, masts of tour boats inexplicably painted to look like pirate ships bobbing on the waves. There was a gentle breeze that reeked of bilgewater, but it was a breeze nonetheless. She sat down on a bench where Sea Hawk had once allowed her to cling to him when she had taken too much ecstasy after drinking too much rakı. He had told her stories of pirates and damsels in distress and swashbuckling adventure for hours while she had clenched his hand and thigh as if both of them would float away at any moment. This was usually a funny story told at parties as an explanation as to why Catra didn’t do ecstasy, but today it brought her nothing but shame for wasting a kind man’s time and betraying a friend by getting too intimate with her boyfriend.

Enough time had passed that her bench was no longer in shadow, so she got up. A man yelled the word ice cream at her, cycling

through five different languages to see which might get her attention. None of them did. She took a different route back but wished that she hadn't when she passed Castle Bar, a restaurant overlooking the sea that Catra had planned to take Adora on their first real date. It would've been a real power move, taking her there for dinner around 5 and sticking around until the light began to wane and the sky lit up with colors. Catra would have cleverly slipped the waiter a fifty to hold them the table in the Western corner so Adora could experience the full display of the sun setting over the Mediterranean like something out of those shitty romance novels she was writing.

As if she would have said yes to a date with you, something purred, *after you forced yourself on her. You can tell yourself she wanted it, but you know. She was scared.* Catra remembered the night that she kissed Adora, the image skewing to reflect the assertions. *You're just like him. You're just like her. Worse because you agreed to it, were practically begging for it*. Images of the Gaziantep Fiasco flooded her mind, usually reserved for when she closed her eyes at night. They did not match the words that her mind was telling her, but she was too distracted to care. Head down, she kept walking.

The next two weeks passed uneventfully. Catra woke up, she went to work, she came home. She had been invited out both by friends and coworkers several times but hadn't gone. Glimmer had been particularly insistent, demanding to know the last time she had left the house. It had only been a few weeks, but Glimmer had always had a radar for when Catra found herself in the Doldrums. Catra had eventually acquiesced to getting yelled at about Adora or whatever and agreed to a beer.

When Glimmer saw her, she barely suppressed a gasp. Not eating or sleeping for three weeks had taken a toll on her body. Her movements were sluggish, her hair was lank, and she had dropped a few kilos.

"Geez, Catra."

“What?”

“You know what. What’s going on with you?”

“Nothing, Sparkles, just a little tired.”

When Catra rubbed her eyes under her sunglasses, Glimmer caught a glimpse of the bags underneath them.

“Take off your sunglasses.”

“Hell no, I can barely look at you with sunglasses let alone with the glare of the sun on the literal sequins you’re wearing. Who the fuck dresses like they’re going to a club at noon on a Sunday?”

“That’s rich coming from someone who looks like a 14 year old boy that hasn’t showered in a year and calls people racial slurs on Xbox Live.”

Catra glanced down at her outfit of orange swim trunks and a home-cut Death Note tank top and shrugged.

“You know what? Fair.”

In one fluid motion, Glimmer snatched the glasses off of Catra’s face.

“Hey, fuck you!” Catra attempted to school her face into a coherent glare but just looked tired and small as she instinctively hunched.

“Holy shit, when’s the last time you slept?”

Catra tried to reach for the glasses but Glimmer held them out of her reach.

“Just a few days, get off my jock.”

“Dude, no, you look like a corpse. What’s going on?”

"I'm a little sick, okay? It's something about the seasons changing. You know, allergies."

"That's not how allergies work, but okay. Seriously, how are you feeling?"

Glimmer handed the sunglasses back and Catra gratefully affixed them to her face.

"Just tired. And hot."

"No, I mean, like, emotionally."

"What do you mean?" Catra asked warily.

"Well, you haven't been out, Khyle won't answer any questions about you, and did you *seriously* never call Adora back after you kissed her? You guys have been dancing around each other for *months*."

Adora's name sent ice through her veins. She had spent the last three weeks convincing herself that she had forced herself onto Adora and that the only logical thing that the other woman could do was loathe her.

"I can't face Adora. Tell her I'm sorry."

Glimmer made a face. "For what?"

"For kissing her like that."

"What?"

"We were just hanging out as friends and then I couldn't control myself and I fucked up her night. I don't even know if she likes girls, so here I am this predatory lesbian stereotype or whatever. Just tell her I'm sorry." Catra's head had sunk to the table, eyes trained to the horizon as she was buffeted by waves and waves of shame.

Glimmer stared at Catra, eyes narrowed and mouth slightly agape as she fought the urge to violently shake her friend.

"Catra."

"What?"

"*Catra*."

"*What?*"

"What in the ever-loving *fuck* are you talking about?"

"Look, don't make this harder—"

"Okay, no, 1, Adora is extremely gay and there is *no way* you don't know because *I* told you that when I *set you up*. 2, she is extremely into you. 3, holy shit she would not shut up about that stupid kiss for a week when we all thought you were already *together*. You are *not* a predator, where is that even coming from? What number was I on? Oh yeah, 4, she thinks you don't like her anymore cause you never called and she never sees you and instead of being sad or mad about that, she is literally just *worried* about you."

Catra gazed at the horizon.

"I'm also worried about you. I know what it's like to have depression. It's hard to be alone inside your head, but sometimes it helps to talk about it."

Catra straightened and swiveled her head to look at Glimmer.

"I'll keep that in mind," she said, flatly.

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That night, Catra laid in bed as she did every night with her eyes wide open and staring at the ceiling. Every time she dared to close her eyes, she was met with graphic images, some memories

and some of her own design. The one thing that they all had in common were the swirling feelings of fear, rage, and despair coloring each one no matter the subject. Today's main feature was the Gaziantep Fiasco, an especially popular show these last three weeks.

Catra had spent the last three years trying to forget about it and for the most part had. It occasionally popped into her head when she was showering or alone in the house at night. It had been three years; she should be rid of it by now, especially since it wasn't that big of a deal. She knew people who had been through far worse, and it was weak of her to think that she deserved to feel as bad as she did.

Even with her eyes open, she remembered how excited she had been to fly to Adana to meet up with *her*, an old friend who had confessed her long-time crush. They had hooked up once before that, right before *she* had moved away, in an alley in Kaleiçi. While it hadn't been particularly satisfying because both women had been wasted, it had still been a desperately-needed confidence boost for Catra. She remembered how smug she had felt when *she* had offered to fly her out to Adana and then drive them both to a swanky hotel in nearby Gaziantep for the weekend. Khyle had high-fived her on her way out, wished her a happy sex trip, and demanded a bag of Antep fıstık[2] as a souvenir.

Catra closed her eyes.

Catra knew that something was wrong the moment she stepped out of the airport. The woman she was meant to meet was standing outside of a car waving her over. She got in and was introduced to the man driving the car as her boss who was doing her a favor. Catra greeted him as politely as she could around her suspicion. The woman assured her that the man knew about them and that he was okay with it and just wanted them to be safe in the Eastern part of Turkey. "How noble of him," she said. After two and a half hours of driving, they arrived at the hotel. When the man came in with them, she grabbed the woman's arm and hissed, "What is he doing?" She assured Catra that it was normal

in this part of the country. Catra had been to the Southeast once and this sounded wrong but she chose to let it go when she was told he would leave after a cup of tea. After the cup of tea, he waited while they went up to get ready to hit the pool. Later, Catra watched from the side of the pool, carefully outside of his field of vision, eyes narrowed as he stared lovingly at the woman as she splashed around. Eventually, he did leave and Catra wasted no time informing her companion that their escort was in love with her and might try something later. She was swiftly reassured that that was not the case. Catra shrugged and allowed herself to be dragged into the empty steam room for further reassurance. While they were getting ready for dinner, the woman informed her that the man would be picking them up in an hour and a half. Catra was irritated and skeptical but eventually accepted the explanation that it was in their own best interests to have a man with them, especially if they wanted to go to a club afterwards. "What fucking club? This is Antep," she had protested but again relented. At dinner, Catra was finally sure what the plan for the night was. The man fed the woman and looked very pleased with himself while Catra glared daggers at him and refused to answer with anything other than curt and thinly-veiled digs. On the drive back to the hotel, the man hopped out of the car to grab snacks and a bottle of vodka. She turned to the woman and told her in no uncertain terms that he was not coming back with them and that she wasn't doing whatever bullshit he seemed to be expecting. She looked panicked, promising her that she would convince him to leave. She did not try to convince him of anything, and he did not indeed leave. Back at the hotel, Catra dragged the woman into their room and practically shouted that this was not going to happen. She would just leave. The woman had broken down in tears begging her to stay, that she would be fired if she didn't stay, that he would tell her parents about her and they would kick her out. He was just going to watch, he had promised not to touch Catra. The sob story continued for a while, Catra's protestations growing weaker until the woman left her alone in the bedroom. Fuck, she thought, where do I go at 1 am in Gaziantep? She's lying to me, but what if she's not? What if he does hurt her? What if, what if, what if. Catra sighed deeply and

bitterly, walking into the sitting area of the suite and refusing to make eye contact as she poured and took three shots of vodka in quick succession and rinsed them down with red bull. If I'm going to do this, she thought as she took shot after shot until the fifth was empty, I might as well be drunk.

The next morning, Catra watched the dawn light filter in through the blinds. She felt absolutely nothing except the ache of broken promises between her legs. The man stirred and touched her arm and she pulled away as if burned. Snarling that she wasn't drunk enough for this shit, she stalked out of the bedroom, slammed the door, and sat on the couch in the hotel robe, the nothingness inside of her filling up with seething rage. She ground her teeth and covered her ears as she tried not to listen to what was happening behind the door. It definitely wasn't good. Fifteen minutes later, the woman came out, head down, and walked slowly to the bathroom. The shower rushed to life. When she finished, she came over to the couch and sat down, sniffling pathetically. With a sigh, Catra opened her arm and the woman snuggled up to her chest whispering apologies that it wasn't supposed to be like this.

Catra opened her eyes and glanced at the time on her phone. It was quarter past 3. Filled with a sudden urge to take a walk, she stood up and pulled on a tank top. She decided that her boxers would suffice and quietly left the house. The night was still and muggy, and she walked down Eski Lara with her flip-flops in hand. After 45 minutes, she stopped at a staircase that led down to the newly opened beach. Two years ago, back when it was just an empty platform, she had convinced Khyle to skinny dip with her in the cold January water on one of their midnight walks. Now she veered to the right and climbed down a couple of boulders. She looked down the five story drop to the rocky outcrop below. The sea was nearly still, gently pushing up against the cliff. *Do it*, something whispered in a voice different from her usual thoughts. *Take the step, you will feel so much better, so much relief,* дете. It was her mother.

The voice was soft, gentle, almost loving and so unlike Snezhana. *I have got you,* дете, *you can do it*. The other thoughts typically warring in her skull settled on a brief armistice to cheer their agreement. *Do it. It's easy. Even you can't screw this up. You deserve this.*

Cut it out! her own voice shouted over the din. She closed her eyes and felt her mother's hand on her cheek, a rare moment of affection from the cold woman. She imagined the sigh she would breathe as she fell, those last few moments before nothing.

This isn't normal anymore, this isn't okay.

Just one step.

Catra flexed her toes against the edge of the rock.

--

Khyle was pleasantly dreaming when he was awoken by someone shaking his shoulder and whispering, "Khalil." He bolted upright in bed and looked at Catra who immediately wrapped her arms tightly around herself. She looked tiny, and he was awash with a sense of déjà vu. With a start, he realized that she had called him by his real name and his eyes widened.

"Catra? What's wrong?"

"I need to go to the hospital."

Chapter End Notes

amca: translates to uncle, but like teyze is an term of respect for older men [▲]
antep fıstık: pistachios. As you can guess from the name, Gaziantep is famous for them.[▲]

Well, here we are.

The next chapter features a bit of narrative deviation where the POV is split between Adora and Catra.

Fall pt. 1

Chapter Summary

> “Welp,” Adora offered.
> “Welp,” Glimmer returned.
>
> --
>
> In which help is sought.

Chapter Notes

> Thank you for sticking around. This chapter starts out with Adora's POV but quickly shifts to Catra's for the majority of it. Can you imagine if I made you read a full Adora after the end of the last chapter? That'd be so mean.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora was pulling her hair out. It had been three weeks since the karaoke night, since Catra had kissed her, and she hadn’t heard from her at all beyond a couple of robotic messages. No one had. It was like she’d disappeared off the face of the earth and everyone was maddeningly unconcerned. When she had first arrived, she’d seen Catra around at least four times a week, and as they’d gotten closer, that had increased to six or seven. Everyone she talked to shrugged and said that this was normal. Catra sometimes vanished for a few weeks, but she always came back as if nothing had happened, as if it were the most normal thing in the world.

A week before, she had cornered Sea Hawk outside of a bar with a rack of shots to ease him into a friendly interrogation. He had been just about to let something useful slip when Merve had found them and he had dropped right back into his idiot swagger act. She had gotten more or less the same out of Bo who had just shrugged but had looked a little nervous. Glimmer overall had been the least tight-lipped, though she was clearly keeping more

to herself than she was letting on. Unlike the rest of them, she at least seemed concerned.

Khyle had been simultaneously the least and the most helpful. A week after Catra had kissed her, when her sadness and disappointment had been fast approaching fever pitch, Adora had received a cryptic text from him reading *you didnt do anything wrong. please just give her time*. He hadn't given her any details or any more information in either text form or in person. Changing tack, she had started messaging him every couple of days, simply asking if she was okay. He always replied *yes* in a timely and dutiful fashion. It assuaged her worries, but this melodramatic secrecy was about to give her an ulcer.

Adora was sitting in the living room with Bo watching TV when Glimmer entered the house and roughly kicked the door closed. She dropped her stuff in the kitchen and plopped down in the armchair next to the couch. She looked irritated and drummed her fingers on the chair absently.

"Hey, Glimmer," Adora ventured.

Adora noticed her and Bo sharing a look, and Glimmer grimaced.

"Just tell her," Bo sighed.

"Tell me what?"

"I saw Catra."

Adora started. "What? When?"

"Just now. We met up."

"Why didn't you tell me?"

"I'm telling you now," Glimmer snapped.

Adora's lips curled into a frown, "How is she?"

Glimmer sighed. Adora didn't like how she rubbed at her face and looked defeated, a rare look on her. "Bad."

"What do you mean 'bad'?" Adora fought to keep her voice even.

Glimmer seemed to consider her words carefully. "She looks exhausted. Thinner."

"What's wrong with her?"

Glimmer shrugged, "She's depressed."

"Glimmer…" Bo warned.

"What, Bo? Why can't I say it? She clearly is, and I'm tired of all of us pretending that she doesn't have problems. It's fucking stupid."

Bo looked visibly uncomfortable. "It's not really any of our business."

"She's our friend! And we've been letting her run around doing insane shit for years because she's fun at parties."

"What kind of insane shit?" Adora interjected fretfully.

Bo ignored her, "If she wants to tell us, she can tell us."

"She's never going to tell us if we just ignore it! Do you know what mania does to your brain over time? Cause I do! My family swept my Aunt Rosie under the rug for years and now she's drooling in a nursing home talking to *angels*."

"What are you two *talking* about?" Adora all but yelled.

Glimmer turned and said to Adora matter-of-factly, "Catra's bipolar."

"Blimey, Glimmer, you can't just call someone that."

"It's not an accusation. It's not a bad thing. It's just a thing that is true. She has manic episodes. She has depressive episodes. She has bipolar disorder." Glimmer looked at Bo as if she were talking to a particularly dense child. "And she needs help."

"Come on, Glim, she used to do a lot of stuff. We all did."

"Nuh uh, not like that. You were on that boat, Bo. You saw how scared she looked. We all could've died."

"That's a touch dramatic, love. The fire was an accident."

Glimmer crossed her arms, "No it *wasn't*. Sure, okay, it was small, but what if we hadn't gotten her back on and she'd drowned, huh? We should've taken her to the hospital then and there, but we were all fucked up and thought we were having a grand ol' time."

Bo was silent.

"We are *bad friends*." Glimmer hissed. She looked furious.

Adora was speechless, and it was around that time she checked out of the conversation. She pushed away her irritation at being left in the dark and was instead a little heartbroken that Catra had thought she had to hide this from her, from everyone in her life. She focused her anger on her friends, those that had ignored and enabled what sounded like a dangerous set of behaviors begging for help.

Wordlessly, she went to her room. She pulled out her phone and called Khyle. He didn't pick up. She sent him a text asking if Catra was okay. Ten minutes later, he replied *yes* and Adora nearly chucked her phone at the wall in frustration. The feeling of powerlessness was familiar and she hated it with every fiber of her being. She felt like a child again, standing over her mother passed out on her bedroom floor. She would do the best she could to rouse her and get her into the shower so she wouldn't be late for her shift at the supermarket. At the time, she had thought she was helping.

Before she could spiral into an unending hell of what-ifs, she rubbed at her temples and headed back to the living room. Bo had retreated elsewhere and Glimmer sat alone where Adora had left her. She looked less angry and more generally unhappy. Adora sat down on the couch.

The silence was thick until Glimmer finally spoke, "I didn't expect you to like her this much."

Adora laughed mirthlessly.

"Either of you. I figured you could work out some tension on each other and that would be that. Nothing messy. Then we'd all be friends. I'd get to see my best friend happy and nothing would change." Glimmer sighed. "Have my cake and eat it, too, and all that."

"Welp," Adora offered.

"Welp," Glimmer returned.

Adora paused for a moment, unsure how to phrase what she wanted to ask. She settled on, "Do you think I could get through to her?"

Glimmer looked pained, "Yeah I do, but I think you should wait for her to come to you. She will eventually. Her thinking is a little… off right now. Very off. But that's the thing, she comes back. She always does."

Adora felt that Glimmer was holding back, but she chose not to push her luck. She would have to be patient. Catra would come back. Adora just had to ensure that she didn't crawl out of her own skin before then.

Khyle and Catra arrived at the emergency room about thirty minutes after Catra woke Khyle up. The building was relatively quiet at 5.30 in the morning. Catra slid the work permit that functioned as her ID to the receptionist. When the woman asked

the purpose of her visit, Catra froze for a second and then told her that she was depressed. The woman gently suggested that she wait for the policlinics to open and then head to psychiatry. Catra grit her teeth and leaned forward to murmur that she was suicidal. The woman nodded and handed back her ID, a strip of stickers with her information, and a number. The two went to sit in the waiting room that held more than one might expect at that hour.

They sat in silence until a young woman in a white coat bustled through, clearly on her way out of the building. She glanced at Catra and did a double-take.

"Catra Hoca?[1]"

Catra blinked at her, recognition sparking but not delivering anything of use.

"It is you! And Kyle Hoca, you're here, too. Hold on."

The woman walked over to a computer near the screen announcing the queue and frowned. She hit a few buttons and Catra's number flashed in bright red. The woman gestured for Catra to follow her. When he made to stand, Catra told Khyle that she would be fine without him and followed the woman into a small area curtained off from the ICU. The woman sat in a folding chair and Catra sat in one across from her.

"Maybe you don't remember me-"

"I remember you, Buse. You were in one of my classes back at English Everyday." Catra's memory had thankfully kicked back in, and she had a knack for never forgetting her students. This one, Buse, had been in one of her B1 classes back when she had worked at the cram school. She remembered the girl freaking out over not being able to pass out of her English preparatory year and start her department at Akdeniz.

"Wow, that was so long ago. You have a good memory."

“I see you passed prep.” Catra managed a small smile.

“Yeah! I’m a resident now, it’s my first year here in Emergency.” The girl beamed with pride.

“Congratulations.”

“Thank you, Hocam.” Her smile faltered as if remembering something, and she schooled her face back into professional impassivity, “Why are you here today?”

Catra grimaced, the embarrassment already flaring inside of her growing to a raging inferno. She closed her eyes for a moment, remembering the last time she had felt this much acute shame. It had been her first time in the psych ward directly after the Las Vegas Incident. After about two weeks, her mental state had deteriorated into dust and ending it all had seemed the most prudent solution for escaping the hell in which she had found herself. She had relayed this information to her psychiatrist who had immediately placed her under 24-hour watch and assigned her several essay tasks to keep her occupied. One morning before breakfast, she had sat in one of the desks in front of the nurse’s station staring vacantly at an empty sheet of notebook paper and a grainy handout about coping skills. She hadn’t looked up when the other patients had filtered in for breakfast and had given her a cursory glance before returning to themselves. She had, however, looked up when the door of the ward had opened and in had walked Chelsea Sanderson of Honors Pre-Calculus, already in her school uniform. It had dimly registered that Chelsea must be Dr. Sanderson, her psychiatrist’s, daughter. The two had made eye contact, the horror on their faces a grisly match, and Chelsea had sprinted out the way she had come.

That was 12 years ago, Catra reminded herself, *Grow the fuck up.* Catra opened her eyes and met Buse’s patient gaze.

“I’m having some psychiatric problems. I’m thinking about suicide. I, uh…. have a history.” Catra trailed off and ran a hand through her hair.

Buse nodded seriously and took out her cell phone. “Let me call my friend. She’s a psychiatry resident and she’s on shift tonight. I know you speak Turkish, but her English is great, and it might be easier for you.”

Catra was immensely grateful. She had not been looking forward to explaining her history and emotions in any language, but English sounded less daunting.

Buse left with a small wave and a gentle command not to go anywhere. Twenty minutes later, a petite woman a bit taller than her took the seat across from her and introduced herself as Aslı. It was a Sisyphean effort, but Catra managed to answer the questions posed to her honestly, not even lying about what specifically had brought her there. She knew that admitting that she had been making plans put her at risk of admittance, but she was too tired to come up with a lie.

She told Aslı about her Incidents and the Doldrums in as much detail as she could. Many of them were foggy at best. She relayed her medical history which consisted of two weeks of anti-psychotics and a week of anti-depressants, both of which had made her feel and act worse. Aslı frowned when she rattled off her previous diagnoses from high school and college.

“Do you know if Bipolar Disorder runs in your family?”

“I know something does, but my mother would rather die than admit it.”

Aslı hummed knowingly. “And none of your doctors have ever talked to you about Bipolar I?”

“No.”

“You fit many of the diagnostic categories. I don’t know why they would have skipped over it.”

“I, uh, might not have been completely honest with medical professionals in the past.”

“That’s okay. I’m glad you’re here now, Ekaterina.”

Catra sighed and didn’t bother correcting her, “Me too.”

--

Three weeks later, Khyle entered the apartment and was met with the recently unfamiliar sound of someone strumming a guitar. He slipped out of his shoes and carefully dropped his bag by the door. He crept through the living room and stood by the open balcony door. Catra’s back was to him as she faltered in her playing and turned to her laptop to check the tab. After a moment, she picked up again and tentatively began to sing, voice barely audible over the guitar.

I was alone, falling free

Trying my best not to forget

What happened to us, what happened to me

What happened as I let it slip

Catra paused a moment and checked the lyrics before continuing.

I was confused by the powers that be

Forgetting names and faces

Passers by were looking at me

As if they could erase it

Khyle sat quietly on the bench. Catra shot him a glance over her shoulder but didn’t stop playing, launching into the chorus. She repeated *Baby, did you forget to take your meds?* four times, each time slower and more drawn out. Here she stopped and turned around.

“Go on, I like this song.”

Catra grimaced. “It’s not too on the nose? I feel like a teenager wailing out my feelings.”

“Well yeah, but at least I didn’t catch you playing Fall Out Boy again.”

Catra feigned offense. “You just don’t understand me, old man.”

“You kids and your zeitgeists.”

In the comfortable silence that followed, Catra took a long drink straight from a pitcher of water filled with lemon slices.

“Soooo,” Khyle began.

“Yeah?”

“How are you feeling? Really and for truly?”

Catra looked thoughtful, “Not bad, actually. Still nauseous and no matter how much water I drink, I’m still thirsty. I might as well get a drip and a fucking catheter at this point.” She took another slug from her pitcher, narrowly avoiding a spill.

“Good good, what about…?”

“You don’t have to be weird about it, bro. I feel… even, I guess? Definitely not crazy. Not happy, not sad, just pretty chill. Better after the adjustment last week, for sure.” Catra nodded, slightly embarrassed. She was the bro being weird about it, she realized.

Khyle nodded. “That’s good. So when are we adding Meds to the setlist? If I have to play Chop Suey! one more time, I’m fucking quitting. Rogelio can deal with it.”

“Mm, hard pass, but we could totally wreck Special K if you’re dying for some Placebo. You can be the grimy grunge boy you were always meant to be.”

Khyle flipped his hair into his face and struck a pose. Catra snickered.

Truthfully, it was difficult for Catra to describe how she felt. After that meeting with the psychiatrist, she had been admitted to the hospital for 24 hours to run some bloodwork and make sure she didn't do anything drastic in the meantime. It had taken a lot of convincing, but she had finally accepted the prescription of Lithium and was allowed to walk out. She had almost surprised herself when she had filled it and had taken it as directed. It wasn't a big adjustment on her lifestyle yet, but it would be. She had to lay off alcohol and coffee, two of her favorite things, but maybe it was for the best. She had been binge drinking at least three nights a week for as long as she could remember and she was getting old enough that the hangovers were catching up to her. It probably wouldn't kill her to dry out a little.

If she were being honest, she didn't feel much of anything, but that in itself was a relief. The intrusive thoughts had mostly vanished, and she was able to sleep again. On bad nights, she took half a benzo and managed nearly a full night of sleep. When she slept, she didn't have nightmares. In fact, she hadn't remembered a single dream since starting the medication, which was fine in her book.

The diagnosis, Bipolar I, wasn't much of a surprise. After all, in her heart of hearts, she knew that giving a manic episode a cutesy name didn't make it any less of a manic episode. She had known for years that something was different about her, but now she was finding that it didn't give her much solace to give it an official name. Quite the opposite, it was more like a sentencing. She would probably be on this medication for the rest of her life, though she was willing to admit that her life would probably end up being a lot shorter without it.

She had taken a few days off from work when she first went to the hospital. The students hadn't been back yet, so all she had missed were posturing speeches from administration and some nausea-inducing team-building exercises. Merve hadn't asked any

questions and Khyle had been sure to fill her in on all the mind-numbing minutia and slightly-more-interesting teacher gossip.

Khyle had done so much for her in the last six weeks. Both at work and with their friends, he had run almost constant interference. Everyone was at least somewhat curious where she had disappeared to, and Catra couldn't blame them, but Khyle had kept her condition to himself. Even though it was dramatic to say, Catra couldn't deny that he was her rock. He was always there, always around to sit quietly with her and watch TV or play video games, always around to tell jokes and force a laugh out of her, always there to pull her into a hug when she fell too deep into herself. They had taken to sleeping on the couches in the living room. She knew it was so he could keep an eye on her, but she was happy not to be alone at night.

That summer, she had gotten used to sharing a bed most nights, albeit platonically and with someone fully clothed, and she missed it. More to the point, she missed Adora. It had taken a couple of weeks on the medication, but she had managed to untangle her distorted thoughts and memories of the night that she had kissed her. Now she was sure that she had blown her shot, not because she was a devious predator, but because she had kissed a woman that had enthusiastically kissed her back and then proceeded to ghost her for 6 weeks. Well, she didn't necessarily ghost her – she had sent one short message in week 4 and then another one last week – but what she had offered was in no way good enough and Catra was acutely aware of that.

It wasn't that she didn't want to message her. Quite the opposite, now that the students were back, she wanted to inform Adora of all the dumb shit they said and did. She wanted to hear about the other woman's day, about that dorky coffee club she had with Perihan and co., even about the jock shit she got up to in the gym. She wanted Adora to casually put her arm around her when they were watching TV. She wanted to hear that bright, clear laugh. She wanted to feel her strong arms wrapped around her, to feel her heartbeat against her back. She wanted Adora to nuzzle her neck and tell her everything would be okay.

However, and this was the rub, it didn't matter what Catra wanted. She found it unlikely that Adora didn't hate her at least a little bit, but she did concede that she was perhaps not giving the woman enough credit. Sure she could tell herself all day that she was holding back for Adora's benefit, but the truth was that she was embarrassed. She was embarrassed of her mental illness, mortified to admit her weakness and bring light to the secret that she'd been hiding from everyone, including herself, for 13 years.

She supposed she had to eventually, but that day was not today.

--

A week later, Catra was leaned up against a wall in the front garden on lunch duty. Her arms were crossed and she was surveying the boys playing basketball and other students milling about with profound disinterest. She glanced at her watch. She still had 30 more minutes of standing there and she was already ready to claw her own eyes out.

She grabbed her water bottle off the window ledge next to her and chugged. She was so goddamned thirsty all the time that she had to stop herself from drinking too much in a day or risk becoming a puddle. With great restraint, she replaced the half-empty bottle on the ledge and sighed. In the corner of her eye, she saw a tall boy sit down on the bench next to her self-designated leaning spot. He stole a couple of awkward glances in her direction before speaking.

"Hi, Catra teacher."

She turned her head and regarded him over her sunglasses.

"'Sup, dude?"

"Nothing."

He fidgeted a bit, mostly clutching at his hands or running them through his short black hair. He wasn't some random student. Catra had known him for years and had been his teacher in

middle school before Merve had snatched her up to the high school. The two were close. It was Catra he had nervously told that he was gay in 8th grade. It was Catra who had fiercely defended him when his peers had bullied him mercilessly. It was Catra who had spent hours convincing the guidance counselor not to tell his hyper-religious parents on him when he had made the heart-breaking miscalculation of coming out to the wrong authority figure. It was Catra who had spent hours with him in the library after school assuring him that everything was going to be okay, that even though the world was dark and terrible and full of injustice, everything was going to get better for him. To be fair, it had gotten incrementally better. Now that he was in 10th grade, his peers had collectively decided that being gay was cool, at least the girls had, and now only the boys leveled slurs at him away from prying eyes where they could still get away with it.

"What's going on, man? You look stressed." She didn't change her position, but she did remove her sunglasses to look at him more clearly despite the sun stinging her eyes.

He glanced around nervously to check that everyone was out of earshot and leaned over the arm of the bench. "I met someone."

"Oh yeah?"

"Yeah."

"Cool."

"He goes here."

Catra raised an eyebrow, "Oh? Anyone I know?" She, of course, knew everyone.

He looked around again and Catra rolled her eyes but leaned down so he could speak low in her ear.

"Bora."

"There are like ten Boras here." She whispered back.

“11A Bora.”

Ah yes, she knew the kid. He played basketball but kept his hair long and shaggy and wore ratty black converse with black wrist bands as a form of low-level uniform-related rebellion. He was nice enough and had a passion for English that came with all the music he consumed. Just the other day after class he had commandeered the smartboard and had enthusiastically pulled up this “cool older band” he had discovered. She had laughed and felt ancient when it had turned out to be Nine Inch Nails. Her goal this year was to feed him as much music cooler than Nirvana as she could.

“Nice kid.” She had straightened back up and now had her hands shoved into her pockets.

He nodded. “Yeah. He asked me to hang out at a café this weekend. Just us.”

“Well, shit, dude, look at you.” Catra grinned at him and tousled his hair. “You gonna go?”

He giggled and slapped her hand away. “I don’t know! What if it’s a joke or something?”

“I doubt he’d do something like that. He doesn’t seem like that kind of person.”

He gazed into the middle distance. “No, he doesn’t.”

“Then it’s probably fine. He probably just wants to hang out with you.” Catra got serious for a moment. “For real, though, if you have a genuinely bad feeling, like a cold dread in your gut that tells you it’s a bad and dangerous thing to do, then listen to it. Or if something seems fundamentally wrong. Always listen to those feelings. But if it’s just nerves or self-doubt, don’t let it talk you out of doing something that might make you happy. You can end up wasting a lot of time that way.”

Catra shrugged and leaned back against the wall. “It’s up to you, though. Do what feels right.”

He looked thoughtfully at her and nodded.

“Yeah okay, that makes sense, I guess.”

“Hey, did you eat lunch yet?”

“Uhh… no?”

She sighed, exasperated. “What are you out here talking to me for? Go eat lunch. You’ve only got ten minutes left. Shoo!” She waved him off.

He laughed a little and the two fist-bumped.

“Fiiiiiiine. Bye, teacher.”

“Later, nerd.”

Catra watched him retreat back into the building. Ata seemed happier this year, less fragile. She hoped that things would be as okay for him as she’d promised time and time again. She hoped that she gave good advice and wasn’t leading him astray. It wasn’t particularly easy to be gay in this country, especially not for a teenager. She wanted to tell him about herself, let him know that he wasn’t alone, but that secret was best locked in a tight vault. Her work life and personal life were separate for a reason. A few calls from a vindictive parent could put her out of a job in a heartbeat and slap her right on a blacklist. Instead, she settled for hinting, and she assumed he had picked it up on some level.

The warning bell sounded and she kicked off the wall. With a deep breath, she boomed to the garden that it was time to get inside or that she’d drag them in herself. On her last sweep before going inside, she spotted some shuffling behind a tree on the side of the building. Upon closer inspection, she saw two 9th grade girls attempting to scale the fence and escape. They were not doing a good job. Catra watched them struggle for another

minute or so and when it was clear that they weren't going anywhere anytime soon, she approached. They didn't notice her until she leaned on the fence next to them and said, "Ladies."

They both balked and nearly fell down. Looking guilty, they climbed to the ground awkwardly.

"Sorry, Catra teacher."

"You should be apologizing to yourselves. That was pathetic."

They looked at her in confusion.

"First off, you tried to hop the fence at the end of lunch when you knew I'd be coming by here. Were you trying to get caught? Second, I'm gonna have to get on Saliha Hoca about what she's teaching you in gym class because that was sad."

She pulled a small pad of pink paper and a pen out of her back pocket. The girls' eyes widened.

"No, wait, please, we're sorry!"

"Shut up." She scribbled a few things on two pieces of paper and ripped them out. She handed one to each of the girls.

"Get to class. And get it together. I'm embarrassed for you."

The girls looked at each other in confusion but decided not to question their sudden good fortune and scurried off towards a side entrance.

Catra hadn't felt the need to bust them. They were overall fine students, if a little vapid, and she found their little escape attempt somewhat endearing. It almost made her feel nostalgic for high school, though she, of course, would never have gotten caught. Besides, she didn't imagine these girls capable of getting into half of the nonsense she'd gotten up to herself.

She had a free period and wasn't excited about marking the stack of crappy essays taking up space on her desk, so she took her sweet time making her way back to the teachers' room. She peeked into the art room where they were watching a movie. Typical. She wandered over to the gym and watched Saliha prance around enthusiastically while leading some miserable-looking teenagers in jumping jacks. She headed upstairs and glanced into a classroom to see Merve facing off against a traditionally difficult student. She did not envy him.

As she crashed the other teachers' room for the good tea, her mind wandered to her conversation with Ata. She reasoned that she had given him decent enough advice, and she also reasoned that it was perhaps advice that she might want to consider taking herself. She had been avoiding everyone but Khyle for weeks. She knew she didn't owe her friends every detail of her life, but it probably wouldn't kill her to be the slightest bit candid. It wasn't as if they didn't know that she had some sort of mental issues – many of them had been there when she had set a boat on fire. Others had seen her curled up in an alley hiding behind a dumpster mumbling about the shadow government. They'd seen her go from normal to dead-eyed and slack for weeks before bouncing back as if nothing had happened. At the time, she'd always blamed drugs and lack of sleep, but they were all sharp enough to see through it if polite enough not to say anything.

And then there was Adora. Adora deserved an explanation. Catra definitely owed her that. She would probably never want to speak to her again, but it was something she had to do for the sake of being a decent person. A part of her hoped that Adora would forgive her and they could maybe be friends and with time, possibly more, but she ultimately found more comfort in steeling herself for the worst.

She found the English Department teachers' room completely empty which was surprising but hardly unwelcome. She sat down at her desk and pulled out her phone. For a while, she stared at a certain chat window. Her thumbs hovered over the keyboard before she finally began to type. After a few seconds, she erased

everything and started over. That, too, was erased. After three more attempts, she thumped the phone back onto the table and glared at the wall in a huff.

"God*dammit*."

She grabbed her phone again and before she could talk herself out of it, she hit call. It rang twice before the line picked up.

"*Catra?*"

"Hey Adora."

Chapter End Notes

Hoca: This is a versatile word that in this context means teacher. You put it after someone's name to make it a title. Hocam means "my teacher." I personally much prefer being called hocam than teacher. It just has a nicer ring to it. However, if someone asked what my job is, I wouldn't say hoca, I'd say oğretmen which is the more literal word for teacher.[▲]

Fun fact: In the first draft of this, I had a full page of madcap antics surrounding Adora interrogating her friends. I eventually cut it for the sake of tone. I also retooled quite a bit of angst. Overall, I think this makes for a decent-enough transition chapter.

I realize that this chapter is a bit short, but I promise that the next one will make up for it.

Fall pt. 2

Chapter Summary

> "What are we?"
> Catra choked on her water and devolved into a violent coughing fit. *Oops.*
> "Fuck," Catra gasped out, "Are you trying to kill me?"
> Adora shrugged, "Possibly. You okay there, champ?"
>
> --
>
> In which our heroines are reunited.

Chapter Notes

> A bit of a longer chapter to make up for last week. And yes, this is my second Prufrock quote. It's "The Love Song of J Adora Prufrock" and you cannot change my mind.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Would it have been worth while

If one, settling a pillow or throwing off a shawl,

And turning toward the window, should say:

> *"That is not it at all,*
>
> *That is not what I meant, at all.*
>
> -T.S. Eliot, "The Love Song of J. Alfred Prufrock, 1915

Adora sat in a café sipping at a latte and tapping her feet nervously. She was still 15 minutes away from her meeting with Catra, and she had already been sitting there for half an hour. When Catra had called her the day before, she had been ecstatic.

This is what she'd wanted, an opportunity to talk. Now, though, now she was filled with enough anxiety to choke an ox.

She had spent weeks thinking about what she would say to Catra were she to see her again, but all of the meticulously-composed speeches and clever platitudes seemed to have vanished in a puff of smoke. For now, she was stuck with vague feelings of sadness, compassion, and more than a twinge of irritation at being left out in the cold for two months. Ideally, she wanted to do a nice combination of hugging, screaming at, and possibly kissing the other woman.

Catra arrived at the agreed upon time of 6 right on the dot. Adora saw her scan the café until her eyes, or rather those damned sunglasses, landed on her. A little hesitantly, if she didn't know any better, Catra walked over to the table and took the seat across from Adora. Catra was dressed in a crisp white button-up with the sleeves rolled up tucked into a pair of bright blue chinos. She must've come straight from work, which made sense considering that it was a weekday. Catra removed her sunglasses and hooked them into her collar. She rubbed her eyes quickly before fixing her gaze on Adora.

"Hi."

"You're alive." Adora immediately regretted her sharp tone when Catra flinched.

Adora tried again. "It's really nice to see you."

Catra ran a hand through her hair and looked up at her shyly. "Yeah, you too. I'm sorry I didn't call earlier."

"It's okay."

"No it's not."

"No, you're right, it's not."

A waiter appeared and asked Catra what she wanted. She ordered water, the biggest one they had or two of the half liter ones.

“No coffee?”

Catra looked embarrassed. “Uh, no. I already had a cup today.”

“Since when has that stopped you?”

“Since about a month ago.”

“Unfortunately, I wouldn’t know much about that.” Adora was snappier than she wanted to be, but she couldn’t help it.

Catra squirmed. “No, I guess not.”

“How about you enlighten me?” Adora crossed her arms.

Catra rubbed her eyes again. “Right, you’re mad at me. That’s fair. You should be mad at me.”

Adora sighed. It had only been five minutes and this was already going terribly. “Ugh, no, I’m sorry I’m being like this. I’m not mad at you. I mean, clearly I am a little. I was just so worried about you, and I still am. Are you okay? I promise I’m happy to see you.”

Catra offered her a tiny smile. “You were, um, right to be worried about me. I’m okay now, though.”

“Look, Catra, you really don’t have to tell me if you don’t want to. You look like you’re about to pass out. We can talk about whatever you want”

Catra huffed out a laugh, “No, no. I do have to. I owe you that much.”

“You don’t owe me anything.”

“Geez, Adora, let a girl bare her soul.”

Adora laughed a little around her nerves. “Okay, okay, sorry. Go on.”

Catra’s smile faded into a grimace, and she ran a hand through the hair around her scalp. “So, this is something I’ve never really talked about before. That’s why I’m acting like such a weirdo. I don’t know how much the others told you, but I kind of have a history of questionable behavior.”

“They didn’t tell me jack shit.”

“Hm, yeah, I guess they wouldn’t. Right, okay, so sometimes I get into this fucked up headspace, I guess, where I get really depressed and there’s nothing to do but ride it out. They usually only last a few weeks and then I’m fine again, no big deal, right? This one, though, was, um, really bad. Like, dangerously bad. So I went to the hospital and they, well, started me on some medication.”

Catra paused. Adora watched as she seemed to debate whether or not to continue. Eventually, Catra took a deep breath and Adora heard her mumble *fuck it*. “You know what Bipolar Disorder is, right?”

“More or less.”

“Alright, so the depression gets paired with something worse. Usually, I can handle the depression no problem, but then there are the other things. I get paranoid and go off the fucking rails for a week or two. It’s dumb, but I’ve always called them ‘Incidents’ even though they’re really just manic episodes. I guess I’ve always known that. Crap, I’m not explaining this well. Okay, uh, oh wait, remember the first time we went to Taka Meyhane and I got mad at Sea Hawk for trying to tell a story about me and a boat?”

Adora nodded.

“That was one of them.” Catra ground her teeth. “I set his fucking boat on fire. I thought there was an assassin on the boat, so I lit

‘er up and dove into the sea like it was a fucking spy movie. They had to drag me back up kicking and screaming. I don’t remember how we got back to shore, but they got me home and Khyle had to lock me in my room.” Catra’s speed and volume picked up. “Oh, and another time when I was a kid, I freaked out about the color green and drove to Las Vegas and almost froze to death in a river but luckily just fucked up my shoulder permanently. I mean, *shit*, dude, I’ve had a death wish since I was a teenager.”

Catra went quiet and gripped the table. Adora waited.

“There’s a reason I’m telling you all this. I need you to know these things about me.”

“Why?”

“So when I apologize, you can make an informed decision.”

“Catra—“

Catra held up her hand. “I’ve got a flow going here. Just let me get through this.”

Adora shut up but leaned forward.

“Adora, I am so sorry. I’m sorry for hiding this from you. I’m sorry for playing with your emotions and hurting you. I’m sorry for leaving you in the dark. I’m sorry for never calling and letting you wonder if I was alive or dead. I’m sorry that I am a pain in the ass and a bad friend.”

Adora regarded her for a few moments, carefully letting the words wash over her. She was feeling a bit overwhelmed. It was heartbreaking that Catra had felt that she had to suffer in silence all these years, but she still had questions. There was so much more that she wanted to know, but she zeroed in on the one burning a hole through her skull even though she feared its answer most of all.

“Are you sorry you kissed me?”

Catra started. “What? I, uh… That’s really the first—“ Catra sputtered a bit but managed to compose herself, “No. I’m not. That was me. That was something I wanted to do, had wanted to do.” She hesitated. “Should I be?”

A soft warmth bloomed in Adora’s chest. “No, you shouldn’t.”

Catra let out a breath. “Okay. I, uh, there’s another thing I should tell you. This kind of thing might happen again. Theoretically, it won’t because of the medication, but I’ve never been on anything like this before, so I don’t know.” She grimaced, “My brain is fucked for life. But, um, if it does, I promise I’ll at least warn you about it. I can feel them coming on.” Here, Catra seemed to remember something and her shoulders sank, “That is, if you still want to be my friend after this. You shouldn’t feel obligated to.”

Adora could’ve laughed right in her face. Instead, she grabbed Catra’s hand where it fidgeted on the table and squeezed.

“Oh my God, shut up. I forgive you.”

“What?”

“I forgive you? Did you seriously think I wouldn’t?”

Catra shrugged, “I don’t know. I wasn’t really expecting anything.”

“Catra, you have a mental illness. Yeah, it was shitty that you ghosted me.” Catra winced. “But you got help and apologized and that’s good enough for me. We haven’t even known each other that long, but you’re already basically my favorite person. You can’t get rid of me that easily.”

Catra smiled, maybe smirked if Adora didn’t know any better. She also thought she might detect a blush, but it was hard to tell with Catra’s skin tone. “I’m your favorite person?”

“Yes.” Adora nodded seriously.

“You’re such a dork.”

Adora let out a surprised laugh at the tease. “Yeah, I know.”

Both women burst into laughter, the tension between them finally waning. Adora rested her head in her upturned palm. “So how has work been?”

And Catra told her. She told her about her classes, the good ones that she can laugh with and the bad classes that make her want to rip her hair out. She told her about the other teachers, the brewing romance between the art teacher and the history teacher, how the history teacher’s wife had showed up in the middle of the school-day to scream at the principal for letting such impropriety happen under her roof. She told her about a boy who had come to her for advice about another boy, how she hoped that the maybe-date would go well. She told and told and told, and Adora listened. While she listened, she took in the other woman, the way her hands flitted to and fro as she got more animated, the way her voice rose and fell with each story, the light in her eyes. She was almost able to ignore the dark circles and the unmistakable glint of fatigue, how much thinner she looked. It wasn’t as bad as Glimmer had said, but it was still noticeable. Adora also noticed a slight tremor in Catra’s hands, had noticed it when she first sat down, had attributed it to nerves, but now saw that it was more than that.

It was hard to stay mad at Catra. Sure, she had some residual ire swirling around her gut, but it was colored with something far more powerful, something bright and airy and warm that curled its way around her heart and softened all the hardened edges. She longed to take the other woman in her arms then and there, to let this feeling fill them both from the conduit of her chest. She longed to bring their lips together, apologies and pardons and conditions forgotten below them like crumbs swept off a table. Yes, Adora *longed*, but there was not much that could be done about it in the middle of a well-lit café. Catra had stopped speaking and was gulping at her second bottle of water like someone was going to take it away from her, so Adora opened her mouth, giving little thought to what might come out of it.

“What are we?”

Catra choked on her water and devolved into a violent coughing fit. *Oops*.

“*Fuck*,” Catra gasped out, “Are you trying to kill me?”

Adora shrugged, “Possibly. You okay there, champ?”

“Yeah, yeah, I’m fine. Ugh, what a fucking question. Um, friends? We’re friends, right?”

“Duh. Are we just friends?”

“Oh. Well, I suppose that depends on you.”

“On me?”

“Of course. I’m the one doing an extended apology here.”

“How in the world are those two things mutually exclusive?”

“Cause I’m relinquishing control?”

“That’s dumb, Catra.”

“No, it’s not. It’s, I don’t know, polite?”

“That’s even dumber. How about this? You tell me what you want and I’ll tell you how I feel about it.”

“Oh come on, that sucks.”

“I mean, possibly a little. But maybe I’m possibly a little punishing you for making me agonize over this question for two months.”

“All right, fine, that’s fair. Fuck, put me on the spot. You’re lucky I am contrite as all fuck right now.”

“Uh huh.”

“Okay, so, before everything,” Catra gestured loosely around her head, “I had this plan. After I kissed you on the swimming platform, I was gonna ask you out on a date. A real one. I had a whole, like, thing ready to go.”

“Ooh, that sounds fun. What day?”

Catra laughed and ran a hand down her face. “Oh my God, is that all you have to say?”

Adora crossed her arms and smiled smugly, “What? You said you wanna take me on a date. I want you to take me on a date. This is pretty much exactly what I wanted you to say.”

“Pretty much?”

“I would’ve accepted leaping over the table to kiss me, too.” This time Catra definitely blushed. “I get why you didn’t do that one, though. We’re in public. Decorum is important.”

Catra chuckled, “Geez, princess, you really are something.”

They spent the next hour and a half chatting. It felt very normal, very calm, and Adora was on cloud nine. When they stood up to part for the evening, there was a clear excitement for Friday, the agreed upon day for the date. In front of the café, Adora pulled Catra into a tight hug that Catra returned with equal enthusiasm. They lingered there longer than they should’ve, but both were lost in the moment. Adora breathed in the familiar scent of Catra’s cologne on her neck, spicy and citrusy, while Catra buried her face in her chest and sighed. Eventually, though, they pulled apart and with a few parting words, took off in opposite directions.

Adora was nearly skipping when she got back to her apartment. She half-expected Bo and Glimmer to be waiting for her on the couch with a thousand questions like they always seemed to be, but she found herself blessedly alone. She went up to her room and sat down at her desk. She usually didn’t work in the evenings, but sue her if she was feeling more inspired than she had in weeks to write steamy bullshit. Her current project was about two

spies on opposite sides of the Cold War. There were guns and gadgets and betrayals and she was happy to have something more exciting to write about than countesses leering at stable boys for once. It was her first time working on an MLM assignment, but she was making it work – slashfic was proving to be a remarkably useful resource.

Adora had just gotten through editing her work from the morning when she heard a knock at her door. She sighed and called out, "Come in!"

Glimmer opened the door and immediately sprawled out on her bed. Adora spun her chair around and regarded the woman mussing up her bedspread.

"What's up?"

"So, how'd it go?"

"How'd what go?"

Glimmer groaned. "Come on, don't be like that."

Adora grinned. Irritating Glimmer was one of her favorite sports. "It went well. We're going on a date on Friday."

Glimmer sat up, "Really? You're going on a date with her?"

"Well, yeah, I like her, why wouldn't I?"

"Uh, cause she kissed you and then ghosted you for 2 months?"

"She apologized. Besides, you said yourself that it wasn't entirely her fault." Adora felt her hackles rising.

"I know, but don't you think you should be careful?"

"I'm an adult, Glimmer, I know what I'm getting into." Adora rolled her eyes. She knew that Glimmer was just looking out for her, but the protective act was wearing thin.

“Yeah, yeah, but what if this becomes a pattern? What if she pulls this shit every time she has an episode?”

“I don’t think it’ll happen again. Even if it does, we talked about how to handle the situation better.”

“It always happens again. That’s the whole thing about bipolar disorder or whatever she has.”

Adora bit her tongue. First, she wanted to snap. No, that wasn’t productive. She could tell Glimmer about the hospital and the medication, but she wasn’t going to betray Catra’s trust barely an hour after she had received it. The narrative was Catra’s to control and Adora knew a thing or two about the powerlessness of having that stripped away.

“We’ll deal with it if we have to. For now, we’re just going on a date, not getting married,” she opted for instead.

Glimmer let out a long breath. “You’re right, sorry. I’m just worried about you. You’ve been a mess over this and I don’t want to see you get more hurt, you know?”

Adora softened a little, “I’ll be careful.”

Glimmer flopped onto her back. “All right, fine, but, I’m still gonna call her a bitch next time I see her.”

“I doubt she’s expecting anything less.”

Glimmer paused. “Do you think… I’ll be seeing her soon? How is she?”

Adora considered for a moment. “She seemed okay. Tired. You were right. But, overall, she seems pretty much like herself.”

“That’s good,” Glimmer said in a small voice.

Adora made the executive decision that it was time for this conversation to come to an end. She turned back to her laptop

and saved the document before closing the lid.

“You wanna watch a movie?”

Glimmer peeked up from fucking up the arrangement of Adora’s pillows. “Yeah, but I’m picking.”

--

For the millionth time in the last 10 months of her life, Adora had to admit that Catra had good taste. That evening, Catra had showed up at her door right on time to pick her up. She had even come in to say hi to Bo and Glimmer who had given her a protective parents spiel that had made Adora flush in embarrassment. Catra had taken it in good spirits, reminding them that she had known Bo longer than any of them and, if anything, he should be threatening to break Adora’s kneecaps. She also reminded Glimmer of a similar speech she and Sea Hawk had given her when she had started seeing Bo. Though there was a vague undercurrent of uneasiness, everything had felt back to regular programming.

They had taken a bus into the city center and had descended into Kaleiçi. After this long, Adora felt pretty comfortable in the maze-like old city, but she suspected that Catra had taken them on a meandering journey through back alleys she didn’t recognize in an effort to disorient her. Adora hadn’t minded; she always enjoyed being surrounded by the ancient buildings and the bustling life in their narrow passages.

Eventually, they had emerged by the sea and had ducked down a dirt path that walked them past the ruins of a tower that looked like it had been snapped in half. Adora had wanted to investigate further, but Catra had yanked on her hand and had led them to an open-air restaurant that looked to be carved into the cliff. Catra had dropped her hand to pull the host aside and murmur something in his ear. The man had nodded and had led them to a two person table right on the railing. Adora had been mesmerized

by the view, the salty air, and the waves kicked up by the stiff breeze.

All in all, it was pretty much perfect. Adora noticed that Catra hadn't ordered a drink, so she refrained as well and got a plain soda. Catra warned that the food wasn't anything to write home about, but Adora generally enjoyed whatever was put in front of her, so she was undaunted. All through dinner, they kept the chat light. Adora talked about what she'd been up to. She spent the most time detailing her newest project, and Catra seemed quite interested, even going so far as to add her own ideas. Some of them weren't half bad and Adora saved them in a note on her phone.

When dinner was finished, Catra reiterated that while the food wasn't that great here, there was a reason that she had chosen this place for their first date. A smile lit up her face and she tilted her face towards the sea. Adora looked over to see the sky lighting up with the first whispers of pink, purple, and orange. She let out an undignified squeak and turned to watch the colors deepen, reflected on the glittering sea. Out of the corner of her eye, she saw Catra dig in her bag and surreptitiously swallow a couple of pills. Adora smiled. Under the table, she felt a hand touch her own, and she grabbed it before it could get away. The two women scooched their chairs a little to the side and angled them to the view so they could clandestinely hold hands more comfortably. Adora could laugh at how much like high school it felt, but she couldn't bring herself to feel anything but bliss at the utter romance of it all.

Truthfully, she had never been swept off of her feet before. Sure, she'd had relationships, but they hadn't exactly been fairy tales. She had always been too busy, too focused on studying or on advancing her career to truly commit to anything more than the superficial. There had been dinners and movies and bars and sex. They had been fun in their way, but they had been hollow at the core, distractions between exam seasons and deadlines. She had never wanted more than that, or at least that is what she had told herself at the time as she had kicked women out of her bed and

had been kicked out of beds in turn. It was always understandable; someone always had work in the morning. Now, though, now she felt that she was finally ready to grow up and let herself want more and not be dragged down by the albatross of misguided obligation around her neck. At the very least, it was a nice thought.

Adora tightened her previously loose grip on Catra's hand and felt the other woman return the pressure. They stayed that way until the sun sunk past the horizon, leaving the last vestiges of light to stain the twilight sky blue and indigo. Reluctantly, they let their hands drop as both rose to leave. It seemed the natural way forward. Catra insisted on paying the check and Adora argued for longer than necessary in a battle whose outcome had already been decided a half-hour before. They made their way out of the restaurant and headed up. When they reached the mouth of Kaleiçi, Catra turned to Adora and asked,

"Wanna do something else?"

In Adora's opinion, there was nothing that could either improve upon or detract from the evening, so she replied, "What did you have in mind?"

"Swimming."

"Swimming?"

"Yeah. We've only got a few more weeks before it starts pouring again. Let's go swimming."

"I don't have my suit."

"Since when has that stopped us?"

Catra had a point. Adora considered. She had optimistically worn matching underwear, but they weren't nice enough that they couldn't get wet. She liked swimming. She liked swimming with Catra. She also sensed that there was more to the offer than splashing around in the dark, which was plenty of fun in and of

itself. Overall, she had come to trust Catra's tendency to make plans that cast Adora as the primary agent while simultaneously obfuscating them from her.

"All right. Lead the way."

Catra grinned and took Adora's outstretched arm. Adora noticed that she was being led towards Catra's apartment and began to grow a bit concerned. When they passed it and made their way to the big stone staircase, Adora frowned.

"We're swimming here?"

"Yup." Catra popped the 'p' loudly and started down the steps.

"Why?" Adora took the stairs carefully but found it easier this time around.

"It's a great place to swim. It's close to my house. I am not letting this place get tainted by my bullshit. It's basically my romantic trump card," Catra listed out matter-of-factly, ticking each item off on her fingers.

"Oh yeah?" Adora said wryly, "You bring all the girls here?"

Catra snorted, "It's cute that you think I date."

"When's the last time you went on one?"

By this time, they had made it to the platform, luckily empty this late in the year, and Catra had wasted no time undoing the buttons on her crimson button-up. Adora looked away blushing, despite having seen Catra change plenty of times, and fumbled with the buttons of her own white and gold dress shirt.

"A real date? 3-ish, maybe 4 years ago, I think."

Adora paused halfway through pulling her jeans down. "Really? That seems so unlikely."

Catra shrugged and shook out the leggings she had just stepped out of. “Why?”

“What do you mean, why?” Adora laid her folded shirt and pants on a rock. “Have you seen yourself?”

This earned a bright laugh from Catra who took Adora’s hand and led her to the edge of the platform. “You’re not so bad yourself, princess.” Adora could feel Catra’s eyes dragging over her as she peeked down the fifteen feet or so at the inky water below them. Catra took them back a few steps.

“Be sure to get a running start. Don’t want you breaking your legs.”

“What?”

“On the count of three.” Catra counted the first two numbers slowly and then leaned up to press a kiss to Adora’s cheek. She continued up to her ear and whispered, “Three.” Suddenly, Adora was running and leaping. There was a moment of weightlessness before she crashed into the water. She sunk, feeling the water engulf her before kicking up and surfacing with a gasp. She swiped the water out of her face and looked around for Catra whom she had lost hold of in the plunge. She didn’t see her and was starting to worry when she felt a pull on her hair. She looked over her shoulder to see Catra treading water and spinning her hair tie on her finger.

“Hey!” Adora said as her hair bloomed out over the water. “Give it back!” She spun around and lunged at Catra who darted away.

“Come and get it, princess,” Catra purred and took off swimming. Adora pursued with a grin, knowing that Catra was the superior swimmer and that she wasn’t getting that hair tie back. Still, she could never resist a race. They stuck close to the cliffs and at one point, Adora lost sight of her target. She swam harder and when she passed a huge boulder, she heard a loud ‘Psst.’ She stopped

and looked up to see Catra crouched on the rock, far out of reach, with a predatory grin on her face.

"Hey, Adora."

Before Adora could properly admire her lithe form glowing in the light of the nearly-full moon, Catra straightened up, hopped to the edge of the rock, and dove back into the water. Adora continued after her, her muscles burning pleasantly from the exertion, and followed her around a particularly large outcrop. What was waiting for her there was a crumbling old building built into the cliffside and resting on a low, tiled platform. She swam over to Catra who was waiting for her at one end.

"So how does it feel to be the slowest person in the world?"

"Shut up. Not all of us are Olympic swimmers."

Catra laughed and grabbed onto the cliff face and a rock rising from the sea and scrambled onto the platform. She extended a hand to Adora, but Adora waved her off. Instead, she felt around with her feet for a hold. The sharp rocks cut into her feet, but she ignored it and launched herself up. She grabbed the edge of a tile and hoisted herself the rest of the way onto the platform.

When she straightened, she found Catra smirking at her with a hand on her hip. She whistled low. "Well, aren't you strong."

Adora rolled her eyes and shoved Catra by the shoulder which caused the other woman to laugh.

"What is this place?" Adora asked, taking in the dilapidated structure. It looked to be about five floors rising up to the top of the cliff. She noticed that most of the tiles on the platform were cracked.

"An old hotel. Apparently, the owner had a dispute with the government and had to cease construction right before they finished. It's just been sitting here for decades. We call it The

Haunted Hotel. I haven't personally seen any ghosts, but the night is young."

Adora wordlessly took Catra's hand and walked towards the building. She examined the salt-stained columns and imagined the unfulfilled vision of the architect to make a Grecian palace. She carefully stepped over the debris and ran her hand over the rough wall with its sparse spots of cracked paint so faded that the original color could only be guessed at. Catra trailed dutifully behind as Adora ascended a staircase at the end of the building and stepped onto a questionably stable concrete platform. Adora walked to the edge and gazed out at the sea. Catra stepped forward, wrapped an arm around Adora's waist, and leaned her head on her shoulder.

"Cool, huh?" Catra said, echoing the trip to the Yanartaş earlier that summer.

Adora hummed. "Can we go inside?"

"What?" Catra lifted her head and turned to fix Adora with an incredulous look.

"Inside. Can we go? C'mon, there's no way you haven't broken in here before."

"I mean, I have, but—"

"Then let's go."

Catra let out a surprised laugh and led them back to the stairs. They climbed another flight and were met with a small broken window next to a tree growing out of a grassy embankment.

Catra walked up to the tree and put her hand on a thick branch. "Okay, princess, we can go in, but you have to promise me to be careful. There's a lot of broken glass and I will not have any severed limbs on my conscience."

Adora crossed her heart eagerly. “Promise!” She watched as Catra ascended the tree and carefully angled her body into the window without grazing any of the jagged edges. Then, she slipped into the building. Adora followed Catra’s path up the tree and attempted to match the way she went through the window only to find it impossible without tearing up her back. She peeked through to see Catra looking up at her with concern. More determined than ever, she grabbed a higher branch and when it supported her weight, she arched her back and lowered herself through the window. Keeping herself taut, she used one hand to reach through the window and grab a pipe. With a quick swing, she brought the rest of her body through and landed on her feet with a soft thud. She was pretty surprised at her own grace.

Her smile was smug as she turned to Catra. “Apologize for doubting me.”

“You’re bleeding.”

“What?”

“Your arm is bleeding there, Tomb Raider.”

Adora looked at her left bicep and found what was indeed a thin bead of red making its way south. The cut was tiny, so Adora licked her finger and put pressure on it.

“It’s just a flesh wound, let’s go.”

Catra looked dubious. “You sure?”

“Yes, now *c’mon*,” Adora whined.

“Whatever you say. Now, seriously, look out for broken glass and rusty nails and whatever other bullshit is in here. I’ve only ever been here in the daytime and you are clearly a mess.”

“Okay, *mom*.” Adora took in the sight before her. Dust motes floated in the air, illuminated by the light of the moon filtering through the grimy windows and the holes in the walls. In a show

of good faith, she watched her step as she made her way through what she assumed was the dining hall. There were the splintered remains of chairs and filthy tablecloths everywhere.

When she was satisfied, she headed up a set of stairs on the opposite end of the room into what appeared to be some sort of spa area. The floor was covered in dusty mosaic tiling that crept halfway up the wall. A tiled bench was built out of a rounded arch that housed an image of what Adora assumed was some deity with the face smashed apart. There were various smash marks all over the tile and Adora scooped some of the debris into her hands to let it run through her fingers. The destruction seemed senseless. It was bleak but also hauntingly beautiful in the moonlight.

Adora headed up another flight to what were probably rooms. They were empty save for the regular broken glass and chunks of wood. What was surprising were the scrubby plants growing out of the cracks in the wall. She wondered how long it would take for this building to be fully reclaimed. One wall was already half-covered in a soft moss emanating from the many cracks. She reached back blindly and Catra instantly slipped her hand into hers.

Catra had been following silently behind Adora while she had been exploring, allowing her to take her sweet time. Adora was grateful for the space intermixed with the physical proximity. Catra seemed to just instinctively know what she needed, what she would want, and now Adora hoped that she could return the favor. She tugged Catra forward and turned her own body at the same time so that they were facing each other. She dropped Catra’s hand to place it on her waist while her other hand went to the woman’s cheek. Catra took a half-step forward and wrapped her arms around Adora’s neck. They stayed like that for a moment, gazing into each other’s eyes. Adora was captivated by the mismatched colors barely visibly in the pale moonlight, by the burn of Catra’s bare torso tempered by the tiny rivulets of water that ran down from where her wet bra pressed against her.

Adora felt that she could barely move except to lazily run her thumb along Catra's cheekbone, frozen by an incongruous mix of tension, anticipation, and profound peace. Catra seemed perfectly willing to drink up the moment as well. Eventually, though, the feeling in Adora's limbs returned and she used the hand on Catra's cheek to gently tilt her head back. Catra slowly rose onto her toes, and Adora took this as all the permission she needed to lean down and bring their lips together.

It wasn't terribly dissimilar to their first kiss. It was slow and longing at first, filled with relief, like falling into bed after coming home from an agonizingly long day. However, that peace was short-lived as Adora tangled her hand in Catra's wet hair and pressed her tongue through her parted lips. Catra responded by tightening her hold on Adora's neck and closing whatever space was left between them. Relief shifted to a passion long suppressed as Adora ran her free hand down Catra's back and side, relishing the cool flesh. Catra broke the kiss and instead traced a line along her jaw and down her neck with her lips. Adora let out a soft gasp when she felt a nip on the side of her throat and then another when she felt nails dig into her shoulder-blade. Catra eventually pulled back from her neck and Adora took the opportunity to shift her weight and slot a thigh between the other woman's legs. Catra squeaked in surprise but quickly recovered enough to grind down. Adora just about combusted then and there but managed to bring her lips to Catra's as the other woman pushed down against her and gasped into her mouth.

All of a sudden, Catra stopped and abruptly pulled away. Adora blinked her eyes open, an apology on her lips for whatever she did wrong. However, Catra, panting, cut her off before she could open her mouth, "Let's go home."

The journey home was a bit of a buzzkill. Luckily, though, it turned out that getting out was easier than getting in when they lugged over a large plastic barrel and used it to slink out of the window. They wasted no time diving into the sea and swimming back to the platform. Adora looked at her clothes reluctantly and followed Catra's lead of leaving her shirt unbuttoned and pulling

on her pants. Catra went barefoot up the stairs, but Adora wanted nothing to do with that insanity, so she pulled on her socks and shoes and followed after. No one was around, so they held hands for the short walk to Catra's apartment.

Once inside, they regarded each other with a hint of awkwardness. Gone was the bravado of before and back was the characteristic uncertainty that haunted Adora's every intimate interaction with Catra. Catra was the one to break the silence.

"We should shower. You can go first." Adora considered suggesting that they shower together, but the words died on her lips when Catra handed her a towel. Defeated, she retreated to the bathroom and fiddled a bit with the tap. She took a moment to examine the cut on her arm. It stung when she poked it, but it was small and fully scabbed over so she wasn't concerned. When the water was warm, she stripped the rest of the way down and climbed in. She tried not to take too long, though she did take a moment to appreciate the scents of Catra's shampoo and conditioner. She wasn't sure which body wash was Catra's – they were both marketed for men – so she picked the one that smelled the best and hoped that she wasn't going to smell like Khyle for the rest of the night.

When finished, she stepped out of the shower and dried off. Not particularly keen on donning her salty clothes, she wrapped the towel around herself, scooped up her clothes, and headed back to Catra's room. She found Catra in her wet bra and underwear with a towel slung over her shoulder. In the darkness, she had thought that they were black, but it turned out they were a deep burgundy. She tried not to stare but apparently did a poor job of it because Catra straightened up with a smirk. She sauntered out of the room, pausing to press a quick kiss to Adora's cheek.

Adora let out a shuddering breath the second Catra was out of the room. She dropped her towel and slid on the boxers that Catra usually gave her and a t-shirt. Adora still had yet to return the first one she had been lent, and Catra had never asked for it back, so Adora wore it to bed at her place most nights which was perfectly

reasonable as she had told Glimmer many times. She hung up her clothes on a hook behind Catra's door and sat on the corner of the bed uncertainly. She wasn't sure what the plan was. It was fairly late, so it wouldn't be unreasonable to go to bed. But it also wouldn't be unreasonable to assume that Catra wanted to watch a movie or something.

Adora wasn't completely clueless. She was fairly sure that they were going to at least continue making out in whatever room they were in, if not more. She wasn't even sure which option she preferred at this point. Sure, she had spent an embarrassing amount of time fantasizing about having sex with Catra. Sure, every fiber of her being thrummed with desire to explore every inch of her. Sure, if Catra asked her to marry her, move to a homestead in the middle of nowhere, and have an army of children, she'd say yes in a heartbeat. These things, however, did not help Adora shake the feeling that she was screwing up somehow. That this was a delicate operation like defusing a bomb and she was on the precipice of cutting the wrong wire and blowing everyone to pieces.

Luckily, Adora didn't have long to play her lifelong game of talking herself out of something that would make her happy. Catra returned with her hair wrapped up in a t-shirt wearing nothing but a black bralette and black and white checked boxer-briefs. She took one look at Adora and raised an eyebrow. "Why are you just sitting there like an awkward dork?"

Adora shifted. "I didn't know if we were going to bed or watching something on the couch."

Catra shrugged. "It's up to you, but I'm exhausted." She made a show of stretching and dropping onto the bed dramatically.

"Bed is fine with me." Adora stood and went to turn off the light. With her hand on the switch, she took a moment to admire Catra languishing on the bed, displaying her toned stomach and legs. It was nothing Adora hadn't seen before, but it never failed to make her heart race. She clicked off the light and made her way

through the dark room to join Catra in the bed. She lay there stiffly for a moment before Catra snuck under her arm and pillowed her head on her chest. Adora melted into the touch and immediately pulled her closer. She heard Catra sigh and felt her nuzzle into her chest.

"I missed this," Catra said, tossing an arm and a leg across Adora.

"Me too," Adora murmured into Catra's hair while running her fingers through it, relishing in the fact that they didn't get stuck in the usual unruly curls. Her hair was over halfway down her back when wet which Adora found fascinating.

They stayed that way for a while, Catra clinging for dear life while Adora played with her hair and rubbed small circles into her back with her other hand.

"Hey Adora?" Adora felt Catra tilt her head up. She angled her own down to make eye contact in the faint light.

"Yeah?"

"I'm sorry."

Adora pressed a kiss to Catra's forehead. "I know. I still forgive you."

Catra shifted a little so her arms were crossed on Adora's chest and her head was resting on top of them. She regarded Adora for a few moments and like it was the simplest question in the world, asked, "Do you wanna make out?" Just as simply, Adora replied, "Absolutely," and hoisted Catra fully on top of her. Catra didn't take long to make herself comfortable and scooched up to capture Adora's lips in her own.

Adora was almost surprised at how similar this was to one of her favorite fantasies. How many times had she imagined pulling Catra onto her as they lay together in her bed? How many times had she imagined running her hands along her body, unapologetically counting her ribs with her fingers, dipping into

the curve of her waist, running her thumbs over her hipbones, and finally gripping the ass that she had only had the pleasure of admiring from afar? Now, though, now it was real and Catra's hands were very tangibly snaking up her shirt in an effort to remove it. Adora arched her back and managed to yank it off with minimal flailing. Catra took the opportunity to sit up and pull her own top off in one fluid moment. Adora only had a moment to short-circuit at the sight before those perfect breasts were pressed up against her own and Catra's tongue was in her mouth and her hands were buried in her hair.

Adora broke the kiss to lean up and bury her face in Catra's neck. Between open-mouthed kisses and soft bites, which Catra encouraged by placing a hand behind Adora's head and pushing, Adora took a quick sniff. She almost breathed a sigh of relief when she realized that she had chosen the correct body wash. Catra did not take long to remind her that she was supposed to be otherwise occupied and Adora happily continued her ministrations, nipping as hard as she dared without leaving marks. They weren't 16 and Catra had a grown-up job, after all. When she pulled back, Catra was giving her a searching look while lightly running her fingers along the waistband of her boxers. Adora gave a quick nod and Catra ghosted down her body taking the boxers with her and tossing them to the side.

Adora laid back and allowed herself to become lost in the show between her legs. It was slow; it was sweet; it was loving. If sex could be kind, then that this was. Traditionally, Adora had treated sex as little more than a transaction, an often boring and mechanical end to a means, and a way for both parties to blow off some steam and make life a hair more bearable. She had rarely finished outside of the comfort of her own hand and had even more rarely relinquished any more control over the situation than was pragmatically necessary.

It was different with Catra. With her, she was able to close her eyes and allow the sensations to wash over her as they arose. She even allowed a few sounds to pass her lips that had always been so stoically sealed. It wasn't long before Adora was fisting a hand

in Catra's hair and prying her eyes open to meet the pair staring up at her with rapt attention. That was enough to send Adora careening over the edge. Shortly after, Catra crawled back up and pressed into her side. Adora, still unable to speak, wrapped her in a tight hug. Catra laughed breathily and nuzzled into Adora's neck, leaving feather-light kisses in her wake. Adora tilted her chin up and brought their lips together, pouring as much of herself as she could into the kiss. She felt Catra smile around her lips. When she pulled away, Adora realized that the smile was a smirk.

"That good?"

Adora barked out a laugh and shoved Catra lightly, suddenly finding her voice.

"Don't look so fucking smug." In one fluid motion, she flipped Catra onto her back and proceeded to lay kisses over every inch of her that she could reach. She was singularly determined to not only return the favor but to make the other woman sing her name to the heavens.

And she did. For the most part. For a significant portion of the night. Twice, though, she had glanced up to see Catra gazing off into space. Each time, she had stopped and Catra had snapped back to reality and had in no uncertain terms ordered her to continue. Adora wasn't sure what to make of it, but she figured now was not the time to bring it up because now was shaping up to be in the top ten moments of her life thus far.

When they had decided to rein it in for the night, Catra had breathlessly taken her customary spot tucked under Adora's right arm. The two had lain in silence, simply basking in their good fortune to be naked and in each other's arms. After either an infinity or five minutes had passed, a bizarre thought had occurred to Adora. It had been less a thought made of words and more of a strange pull to action that had led her to slowly turn her back to the other woman. Catra had briefly hesitated, perhaps confused, but had eventually grabbed the long-since kicked-away blanket

and pulled the other woman’s back to her chest, draping one arm around her waist and snaking the other one under her neck.

And this was how Adora found herself being held for the first time since she was a child. She took Catra’s hand where it was held to her stomach and brought it to her lips for a soft kiss. She intertwined their fingers and pulled them to her chest. She felt Catra kiss and nuzzle between her shoulder-blades and loosed a deep sigh the depths of which Adora herself could not even fathom.

It was in this way that Adora fell asleep.

Chapter End Notes

I wish I had some pictures of the Haunted Hotel to add here because it's such an eerie little place. My Khyle and I often talked about getting our hands on a waterproof go-pro but never did. One time, we got all the way to the top and squirmed out of this broken panel at the bottom of a locked door to find this pristine, well-maintained garden. It was also well-gated because a security guard caught us and was unsettled to find two wet foreigners in bathing suits wandering about the place. We convinced him to let us go back down the way we came.

You don't care about that, though. They did it! Isn't that something? I'm proud of them.

Tune in next week when Catra probably has some opinions about all this. As always, thank you for reading.

Fall pt. 3

Chapter Summary

She made her way upstairs and stopped at the bathroom door. On the other side, she heard faint retching, so of course she had to call out, “Having fun in there, Glynnis?”
She heard a muffled reply and then a bright, familiar laugh. “Wow, that was mean! Catra, did you hear that?”
“Nah. What’d she say?”
“I’ll tell you later. How’s it going?”

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In which things are defined.

Chapter Notes

A little note, there's quite a bit of casual drug use discussed at the end.
It should also be noted that Catra gets very victim-blamey with herself in the beginning.

Also, if anyone's curious, Catra's theme song for this chapter is The Good Life by Weezer. I was really into that song when I was working on the second half of the fic.

Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra awoke fairly early the next morning to find herself trapped in her bed in a new and exciting way. Sometime in the night, Adora had taken both of her hands and crossed them over her chest in an unbreakable X. When Catra attempted to free either of them, she was met with a tightening of her fingers and a pull that nearly dislocated her shoulders. *Jesus Christ, Adora,* Catra thought as she choked on a mouthful of the other woman’s hair, *Why are you like this?* She was by no means new to the act of Houdini’ing

her way out of Adora's titan grip first thing in the morning when she needed to perform such apparently unreasonable acts as making coffee or using the bathroom, but this was on another level.

She thought about waking the sleeping woman, but she just couldn't bring herself to. It wasn't because Adora looked peaceful in her sleep. In fact, she never really did– Catra knew this because she had often been kicked awake in the middle of the night to find the woman scowling and murmuring angrily at some unseen force. It more came down to the fact that Catra wasn't exactly wild about looking a gift horse in the mouth. There was a naked woman in her bed, and she was mildly afraid that if she were to make any sudden movements, she would take off without warning. Besides, Catra's grand plan still had one key component, and it was about time to get cracking on it.

With considerable effort, she managed to free her left hand. She then used it to pry the fingers off of its mate, which had long since gone dead to the world. With her arms free, albeit one hanging limply against the bed, she set to work on her legs that were tangled up with Adora's. A few experimental tugs yielded the predicted results of Adora's iron thighs clenching around hers. *Fuck, does she live at the gym?* Suddenly inspired, Catra carefully poked the inside of Adora's knee, and when the leg jerked, she took the opportunity to slide out. Finally free, Catra quietly left the bed, but not before taking a few moments to admire the woman currently stretching out to starfish on her sheets. *Good job, kid.*

Catra pulled on her discarded underwear and a bra. She also found a clean-enough shirt and a pair of shorts. She stopped in the kitchen and grabbed a couple canvas bags. She shoved her wallet and keys into her pocket and was about to head out the door, when something occurred to her. She headed into her room and grabbed a notebook off of her desk. She opened it, scrawled a quick note as to her whereabouts, ripped it out, and placed it on her pillow. She couldn't resist pressing a small kiss to Adora's forehead as she leaned back. Satisfied, she headed back to the door and slipped out as quietly as she possibly could.

Once outside and heading to the market, she allowed herself a moment to reflect on the events of the last 24 hours. The date had gone off without a hitch. Who didn't love a sunset from a scenic view? The most dangerous variable had been bringing Adora back to the swimming platform, but the risk had been well worth it to see the wonder on the woman's face as she had explored the Haunted Hotel. Catra hadn't even been the one to suggest trespassing, which was a nice change of pace, and if she had bloomed with pride over Adora's suggestion to do crimes in an excessively gay fashion, then who could blame her?

She shouldn't be surprised that Adora had been the one to kiss her, Catra supposed while considering the relative ripeness of a mountain of tomatoes. Adora had tried to kiss her ages ago at her permit party. Catra soured a bit at the memory, remembering Saliha's untimely entrance like she was a Kramer-esque foil in some crappy romcom. Of course, Catra was aware that it was not Saliha's fault that Adora and she had spent the entire summer in a game of chicken seeing how far they could push the boundaries of friendship before one of them just made a fucking move already, but she still couldn't help but lament the wasted time. Then again, the situation had forced her to be in top form for most of the year, planning surprise after little surprise in an effort to woo a woman who was clearly already wooed if any outside observer had anything to say about it. And good God, did they all have something to say about it.

Catra paid for her produce and made her way to the charcuterie across the street. There, she pondered various cheeses while she considered the several problems presenting themselves in her short-term. Firstly, though not necessarily most immediately, she still had yet to reintegrate herself with her social group after her extended hiatus. Sure, she had disappeared for a few weeks before. Every year, in fact, usually around this time except for the time she had lost her shit in the middle of winter to shake it up a little. But this was different. She had been incommunicado for two months, and her friends' typical polite overlooking could not be relied upon this time. Plus, there was the novel factor of Adora pursuing her little investigation and kicking up extra curiosity. She

still wasn't sure what to say to everyone, but she figured she'd just show up to the bar one night and go from there.

Luckily or perhaps unluckily, some of the heat would likely be transferred laterally to Adora and hers newfound relationship. This was problem number two. Catra was decently sure that they weren't exactly friends anymore after last night, and she didn't anticipate that Adora would be opposed to the label of 'girlfriend'. Especially not after she made this kickass breakfast for her. Everyone else, though, was going to have a fucking field day with it, but Catra was going to take all of the teases and 'I told you so's' with grace because fuck them, she was happy and no one was going to ruin that.

Except, well, possibly herself. There was one more problem floating at the edge of Catra's consciousness, one that she very much didn't wish to address. It had to do with the surfacing of memories of a certain *event* while she was supposed to be enjoying herself in the throes of passion. She knew that Adora had noticed because of course she would, but when Adora had caught her gazing into the abyss, her body suddenly stock-still, Catra had snapped back to herself and had assured the other woman that continuing was in her best interests. It was supremely irritating that one stupid night three years ago was still rearing its ugly head when she was supposed to be at her happiest. She had let it control her for far too long; pathetically, Adora was the only person she had dated since. Sure, she'd had sex a couple of times, but it had been uncomfortable and plagued with bad memories, so she'd mostly sworn off of it in the last couple years.

She'd thought about telling her a few times, held tight under the cover of darkness, but each time the words had made it to her tongue, she had swallowed them before they could escape. It had been so long ago that the thought of confessing seemed almost silly. It wasn't like she hadn't told anyone. Khyle knew. She remembered stumbling in the door of their apartment clutching a heavy bag of sweets in her fists like a lifeline. The man had given it to her before dropping her off at the Gaziantep bus station. It

had been filled with a couple hundred liras worth of baklava and various other regional confectionary. Instead of throwing it at his slimy, smirking face like she'd wanted to, she had clung to it on the bus to Adana, on the plane to Antalya, and on the tram ride back to her apartment. When Khyle had come to greet her with a hug, she had shoved the bag into his outstretched arms and had just stood there like a statue. His smile had faded as he realized that something was deeply amiss. Later, he had coaxed her to take a walk in the park with him, and it had all just spilled out of her as if she were a sieve. She had told him every detail, putting the story together more for herself than for him. Since then, that story had remained locked up tight in the hollow of her chest save once.

Mostly, she went back and forth on if anything had really been done to her. She knew that it wasn't great, but just because something was morally dubious didn't mean that she had any right to claim a crime. It could've been worse. Mostly, she was embarrassed that she hadn't had the fortitude to walk out of that hotel room. This was what stuck the story in her throat. What if she told Adora and the woman thought she was weak and stupid for being so torn up about the obvious consequences of her own actions?

Catra shook these dark thoughts from her head as she let herself into her apartment. She dropped the bags in the kitchen and peeked into her room to see Adora still asleep and cuddling Catra's pillow, the note face-down on the floor. Catra resisted the urge to strip down and join her and instead gathered up Adora's sleep clothes, folded them, and placed them on a chair next to the bed. On her way out, she grabbed her headphones and slipped them over her ears. She turned on her throwback playlist to get her mind right and got to work on breakfast.

She pulled out all of her small dishes and began filling them with black and green olives, two kinds of jam, honey, clotted cream, three kinds of cheese, homemade hummus, and Balkan breakfast spread. She tossed the two loaves of bread into the oven on low to warm up. She chopped up tomatoes, cucumbers, and green

peppers and arranged them on a plate before blasting them with olive oil, seasoning, and lemon juice. She cleared the round table in the living room and laid down a light blue cloth. On top of that, she arranged what she had so far and went back to the kitchen to chop peppers, onions, and tomatoes.

Catra's dip in mood rectified quickly when she saw how badly she was *absolutely killing it*. She had even started to dance around the kitchen, jamming out to Fall Out Boy like she was 14 again. She had just thrown the tomatoes onto the sizzling peppers and onions, singing *Why don't you show me a little bit of spine/ You've been saving for his mattress/ I only want sympathy in the form of you/ Crawling into bed with me* when she whirled around and stopped dead in her tracks. Adora was in the doorway in the clothes Catra had left for her by the bed, holding a fist to her mouth. Catra recognized the gesture as the one that Adora always used to stifle a laugh and felt the heat rise to her cheeks.

"Was that Fall Out Boy?"

"No."

"Yes, it was."

"No, it wasn't."

Adora laughed brightly. "Yes, it *was*. You were singing Dance, Dance! Put it on the speaker."

"Not on your life, princess." Catra turned off her headphones and dropped them around her neck.

Adora pouted and retreated into Catra's room. She returned with a speaker and swiftly snatched Catra's phone off of the counter.

"Hey!" Catra jumped for her phone, but Adora held it out of her reach as she scrolled through the playlist with one hand and pushed Catra's face away with the other. Eventually, she settled on something. 'Sugar We're Going Down' filled the kitchen and Catra

made another dash for her phone as Adora sang along and dodged her. Eventually, Catra relented.

"You would like Fall Out Boy."

"This is *your* playlist!"

Catra went back to the stove and removed the cover from the pan. Adora padded over and wrapped her arms around her from the back. Catra twisted around to face Adora and leaned up to kiss her. With her free hand, she grabbed an egg off the counter and cracked it into the pan one handed. Never breaking the kiss, she cracked another one and replaced the lid. That had better have looked as cool as she thought it would with as much as she'd practiced.

"Show-off," Adora murmured against her lips.

"You love it."

"I might."

They made out until Catra broke them apart to turn off the burner. She reluctantly slid out of Adora's grasp and grabbed the pan along with the now toasty bread from the oven and headed into the living room. "C'mon, princess. Breakfast time."

Adora hummed happily and followed. When they got to the table, Adora oooh'ed and inspected the various things. "You did all this?"

"Nah, someone broke in and made us breakfast."

"It was nice of them to leave the TV."

"Wasn't it?"

"Seriously, what is all this?"

"It's Turkish breakfast.[1] Don't tell me Sparkles and Bo haven't taken you out for breakfast before." Catra handed Adora a hunk of

bread.

Adora took it and looked lost. “No. Is this a normal thing?”

“Yes.”

Adora still didn’t move.

“Adora, Jesus, put your fork into one of the things and put it in your mouth. It’s not that complicated.”

“I don’t know where to start!”

Catra rolled her eyes and layered her bread with sauce and cheese and shoved it into her mouth. Adora seemed to get the idea and did the same. When she tasted it, her eyes lit up.

“What’s this cheese? It’s salty.”

“Ezine. I got the fancy kind.” Catra ate an olive and put the pit in the small pile growing on her plate. She then took some bread and used it to scoop some menemen out of the pan. Adora did the same and burned her tongue but that did not seem to slow her down.

“What’s this?” She pointed at the pan.

“You’ve been here 10 months and you’ve never had menemen? You’re such a yabancı.”

“Not all of us can be as cultured as you.”

The two ate and bantered, occasionally playing footsie under the table that eventually devolved into a back and forth kick fight. After a particularly hard jab to Adora’s shin, Catra apologetically lathered some bread in clotted cream, drizzled it with honey, and shoved it into Adora’s mouth. However, as all leisurely weekend breakfasts are destined to do, it drew to a close and the two set to clearing up. As Adora loaded the rinsed bowls that Catra handed her into the dishwasher, she said,

“I can’t believe you made me breakfast.”

“Why? Clearly I’m amazing at it.”

“Clearly. You’ve never made me breakfast after I stayed over before.”

“I haven’t?” Catra knew damn well that she hadn’t.

“No. It’s always just coffee. Or we go out for something to eat.”

“Well, maybe this morning is different.”

“Different? Different how?” Adora’s tone was teasing.

“You know how.”

“No I don’t. I’m just a big empty-headed jock, remember? Spell it out for me.”

Fine. If this was how she wanted to play it, Catra could hang. “You made me come like five times last night. The least I could do is feed you in the morning.”

Adora nearly dropped a plate as Paramore played quietly in the background. Catra smirked at her little victory. Adora, though, recovered quickly and pivoted.

“About that.”

When she didn’t continue, Catra prompted, “Yes?”

“Last night meant something, right?”

Catra blinked and felt her bravado drop straight through her to the ground. She spent far too long attempting to compose a suitably snarky reply, and when she saw Adora slump out of the corner of her eye, she softly said,

“It did to me.”

The smile reappeared on Adora's face. "Cool. Do you want to be my girlfriend?"

Cool? COOL? Catra could not believe her fucking ears or how this woman had managed to survive this long in society being so maddeningly *like this*.

"Goddammit, Adora. *Yes*, of course I do. I took you on a date, brought you home, and made you breakfast in the morning. In the last 10 months, I have spent more time with you than anyone else in my life. I feel like I have made my feelings *clear*."

Adora grinned. "Yeah, that's what I thought. Just making sure." *God, how was she so fucking chipper all the time*. Catra let out an exasperated laugh and dragged them both back into the bedroom. There, they whiled away the rest of the morning and a good portion of the afternoon. Sometime later, Catra laid on her back with her arms behind her head. Adora was between her legs with her arms folded on Catra's chest and her head resting on them. She was amazed at how easily they had slipped into this, like they'd been here for ages. To be fair, their friendship had been almost concerningly intimate, and the removal of clothing had been the logical step forward for months. Catra took a moment to lament all the time that could've been spent just like this, but she didn't allow herself to be chastised too harshly.

After all, they had all the time in the world, Catra began to let herself believe.

Adora took a break from lazily running her fingers along Catra's collarbone to gaze up at her.

"Sup?" Catra said.

"It's Bo's birthday party tonight."

That was… not what she was expecting. "Fuck. It's October, isn't it?"

"Sure is. It's at my place. Wanna come?"

"I don't know, Adora…" Catra bit the inside of her cheek. What a shit friend she was to forget her friend's birthday. Even though Glimmer was typically the organizer for Bo-related parties, Catra was usually involved to some degree no matter where her head was at.

"You should come. It'll be fun. You can stay over after like you always do."

"Careful. You'll get sick of me with that attitude."

Adora snorted. "Shut up, no I won't. C'mon, I bet everyone would love to see you, and I know Bo wants you there."

"Don't you think I'll be kind of a, uh, distraction? I'm not trying to steal Bo's night."

Adora rolled her eyes and flailed her arm out towards the end table to grab her phone.

"What are you doing?"

Adora wordlessly opened her phone and tapped a few times. The sound of ringing from the speakerphone filled the room.

"Seriously, what are you doing?"

After three rings, a man picked up. "*Adora!"*

"Bo!"

"*How are you? What's up? Is everything okay?*"

Adora giggled, "Everything's great! Say hi to Catra!"

"*Catra's there? Hi Catra! How'd the date go?*"

"What the fuck is happening right now?"

"*That's good to hear! Are you coming to my party tonight?*"

"Are you talking to me?" Catra asked, more than mildly unsettled that she was having this bizarre conversation naked and with the phone resting on her left boob.

"*Of course! You have to come. We all miss you!*"

In the background they heard a muffled voice say, "*Is that Adora? Where the hell is she?*""*Catra's.*" "*Why did I even ask? Give me the phone.*" Shuffle, shuffle. "*Adora? Please tell me you finally got some. I can't take another year of your lesbian pining bullshit*."

"You were pining over me for a year, princess? That's embarrassing."

"*Of course. Of course I'm on speaker and Catra's there, too. Whatever, both of you need to get the fuck over here and help me set-up.*"

"Who said I was coming?"

"*Me. You have to crawl out of your sad cave sometime, Ekaterina. You're clearly fine.*"

"Fuck off, Sparkles."

"*Make me, bitch. You guys better be here in an hour or I'll come get you myself.*"

Before Catra could retort, the line went dead. Adora looked up at her with puppy-dog eyes and Catra groaned. She guessed she was going to a fucking party.

--

Parties, it turned out, were a lot less fun when you weren't getting shitfaced, Catra mused as she watched Bo and Sea Hawk sing "Don't Go Breaking My Heart" on top of Glimmer and Adora's groaning coffee table. Instead of protesting this abuse to her furniture in her typical fashion, Glimmer had been locked in the bathroom for the last half hour while Adora 'held her hair back'. Of

course, Glimmer's hair was too short to get vomit in it without getting creative, but Catra was not going to begrudge her some company while she revisited for the millionth time in her life the age-old lesson that vodka and tequila don't mix.

Catra picked at the last vestiges of the label on the beer she'd been drinking for the last two hours. Nobody had seemed to notice that she wasn't paced with the crowd, and she was pleased that her trusty plan to keep a bottle in her hand all night was working. Really, everyone seemed to be giving her space in general, which she appreciated immensely. She had to admit, though, it was odd to be on the outskirts, fully sober, watching her friends in their natural habitat instead of flailing around in the thick of it.

One of Bo's colleagues, a woman, sat down next to her. The two made mind-numbing small talk about where they worked, where they were from, how long they had been in Turkey, and of course what had brought them there. Catra gave her canned but proven to get a laugh answer that she preferred teaching abroad to working in a Starbucks in the States. The other woman chuckled politely. Somehow, the woman – Egyptian, she'd learned – got onto a tangent about ELT theory, and Catra scanned the room for any opportunity to escape. It wasn't really the woman's fault – she seemed nice enough – Catra just wasn't feeling it tonight.

She also felt a twinge of resentment for Bo's colleagues on principal. Outsiders to the group, especially ones from other schools, meant that she needed to be on her best behavior or at least at her most semi-functional. You get blackout on rakı at *one* conference and fall in the hotel fountain, and suddenly you have a *reputation in the teaching community*. So Catra kept it reined in, which unfortunately included going back into the closet. It wasn't like she wasn't used to keeping one foot inside at all times, but it was grating having to explain again and again that yes she was almost 30 and no she wasn't married and no she didn't have a boyfriend and no she didn't have anything against Turkish men and haha yeah maybe she just hadn't met Mr. Right yet.

What made this vastly more irritating than usual was the fact that she had recently acquired a girlfriend, and now she had to keep her hands to herself the second that she had gotten permission not to. Sure, Adora had pulled Catra into her room for some privacy at the first opportunity, but they hadn't been gone for more than five minutes before Glimmer had dragged them out for jello shots that Catra would have loved to have taken five of but instead had to skirt around. At least Glimmer was paying the price now.

Adora had been understanding – too understanding – when Catra had sheepishly told her that they needed to keep everything on the down-low for the party and in the future when they were out at the bars. There was a lot that they could get away with because they were two women that could be explained away as friendly, but they still had to keep their shit on lock. Adora had told her that she knew what she was getting into when she moved here and also that she intimately knew what it was like to do something that sucked for the sake of your career. Still, Catra felt guilty.

Catra also felt guilty that Adora wasn't drinking. She'd never even told Adora that she had to cut down on alcohol for the medication, but the woman seemed to have cottoned on and was forgoing herself. Catra didn't want to deny Adora any opportunity to have fun, but she did have to admit that it was nice not to be alone in a sea of drunk people. It also wasn't as if Adora hadn't had anything – she'd been peer pressured into a couple of jello shots – so she probably had at least some sort of buzz going. Catra just wanted all this to be over so they could finally be alone.

She took a sip of her beer and grimaced. Warm and flat. Great. The colleague daring to be friendly in her direction was long gone, so she went to the kitchen and dumped the rest of the liquid into the sink. She grabbed a new beer from the fridge and after making sure the coast was clear, poured about half of it down the drain. From there, she decided to take a lap. Khyle was in the corner. Usually, she'd be talking to him, but he was otherwise occupied with some girl he'd been seeing the last few weeks. The

freedom of her hand on his thigh and his arm around her in front of everyone pissed her off, but she pulled it back when she realized she was being unfair. Khyle had been through it before when he had dated guys, and it was hardly his fault that society sucked. Besides, the woman was cool. At the very least, she hadn't scratched out Catra's eyes for the grievous crime of being both Khyle's best friend and a woman, which was nice.

She made her way upstairs and stopped at the bathroom door. On the other side, she heard faint retching, so of course she had to call out, "Having fun in there, Glynnis?"

She heard a muffled reply and then a familiar laugh. "Wow, that was mean! Catra, did you hear that?"

"Nah. What'd she say?"

"I'll tell you later. How's it going?"

"Bo and Hawkins are doing duets and are about to bust through your coffee table, so I'm going upstairs to avoid liability."

"Ooh, that's probably bad. I'll get Glimmer to bed and come find you, okay?"

"Sure."

Catra headed back to the stairs, pausing briefly to send a longing look into Adora's room, specifically at the impeccably-made bed. It stared back, taunting her. The terrace was quiet save for the hum of the sauna that someone had locked themselves into. Catra slumped down on one of the couches, spread out her arms and legs, and dropped her head back with a sigh. This sucked. She wanted a real drink. She wanted to be drunk. She had forgotten what a nightmare it was talking to people sober.

Catra was under no illusion that she hadn't developed a sort of dependence on alcohol over the years, but she didn't appreciate it slapping her in the face like this. She'd drunk a little in high school, to loosen up at parties, but college had really been her

time to shine. Her mini-fridge had been stocked exclusively with Natural Light and a plastic handle of vodka from day one. Having been blessed with a roommate with similar sensibilities and a propensity to get handsy when intoxicated, Catra had drunk constantly. Over the course of the year, one shower beer had turned into two and then into a cup of vodka with a splash of OJ hidden in her shower caddy.

She'd taken a little break sophomore year when she'd met her first real girlfriend who had been suitably horrified at her habits and had insisted that she slow down. Catra had given it a go, limiting herself to weekends in a show of good faith, but that had all gone out the window when she'd gotten depressed and had found herself committed. When she had returned to the real world, she had found that she no longer had a girlfriend to behave for. It also hadn't helped that the anti-depressants she had been given had thrown her into a nasty mania that manifested in her old pal risky sexual behavior, and self-loathing and sex with men always went best with enough vodka to black out.

While Catra's grades had never been bad, they had only ever been good enough to keep her scholarship. She had spent the last couple of years in school rectifying that fact, and if one time, she drank half a fifth of tequila and a six-pack of Strawberitas and had taken back-to-back essay finals still pissed, she had done it with aplomb.

In Turkey, she had dried out a bit at first. She hadn't had any friends and had spent all of her time in her apartment or at work, so it hadn't been necessary. But then she'd met Khyle and a whole slew of new people and suddenly she'd been drinking every night again. On top of that, she'd done whatever was around to eat or put in a pipe or up her nose. After a few years, though, it had begun to wear on her just like it'd begun to wear on all of them. Sure, she'd do a line with the boys for old times' sake, but now she had limits. Her body hated her drinking more than 3 nights a week. She'd laid off the psychedelics since Khyle had accidently dosed her with 12 hits of acid and she'd lost her mind on the

beach in front of everyone. Everything else, well, she found she just didn't particularly enjoy anymore.

The real problem was that Catra wasn't really sure who she was without drinking. For a decade, she'd been the party girl. The girl who knew where to get the best shit. The *fun* one. And now? Now she was barreling toward 30, sipping on a beer stone-cold sober and trying to fool the people around her that she could still hang.

She had long since closed her eyes, so she tensed when she felt someone plop down next to her. She relaxed, though, when she felt Adora's body press into her side and her lips ghost along her neck. Catra lazily opened an eye and reached up a hand to tilt up Adora's head and kiss her properly. Adora's hands moved from her shoulder to her cheek, and Catra sat up a bit to be less of a douche. They continued in this manner for a while, hands wandering and Catra casting quick glances at the stairs, until the sauna door creaked open. Adora tore her hand out from under Catra's shirt and frantically fixed her mussed up hair.

Merve watched the scene for a moment before heading over to the couch opposite them and plopping down in just a towel, Perihan in tow. The look on Perihan's face was slightly confused if not a little pleasantly surprised.

Merve, on the other hand, looked as deeply amused as her typically expressionless face would allow. The bitch.

"Don't stop on our account, kızlar."

Adora shot Catra a searching look, and Catra gave a small nod and flick of her head. Adora wasted no time snuggling back under her arm and Catra pressed a quick kiss to her cheek. Merve and Perihan were cool. She knew Merve from back in her cram school days. Back then, she was the woman that Sea Hawk called his girlfriend who seemed to hate his guts. She hadn't been terribly fond of Catra back then, or any of Sea Hawk's friends, really, even Bo, so she hadn't taken it personally. Further, when her school had urgently needed a native English teacher, she'd made it her

business to recruit Catra specifically. If Merve had seen her puking into the sea followed by immediately chugging whiskey straight from the bottle and thought that she was a good person to drop into a room full of 13-year-olds, that had been her prerogative. Interestingly enough, though, she hadn't been wrong.

Merve had fully defrosted when Glimmer had come on the scene and, after a night on the town, had dragged Catra and Merve to her place for a 'girls night' at 4 am. This 'girls night' had included a bottle of tequila and the youtube sing-a-long versions of Disney Princess songs. Catra vaguely remembered doing the boy part of 'A Whole New World' for Glimmer and being bullied into singing the entirety of 'Poor Unfortunate Souls' just so Merve could show off with the vocals at the very end. Whatever else had happened that night, Catra and Merve had come out the other side tight, and while they didn't hang out outside of work or the main group too often, everyone knew that they were not only work wives, but ride or die 'til the bitter end.

Perihan, well, Catra didn't know Perihan all that well. She had started showing up to parties about 4 years back with some vague connection to Sea Hawk. Sea Hawk had a nigh-professional propensity to pick up randos with access to drugs, but they rarely stuck around for too long. Perihan was different, though. Perihan, for the most part, drank sparingly, but boy did she like her psychedelics. By day, she ran a string of flower shops that maintained a strangle-hold on the wedding industry throughout both the Antalya and Muğla provinces with plans to extend all the way up the Aegean coast to Izmir, and by night she smoked enough DMT to meet God. If Catra was any judge of blown-ass pupils, and she liked to think she was, Perihan was smack dab in the middle of some sort of cosmic journey or whatever dumb euphemism she was using these days.

In truth, Perihan made Catra a little uncomfortable. Sure, she'd been to Perihan's house a feel times to read coffee grounds and tell the most outrageous fortunes she could come up with to see what the woman would buy, but that had always been semi-malicious at best. So, when she said she didn't know Perihan very

well, it was true. The problem was that Perihan knew Catra very, uncomfortably well. When Catra had lost her mind on too much acid, it had been Perihan who had laid Catra out on her lap and whispered soothing mantras to her while rubbing her back. When she'd recovered the ability to speak, Catra had treated that lap as a confessional, letting secret after secret spill from her lips: her fears, her insecurities, her past, culminating with what had happened to her in Gaziantep. Catra vividly remembered clinging to Perihan as hard as she could, sobbing grotesquely into her shoulder. Perihan had simply held her and pet her hair. It was embarrassing, but to this day over two years later, Perihan had never made reference to that night aside from a glint in her eye every time she talked to Catra that Catra did not like one bit.

"So," Perihan said, crossing her legs primly, "This is new." There was that damn glint again.

Adora beamed, but Catra decided to dick around a little and scrunched her brows together. "What are you talking about?" She gave Adora's shoulder a quick squeeze.

"Come now, Catra," Perihan answered, unfazed.

"Bo's one of my best bros. This'll be the sixth birthday party of his I've been to. My dedication to the power of friendship is hardly news, Çiçekçi." Meaning flower-seller, it was one of her less endearing nicknames.

Perihan gave a small smile, and Merve interjected, "Uh huh. When did you two start snogging in public?"

"I'm sorry, you're gonna have to use real words. Not all of us went to a fancy boarding school in London."

"It was Bristol."

"Hey, c'mon," Adora popped in, "What's a little friendly face-sucking between gal pals? Is that not what you two were doing in the sauna?" Catra bit back a laugh. She loved it when Adora went along with her bits. She was so fucking perfect, it hurt.

Merve rolled her eyes. “What did you do to her? She used to be nice.”

Adora shook her head. “I was never nice. It’s just the way my face looks. I’ve got Resting Nice Face.”

“It’s true.” Catra grabbed Adora’s face at the chin and smooshed her cheeks together. “This is how she looks on the inside. Hmm, you’re still cute. Could you, like, do something about that?” Adora crossed her eyes and knitted her brows in a show of solidarity. “Yes, perfect.” Catra turned Adora’s head for a messy kiss.

Merve groaned, “I *hate* this.”

Perihan was as serene as ever. “Do not deny the girls their love, Merveciğim. It has been a long road to this lovely wood, and they still have long to go before they rest.”

It was Catra’s turn to roll her eyes, “You are not badly quoting Robert Frost at us right now, Çiçekçi. I have too much respect for you to believe that’s what’s happening here.”

Perihan just smiled. “Perhaps. Or perhaps it is time for you to allow yourself some happiness. It has been a long time, Catracığım, and you do not deserve to be defined by your past no matter how deeply you believe it to be true.”

And there it was. That rainbow-fractal-fueled sage bullshit that Perihan always had to bust out during a casual conversation at a party. Catra’s jaw clenched, but before she could find out what other wisdom the mushroom gods saw fit to grace her with that night, Perihan turned to Adora and inquired after her newest project. Adora was all too happy to talk about it in depth, and Perihan was all too happy to listen. Theirs was a weird friendship. Catra often forgot that the two hung out at least once a week, and she honestly could not see the appeal on either end.

Catra realized that Merve was giving her a funny look. She also realized that she was as stiff as a board, clenching her thigh hard enough for her knuckles to go white, and scowling hard enough to

cut steel. She quickly schooled herself back into her default cooler-than-thou indifference. Merve raised an eyebrow. Catra sighed, pulled her arm out from Adora's shoulders, ignored the sad look that Adora shot her, and leaned forward to rest her forearms on her spread knees. Merve, still in a towel, leaned her elbow on her crossed knee and rested her chin in her hand.

"So?" Her eyes flitted to Adora and then back to Catra.

"Last night."

"*Finally*. I've been embarrassed for you for like 6 months."

Catra scoffed. "Like you can talk. You still don't let Hawkins call you his girlfriend. It's been like 6 years, man. You *live together*."

"That's different. You've met Sean. Can you imagine what would happen if I actually admitted to him that I enjoyed his company?"

"You'd have a bigass wedding in Izmir with like a thousand people and he'd set the venue on fire during the halay[2]."

"Piss off. Also, accurate." Merve shuddered.

"When are you guys getting married anyway? Tick tock, tatlım."

"Siktir git, Kedi teyze. How'd you do it?"

"Do what?

"Win Adora's big, dumb heart."

"Maybe she just couldn't resist the sexy Primov charm. Ever thought about that?"

"No I haven't, and I never will."

"Rude."

"Don't tell me you took her to the Waste or something."

“Jesus. Fuck no. Who do you think I am? I took her to Castle Bar.”

“Sunset dinner? I never took you for a romantic.”

“I’m the most romantic bitch you’ll ever meet, Mermaid. Too bad you missed your chance, I could’ve made an honest woman outta you.”

“Quelle tragique. What else?”

“You fishing for ideas here? What, finally ready to press your suit with the jackass?”

“Hardly. Your shitty life is like a serial for me.”

“At least tell me I’m better than ‘Kara Sevda’.”

“You’re no Nihan, bebeğim, but you’ll do in the off-season.”

“Shit, you’re breaking my heart over here. I took her to the Haunted Hotel, by the way.”

“And then to the hospital for couple’s tetanus shots?”

“What can I say? I’m a romantic.”

“What next?”

“Sakin, dedikoducu kızı. A gentleman never kisses and tells.”

“So you didn’t shag her then?”

“No, I did, but you don’t have to be so fucking weird about it.”

Merve leaned back, snickering into the back of her hand. “Well, congratulations, kedicik, maybe you aren’t as pathetic as I thought.”

Catra leaned back as well, resting her palms behind her head. “Thanks. Let me know if Hawkins says yes. Gotta get my best man suit sorted.”

“As if you’d even be invited.”

“Have mercy, Mermaid, you’re gonna make me cry.”

Adora looked over. “Why are we crying?”

“Catra’s not invited to my wedding.”

“Aw. I can come, though, right?”

“Of course.”

“Okay good.”

Catra whistled low. “Wow, the loyalty is staggering.”

Adora shrugged. “Sorry, babe, I never say no to cake. There’s cake at Turkish weddings, right?”

“Of course,” Perihan provided.

“Did you just call me babe?”

“Yeah. You gonna do something about it?”

Before Catra could up the ante, Merve got to her feet. “Alright, I’m leaving before I spew. Hadi gidelim,[3] Peri.”

“Tabi, canım. Bir dakika geliyorum.”

Merve nodded and returned to the sauna. Once the door was closed, Perihan turned to Catra and Adora who were very graciously not pawing at each other, much to Catra’s dismay.

“As I was saying to Adora, I am very happy that you two found each other. The divine love within you both has waited long to find its match. The gold of Adora’s aura has brightened considerably and the red overlay of yours has all but faded to reveal the brilliant sapphire beneath.”

Catra blinked. Perihan was on another fucking level tonight, and she had the displeasure of being sober for it. Her first instinct was to be snarky, but she figured that she should probably at least try to play nice for Adora's sake. "I guess I have been feeling less red lately. Tell the universe thanks for me or whatever." Close enough.

"Commune with yourself, Catracığım, you are the universe, expressing itself as human for this brief moment."

"Oh right. How could I forget?"

With that, Perihan stood and joined Merve in the sauna.

--

Sometime later, Catra lay in Adora's bed, her head pillowed on the other woman's shoulder. Adora was absently playing with her hair. Despite having gotten off twice in the last hour, Catra was agitated. Sure, she'd not enjoyed parties before. As a rule, she didn't enjoy parties nearly as much as she pretended to anyway, but something about tonight was gnawing at her. She thought about talking to Adora about it – she liked Adora, and Adora was her girlfriend. She was the ideal candidate. Predictably, though, Catra wasn't feeling burdening anyone with her bullshit in what was supposed to be a bubble of post-coital bliss, so she was playing it cool.

Adora glanced down and asked, "Hey, are you okay?"

Clearly, she wasn't doing a good job.

"Of course. Why?"

"You're scowling."

"Am not."

"Are too. What's wrong?"

“No—“ Catra paused and considered pushing the ‘nothing wrong’ narrative further until the matter was dropped but considered that maybe a little honesty wouldn’t kill her. With that settled, all that was left was to decide where to begin. Perhaps not wisely, she picked the easiest target. “How are you friends with her?”

The hand in Catra’s hair stilled. “Who?”

“Perihan.”

“Oh. She’s nice. What’s wrong with her?”

“That cryptic, I-just-ate-a-sheet-of-acid-I-can-see-auras-space-cadet noise she always spouts.”

Adora shrugged. “Oh, that. I mostly ignore it. She usually wants to talk about plants and do yoga or cook. I mean, I have always thought it was kinda weird that she comes to parties like this if she’s gonna be sober the whole time, though. Maybe I’ll ask her about it on Monday.”

Catra snorted. “I’m sorry, did you just say sober?”

“Yeah? Why?”

Catra scooted over and propped her head on her elbow so she could look Adora in the face. “You think she was sober tonight. When she was talking to us, you’re telling me that you think she was sober?”

Adora furrowed her brow in confusion. “Well, yeah. I mean, I guess I saw her smoke a joint a few hours ago.”

“Adora, I will bet you any amount of money that that woman was on at least a quarter ounce of mushrooms.”

Adora mirrored Catra’s position. “Really?”

“Yeah, really. Her pupils were the size of dinner plates, man. She said I was the *universe*.” Catra tried to bite back a grin.

“I guess, but she’s always like that.”

Catra couldn’t hold back her laughter a second longer. “Uh yeah, because she’s literally always tripping balls.”

Adora looked shocked. “You’re fucking with me.”

“I am not! I’ve known Perihan for years, and I can promise you that I have never once seen her sober. Dude, she probably doesn’t even know what we actually look like. For all we know, she thinks you’re 8 feet tall and I’m a giant cat. You hang out with her all the time. How did you not know this?”

Adora pouted. “I don’t know! Stop laughing at me!” Catra popped a hand over her mouth to stifle the giggles bubbling out of her. Unfortunately, though, this was the funniest fucking thing she’d ever heard in her life, so it wasn’t working too well. It didn’t help that she could see the blush on Adora’s face despite the low light.

“Sorry, but holy shit, Adora, that’s really funny.”

“I’ve never been around people doing drugs like that,” Adora whined. “You’re seriously saying that she’s on something every day?”

Catra had mostly gotten herself under control. “Probably not every day or she’d fry her brain, but every time I’ve seen her in four-ish years, yeah.”

“That’s *insane*. How does that even work?”

Catra shrugged the best she could on her back where she had fallen in a burst of mirth. “I dunno, man. She’s got a helluva constitution.”

Adora inched closer so that her face was right above Catra’s. “You’ve done stuff like that, right?”

“Yep.”

“Have you ever been on anything in front of me?”

Catra laughed. “God no, I cut that shit out years ago. Trust me, you’d be able to tell. I don’t think I’ve ever been anything but drunk around you. I’m kind of boring now, to be honest.”

Adora gave her a quick peck on the nose. “I don’t think you’re boring. What’s it like?”

“What’s what like?”

“You know,” Adora waved her hand around, “Mushrooms and stuff. Hallucinogens.”

“Oh,” Catra paused a moment, “They’re interesting, I guess. You see stuff, mostly patterns and breathing walls, not like pink elephants or TV stuff like that. You think about things differently. It’s kind of refreshing in a way, but if you take too much, you run the risk of getting stuck in a brain prison for 12 hours, and I can tell you from personal experience that it sucks ass.”

“I’d imagine. Tell me about it.”

“Really?”

“Yeah, I like it when you tell me stuff.”

Catra sighed. “Okay, fine. So, one time we had this vial of liquid acid that we got from this Australian chick that got deported—“

“Wait what?”

“Yeah, that’s another stupid story. Remind me to tell you about it. Or better yet, ask Bo, his version is definitely more colorful than mine. Anyway, we had this vial and we were on the beach one night, my birthday actually, and stupidly, I had Khyle put the eye-dropper thing in my mouth. I felt one drop, then two, and then I lost count after seven. Two is usually my max for context.”

“Oh fuck.”

“Yeah. So Khyle asked me if I got any, and I knew I was absolutely fucked. He felt really bad and took like five in solidarity which was dumb as fuck, but it was kinda nice of him in a weird way. Anyway, I barely remember the peak, but afterward, I couldn’t remember my name or where I was or who anyone was or what, like, the concept of society was. It should also be noted that everyone was there and had like three beers, so it was massively humiliating. Glimmer wouldn’t let me live it down for like a year. Weirdly enough, it was Perihan who helped me keep it together. Eventually we all made it home and I gave Khyle my emergency Xanax so he could come down and then laid on the balcony tasting the sound of a cash register ding for the next five hours.”

Adora rested her chin on Catra’s shoulder and gazed up at her. “You have so many cool experiences.”

Catra snorted. “What are we, teenagers? Me doing too many drugs and embarrassing myself in front of an audience is not a ‘cool experience’.”

“I suppose. Still, it’s more than I’ve done.”

“That’s bullshit. You’ve done plenty of cool things.”

It was Adora’s turn to snort. “Like what?”

“For one, you said fuck you to the man, quit your big-girl job, and moved halfway across the world on a whim. That’s cool as shit.”

“I guess. I don’t really see it that way. It just seemed like the logical thing to do at the time.”

“No way, deflection is my bag. Also, what about that thing with you hulking out and ko’ing three dudes in a Target parking lot?”

Adora laughed. “Oh come on, that was nothing.”

“In what fucking universe is that nothing?”

"That girl was in trouble! You would've done the same thing! Wait, you *have* done the same thing!"

"That doesn't sound like me."

"Yes it does! Remember the night we met? You told off that slimy guy who was hitting on me."

Catra laughed. "I forgot about that! Oh yeah, I called him 'yavşak'. Oh man, and I called him way worse after that. I'm lucky he didn't pop me one then and there. God, when I saw him cornering you like that, I got so mad."

"When I learned what 'yavşak' meant, I was pretty impressed. I mean, I was impressed before, but it was still pretty hot to have my honor defended like that."

"Anything for you, princess."

"And they say chivalry is dead."

After a beat. "When's your birthday?"

Catra's brows wrinkled. "Huh?"

"You mentioned your birthday a minute ago. I've never heard you mention it before."

"Oh." Catra stared at the ceiling and did some calculations. "About a month ago, I guess. September 10th. The big two-nine."

"Seriously?"

"Yeah? Why?"

"Didn't you do anything?"

"No. I'm not the hugest fan of my birthday if I'm being honest and I was extra not into it this year. Besides, it's not like I would've done anything without you." All of which was true, though Catra

wasn’t particularly into the idea of getting into her complicated relationship with her birthday at this moment.

“I guess that makes sense. Still, you could’ve told me.”

“I don’t even remember what I was doing that day. Either crying or puking. Most likely both.”

“Gross, but also sad. You had a bad time these last couple of months, huh?”

“Yeah. I did. I’ll tell you about it sometime. Soon, but not right now, okay? I just, I’m too happy right now.”

“Okay.” Adora pulled Catra to her chest and buried her nose in the crown of her head. Catra tangled their legs together, tossed an arm over Adora’s waist, and sighed. There were so many things that Adora seemed to want to know, and Catra itched to tell her, and she would, she reasoned, in due time.

In due time.

Chapter End Notes

Please just go google Turkish Breakfast. It's the best damn thing in the world. [▲]
Halay: traditional wedding line-dance thing. Pretty fun.
tatlım: my sweet
Kedi: It means cat. Calling her kedi teyze is saying she's a gossipy cat.
Kara Sevda: A super-popular prime-time soap in the 2000's. Kara Sevda doesn't translate well, but Forbidden Love is good enough.
Sakin, dedikoducu kızı: Relax, gossip girl
kedicik: kitten [▲]
Hadi gidelim: Let's go.
Tabi, canım. Bir dakika geliyorum: Of course, my dear. I'm coming in a moment. [▲]

Aw, look at them enjoying each other's company and sort of having their shit together. Tune in next week for the thrilling conclusion of Above the Vaulted Sky, whatever that means! (especially since there's also a decently-lengthy epilogue.)

Winter

Chapter Summary

"What's up with them?"
Glimmer yawned. "It's raining, Adora."
"I can see that."
"No, it's the *first rain.*"
"Is this one of those bizarre things you guys do that I couldn't possibly understand?"
Glimmer rested her head on Adora's shoulder and closed her eyes. "Well, well, looks like you're finally getting it, babe."

--

In which we wrap it up.

Chapter Notes

Hi! Here we are!

This chapter is a behemoth, but there was no natural point to split it, so here it is all together. Also I was looking back on the last chapter and the footnotes were an absolute *mess,* so I tidied them up.

Enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

I long for scenes where man hath never trod

A place where woman never smiled or wept

There to abide with my Creator, God,

And sleep as I in childhood sweetly slept,

Untroubling and untroubled where I lie

The grass below—above the vaulted sky.

-*I AM*, John Clare, 1848

Due time came sooner than Adora expected. It didn't take more than a few days for Catra to begin opening up, albeit in carefully metered doses. The first parcel of information appeared one evening when Catra came straight to Adora's after work and wasted no time flopping onto the couch and nesting her head in Adora's lap. The two watched a couple episodes of some reality house-flipping garbage before Catra paused the show and began speaking unbidden.

She told Adora about going to the hospital, how a former student had recognized her and skipped her through the line. She told about the Lithium, how at first it made her too sick to do anything but lay on the bathroom floor, how it made her body shake and weep, how she had to pull this all together after a few days and drag herself back to work, how she hid out on the roof to avoid her colleagues while Merve and Khyle covered for her. But, she said, it had calmed her down and wrangled her despair back from fever pitch, which was enough, even if she had been crying more than not. She told how things began to fall into place, how her stomach settled and her body stilled even if her hands still held a faint tremor. She assured Adora, and perhaps herself, that she was feeling okay, better than okay. Happy. Alive and happy.

And this was where it stopped. Adora knew better than to inquire about anything outside of the established timeline, and her burning curiosity about the three weeks before the hospital would have to be sated on another day. That, of course, did not stop her from asking, and it sure as hell didn't stop Catra from shutting her down.

With which Adora was fine. Sort of. Ish. She was making herself be okay with it, and she was managing to wrestle down the screaming urge for control quite effectively, if she did say so herself. After all, she was a new woman. Gone was the Adora that took every case assigned to her and did her own work along with her teammates' and then checked and fixed the work they managed to do. Gone was the Adora that threw a first-year associate's brief in the trash in front of the whole office because he dared split an infinitive. Gone was the Adora dubbed Scourge of the Paralegals in hushed whispers.

No, she wasn't a lawyer anymore. Further, she reminded herself, Catra was not a case to be researched and won. She was a person. Still, something stuck in her brain and not-so-pleasantly egged her on that with the right set of questions, Catra would answer anything she wanted. It was hardly rocket science. Everyone broke eventually, and Adora had always been particularly gifted at crafting the perfect sequence of questions to get whoever was on the receiving end to tell her exactly what she and everyone around her needed to hear in order to further her agenda.

It was not a skillset of which Adora was particularly proud. In one of her first trials, she had managed to get a tight-lipped witness for the prosecution to admit to a decades-long affair with her gardener. While deemed irrelevant at the time – and absolutely irrelevant in the grand scheme of guilt and innocence – it had been the lynchpin her team needed to discredit the key witness and dismantle the case. She'd really proven herself with that one, and she remembered glowing with pride as all the partners congratulated her at the swanky bar they all frequented. She had felt so powerful, and in that moment, she'd known that everything in her life had been worth it to be where she was right then.

That woman, though, that woman who dared to have an affair to rival her husband's own mythical levels of infidelity, lost a son. She'd lost a son when his classmate had crushed him between the grill of his Lexus and the garage door as she'd watched helpless from the porch. Of course, this had meant little to 26-year-old

Adora who was busy learning to stomach single-malt scotch straight-up so middle-aged men in Givenchy suits could murmur in her ear that she was on her way up. As far as Adora had been concerned, these fathers she had never had could take her hand and launch her into the stratosphere with or without a helmet.

Catra knew little about this side of Adora. Sure, she'd heard about the case that broke her and the others that should've. Adora was ashamed of all that, of course, but part of her still glowed with the faint embers of pride at her accomplishments. After all, she'd worked her ass off for most of her life, and she had to feel something for it, even if it was all wrapped in a thick blanket of ill-ease. She could tell Catra how badly she felt for her part in stripping away justice from those who deserved better, but she couldn't share this. She couldn't bear to expose the grinning sycophant soaking up adulations left and right or the terrified girl altering her sales rack Nordstrom's pantsuits to look fancier so the men around her wouldn't be able to smell the trailer trash nobody she was inside.

To say that Adora hated herself was not entirely accurate. If truly pressed, as she had been by Perihan on a particularly oppressive July afternoon, she would admit that she perhaps had trouble coming to terms with the different phases of her life and how they synthesized into a coherent self. The lonely child running barefoot through the hollers in Tennessee, the taciturn teenager desperately trying to make good in a polished world, the model collegiate scholar and athlete with all the potential in the world, the adult entrenched in the grime of ambition. And who was she now? A free-spirit? An adventurer? A failure? An embarrassment?

She simply wasn't sure. She knew that everything was going well right now. She was sure of that at least. She had set everything up so that she didn't have to consider the past or even the future for that matter. As long as she kept up with her work and steadily fed into a savings account, she was free to live indefinitely in the present. She had friends. They were great. They were fun. But they paled in comparison to Catra.

Catra, well, Catra was something else entirely. Something deep in the recesses of her mind told her that she was getting too attached, that she'd fallen too hard too fast. Adora wasn't sure if that was the kill-switch that had traditionally ended any of her previous relationships when they had gotten even a hair past casual or if it was actually something worth listening to. Of course, she wasn't about to stop spending every night and most evenings with Catra. She wasn't about to give up telling stories both happy and sad about her childhood while being held. No, Catra provided something that she'd had no idea she'd needed for years. Not just a shoulder to cry on, but a shoulder of total understanding and acceptance. And she wanted to return the favor, but she couldn't do that if Catra kept those beautiful lips sealed.

Though, perhaps she understood why Catra felt she had to keep some things to herself. Adora hadn't meant to react poorly, she really hadn't, but when Catra told her what had happened to her in Gaziantep, Adora hadn't been able to keep her cool. She'd been furious. She'd leapt out of the bed completely naked, flipped on the lights, and had grilled Catra for details. Catra had reluctantly complied, giving names she clearly couldn't stand to say and actions she couldn't bear to relive, all while her arms wrapped tighter and tighter around herself.

Somehow, in that moment, Adora had decided that she was going to use her powers for good. She was going to find that guy and that woman and ruin their lives the way they'd ruined her girlfriend's. In that moment, she'd had so many plans, so many brilliant schemes to get revenge and serve justice. This was who she could be. Then, she had seen Catra with a pained look in her eye, her shoulders hunched, like glass mere moments from shattering.

And then just as suddenly, it had all stalled. Her rage, her plans, her desperate bid for redemption. She'd wrapped Catra as tightly as she could in her arms and had begged forgiveness. Forgiveness for overstepping, forgiveness for proving that the vault in her heart had best remain sealed. It had taken awhile, but Catra had

eventually relaxed and had gone to sleep with her face buried in Adora's chest.

Still, things weren't quite right for a while. Catra was distant, moody. She spent a few nights at her place but came back to hers when she got sick of listening to Khyle having sex with his girlfriend *from across the whole goddamn house, Adora, I'm gonna fucking kill him*. That night, Catra admitted that she was feeling a bit alienated from everyone, including herself. She figured that things would be better once it rained. Adora didn't quite understand such a cryptic statement, but a few weeks later, she did.

One day it was the usual 90 degrees out from morning til night, but around ten, the sky opened up. Adora heard the faint rush of water and saw the wind jostling the curtain from the open window. As most might do, she made a small, pleased noise and went back to typing. She was not left in peace for long.

"Everyone up to the terrace now! This is not a drill!"

Bo's voice bellowed up the stairs, and Adora heard frantic pounding on the steps. Leaping into emergency mode, she hopped up and waved frantically at Catra to take off her headphones.

"Where's the fire, princess?"

"Bo says to go to the terrace. C'mon!"

Catra looked suspicious for a moment, but in the quiet, she heard something that made her face split into a grin.

"Finally!"

Catra ran out of the room, stopping only to grab Adora's hand and drag her along with her. Catra took the stairs two at a time, and the pair emerged on the terrace to find Glimmer sitting on a couch and Bo leaning on the railing, getting soaked in the downpour.

Catra jogged over to join him, and Adora took the seat next to Glimmer.

“What’s up with them?”

Glimmer yawned. “It’s raining, Adora.”

“I can see that.”

“No, it’s the *first rain*.”

“Is this one of those bizarre things you guys do that I couldn’t possibly understand?”

Glimmer rested her head on Adora’s shoulder and closed her eyes. “Well, well, looks like you’re finally getting it, babe.”

“Glim, it’s barely ten, when did you get ancient?”

“Shut up, I had a long day.” Adora wrapped her arm around Glimmer’s shoulders as Bo and Catra returned from dancing around in the rain and began hunting around for supplies to start a fire in the raised pit. After a short argument about how the ashes were to be disposed of that mostly consisted of Bo convincing Catra not to pitch them off the roof, a fire was lit, and the four settled around it. Glimmer was resituated onto Bo’s chest where she promptly fell asleep after grumbling about his damp shirt. Adora felt for her when Catra laid her head on her lap and her wet mane of hair dripped all over her sweatpants.

Still, though, it was nice. The fire fought off the season’s first hint of chill. They sat mostly in comfortable silence until Bo broke it.

“So, are you enjoying your first, first rain of the year?”

“Me?” Adora asked, and Bo nodded, “Yeah, it’s fine. I’m not really getting the big deal. It’s rain. Fire’s nice, though.”

Catra stretched in her lap, “I've got this one. It's a metaphor. The city spends 8 months boiling and gathering dust, and so do we.

Think about it, when have you felt truly cold in the last 8 months? See, all that heat and pressure builds inside of you, inside of everybody, until it feels like just one more peek of the sun through your blinds will make you explode. Then, finally, nature takes pity and blesses us with rain. All the grime, all the sweat, all the pain of the last year gets washed away in a great November deluge and you can start again with a clean slate. April showers bring May flowers, y'know?" Catra turned to Bo. "Did I leave anything out?"

Bo shook his head. "You about covered it."

Adora smiled and gently removed Catra from her lap. Wordlessly, she stood and walked to the other side of the terrace. She was immediately pelted with fat drops of rain as she made her way over to the railing. With one hand shielding her eyes, she gazed out at the sea that churned faintly in the cloudy moonlight. She stood there for about a minute before she felt an arm wrap around her waist.

They stood in silence for a few minutes before Catra spoke:

"This year is going to be different."

"Yeah. I think so. Clean slate and all that, right?"

"Look at you listening to me when I talk."

"I try. It wasn't all bad, was it? This year?"

"Of course not. I met you, didn't I?"

Adora's heart thumped. "It was the best year of my life."

"Really?"

"Yeah."

Catra turned to peer at her in the darkness. "Hey, can I tell you something?"

Adora mirrored her stance. “Anything.”

“I love you.”

Adora blinked and then wrapped Catra in a tight hug. In her ear, she mumbled, “I love you, too.”

--

Truthfully, that was not the first time that Adora had heard those words from Catra. For the last couple of weeks, she’d heard their muffled whisper when she was on the border of sleep and wakefulness. The first couple of times, she had thought she had just been dreaming, but after a solid week, Adora had accepted that she had been hearing in her sleep something that Catra was too frightened to say when she was awake. Adora had felt the same for longer than she cared to admit, and the words had been living on the tip of her tongue, threatening to escape every time she held Catra in her arms, over breakfast, hell, every moment they were in the same room.

Still, she couldn’t be the first to say it. She told herself that it was Catra who wanted to say it first, and that she was respecting the other woman by letting her set the pace. Even Adora knew that was absolute horseshit, though. In truth, she couldn’t pinpoint exactly what held her back. To this point in their relationship, she’d been mostly open about what she wanted and how she felt. It had been quite an achievement in Adora’s book. This, though, this was different. Thinking back, she’d never told a woman, or anyone else for that matter, that she’d loved them romantically.

She’d been told approximately twice. The first time, she’d quickly gathered her clothes and made for the door as if the building were on fire. The second time, she’d at least allowed the dinner to finish before driving the woman home and promptly ghosting her. Looking back, they were yet another couple entries in her collection of not-so-proud moments. However, being less of a douchebag was on her many-itemed list of things she wanted to change about herself. And she was doing pretty well. Not being

able to say ‘I love you’ first was just another hiccup in the road to self-improvement for Adora Gray.

There was, of course, one glaring item on the list she’d been ignoring, aptly titled ‘stop avoiding emotionally-charged encounters that will make you uncomfortable’. More specifically, she still hadn’t told Saliha about her and Catra. She hadn’t meant for this love triangle of poor communication to go on this long, but, as she told herself, things had gotten complicated. First, like a coward, she had promised herself that she would tell Saliha if the friendship ever officially became anything more. Then, Catra had disappeared and then reappeared and everything had happened all at once. Next, she had the purgatorial period that she might still be in where everything was new and could blow up at any moment. After certain mutual admissions, though, she thought that was probably done. Maybe.

Still, this was bad. Infinite arsenal of excuses aside, she was doing a bad thing. Saliha was her friend, and it was getting harder and harder to play basketball or drink coffee or participate in idle conversation without it coming up. Up until this point, she’d been banking on Saliha confessing to Catra and getting shot down, but things had changed and keeping up that hope was definitely an even more profound dick move than before. She’d vaguely mentioned it to Catra, asked if she would care were Saliha to hypothetically learn that they were together. Catra had considered it for a long moment and then asked her if Saliha had explicitly come out to her. Adora had nodded and Catra had shrugged.

Adora couldn’t rely on Perihan to do it, either. Ever since Bo’s party, she’d been sending her pointed glances anytime Saliha said anything about anything. She was still shocked by Catra’s revelation, more-so because she knew that Perihan’s not-so-gentle nudging came from a place of impeccable perception. There were so many things she seemed to always just *know.* Mostly, she seemed to have a keen eye for what was right and what was wrong. And these days, Adora was coming out on the side of the latter.

These thoughts plagued Adora as she made her way to the park a week after the first rain. After that all-night storm, the sky had cleared to its usual pristine blue, but the temperature had remained in the mid 80's with a stiff wind. It was refreshing, and Adora was excited to play basketball without losing half of her body weight through her pores. That is, if Saliha didn't kill her, or worse, start to cry.

Adora reached the park first and found the courts deserted aside from a few teenagers loitering around the fence. She stretched and did a few lay-ups to warm up. As soon as she was moving, she felt better. This was going to be fine. Saliha would understand. These things happened. She drilled a few free-throws. The first two went in clean, but the third flew off the rim right into Saliha's hands who made a show of charging the net and sinking a fancy reverse lay-up.

Adora whistled. "You haven't been here one minute and you're already show-boating."

Saliha jogged up laughing and pulled Adora into a one-armed hug. "Sorry! Couldn't help myself. Oh, and sorry I'm late. Practice with the boys went over."

Adora knocked the ball out of her loose grip and sent it up. Swish. "How are they doing? Is Bora back from his twisted ankle?"

"Wow, you remember everything! He's much better now, but he could still use some time. I'll let him play a little in the game on Saturday, though. He's a good kid, and I think he even has a little boyfriend now."

"Aw, good for him. Shoot for first?"

"Sure."

Adora won the shot, and the two played one-on-one for a while. The game wasn't lazy, but they were clearly letting each other warm-up. The score stayed pretty much even. Both pushed harder on the second game, but Adora got the familiar feeling that she

was being allowed to win. She knew that Saliha held back because of the rare times she'd seen her go full tilt. The woman was overly humble, though. It had taken six months for her to mention to Adora that she'd played for Fenerbahçe for 5 years where they'd won 5 out of 5 years of national titles. Not only that, but she'd been part of the National Team that went to the London Olympics in 2012. Saliha, of course, waved this off like it was nothing. She was a teacher now, and those days were behind her.

Adora had no such adulations on the court. She'd played basketball in high school, but college had forced her to pick between it and lacrosse. Of course, she had chosen lacrosse. She was the one to watch. She was going places. She was the star. Basketball, though, she had always enjoyed for the sake of it. She had only ever been above-average at best, and the team had been middling, but she hadn't been bothered. It had been a nice break from the pressure of winning, the pressure to perform both self-imposed and impressed upon her by the authority figures that had surrounded her like hyenas as soon as they had caught the scent of her potential.

Still, Adora didn't want a pity win, especially not today, and she communicated this to Saliha in no uncertain terms. The woman hemmed and hawed and tried to convince Adora that she was playing normally, but Adora was having none of it. Eventually, Saliha relented, and trounced Adora in the third game 11 to 4. After Saliha easily sunk the winning basket over her head in a beautiful fade-away, Adora whooped and clapped her on the back.

"That's what I'm talking about! You kicked my ass, Sal!"

Saliha blushed and rubbed the back of her neck. "I didn't mean to do that. All the training, you know?"

"No, it's amazing. You can't let me get soft, coach."

Saliha laughed. They gathered up their stuff and headed to a nearby café for the customary post-game smoothies. It was a ritual that Adora treasured. Best 2 out of 3, loser buys drinks, a

nice catch-up while they wind-down. Today, though, as the adrenaline wore off, Adora found her leg bouncing and a hangnail bleeding in her mouth as Saliha went on about the high school boys' team and how they were blowing through the season and had a decent shot at play-offs.

"Listen to me talk and talk about nothing. What about you, Adora? Anything new with you?"

Oh God. It was time. Rip the band-aid off. C'mon. Do it. *Do it*.

"I, uh, yeah actually. I'm kind of, um, seeing someone. Romantically."

Saliha's eyes widened and her hands flew to her mouth to muffle a squeal. She leaned forward and lowered her voice. "You have a girlfriend?"

Adora licked her lips nervously. "Yep."

"Who is it? Is it anyone I know? Oh my God!" Saliha gasped. "Is it the woman you had a crush on?"

"Yeah, it's her."

"You don't have to tell me. But it's one of the foreigners, right? I mean, you don't have to tell me." Saliha crossed her arms and leaned back, but she was vibrating. Adora sighed.

Do it.

"Yeah, one of the foreigners. You know her. It's Catra. Primov. You guys work together, right?" Adora knew *damn well* they did.

Saliha went still. Oh no. Here it came. There was silence for a moment that felt longer than an eternity. Then, Saliha broke into a smile, albeit a bit pinched at the corners. "That's really nice, Adora. I'm happy for you two. Since when?"

Adora was thrown for a loop, but she wasn't about to question the gift of good fortune. After a moment to compose herself, she replied, "About a month ago."

Saliha considered. "Mm, that makes sense. She's been happier lately. At work. More like herself. She was having a bad time before that, right? She wouldn't tell me anything, but she seemed sad. Ever since we came back to school. She missed a few days, too, and she never calls out sick."

Adora shrugged. "Yeah, I think she was. She didn't tell me much, either."

"That's our Aslan." Saliha's smile grew a touch more genuine. "I guess it makes sense."

"What does?"

"You and Catra. I don't go out as much as Perihan and you all, but when I do, you two are always together. At karaoke, you even disappeared altogether. Kinda obvious now that I think about it, huh?"

Adora shrugged again and Saliha thankfully changed the topic. They chatted for a while, shorter than usual, and then Saliha was making some excuse to go. Adora wasn't about to begrudge her. The two stood to leave and Adora was engulfed in another hug. When she was released, Saliha held onto her shoulders.

"You're happy, right?"

Once again flabbergasted, Adora nodded dumbly. "Yes."

Saliha pulled her in again. "Then I'm happy for you."

--

Time passed quietly. Adora followed her established routine. Wake up (more often than not with accompaniment), run (more often than not getting drenched), work, hang out with whomever was

around (more often than not Glimmer who was looking particularly gloomy lately but refused to talk about it). Thanksgiving was spent at Lonnie and Rogelio's restaurant. That night, she felt her first pang of homesickness.

The Thanksgivings of her childhood had often been a lackluster affair. The years when they had a hot rotisserie chicken and real, Kraft brand mac and cheese were decent memories, but the other years certainly were not. Of course, the Thanksgivings at the Bright household weren't anything to scoff at by any means. No, those were events of abundance with more food than she could imagine. Still, she had never truly gotten comfortable with Glimmer's family. Micah and Angella were kind people who had only ever treated her with the highest degree of warmth and acceptance; however, that had never stopped Adora from feeling like a stray dog in their fancy Boston mansion or their fancy beach house on Cape Cod or their fancy estate in The Hamptons.

This year, like so many other years, Adora had sat there, surrounded by the people she had come to love most in the last year, eating some of the best food she'd ever eaten, and her heart had ached. Even with Catra's hand on her thigh and Glimmer's first real smile in weeks and Bo's stories and Khyle's animated teasing, even with all that, with all that she had ever wanted surrounding her, Adora had felt empty.

A few hours later, sitting on Catra's bed while the other woman took a shower, Adora burst into tears. If anyone were to ask her why in that moment, she could not begin to explain. She wasn't usually a crier. She couldn't even remember the last time she'd shed real tears over something other than a dog movie, let alone curled into a ball and gasping out wrenching sob after wrenching sob on someone else's bed. No, Adora could not put words to the despair coursing through her, but she was going to have to try because Catra was stumbling across the room in a towel and kneeling next to her on the bed. Adora didn't try at first; she instead latched onto Catra and buried her face in the damp towel covering her chest.

Catra held her patiently until Adora's sobs settled to hiccups and she steadied herself enough to peek upwards.

"'m sorry."

Catra's brows knit together. "What for?"

"I'm a mess." Adora sniffed and pulled away to lean against the wall.

"A little, but I don't mind."

Adora barked out a laugh. "Thanks."

"Wanna tell me what's up?"

"I'm sad."

"Shit, no way."

Adora laughed again, a little less roughly. "Shut up. Aren't you my girlfriend? Shouldn't you be comforting me?"

"What, do you want me to take the towel off?"

"No. Maybe. I'll think about it. Ugh, I can't believe you saw me crying. I bet I look like shit right now."

"Nah, you're always cute, princess. I'm biased, though, so you might want to get an outside opinion."

"Pass. Also, are you saying that you like me? Gross."

"I'd never admit to such a thing. So?"

"So what?"

"You know what. Do you always have a good cry on my bed when I take a shower without you?"

Adora snorted and slumped out of her ramrod posture. “No. Just, Thanksgiving.”

Catra nodded. “Ah. Anything in particular?”

“It’s really stupid.”

“No, it’s not.”

“Yes, it is.”

“No.”

“Yes.”

“Oh my God. Just tell me. I promise I won’t be shitty about it.”

“You swear?”

“Cross my heart and hope to die.” Catra even went so far as to make a little x in the general area of her heart.

Adora took a deep breath. “Mac and cheese.”

“Mac and cheese?”

“Yes.”

“Okay.”

“That’s it?”

“What? Did you honestly think I was going to laugh at you?”

“A little.”

“Shit, I’ve gotta be nicer.”

Adora shrugged. “No, you’re nice. Well, to me, at least.”

Catra leaned against the wall next to her, one hand struggling to keep her towel in place and the other gently taking Adora's hand. "This isn't an interrogation. I'll let it go if you want me to."

Adora considered the offer and eventually shook her head. "No. I'm a big girl. I can talk about my feelings. Do you, like, wanna get dressed?"

Catra yanked on her towel again. "Nope, this is great. I love this. Go on, princess, I'm all ears."

Adora took a steadying breath. "It's not really about the mac and cheese, I think. It's about something bigger."

"Yeah, you're feeling homesick, right?"

Adora blinked, "How did you know?"

Catra shrugged, "People attach to weird things when they're away for a long time. One time, Hawkins started wailing in the middle of a club in Kemer because he realized he hadn't had a glass of Milo in ten years. What's the story?"

"I don't know if I have a story, per se. I've never really liked Thanksgiving. I told you that my mom was kinda erratic when I was growing up, so it was usually just a regular day. Then when I went to the boarding school, I started going to Glimmer's house, and her family is so, like, unimaginably rich, and it felt weird sitting around that big table with the fancy tablecloths while servants – servants! Did you know her family has, like, a massive staff? That kind of rich. Anyway, so I was this dirty little poor kid they pulled in out of the rain and handed five different forks to. They were nice, don't get me wrong, very welcoming, but it still felt weird, y'know?"

Catra laughed. "Sparkles has servants?"

Adora nodded. "Oh yeah. Butler, chauffeur, and her dad has a personal valet."

“Wild. I would’ve lost my shit if I had to go there when I was a teenager.”

Adora laughed. “I got used to it.”

“Did you ever have a good Thanksgiving?”

“A few. Sometimes, when my mom was having a good day, she would bring home a rotisserie chicken from the supermarket and a box of mac and cheese. It would be just us, like always. I guess I miss that. I miss her.” Adora sniffed.

Catra squeezed her hand. “I bet.”

“It’s been so long, but I still miss her sometimes. This is all kinda nice, though, it’s nice to remember that there were good times. I always get caught up in all the bad time, all the wasted time, I forget about the rest.”

Catra nodded. “That makes sense.”

Adora laughed. “Does it? I feel like I’m just spouting nonsense.”

“It does. How are you feeling?”

“Better. Thank you.” Adora leaned over and kissed Catra on the cheek.

“You did me a favor. For once, I cannot wait to see Sparkles.”

“Be nice to her. She’s sad.”

“Really? About what?”

Adora shrugged. “I dunno. She won’t tell me.”

“Okay fine. Because you asked, I’ll be 10% nicer.”

“Good enough for me.”

Adora laid her head on Catra's bare shoulder, closed her eyes, and luxuriated in the comfortable silence that followed.

Eventually, Catra casually asked, "What brand did you say that mac and cheese was?"

"I didn't, but Kraft, the regular kind."

"Cool, and what time is it?"

Adora frowned and checked her phone, "11:30, why?"

"Perfect. Up and at 'em, princess."

Catra hopped off the bed and quickly pulled on a pair of boxer briefs and a sweatshirt. Adora followed after her to the kitchen where she watched the other woman climb onto the counter to dig through the highest cabinet. After a few moments, Catra launched a blue object in her direction and she caught it. She found that the object in her hands was a beat-up box of Kraft mac and cheese, Original flavor. She blinked a few times at the box and turned it carefully over in her hands.

Catra hopped off the counter. "I picked this up in Adana at this thing called the American Bazaar. It's this sketch alley of shops full of stuff that 'fell off a truck' on the way to the Air Force base there. Wanna make it?"

Adora stood stupefied. "Really?"

Catra stooped down to grab a saucepan and brought it to the sink. "Yeah. I'm hungry."

Adora snapped out of it and snorted. "There's no way. We ate at least three gallons of hummus."

"Nope. I'm starving. Wasting away. Help me, princess, you're my only hope."

Adora laughed, fully this time. "Fine, gimme the pan."

Approximately twenty minutes later, the pair sat at the kitchen table attempting to pile mac and cheese on top of their already packed stomachs. It didn't matter, though, because as Adora took bite after bite, she couldn't help beaming.

Later in bed, Adora was still smiling while they both laid on their backs staring at the ceiling and digesting.

"Thanks."

"For what?"

"The last couple of hours."

"Oh. My pleasure."

"Seriously, it was very sweet of you."

"Ew, I'm not sweet. Take it back."

Adora laughed. "Never. Hey, I never asked about you."

"What about me?"

"What were your Thanksgivings like? Before here."

"Oh." Catra shifted. "They weren't anything special. Snezhana thought it was an 'idiotic American tradition', so we didn't usually do anything. She always wrote up a little speech for me to say at school when the teacher asked so I wouldn't make her look bad."

"Whoa."

"Yeah, she'd have me say what we ate and who we saw and all that. And she worked at the school, so she'd know if I didn't do it exactly right. Then, there were a couple years where she had the priest and some other church people over, and she cooked this big-ass meal. She didn't cook anything but what I've always assumed was Bulgarian food, so it was surreal to see her, like, basting a turkey and putting marshmallows on sweet potatoes.

She was always extra-on-edge when we had church people over, so it was stressful."

"That sucks."

Catra shrugged. "Eh, it was a long time ago. Your story's worse."

"No way. Yours is worse."

Catra turned to fully look at Adora in the dim light. "Are you seriously trying to throw down right now over which one of us had the crappier childhood?"

Adora grinned. "Maybe. What, afraid you'll lose?"

"Nah. None of that matters anymore." Catra rolled back to stare at the ceiling wistfully. "We're grown-ups now. We're here. Nothing back there has to define us anymore."

That took the wind out of Adora's sails. "I guess you're right. Still, that sounds like a lot of responsibility. Defining ourselves."

"Maybe. I think we're doing a pretty decent job at it anyway, princess."

"I suppose we are."

Catra leaned over and pressed a kiss to her forehead. Adora pulled her down for a kiss on the lips and a hug. When she released Catra, she smiled and said, "I love you." Catra smiled back.

"I love you, too."

--

A little before Christmas, Catra finally told Adora about the missing three weeks between their first kiss and Catra's entrance to the hospital. If Adora were being objective, she would understand why Catra hadn't wanted to tell her. It was rough. It was rough

for Adora to hear the details about the distorted thoughts that kept them apart, and it was clearly rough for Catra to say it. It was worse to hear about the night of the cliff, worse that Catra's tone was more embarrassed than anything, as if ashamed that she couldn't control herself. Adora left the conversation sad and miffed at Khyle for not telling her what was going on. The two clearly had an iron-clad sense of loyalty to one another, and she couldn't help but wonder what else he would be willing to hide from her in the future.

Still, it was a good talk, and Adora was happy to finally be caught up. Catra seemed happier, too. She hadn't even complained about attending the annual Christmas party at Bo's. Catra didn't drink more than a beer, but something about knowing that it was the medication keeping her sober as well as her plaintive urgings galvanized Adora to indulge more than usual. Catra and Khyle all but carried her back to their place, and the next morning answered the question of why she'd been feeling so much better these last couple of months.

The Horde had started having practice again, and slowly-but-surely Catra had started coming out again. Less than before, but she was around. No one seemed to ask any questions which simultaneously annoyed and impressed Adora. It seemed that they cared little about their friend and whether she was around or not, or perhaps it was because Catra had spent years cultivating an air that effectively repulsed any line of questioning.

Two weeks after the New Year, The Horde had their first show at The Waste. As Adora sat with everyone at a round table, a leather jacket slung around the back of a chair next to her, she was struck with a sense of déjà vu. She watched Khyle, Lonnie, and Rogelio set up, but this time Rogelio waved and Khyle blew her a kiss. Lonnie just rolled her eyes and yelled something at the both of them. After a few minutes, the lights dimmed, and Catra appeared from the back room and sauntered onto the stage. The crowd, including Adora, went wild.

While The Horde wasn't exactly the most famous of the Kaleiçi bar bands, they had a dedicated group of regulars that had missed them during their nearly-four-month absence. Adora found that she had missed seeing Catra like this. A year ago, she'd been flustered to the point of stasis by the woman slinking around the stage, but now she saw the bright smiles, the laughter, and the camaraderie between them all. They were all genuinely having fun, and Adora hadn't realized until this moment how much she had desperately needed to witness that.

At the beginning of the last song of the first half of the set, Adora saw Sea Hawk sneak off to the bar. She followed after him and entered into a tense negotiation about the beers for the customary intermission skulling. He seemed to think that 2 one liter mugs was the only appropriate way to welcome back the band from their sojourn of time immemorial. He was not dissuaded by arguments about the quality of the music for the rest of the night nor with appeals to the practical concerns of sucking down a bunch of beer and having no access to a bathroom on stage. It wasn't until Adora changed tack and demanded the right to buy the beers as a grand romantic gesture that Sea Hawk nodded seriously and left her at the bar with a wink.

Adora sighed in relief and bought a round for the table. As if on cue, Bo appeared at her side to help pass them around. The song ended and Catra made her way back to the table with Lonnie, Rogelio, and Khyle in tow. They took seats, and Adora and Bo plinked 50 cl mugs down in front of them. Catra gave her an odd look before smiling gratefully. All of a sudden, everyone was looking at her, and Adora blinked owlishly. Glimmer finally elbowed her and motioned for her to stand up.

"Oh," Adora said as she got to her feet, "This means I have to give the speech?" Everyone stared. "Okay, wow. Good job everyone. Everyone in the band. You guys are great, I mean, you're always great." Glimmer kicked her under the table. "Geez, Glim, that hurt. Okay. It's been awhile since the last time we were all here together to watch our friends play, and I gotta say I've

missed everyone. And it's amazing that we can all come together and support each other. I can honestly say that you all are the best group of friends I have ever had. Ever. A year ago, I came here like a sad little puppy on Glimmer's doorstep, and a year ago, you all accepted me with no questions asked like you'd known me for years. And, you know what, that might not have meant anything to you at the time, but it meant everything to me. So this one is for all of you, The Horde, the Waste, and Antalya, this place we call home!"

Adora raised her beer, everyone joined her and shouted out "Şerefe!" before tipping their glasses back. As everyone finished, they slammed their empty mugs on the table. Glimmer, Bo, Catra, Sea Hawk, Feyza, and Lonnie whooped loudly. Perihan, Merve, Khyle, and Rogelio were more subdued, but shot Adora some form of a smile. After some brief conversation, Adora found herself dragged outside. Catra hopped up on the short wall and Adora followed her while the other woman lit a cigarette.

"Nice speech, princess."

Adora laughed. "Was it? I was just rambling. I thought Sea Hawk would do it. I guess he thought I was going to take the opportunity to publically declare my undying love for you or something."

"Wow, you really missed the mark there. I love nothing more than brash declarations of love in a shitty bar in front of an audience."

"I have never been sorrier in my life."

Catra giggled.

"Thanks for running interference on the beers by the way. If I had to do a bavyera, I probably would've puked on the table."

"He wanted to do two."

"Dude."

“Why don’t you just tell everyone? That you don’t want to drink so much anymore. We’re not in high school, they’ll understand.”

Catra sighed. “Yeah, I will eventually. I think I’m just not ready for everything to completely change yet. I’m still trying to figure out who I am without drinking, as dumb as that sounds.”

Adora wrapped an arm around Catra’s waist. “It’s not dumb. I moved across a whole ocean trying to figure out who I was.”

Catra rested her head on Adora’s shoulder. “Yeah, you’re pretty dramatic.”

“Hey!”

“Did you?”

“Did I what?”

“Find yourself.”

Adora considered for a moment. “I don’t think there was any ‘self’ for me to find. I found you, though. That was pretty cool.”

Catra hummed. They stayed like that for a few minutes until Catra abruptly slid off the wall and turned to offer Adora her hand.

“C’mon, princess. In case you haven’t noticed, I’m kind of in the middle of something.”

Adora took the hand and hopped down. “Wait, this isn’t a date?”

Back inside, Adora settled in for the second half of the set. Everything was mostly unchanged aside from a little shuffling, and they ended with ‘Lost on You’ as per. However, as the song faded out, the band did not leave the stage. Instead, Catra picked up an acoustic guitar from the side and shrugged the strap over her shoulder. She grabbed the mic and purred something in Turkish that made the audience chuckle.

Then, she turned to their table and said, “We’ve got one more song for you. A little low-key, and everyone’s mad I made them learn it, but they can deal.” Catra smiled, locked eyes with Adora, and continued, “We hope you like it.”

Catra launched into a familiar melody and Adora’s breath caught in her throat. In time, the rest of the band joined in and Catra leaned into the mic.

You got a fast car

I want a ticket to anywhere

Maybe we make a deal

Maybe together we can get somewhere

Any place is better

Starting from zero got nothing to lose

Maybe we'll make something

Me, myself, I got nothing to prove

You got a fast car

I got a plan to get us outta here

I been working at the convenience store

Managed to save just a little bit of money

Won't have to drive too far

Just 'cross the border and into the city

You and I can both get jobs

And finally see what it means to be living

Adora watched, enraptured, as Catra smiled through the song. Glimmer pinched her cheek fondly, but she couldn't even object. At the chorus, she felt her eyes fill with tears.

So I remember we were driving, driving in your car

Speed so fast it felt like I was drunk

City lights lay out before us

And your arm felt nice wrapped 'round my shoulder

And I-I had a feeling that I belonged

I-I had a feeling I could be someone, be someone, be someone

Logically, Adora knew that this was a sad song, but in this moment, she felt nothing but hope and promise for the future. As Catra sang and sang, as the song came to a close, Adora wanted nothing more than to sprint up to the stage and kiss the woman she loved. Unfortunately, though, that was not an option, and Adora had to wait as the song ended, as Catra bid the audience farewell, as the band packed up.

Still, when Catra eventually made it back to the table, Adora couldn't help herself and pulled the other woman into her lap for a crushing hug. In her ear, she whispered, "I love you." Catra, though a bit startled, hugged her back and whispered, "I love you" back. The table aw'ed and Catra took the opportunity to tell them to fuck off and clamber into her own seat.

Everyone congratulated the band on their re-debut and everyone settled into conversation.

Adora turned to Catra, "Hey, wait. Was that song for me?"

Catra scoffed, "As if. You are seriously the most conceited person I've ever met."

Lonnie scoffed back, "Oh fuck off with that. She was so excited about this for weeks. It was a pain in the ass, too, scumbag, we had to make an acoustic ballad into a rock song."

"Aw, don't be mean. It was fun! Bise was kinda crazy over it, though."

"No, I wasn't. It was a natural addition to our set."

"Oh yeah, definitely." Khyle dropped into his surprisingly accurate Catra impression. 'Lonnie that bass sounds like shit, do it again, Khyle you're coming in too early. We have to make it perfect. I have to show Adora how much I—"

"Lies and slander. Adora, we're suing them for defamation of character."

"You know I wasn't that kind of lawyer."

"Then why do I keep you around?"

"My sculpted physique, sparkling personality, and overwhelming sense of modesty?"

"Oh right, how could I forget?"

"Plus, scumbag here'll get you out of any trouble you get yourself into."

"Thank you, Lonnie. I have many skills."

Khyle laughed, "Is that from Xena?"

Adora nodded seriously. “Yes.”

--

Not long after, Merve came over looking agitated and leaned down to murmur something in Catra’s ear. Whatever she said made Catra’s eyes go wide. She immediately stood up and absently told the table that she’d be back soon before following Merve outside. Adora was mildly disquieted, but thought little of it until 10 minutes later when Catra stormed back into the bar with murder in her eyes. She stomped right up to Sea Hawk who was jovially taking shots with Bo and Feyza and yanked him to his feet by his collar.

“Catra, hello, to what do I owe the pleasure?”

Catra did not reply, dragged him to the double doors, and shoved him out roughly. As if remembering something, she returned to the table and grabbed her jacket. While aggressively pulling it on, she turned to Adora.

“You should probably go home without me. You can go back with Khyle if you want to stay at my place tonight. I’ll be back by morning.”

Adora blinked, “You look really mad.”

Catra laughed mirthlessly, “You ain’t wrong, princess. I’ll call you later, okay?”

“Yeah okay.”

With that, Catra stalked back out of the bar. Whatever the deal was, Adora pitied Sea Hawk. Immediately, Adora turned to Glimmer who looked bored with the whole display.

“Any idea what the problem is?”

Glimmer waved her hand vaguely. “I don’t know, Adora, take your pick.”

“Should I go out there?”

“God no. Yelling at Sean is one of Catra’s favorite drunken pastimes. Let it run its course.”

“She isn’t drunk.”

“Oh yeah, I forgot she’s on her whole ‘I’m not drinking but being super mysterious about it’ thing. What’s up with that anyway?”

Adora fidgeted, “I’m not at liberty to say.”

“Whatever, I know it’s either the medication she’s on or she found Jesus. And I know you and Ekaterina are doing anything but praying on Sunday mornings.”

“Hey.”

“I’m not complaining. You guys fuck all morning and then she makes a huge breakfast. Be as loud as you want as long as she keeps the good shit coming.”

Bo leaned over, “Seriously, that açma she made last week was heavenly. I hadn’t the faintest she knew how to use an oven.”

Adora ignored both of them, “Bo, why is Catra yelling at Sea Hawk?”

Bo’s face fell. “Oh, uh, I don’t know.”

Glimmer scoffed, “I know that face. He definitely knows. Babe, please tell her before she goes out there and does something stupid.”

“I said I don’t know!” Bo’s voice cracked.

Adora stood up and casually brought her chair to Bo’s other side so that he was fully flanked. “Wow, you’re a bad liar.”

“You can’t even imagine.”

“I am not!”

“Bo, I will get it out of you, I swear to God. I am trying to be a better woman now, but I will go back to my old ways.”

“You’d better listen to her. I saw her in court once. She made a cop cry on the stand. It was beautiful and terrifying.”

“Thank you, Glimmer. I appreciate that.”

Bo threw up his arms. “Okay fine! I’ll tell!”

Glimmer looked mildly disappointed, “I thought he was going to put up more of a fight.”

Adora shrugged, “It’s easier this way. Now, Bo, why is Catra mad at Sea Hawk?”

“Well,” Bo said, wringing his hands, “I’m not completely sure why Catra is throwing one, but something big did happen that might have something to do with it.”

“And that would be?”

“Well…”

Adora bored her eyes into Bo’s until he looked away. Even Glimmer leaned forward. This intrigue was proving more interesting than expected.

“Sea Hawk proposed to Merve.”

Adora blinked. “What?”

“You cannot tell anyone!”

Glimmer rolled her eyes. “That happens every six months. Why would Catra care?”

“Merve said no.”

“To the shock of absolutely no one.”

“She didn’t say no at first. She said she would say yes, but only if he got his act together.”

Adora furrowed her brows. “What do you mean?”

Bo fidgeted again. “She wanted him to quit drinking, or at least cut down.”

Glimmer’s jaw dropped. “And he said *no*?”

“It’s more complicated than that, but I suppose, yes.”

“That idiot! I’ll kick his ass myself.”

Bo shrugged. “I assume that’s why Catra’s reading him the riot act. Maybe some good will come of it. Please don’t tell anyone else, though.”

Adora nodded, “Yeah, of course, they can work it out themselves. Catra’s probably okay, though, right?”

Glimmer snorted and stood up. “She’s fine, Adora. Come get a drink with me.”

Adora obediently hopped up and followed Glimmer to the bar where she ordered them each a cocktail. When the drinks arrived, Glimmer made a beeline to a small, recently vacated table on the other side of the bar. It seemed that its previous owners were trying their luck in the back room. Adora wished them all the best. She’d been back there a few times over the year when she hadn’t been able to avoid someone dragging her in or when she was following along after Catra like a lovesick puppy.

The two sat in a silence long and uncomfortable enough to make Adora squirm. This was how it’d been with Glimmer for the last month or so. Something was off-balance, and Adora hated that there was nothing she could do about it. Of course, there was nothing she could do about it because everyone in her daily life

seemed to get off on keeping secrets. It was especially disconcerting to see this behavior in Glimmer, someone who she had always known to speak her mind as if wielding a heavy blunt instrument.

If Adora were to truly examine her frustration, she might find that perhaps she was most unsettled by the concept that her best friend could have the capacity to change. Since high school, Glimmer had always been the constant. Fiery, uncompromising, and unabashedly unafraid to give word to thought, Glimmer Bright was everything that young Adora wasn't but desperately wished to be. Over the years, Adora grew out of her idolization, but she never stopped admiring the other woman. And now this same woman sat across from her glaring into her gin and tonic and refusing to speak.

So, Adora spoke for her. "Not that I don't enjoy a nice walk, but what are we doing over here, Glim?"

Glimmer slowly lifted her eyes and schooled the frown on her face into neutrality. "I wanted to talk to you."

"Yeah, I figured. What's up?"

Glimmer groaned. "Ugh, could you just stop being so chipper for a fucking second?"

Adora held up her hands, "Whoa, what is going on with you? Are you mad at me?"

"No, I—" Glimmer ran a hand down her face, "Fuck. Sorry. I'm in a shitty mood."

"You've been in a shitty mood for a month. Did something happen? Just tell me. Seriously, I won't be mad. I promise I won't react at all. Whatever it is, I just wanna hear it."

Glimmer raised her eyebrows. "What the fuck, Adora? When did you get like this? Is this how you have to talk to Catra to get her to spill her million secrets?"

Adora narrowed her eyes, slipping from concerned to annoyed in a heartbeat. “Stop changing the subject. You brought me all the way over here to tell me something, so tell me.”

Glimmer glared, and Adora glared back. However, something in the back of Adora’s mind reminded her that this was not how she wanted this to be going. It reminded her that her best friend was clearly in a bad place and while she was lashing out like an asshole, she needed support. As such, Adora deflated and uncrossed her arms. She took a deep breath and stripped the anger from her voice.

“Glimmer?”

Glimmer loosened a bit at her tone. “Yeah?”

“What’s wrong?”

Glimmer took a deep breath and sighed it out. “I’m moving back to the States.”

Adora choked on her drink. “What? Why?”

“Mom wants me back. She said that I proved myself out here and that she and the board decided I’m ready.”

“Ready for what?”

“They want to start training me in operations. Mom says the current COO is retiring in a few years, and it was always the plan to put me there eventually.”

Adora frowned. “That’s huge. I want to congratulate you, but you don’t seem happy.”

Glimmer rubbed her eyes. “I’m not. I mean, I am, I guess. I have to be. This was always gonna happen. That was the plan. Send me off to Turkey after Stanford and let me work out my insubordination or wanderlust or whatever and then bring me back when I’d be more amenable to, I don’t know, pantsuits?”

“Pantsuits have their merits.”

“Ha, yeah. You’d know.”

“Have you told Bo?”

Glimmer looked miserable. “No.”

“Glimmer!”

Her head thunked onto the table. “I know! I’m scared, okay? I’m so fucking scared of what he’ll say. He has this amazing life here, and he loves his job and his friends, and I’m supposed to ask him to come to Boston with me where he doesn’t know anyone and might not even be able to teach? He’s just gonna tell me to fuck off.”

Adora reached across the table and put a hand on Glimmer’s. “Hey, c’mon, that doesn’t sound like Bo. He loves you. You guys will figure something out.”

Glimmer did not raise her head. “I guess.”

“I get why you haven’t told him, but why didn’t you want to tell me?”

Glimmer lifted her head and placed it heavily on her fist. “Fuck, Adora, how could I? I’m over here whining about my corporate destiny or whatever when you’ve thrown all that shit away to write books with your hot girlfriend. Ever since we were kids, you always made your own way despite having to overcome so much, but you always fucking did it and were always the best. I mean, *Jesus*, Adora, you’re the strongest person I know. You always have been. How could I tell you how much of a weak and spineless trust fund brat I am?”

Adora blinked, a smile slowly crept onto her face, and all of a sudden she barked out a laugh. Glimmer’s face went from shocked to irritated as Adora’s giggles continued bubbling out.

"What?"

Adora wiped her eyes and tried to stifle her laughter. Eventually, she choked out, "Oh my God, *what*? Glimmer, holy shit, I am not strong. Almost everything I've ever done in my life was because I was ashamed of being poor and wanted people to tell me I was good enough! I was so scared and insecure all the time! You were literally my idol for years because I thought you were the strongest and coolest person in the world. I still look up to you so much and still want to be you when I grow up. Even quitting my job and coming here was such a *you* move for me. I never would've had the guts to do that if not for you."

Adora managed to get her laughter under control and looked up to see Glimmer smiling faintly.

"Really? You mean that?"

Adora smiled brightly. "Of course! Glimmer, you are so fucking awesome. You're going to be an amazing COO, or if you don't want it, you'll be amazing at whatever you decide to do instead. There is no one who I have believed in as much as I believe in you. You could never let me down."

Glimmer quickly pawed at the tears threatening to run down her cheeks. "God, Adora, when did you learn to talk about feelings?"

Adora shrugged. "This year, I guess. Do you want a hug?"

Glimmer smiled. "From you? When's the last time you showered?"

Adora rolled her eyes and stood up. "A few hours ago, and I know you know that cause you were yelling at me to hurry up. Come here."

The two embraced tightly and the world melted away for a moment. Gone was the mildewy bar, the repetitive Spotify playlist that hadn't been changed in at least a year, the idle chatter around them. Gone were the responsibilities of the future, the drama of the present, the pain of the past. As Adora held her best

friend tightly, she was embraced by the good fortune of running late for a class fifteen years ago that unspooled a thread of cherished memories that settled in this moment as yet another in an unending, unbroken chain.

When the two finally pulled apart, Glimmer wiped her eyes and sniffed.

"Now I have to go fix my make-up. I hope you're happy."

"I am!" Adora pinched Glimmer's cheek. "Let's go get you cleaned up."

A few minutes later, Adora sat on the slightly-damp bathroom counter next to the sink against her better judgement and kicked her legs back and forth while Glimmer dabbed gingerly at the wing of her eyeliner with a tissue.

"Hey, Glimmer?"

"Hmm?"

"Do *you* want to go back?"

"I don't know, Adora. On one hand, Mom and Dad have been talking about me taking over the company one day like we're royalty or something since I was a kid. You know how my mom can be. She has all these expectations for me cause I was her 'miracle baby' or whatever." Glimmer pulled a palette out of her bag. "And you know we've never really gotten along that well. I mean, God, you saw some of those fights when we were teenagers. It was brutal. I thought she hated me for years. Up until I took the job out here even." She gently blended the new edges on her eyeshadow. Adora watched the process with as rapt attention as when they were teenagers. "Don't get me wrong. I know she loves me and all that, but I'm asking myself here if I want to take this job cause I want it or if I feel like I have to so my mom will be proud of me, you know?"

Adora nodded, understanding as well as she could.

"Dad wouldn't care. He never made the company, like, the entire basis of his identity. Not like Mom did. And I don't want that to happen to me, I guess. I don't want the crushing pressure and the phone calls at every hour of the night. You know, I remember waking up and going downstairs to see her leading a conference call at 2 am or pacing the halls yelling at someone on the phone or just looking so exhausted. I mean, the next day, she'd look like a fucking queen that got 10 hours of uninterrupted beauty sleep, but still. It sucked for her. It probably still does.

But then again," Glimmer said as she applied lip gloss, "Who the fuck am I to turn down a challenge? It'd be badass, and it's the next logical step in the company, you know? Besides, I miss home, too. It's great here, I love it, but holy fuck what I wouldn't do for some Taco Bell."

Adora laughed at that. "Taco Bell? Seriously?"

Glimmer zipped her bag shut and replaced it in her purse.

"Don't talk shit about Taco Bell when I'm vulnerable, Adora, I swear to God. Now let's get out of here before someone thinks we're fucking."

When they exited the bathroom, they were met with a predictable line of glares. As the door slammed shut, Adora and Glimmer burst into laughter that continued all the way back to the big table. Once there, Bo shot Adora a searching look and all Adora could do was shrug. Glimmer would tell him eventually, and for now she at least appeared to be in a better mood as she argued with Feyza over the merits of sparkly lip gloss versus unadorned lip gloss.

The rest of the night passed uneventfully, though Adora checked her phone every couple of minutes to see if Catra had called. She hadn't. At the end of the night, Glimmer decided to go to Bo's – hopefully to have a heart-to-heart – so Adora left with Khyle. His girlfriend, who Adora had become fond of, had to leave early, so it was just the two of them. Adora had, for the most part, gotten

over his refusal to tell her about Catra's condition, but it still stood that the two did not often hang out alone together.

So when they found themselves sitting together on the couch scrolling for a movie to watch, Adora floundered for conversation. Unsurprisingly, the only topic she could land on was Catra.

"What do you think they're doing?"

"Bise and Sea Hawk?"

"Yeah."

"Talking, probably. They've got a spot down in the harbor for it."

"Oh yeah?"

"She'll be mad I told you, but that's where they would always go to talk her down from a bad trip."

"That happened often?"

"Yeah, kinda. We were stupid back then. Hey, how about this?"

Adora glanced at the screen to see a gory slasher she'd never heard of previewed. "Can we do a comedy?"

"Sure. Anyway, Bise was like the leader back then, so she wanted us to see her as all cool and badass, but it sometimes meant that she did too much to keep up with dudes double her size. When that happened, Hawk would take her down to the harbor and remind her that she wasn't alone. She needed that sometimes. We all do, but the loneliness always hit her hardest. What about this one?"

Adora saw Scary Movie 3 on the screen and shrugged. "Sure."

Khyle hummed happily and started the movie.

"Hey," Adora said, "Why are you telling me all this?"

“You asked?”

“I guess, but you’ve never told me about Catra before.”

“Oh, that. Well, you know Bise. She keeps herself locked up tight. She didn’t even tell me about any of the mental stuff until I’d known her for a couple years, and I think the only reason she did then was because I actually saw it when we moved in together. Back in August, you hadn’t really been around that long, and I didn’t know what was going on with you two. You were always together and sleeping in the same bed, and it was kind of weird, no offense. I wasn’t sure what was holding you back, or her even cause she was all guarded about it. And honestly, Bise hasn’t been treated well in the past, so I wanted to make sure you weren’t going to hurt her.” Khyle shrugged. “Besides, it was her story to tell.”

Adora mulled that over for a moment. “I suppose that makes sense.”

“I’m glad you’re here now, though! I’ve never seen her so happy.” Khyle reached over and mussed up Adora’s hair. Adora slapped his hands away, laughing.

“Okay, enough about Catra. What about you? You seem pretty happy these days.”

Khyle nodded, “Oh yeah, sure. Things with Fulya are going pretty well. I met her parents last week, and they seem okay with everything. Me and her. I’ve been doing some more translation jobs which pay in dollars, so I’ve got some good money coming in. Yeah, I’m good.”

“That’s good.”

Both Adora and Khyle turned back to the movie. Adora found it difficult to pay too much attention, though. Khyle was a guy that was tough to pin down. On the outside, he was funny and affable with a charm that could melt the coldest heart. And maybe that was all there was, but something told Adora that he was hiding

something. It had always nagged at the back of her mind, but she'd never had anywhere concrete to take it. Though, if she thought enough about it for more than a second, she'd find that perhaps her misgiving was the result of nothing more than rank jealousy. She knew she placed highly on Catra's VIP list, but she also rationally knew that as long as Khyle was around, she would ultimately fall below him. She also knew that this line of reasoning was ridiculous and made her feel like she was in middle school.

Regardless, she felt that she'd made an important ally that night. More than that, she genuinely liked Khyle and always had. In the end, she wasn't going to let her more childish feelings get in the way of being his friend. When the movie ended, the two headed off to their rooms but not before Khyle pulled Adora into a tight hug.

"Good night, Adora. I'm glad you're waking up here tomorrow."

Feeling like an immense jerk for thinking even a single negative thing about him, Adora replied, "Thanks, and thanks for letting me stay. Good night."

Khyle left her with a small squeeze on the shoulder. "Don't mention it."

Later, as Adora lay in Catra's bed staring at the ceiling and chewing the inside of her cheek, her phone buzzed.

Catra (02:39): hey. did you go back with khyle?

Adora (02:39): yeah. we watched a movie

Catra (02:40): good. Im glad youre there. it might be stupid, but tonight made me really miss you

Adora (02:40): its not stupid. I miss you too. are you coming home?

Catra (02:40): in a couple hours probably. I went to Hawkins place. Ill be there when you wake up

Adora (02:41): okay. love you

Catra (02:41): love you too. and sorry about all this. Ill explain tomorrow

Adora (02:42): don't worry about it, I made Bo tell me. his will is weak

Catra (02:42): that's my menace to society. see you soon, princess

Adora (02:42): see you

Adora stared at her phone long after the light went off. *Hmm*. With the knowledge that Catra was safe somewhere that she knew came a rush of fatigue that settled in her bones. *What a weird night*, she thought as she rolled over to cuddle Catra's pillow and fell immediately into a deep sleep.

It was a hot summer day in Laurel. Hotter than usual and more humid. Still, Adora was running her hardest through the woods. She ran and ran and eventually came upon Brayden and Glimmer in a wide clearing. Glimmer was in her uniform and her light brown hair was tied up neatly with a chopstick while she held Brayden face down in the dirt. Adora was about to tell her to let him up when Catra put a hand on her shoulder and said that he deserved it. Adora reached up to touch her hair, shorn down to a buzzcut, but had to get on her tiptoes cause Catra was so tall. Brayden whined into the dirt and Adora turned to look at him, less sympathetically than before. Glimmer stood up and said her mom was calling and she had to go. Adora turned back to Catra to find her own mother staring back at her as she ran her fingers through her honey blonde hair. Adora wanted to hug her but found her body frozen save for the hand tangled in her mother's hair. In the distance, Adora heard the screech of tires and the crunch of a car against something hard. She whipped around to find nothing but Brayden on his knees crying. When she turned back, she found one of the senior partners from her old firm. Mr. DeMarco placed a hand on her cheek and told her he was proud of her. His hand

was like a cold fish. She wanted to run but found that she couldn't. The hand on her face started to burn and she realized that the clearing was engulfed in flames. Her feet began to move and she was running through them. Her chest heaved and sweat ran into her eyes but she ran harder. This is the wrong way. *Adora looked to her side and Ms. Razz flew there on a broom.* You need to go back to the beginning. *Ms. Razz dissolved in the flames and Adora fell to her knees, choking on smoke*.

Adora jolted awake with a gasp. Frantically, she felt around her body and cast wild eyes around the room until they landed on Catra sleeping peacefully beside her. Adora gingerly touched the woman's hair and spooled a curl around her finger. Everything felt right, and her breathing started to settle. *Weird dream*, she thought as images of flames slipped from her memory and she laid back against the pillow. After a few more moments spent blinking at the ceiling, she turned toward Catra and gently pulled her back flush against her chest. Catra sighed in her sleep, and Adora buried her nose in her slightly-damp hair. *Just a dream*, she thought as she fell back to sleep.

The next day was Sunday, so Catra made breakfast for the house. Over it, she told Adora and Khyle about her night with Sea Hawk. Adora could tell that she was glossing over quite a bit, but she didn't begrudge her. While she was somewhat curious, she was cognizant enough to realize that it was none of her business. Besides, if experience were to be trusted, she'd find out eventually.

More importantly, Adora found that she didn't care nearly as much as she expected herself to. Something else was taking up space in her mind, something nebulous and indescribable. Adora chose to ignore it for the time being and went about her day. She spent some time with Catra which she deemed a good enough warm-up for the gym. There, she meant to head straight to the rowing machine but found herself diverted by the siren's song of the treadmill. Something about running seemed important, but she couldn't quite put her finger on it. By the time she finished, she'd torn through 20k, the throbbing in her legs and the blood

thumping in her ears the only indication that she'd done anything at all. She headed to the showers without touching the weights and let the cold water wash over her without bothering to adjust the tap. *What is wrong with me today?*

From there, she headed back home. It had been discussed that Catra would join her there later for dinner. Hopefully, Bo and Glimmer would also be in attendance. No one was there when she arrived, so she headed up to her room to do some work in the hopes that it would distract her from the void creeping up around her. She spent an hour staring at her project in disgust before closing the document and pulling up social media.

A girl she had gone to high school with had questionable but unsurprising opinions about gun violence that she expressed from the driver's seat of her car. A guy who used to hassle her for a date back in law school just had a third kid and named it after *Game of Thrones*. An ex published a new article in the Stanford Law Review and accepted a teaching position at Vanderbilt. Adora scrolled through the woman's pictures. Trip to Rome. Trip to Napa Valley. Mediterranean Cruise. *Huh*. *She was close*. Same woman in all the photos. *Must be her girlfriend. Short*.

Adora suddenly felt a pair of arms wrap around her neck and lips press to her temple. In a flash, she felt the overwhelming ill-ease vanish. She turned toward Catra and smiled.

"Hi. How'd you get in?"

"You gave me a key, remember?" Catra brandished a freshly-made copy.

"That sounds vaguely familiar."

"Whatcha up to?" Adora felt Catra's head turn to the screen so their cheeks were touching.

"Stalking."

"Fun. Who's this?"

Adora considered lying. That's what people in relationships did, right? Seemed silly, though. "My ex. The one with the dark hair. The other one is her girlfriend, I think."

"Interesting."

"Why?" Adora wondered if she had miscalculated.

"You never struck me as the kind to have a type."

"What do you mean?"

Catra laughed. "*Adora*. You seriously don't see it? Okay, imagine me a few inches taller and tell me you don't notice anything."

Catra came around to stand beside the screen and mimicked the expression of the other woman, big smile and all. Adora frowned, mostly because she could not deny what was in front of her. The physical similarity was undeniable. Same figure, same skin tone, same eyes – one of them at least, same beautiful smile.

"You may have a point."

"Right?" Catra fell onto Adora's lap, lazily draping her arms around her neck. "My hair used to be short like that, too."

"Oh yeah?"

"Mm-hm. Chopped it all off in college. Big mistake, though. I thought I'd have, y'know, curls on top of my head, but I ended up looking like a shitty character build in Tony Hawk Underground."

Adora laughed and wrapped one arm around Catra's back and the other under her knees. "I'm finding that hard to visualize. Any pictures?"

"Nah, they all burned to ash in the great fire of two-thousand-whatever."

"That's so believable. Guess I'll just have to drop it forever."

“Your understanding is greatly appreciated.”

“Or I could hassle you about it until the day I die. I’ll leave it up to you to decide which is more likely.”

“Fine.” Catra turned toward the computer and pulled up a new window. “But I expect at least 3 embarrassing photos in return.”

“Naturally.”

Catra logged into Facebook, something Adora found interesting considering she’d said long ago that she didn’t have one. She scrolled into her secret photo albums and eventually settled on a photo. She clicked and it blew up on the screen.

“Awwww. Look at you!”

“Yeah, yeah, yuk it up, princess.”

In the photo, a younger Catra scowled at the camera with a red solo cup in one hand while the other held a cigarette and flipped the bird. She wore an over-sized golden-yellow sweatshirt with the neck cut out. As promised, her hair was short and styled into a sort of faux-hawk with bits sticking off in every direction. The hair gave her pause, something stirring vaguely in her subconscious. She smothered it.

“I like your sweatshirt. Very Flashdance.”

“My friend from high school ‘made’ it for me. I’ve still got it around somewhere. They’d kill me if I lost it even though they know damn well it’s hideous.”

“You look good in yellow. I’ve never seen you in anything lighter than blue.”

“It suits my image. Can’t be dark and mysterious in hot pink, now can I?”

“I suppose not.” Adora gave her a kiss on the nose and Catra returned one on her lips. “But I know your big mysterious secret.”

“Do you now?”

“Oh yes. You, Catra Primov, are sweet and loving and one of the most kind-hearted people I’ve ever met.”

Catra rolled her eyes. “Ew.”

“And apparently that’s all affirmed by your brilliant sapphire aura. Auras don’t lie, my love.”

“If you say another word, my soul will leave my body and I swear it will haunt you forever. Also, aren’t we supposed to be having dinner? It’s like 8 and some of us have work in the morning.”

Adora snorted. “You’re on winter break.”

“An educator’s work is never done, princess. Want me to order something?”

Adora glanced at the clock on her wall. It was getting pretty late. She gave Glimmer a call and got sent to voicemail. She wasn’t sure if that was a good sign or not.

Forty-five minutes later, Adora poked at the recently-delivered food on her plate and listened to Catra chatter about the conference she was being made to attend in Ankara later that week. She seemed to be in a good mood. It was nice seeing her like this. Cheerful. Upbeat. Happy. Before, Adora only witnessed this side of her in bursts, or the manufactured version projected for everyone else. It was as if every day Catra got a little more buoyant, like she was able to take a break from a lifetime of treading water.

Adora considered this further as she lay in bed. Catra was fast asleep on her chest. She was sleeping better, too. In all their time spent sharing a bed in the last year, Adora had rarely seen Catra actually asleep. Adora always fell asleep first and then her first

stirrings in the morning inevitably woke Catra up no matter how quiet she tried to be. Adora tightened her hold on the other woman who sighed in response.

She was glad that Catra was doing well. Unfortunately, though, worrying about Catra or their nebulous relationship had traditionally occupied a good portion of her waking thoughts, and now she wasn't sure she cared for what was filling the recently vacated space. It wasn't an unfamiliar feeling by any means. No, she knew it well: Restlessness. In this case, she had the distinct feeling that she was fucking up. What exactly she was fucking up was a topic up for internal debate.

The unarguable truths that she had were: she didn't regret leaving her job or profession at large; she didn't regret moving abroad; she didn't regret her relationship with Catra. Overall, she felt pretty confident about her life as a whole. Still, there was something bothering her on a foundational level and no matter how hard she stretched towards it, it slipped from her grasp like smoke. All she could manage to put into words was that *something* was wrong. She was doing *something* wrong. *Something* was wrong with her.

Adora rubbed at her face with her free hand and then looked down at Catra. At least she hadn't noticed yet. Maybe she wouldn't. Adora grabbed her phone. 3 am. Jesus. The light went off and she was in the process of putting it back on the nightstand when it buzzed. Maybe Glimmer was finally getting back to her. No. It was an email. From one of those ancestry companies. It said that she had a message. She clicked the link and it asked for a password. Typically, she would leave something asinine like this until morning, but she didn't have anything better to do, so she carefully placed Catra's head on the pillow and climbed out of bed.

Figuring some fresh air might do her good, she pulled on some sweatpants and a heavy jacket and headed up to the terrace. On her way, she cobbled together a vague memory of spitting into one of those DNA kits back when she was a first-year associate alongside the whole firm at the annual Christmas party. It was

windy, so she pulled up her hood and cozied up on the couch with a blanket and reopened the webpage. After two tries, she guessed her password and opened the message.

The sender had no profile picture, but the name displayed was Mara Etter. It rang a bell, but Adora didn't pursue it and read on:

Dear Adora,

I'm sorry to bother you, and I hope that I'm not overstepping, but I recently took one of these tests and it says that we're half-sisters which was news to me. Apparently, we have the same father, Randall Miroph. He passed last year, so I can't ask him about it, so I guess I'm selfishly contacting you for answers.

I have a million questions, and maybe you do, too, but I won't ask anything of you unless you want to talk to me, too. Just know that I'm thinking about you, and I hope you're doing well in the world.

Here's my phone number and email if you ever want to talk.

XXX-XXX-XXXX

XXXXXXXXXXX@gmail.com

-Mara

Adora read the message three more times before staring at her phone until the screen went black. In the reflection, she saw that her mouth had fallen open. She pocketed her phone and stood up. Her feet took her to the railing and she held the bar tightly as she gazed at the angry, inky sea.

Mara.

Why did that name seem so familiar?

Randall Miroph.

That one she knew from her birth certificate. That was him. Her father. Adora had never met the man. According to her mother, he had disappeared the minute she'd been swaddled in her pink blanket. Also according to her mother, he was *a goddamned dirty snake slicker'n owl shit good-for-nothin' cur*, so she hadn't exactly been an unbiased source. Besides, Adora had learned young that it was not a topic to casually raise. And what about now? Nothing was stopping her from learning more, but what good was it to dredge up the past like that?

Obviously, she could just delete the email and everything would be done and dusted. Still, she had a sister. Maybe younger, maybe older, but she had clearly been the one who had had their father while Adora had not. Anger flared in her chest as she remembered her mother face down and crying on her bed, too inconsolable to speak while Adora sat beside her and pet her hair. She remembered how her mother pulled her close, tight enough to bruise, and whispered over and over how much she loved her, how she would never let her go, that all they needed was each other and everything would be okay.

It hadn't been okay, though. She'd wrapped her asshole husband's car around a tree and Adora had never set foot in that godforsaken town again and had made something of herself. Unlike any of them. Unlike Mara? She didn't know, and she didn't want to know.

But maybe she did.

She was startled out of herself by a quiet "Hey."

Adora turned to find Catra leaning against the railing with a blanket around her shoulders.

"What are you doing up here? It's cold."

Adora stared at her for a moment, let go of the railing, and gathered the woman in front of her up into a tight hug. After a surprised beat, Catra dropped the blanket and hugged her back.

“Did something happen?”

Adora just held tighter, relishing in the warmth and even the hair whipping against her face. Catra was here. Catra saw that she was gone and came to find her. Catra might not always be here, but that was okay. For now, Catra was here.

“Adora?”

“I love you.”

“I love you, too.”

“I have a sister.”

“What?”

Adora laughed breathily. “Right? I just found out. She sent me an email.”

“Wild.”

Adora released Catra and bent down to grab the lost blanket. She draped it over their shoulders and they both turned toward the sea.

After a bit, Catra asked, “Is that what’s been bothering you today?”

“You noticed that?”

“Duh. You’re, like, insanely transparent.”

“Am not.”

“Are too.”

“Okay, maybe I am. It wasn’t that, though. I don’t know what’s been bothering me. I’ve been feeling, I dunno, restless lately.”

Adora felt Catra freeze under her arm.

“Oh. Are you thinking of… going somewhere?”

“Of course not.”

Catra relaxed a little and the two stared out into the distance. Among the murk, something steeled inside Adora.

“Hey, Catra?”

“Yeah?”

“Can I tell you something?”

“Okay.”

“I wanna tell you that I’m, well, I’m all-in.”

“All-in?”

“Yeah, like in poker.”

“With what?”

“This. All of this. Us. I know it’s early, but I-I know right now. I know that I’m not going anywhere, I don’t want to go anywhere, unless it’s with you.”

Catra was quiet a moment and then leaned into Adora’s side.

“Me too. I’m all-in.”

The two women stared out at the sea, both contemplating the weight of their mutual declaration. Both felt nothing but warmth despite the chill. Before them churned an angry sea and whipped a harsh wind but it meant little as they pressed together under their blanket. Later, they would return to their bed and fall asleep. In the morning, they would wake up together and go about their days. Now, though, now it was only them, gazing out at the home they had come to know and realizing their unbelievable good fortune to be doing it together.

Chapter End Notes

There it is! Above the Vaulted Sky, everyone!

I'm gonna give my little exit speech here even though the epilogue is a solid 10k words. This is like the first goodbye that sets off the hour-long goodbye dance at a family gathering.

I want to thank all of you for reading. Thank you for the kudos and comments, but thank you equally to those silent supporters who have been sticking with me from whatever point you started reading. This is the most hyper-specific AU in the world, and I appreciate everyone for clicking and giving it a chance. Thank you to my partner who beta'd for me and helped me immensely. You're the best.

This story started as an idea I couldn't get out of my head in January. I wrote up until the last chapter in a manic frenzy in a few weeks. The rest I had to do properly medicated. Overall, writing this was probably the most cathartic experience of my life, and it means so much to me to share it and have it received positively. Turkey's a weird place to live for 6 and a half years, and I feel like half of this just ended up reading as a travel ad. I didn't mean it to come off that way, but if you do get the chance to travel to this part of the world, I highly suggest it.

Stick around for the epilogue where any storylines you're mad at me for not resolving probably get resolved, we take a break from Adora's never-ending inner-monologues, and I talk more about the sequel.

Epilogue

Chapter Summary

"For the love of god, Feyza, I sent you out here to find her, not smoke whatever vile shit I'm smelling. Merve's looking for you both."
"It's the 21st century. She could've called," Feyza replied.
Catra snickered.
Glimmer turned to her. "Oh no, nothing out of you. Get the fuck back in there. We have pictures in an hour, and your hair is still a puffy mess."
Catra made a show of standing up and stretching leisurely. "Glad to see our beloved homeland hasn't pulled that stick out of your ass, Sparkles."

--

The gang goes to a wedding and the reader has to click on a lot of footnotes.

Chapter Notes

UPDATE 18/09/2021: I didn't realize until months after I posted this, that I had changed Snezhana's name. I don't know if anyone noticed, but it's fixed now along with some other pertinent stuff in that phone call. Also if all this editing sent a million notifs to my subscribers, I am v sorry.

Please visit the Playlist for the full wedding experience. Best enjoyed during the wedding scenes.

Fulya is Fluttershy? I don't know, don't think about it too hard.

A note:
Non-graphic depiction of a suicide attempt near the end

See the end of the chapter for more notes

1 Year and 6 Months Later

Catra emerged from one of the resort's side entrances into the dazzling June sunlight. She groaned and pulled her sunglasses out of the inner pocket of her jacket. With them properly affixed, she headed over to the deserted pool and carefully lowered herself onto the edge of a lounge. Once settled, she fished a vape pen out of her pants pocket and took a drag. She exhaled with a grimace. Why she had thought that pink lemonade flavored liquid was in any way a good choice was a mystery for the ages. Mostly, though, she wished she had a goddamn cigarette. After the week she'd had, no one could blame her. She might snag one tonight for old time's sake.

She took another pull and sighed it out. Gross, but it did the job.

"You wrinkle that suit and Merve's gonna kill you."

Catra turned her head to find Feyza standing next to her with a hand on her hip. Catra couldn't help but think that she looked remarkably grown up in her ice-blue dress trimmed in white despite being perfectly aware that she was in her twenties. Still, it was hard for Catra not to picture the sixteen-year-old Feyza that had been sent to Antalya to stay with her cousin Merve while she finished out high school. Back then, she had done everything she could to appear dignified and unbothered by the fact that her father and stepmother had essentially tossed her out for the crime of taking too long to mourn the untimely death of her mother. Now, in spite of everything, she stood strong with a degree in Environmental Engineering, a job with a German company fresh out of school, and a black belt in Taekwondo to boot. Catra couldn't help but be proud of the kid.

"You can run and tell the Mermaid that I'm being good. I just needed to get out of there for a minute. Your cousins are a whole fucking lot."

Feyza took a seat on the lounge next to her and held out her hand. Catra looked at the hand and then the vape in hers and shrugged as she handed it over. Feyza took a deep pull and blew it out.

"Yeah, I know what you mean. Every time I come home, it's the same three questions. Why did you cut your pretty hair, when are you moving back to Izmir, the Soylu's boy you went to middle school with just started his residency at Ege, do you want me to give him your number? And now that Merve is finally getting married, I'm target number one. This tastes fucking awful, by the way."

Feyza took another pull and handed it back. Catra took it. "You're telling me. It's just one more day. You'll survive. In the meantime, if any of your teyzes get too mouthy, call me over and I'll kick her ass."

"I might take you up on that."

Catra exhaled and passed it to Feyza. "Anything for you, minnoş.[1]"

Feyza scoffed. "I've been taller than you since I was 14."

"I don't give a shit how tall you are. You're minnoş, nerd, get over it."

"Whatever." Still, Feyza smiled and gazed past the pool to the glittering sea.

Catra pocketed the vape and joined her. It was the quietest it had been all weekend and she relished in it. In the distance, she could hear men arguing as they erected what seemed like the thousandth tent in a set of millions dotting the sprawling resort. Merve's father was really going all out. A breeze kicked up and Catra sighed. Her moment of relaxation was short-lived, however, for the second she dared to close her eyes, she was snapped back to attention with a bellowing:

"Oh, what the fuck is this?"

Catra opened her eyes to behold Glimmer who was really living up to her name with a sequin-covered dress of iridescent blue. When neither woman acknowledged her, Glimmer frowned and put her hands on her hips.

"For the love of god, Feyza, I sent you out here to find her, not smoke whatever vile shit I'm smelling. Merve's looking for you both."

"It's the 21st century. She could've called," Feyza replied

Catra snickered.

Glimmer turned to her. "Oh no, nothing out of you. Get the fuck back in there. We have pictures in an hour, and your hair is still a puffy mess."

Catra made a show of standing up and stretching leisurely. "Glad to see our beloved homeland hasn't pulled that stick out of your ass, Sparkles."

"We're not doing this today, Catra, I swear to god. Everyone's still pissed about the shit you pulled Wednesday. Now move! You, too, Feyza."

Catra didn't push her luck, grinning as she made her way back to the resort. Earlier that week, she and Bo had 'kidnapped' Sea Hawk and his brother in from Melbourne for a surprise stag party the day before everyone was set to leave for Izmir. Phones off and confiscated, the group had gone white-water rafting through a canyon in Manavgat, had come back to the sea for wind-surfing, and had ended the night at the amusement park. They had reappeared late that night to find Merve and Glimmer absolutely goddamn furious with them, but it had been worth it to show their bro a deeply needed good time.

Sea Hawk had been sober a bit over a year, and the restructuring of his life had been hard on him. A few months after talking with Catra in the harbor plus a lot of soul-searching, he'd dedicated

himself to getting help. One six-month stint in a rehab center in Balıkesir later, he was plunked right back into his life, albeit dried out and with theoretically better coping skills. Unfortunately, that life revolved around drinking and had for decades and reforming it had seemed like a task insurmountable. Though she hadn't liked admitting it at the time, Catra had still been doing some less intensive navigation of her own in terms of partying and self-understanding. There'd been quite a bit of moping from both of them followed by a flurry of activity. Sea Hawk had picked up the ukulele and had taken to serenading those ill-fated enough to be in his vicinity while Catra had settled on screaming at strangers on GTA online. It had worked well enough to keep both of them on the straight and narrow.

Soon enough, Catra was standing in front of the sliding glass door of the cabana where the bridal party was getting ready. She was not allowed to linger long because Glimmer wrenched it open and not-so-gently shoved her inside. She expected that Feyza met the same fate when she felt someone crash into her back. The room went silent.

Merve glanced up from where she sat in hot rollers having her make-up done and turned her head to face the derelicts. The make-up artist seamlessly followed.

"Well, well, if it isn't the prodigal cat. And Feyza, my beloved kuzen. How joyous."

Catra wiped some dust off her jacket and put on her most winning smile. "Why, Mermaid, how nice to see you. Love what you've done with your hair."

"Cut the shit, Catra. The hairdresser has been waiting since half one. I'll kill you later."

"Yes, ma'am."

Catra sauntered over to her seat where two faces awaited her, one friendly and one not so much and sat down. The latter

mumbled something unpleasant about foreigners and began roughly dividing her hair into sections with clips. The former looked moments away from busting a blood vessel from holding in laughter.

“Something funny, princess?” Catra peered at Adora out of the corner of her eye.

“Nope. Nothing. Not at all.”

If she weren’t so focused on remaining indifferent to the world around her, Catra might have noted how cute Adora looked with her hair up in rollers or how her sky blue, floor-length dress with a slit up the side made her look like a Disney princess. Instead, she grunted as the hairdresser yanked a chunk of her hair down, liberally sprayed something, and dragged a comb through it.

“That’s what I thought.”

“I bet if you apologize to Emre, he’ll stop pulling your hair like that.”

“I was gone for 30 minutes. God forbid I need a breather from the break in reality collectively befalling everyone within a 10 meter radius of the Mermaid and Sparkles.”

Adora snorted. “You’re so dramatic sometimes.”

“Am not.”

“Come on, you have to admit it’s at least a little fun. You had fun at the henna thing[2] last night.”

“Perihan cornered me and cried for an hour about the alignment of the planets and love frequencies.”

“Yeah, Saliha was a mess, too. You told me that everyone was gonna cry, but wow! I mean, Saliha didn’t surprise me, but Feyza and Merve? I’ve barely seen either of them laugh, let alone cry.”

Catra shrugged as product was worked through her hair. “It’s a cultural thing, I guess. One of those things you can’t really get cause you had to be there.”

“Yeah, I guess. Still, I’ve been here, what, 2 and a half years? And I’m still surprised that there aren’t more differences. Sure, I’ll probably never get used to the million different ways to greet someone or how touchy-feely everyone is, but a lot of things are familiar in their way.”

Catra looked straight ahead. “After a while, the other stuff kind of just fades away until it stops mattering. At least, in my experience.”

The blow-dryer clicked on and ended the conversation. Catra took a moment to check her phone. She had a missed call from what looked like a random google voice number with a US country code. No one from the US called her except maybe DT, but they used WhatsApp like a civilized human being. Besides, she hadn’t heard from them in nearly a year. Reasoning that anyone calling her in the middle of the night in the US was most likely a wayward scammer, she pocketed the phone, dismissing both the notification and the inexplicable sinking feeling in her stomach. Luckily, she wasn’t left to brood long because as soon as the dryer clicked off, the hairdresser got to work weaving her hair into some sort of loose up-do, and it was abundantly clear that he had not yet forgiven her for earlier.

Trying not to wince, Catra glanced back over at Adora who appeared to be playing some dumb game on her phone. Things were going well with them, at least better than Catra had expected. Some part of her had always assumed that when Adora heard all the sordid details of her past, she would take off running. When she hadn’t, Catra figured she would get bored of her bullshit and the country as a whole and hop on the next plane to wherever. When she hadn’t done that either, well, Catra had been stymied.

As Glimmer had prepared to leave last summer, Catra had hemmed and hawed about doing something she very much wanted to do, namely, asking Adora to move in with her. She had reasoned that it was too soon, that were the offer to leave her lips, it would yank a string and everything would unravel through her fingers. Khyle had not shared her concerns and it had taken a sit-down from him – where he less-than-politely informed her that if she didn't make the fucking offer, then he would do so himself – to get off her ass and potentially send the main source of happiness in her life up in flames. To no one's surprise, Adora had said yes, and life had been one big ball of domestic bliss ever since. Well, for the most part.

The hairdresser curtly informed her that they were finished and handed her a mirror. Catra took it and examined whatever it was taking place on her head. It was cute, she supposed, a little feminine with the suit, but she wasn't about to complain about something that was done and would get her out of this damn chair. Unfortunately, she was not to leave what was apparently her new home at this time because a woman jogged over with a cosmetic case the size of a bowling bag and plunked it down on the table besides her. She seemed about as pleased as the hairdresser to see her. As various materials were spread across her skin, Catra glanced over at Adora who was chatting amiably with the hairdresser as he unspooled the rollers from her hair and began to deftly craft a bun similar to her own.

No, things were good. For her, at least. All smooth sailing except for an eensy-weensy little incident when her meds dipped below their proper level six months or so ago. It wasn't that big of a deal, she'd just gotten a little up and at 'em, had gotten a little too into the Decemberists, and had gotten a little too obsessed with the perhaps less than feasible idea of composing, recording, and releasing a concept album. All of this had had the potential to become quite the productive venture if not for the unfortunate detail that she sucked at writing songs. When she had expressed this particular frustration to her therapist in a particularly exuberant manner, it had been gently suggested that perhaps it might be wise to go get her blood checked. A little adjustment

later and she was back to her old surly self. No harm, no foul. Maybe she'd impulsively texted an ex and a few randos from high school trying to start a record label, but hey, whatever, everything was fine now.

A woman wearing a headset poked her head into the cabana and politely informed everyone that the photographer was set up and ready. Suddenly, everyone was up and chattering as they bustled about the room and then out the door. God, Catra was tired of all this. Still, as Adora waved goodbye to her new best friend the hairdresser and fell into step beside her, she couldn't help but feel a tiny bit soothed. Down by the beach, they were painstakingly arranged, but the tension between Merve and the photographer was palpable. This was especially clear when he tried to remove Feyza from Merve's side and throw off the carefully-planned gradient of blue. The final straw was when he tried to shove Catra in with the bridal party. Fed up, Merve grabbed her by the back of her jacket, dragged her next to Khyle where she belonged, and informed the photographer to, loosely translated, take the fucking picture or she'd shit down his throat.

Unsurprisingly, he did as he was told.

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A number of hours later, Catra sat at a table watching her friends dance. The sun had long-since set, and while it was still hot as all hell, there was at least a breeze coming in off the sea. Her jacket was draped over the back of her chair along with her white tie and her sleeves were rolled up, but she was still sweating through her sapphire dress shirt. It was better than Antalya, at least.

Her mood had improved significantly over the course of the day. After the pictures, they'd all been herded under yet another tent for the legal joining of Sean Hawkins and Merve Denizoğlu. Catra had sat at a big table with Sea Hawk, Merve, and Feyza as a legal witness. Normally, it would've been Bo, but as he was no longer a foreign national, the best he could do was provide moral support from the audience. Still, Catra had whipped out her best signature

and couldn't help but glow with pride at how happy her friends looked. If anyone deserved it, it was them.

After the marriage certificate was issued, everyone had made their way over to a massive tent near the beach and had readied themselves for the actual fun of the weekend. The tables hadn't been assigned, but she'd predictably ended up with the usual suspects minus the happy couple that were locked in with mostly Merve's family. Sea Hawk could talk to a fencepost in any language and be happy, but his brother who didn't know a word of Turkish had looked miserable until Bo had borrowed him from the table and never returned him. After a lavish fish dinner, everyone had queued up for the gold ceremony. Adora had seemed inordinately excited about the process, so Catra had tasked her with the honor of pinning the gold coin to Merve's sash while Catra had punched Sea Hawk in the arm lovingly enough that he had squeaked and had to rub at it.

And that's when the real fun had begun. The band and DJ had roared to life and everyone had made a break for the floor to dance to a mix of Turkish and foreign pop alongside more traditional folkish fare. Catra and Glimmer, any speck of enmity from the day forgotten, had teamed up to drag Adora into the fold for a marathon halay[3] at first led by an over-enthusiastic Sea Hawk trying his very best and then mercifully taken over by a cousin who showed off just as egregiously if more competently. In the line, Catra had hooked her pinky with Adora's and hadn't been able to keep herself from laughing as the woman fumbled through the steps. By the time Adora had gotten a handle on it, the band shifted to a rock song that made her gasp.

"You guys play this one!"

Catra grabbed Adora's hand and spun her around. "It's a really popular song, princess. Everyone plays it."

"Your version is the best."

Catra laughed and put her hand on Adora's waist as platonically as she could. "Thanks."

Now, approximately two hours later, the DJ was on what seemed like his sixth Kylie Minogue song, and Catra was getting bored. Perhaps more accurately, she was distracted by an inexplicable dread snaking up from her gut. It didn't help that she'd missed another call while she was dancing from that weird scammer number that she couldn't call back. Worrying about it made her feel silly, as if she were some horror movie bimbo about to get axed in the back of the head at any moment. Really, the worst that was going to happen to her tonight was getting cornered by that one wined-up Denizoğlu uncle with an unhealthy interest in US politics.

She was fine. She just needed a break. In fact, she wouldn't mind a drink. As if hearing her silent plea, she saw Khyle heading in her direction with a beer in each hand. He plopped down next to her and handed her one of the bottles. Catra gratefully accepted it and took a deep draught.

"Thanks, man. You're a life-saver."

"My pleasure. I saw you hadn't had anything tonight and thought you might be thirsty."

"Wow, you counting my drinks now?

"Sometimes!" Khyle laughed and clinked the top of her bottle with the bottom of his.

The foam rose up and spilled out of the top in a torrent. "Aw, you dick, I think some got on my shoes."

Khyle gasped. "Oh no, the horror! Better take them off and come down to beach with me while they dry off. There is literally no other option. I am so sorry for this inconvenience."

Catra was already enthusiastically tearing her socks off and cuffing her pants to the knees. "Well, shit, if there's nothing else

to do, but I will be having a word with your manager."

"Naturally, Bise-ma'am." Khyle hopped up and offered his arm. "Shall we?"

Catra took it. "God yes, get me out of here."

The two walked the hundred meters or so down to the beach, each step dulling the music, laughter, and shrill voices emanating from the well-lit tent. By the time her feet touched the white sand faintly glowing in the moonlight, Catra's anxiety had all but melted away. She shoved Khyle to the side and took off running toward the sea. He was hot on her tail, though, and by the time she skidded to a stop in front of the water, she felt a body smack into hers and then arms wrap around her to prevent her from flying face-first into the spray.

Catra burst out laughing. "You're getting slow, old man."

Khyle squeezed a little. "You cheated and also I let you win."

"Uh huh." Catra took a sip of her beer and listened to the waves that had framed the new life she had built for herself nearly eight years before, albeit from a different sea. "Hey, you wanna walk to Ayvalık?[4]

"Sure, I'm starving."

The two took off with their feet in the water. Catra shoved a hand into her pocket and relished in the comfortable silence. It'd been awhile since she'd had time like this with Khyle, just the two of them. Now that Khyle had moved in with Fulya and everyone had cut down on partying, it seemed like the two of them never saw each other anymore. And when they did it was dinners and double dates and outings that were so grotesquely *adult* it made Catra want to puke. Which was good, she supposed – they were all a little too old to be railing MDMA off of dirty bathroom sinks – but surely there had to be a middle ground. There had to be something between her old life and this one.

Catra sucked down several swallows of her half-empty beer and felt light-headed.

“Let’s sit.”

“Where?”

“The sand?”

“Merve’ll be mad.”

“You know these are our pants, right? We own them.”

Khyle shrugged, took a few steps back, and plopped down on the sand. Catra snuck a glance over at the speck of the flickering tent in the distance and at another, smaller speck on the beach off to the side, dropped down next to him, and mirrored his position with legs pulled to her chest and chin resting on her knees as she gazed out into the waves.

After a few minutes of silence Khyle spoke: “How come we never do this anymore?”

“Do what?” Catra asked despite knowing exactly what he meant.

“Running off, getting our clothes dirty, you know, fun stuff?”

“You know why.”

Khyle sighed. “Yeah, I do. Still. I miss this. Remember that time we ditched the Waste right after our gig and hitched up the mountain to Geyikbayırı?”

“Yeah, Lawan was pissed we didn’t help load the van back up. She didn’t talk to me for a week and then put a piece of hair on my falafel next time I saw her.”

Khyle laughed. “She was just mad we didn’t invite her. Do you remember why we went up there?”

“You wanted to hook up with that smelly hippy dude you were obsessed with and needed a girl to get a ride up there?” Khyle shoved her lightly.

“I was not obsessed with Eduardo! And he wasn’t smelly.”

“He reeked like come-socks, dude.”

“As if your hook-ups were any better.”

“Wow, you really wanna do this? At least no one I ever brought home gave us scabies.”

“Remember when that one chick woke me up banging pots and pans together and threatened to get me deported back to Syria?”

“Okay, fine you win, that one was bad. I’m still sorry about that.”

Khyle put an arm around her shoulders. “I know. I’m just teasing. But back to the reason we went up the mountain that night. I don’t know if you remember, but it was late summer. You’d been really sad for a few weeks, but you were coming back around. I’d broken up with the Canadian the month before, so we just sorta locked ourselves in the house and let everything go to hell. It was kind of fun, in a way, us hiding from the world.” Khyle paused. “It wasn’t fun for you, though. I didn’t really get how it worked for you back then.”

Catra leaned into his side. “It didn’t help that I never really told you.”

“Still. Anyway, while we were doing the gig, I got this feeling that I could fix everything if we could just get away for a little while. Breathe some fresh air, climb a little, wake up to birds that weren’t seagulls. You know, nature shit. So we got up there and found Eduardo’s tent in the dark –“

Catra rolled her eyes. “And if I recall correctly, he was on a crapton of ketamine, rambled about Aleister Crowley for two hours, and then tried to rope me into a threesome.”

"And you laughed in his face, stole his blanket, and took off into the woods."

Catra smiled. "It was nice of you to come after me. I didn't expect you to. But it was nice, sleeping under the stars like that. Quiet and peaceful. And you know, I did feel better after that weekend."

"I think that's what we're doing now."

"Like now-now?"

"No. In general. That peace we got laying under the stars on the forest floor, I think we might have that now, only with less noise everywhere else. I feel that way with Fulya. And you feel that way with Adora, right? I think they're that peace for us that we only used to get in little bits. That's why it feels a little weird. Everything was always so chaotic, even before Turkey, for both of us—"

Catra looked up at him. "Hold on, are you seriously comparing my bullshit to a wholeass revolution?"

Khyle poked her forehead. "It's not a competition, Bise. Besides, I think chaos is something we make inside of ourselves a lot of the time and it comes out in the way we act."

"Have you been talking to Perihan again?"

"Will you stop interrupting my speech?"

"My bad. Continue."

Khyle pulled his arm back to run a hand through his hair, paused, and just kind of patted the gelled mound. "Actually, I think I'm mostly done. The point is, do you think I should ask Fulya to marry me?"

Catra blinked and turned to him. *"What?"*

“Do you think I should ask Fulya to marry me?”

“I heard you.”

“I know it’s kinda soon, but it feels right. I have enough money saved up from translation for a down payment on a place and a nice wedding.”

Catra shook her shock away. “Okay, but have you guys talked about it? Does *she* want to get married?”

“We’ve talked a little. She wants to get married and have kids before too long.”

“Kids? Do *you* want kids?”

Khyle looked out at the sea thoughtfully. “For a long time, I thought no, but the older I get, the better it sounds. A wife, our own apartment, kids, a summer house in Kaş for school breaks. It sounds nice, right?”

Catra imagined it. It sounded nice enough, she supposed. “I guess. It’s just kind of a surprise. I never thought of you as the settling down type.”

“Me neither. It’s something that’s been changing in me lately. I can feel it. I guess this is growing up.”

“Blink?”

“Yeah.”

“You suck.”

“Do you think she’ll say yes?”

“Why wouldn’t she?”

“I dunno. You two are friends, aren’t you? She’s over at your place more than I am.”

"I mean, sorta. She's more Adora's friend than mine. They've got this weird little trio with Saliha going. And of course Adora roped her into Perihan's coffee cult."

"Okay, but what do they even do there?"

Catra held up her hands. "No fucking clue."

"Do you think they make-out?"

"That is by far the least irritating possibility. Anyway, ask Adora."

"I'm not asking Adora, that's weird."

"It's weird to ask me!"

"Is not! You're my best friend. That's what best friends do!"

"Life isn't an episode of *Friends,* dude."

"Yes it is. You're Ross."

Catra shoved him, and he shoved her back. "The goddamn *audacity* on this beach right now, I swear to God."

"Fine. You can be Phoebe."

"Better."

They went quiet. Catra mechanically picked up handfuls of sand and let it run through her fingers. The wind blew a few loose strands of hair into her face.

"You should go for it."

"You think?"

"Obviously you should probably talk to her about it since I'm not, like, the oracle, but if it's something that you think will make the two of you happy, then yeah. There're always reasons not to do

something, but if you think you can outweigh those, then why the fuck not? You deserve to be happy."

"You're right. Thanks."

"No prob."

"What about you and Adora? Wanna make it a double wedding?"

"Oh fuck off." Catra stood up and patted vigorously at her sandy pants. "In case you've forgotten, we can't really do that here."

Khyle stood up, too. "What about the states? It's legal everywhere there, right?"

They took off walking.

"I mean, yeah, but the passport situation would just be a nightmare even if no one changes their names. And what about the rings? Can you imagine if I just rocked up to work one day with a wholeass wedding band on my finger? They'd have a fucking field day. I mean, who wants to be married in their 'heart' or whatever? At the end of the day, we'd still be 'roommates.'"

"So you *have* been thinking about it!"

"You asshole."

"C'mon, why can you not admit that you love the woman you've been with for like a year and a half and were in love with for a year before that? That's so tsundere of you."

"Your mom's a tsundere."

Khyle laughed. "Oh my god."

"What do you want me to say? That Adora's the best thing to ever happen to me? That she's filled my life with more joy in the short time I've known her than the rest of my life put together? That

the prospect of life without her makes me want to puke, cry, and die at the same time?”

“Yeah, basically.”

Catra crossed her arms. “Fine. That, then.”

Khyle grinned. “Aw, Bise, that’s sweet. The legal stuff sucks, though. I’m sorry about all that.”

Catra shrugged. “It is what it is. Race back?”

Without answering, Khyle took off like a shot, ignoring Catra’s cries of ‘cheater.’ He won the footrace, but Catra wasn’t mad because on the way they’d seen Perihan and Saliha wandering along the shore hand-in-hand. Catra made a note to ask Adora about it later. Before they reentered the fold, Khyle gathered Catra up in a tight hug. She hugged him back and sighed. They’d been too distant over the last few months, and she hadn’t realized how deeply she’d missed him. They pulled apart and headed in. Catra spied Adora at a table with her head close to Glimmer’s whispering conspiratorially. She wasn’t about to break whatever that was up. Bo was out on the dancefloor flailing his heart out. Good for him. Merve was with some of her cousins, and Sea Hawk and his brother were conspicuously absent. Hmm. Eventually, she caught sight of Feyza squirming at a table locked in on both sides by three middle-aged women aggressively fanning themselves with the wedding programs.

“Wanna come sit with us?” Khyle asked, gesturing toward a table where Fulya talked animatedly with Lawan and Rogelio.

“Can’t. I gotta go save the kid. She’s three teyzes deep.”

“Such a noble Bise.”

“Nah, I’m just making sure that hotel money takes care of me in my old age.”

With a friendly punch to his shoulder, Catra left Khyle. She found her shoes, patted her hair back into place, and tucked in her shirt. When she felt sufficiently presentable, she made her way towards the encampment holding Feyza. She slid behind the young woman and put her hands on both of her shoulders. Feyza tensed up but relaxed when she glanced up and saw who it was.

Catra regarded the three older women gazing at her with ill-concealed bemusement. She put on her most gallant smile and gave Feyza's shoulders a squeeze.

"İyi akşamlar[5], umarım konuşmanızı bölmüyorumdur ancak güzelliğiniz karşısında iltifat etmeden duramadım. Siz de bu harikulade düğünde Feyza kadar eğleniyor musunuz?"

Out of the corner of her eye, she saw Feyza shoot her an incredulous look. One woman nodded gracefully.

"Halimizden[6] oldukça memnunuz, sonunda Merve'nin evlendiği görmek bizi ziyadesiyle mutlu etmekte. Tabi sizin gibi güzel ve kibar arkadaşlarıyla tanışmak da cabası."

Catra gave an affected laugh that she hoped conveyed that she wasn't aware that they'd probably already spent a solid 45 minutes talking mad shit about her outfit and had at least another half hour in the tank, placed a hand over her heart, and bowed her head slightly.

"Bayanlar,[7] işim olmasa sizi daha da mutlu etmek isterdim ancak izninizle Feyza'yı birkaç dakikalığına ödünç almam gerek."

The woman smiled and waved her hand. "Tabi, lütfen. Buyrun.[8]"

Feyza did her best not to leap to her feet like she had a lit match in her shoe. As they were walking away, Catra's hand still on Feyza's shoulder, Feyza turned and said, "What the actual fuck was that?"

"I think a little gratitude is in order, minnoş. I just saved your life."

“By flirting with my Aunt Fatma?”

“I was the perfect gentleman. They loved it.”

Feyza glanced back over her shoulder. “My god, they did, didn’t they?”

Catra grinned. “See? And now Fatma teyze will have something to think about when Mustafa amca’s snoring his way through a rakı drunk next to her. I am basically a public servant.”

“One, fuck you, ew. Two, how the hell do you know my uncle’s name? Three, you are getting sand on my dress. What have you been doing, building a fucking sandcastle?”

“I just guessed. He looks like a Mustafa. And they’re my pants and I can do whatever the fuck I want with them. Now sit.”

They made their way over to Khyle’s table and Catra gestured toward the seat next to Rogelio. Feyza made to sit elsewhere and Catra clicked her tongue.

“Jesus. Haven’t you ever avoided anyone before? You and Rogelio are blocked by the cake.”

“Fuck, Catra, let the girl live,” Lawan chimed in. She looked profoundly bored, something only accentuated by her sparkly gold cocktail dress and matching eyeshadow.

Catra threw her hands up. “All right. Sit where you want, but Fatma teyze’s never going to let me hear the end of it.”

Fulya leaned forward. “Give it to us straight, canım. How bad was it?”

Feyza rolled her eyes. “They narrowed down the potential husbands to three and they’d each picked a champion when Catra showed up. Oh, and did you know that my cousin Fırat is an engineer in the US and is doing very well? Apparently that’s big news even though he’s been there for like 10 years. Oh, and my

cousin Beste had another kid, which was super shocking, especially since I can literally see her over there." Feyza pointed at a woman cooing over a baby at another table.

Fulya shook her head and the light caught the dusting of glitter on her cheeks. "No detailed analysis of gold coin offerings? I was really looking forward to hearing what cheap bastards only gave quarters and who swung their dicks around with the whole coin."

Rogelio laughed. "We chipped in for a half."

Khyle grinned. "Hell yeah we did! Big dicks all around!"

Catra leaned back in her chair and flagged down a waiter. She ordered a round for the table. By the time it arrived, the topic had switched to the newly-discovered mold problem at the new restaurant. Fulya had taken off her glasses and was nodding intently as Lawan detailed what yet another inspector had told her earlier that week. As an Agricultural Engineer, she probably knew at least something more than Catra who'd been hearing about this stupid mold non-stop for a month. She didn't feel too bad tuning them out and taking a moment to admit that Fulya cleaned up nicely. The auburn hair usually pulled up into a bun was cascading down her shoulders in loose ringlets and she wore a flower crown that Perihan had probably made her if the matching one she'd spied earlier on Adora's head was any evidence. She wore a floor-length emerald dress that matched her eyes with a slit up the side that Khyle was currently slipping his hand under. Speaking of, Catra glanced over at Adora's table. Bo had joined them and the three appeared to be playing paper football. Where the fuck did they find paper?

Catra sipped at her beer and eyed the band. As they played yet another Tarkan song, she felt truly sorry for them. She could kill Merve and Sea Hawk for this list. She took another drink and started to feel looser. Every time she drank now, she felt like a 13-year-old girl discovering her first wine cooler. The song ended and the lead singer announced something about a special event that demanded everyone's attention. Everyone turned to the stage as

Sea Hawk emerged from what appeared to be some bushes and headed up to the mic with a stool in one hand and his ukulele in the other. *Oh no.*

His brother ran up after him, helped him adjust the mic stand, and clapped him hard on the back on his way off the stage. He sat down next to Merve who watched the scene with equal parts fondness and suspicion.

Sea Hawk cleared his throat and leaned forward. “Hi, everyone. I hope someone will translate for me because I don’t want to make any mistakes tonight.” A few people chuckled. Catra and Khyle shared a look. “Anyone who knows me can tell you two things. One, I love Merve with all my heart and I have from the first moment I laid eyes on her that magical summer night 8 years ago. And two, that I talk too much.” Another few chuckles. “So instead of making a grand speech like I usually would, I want to borrow a song that tells my feelings better than any one of my million words ever could. Merve, my love, this is for you.”

Sea Hawk pulled his ukulele to his chest and started picking a familiar melody the Catra couldn’t quite place. He leaned into the mic and started to sing.

It's a little bit funny
This feeling inside
I'm not one of those who can easily hide
I don't have much money, but boy if I did
I'd buy a big house where we both could live

If I was a sculptor, ha
But then again, no
Or a man who makes potions in a traveling show
I know it's not much, but it's the best I can do
My gift is my song, and this one's for you

Here he gazed out into the audience, met Merve’s eyes, and smiled.

And you can tell everybody
This is your song
It may be quite simple, but now that it's done
I hope you don't mind
I hope you don't mind
That I put down in the words
How wonderful life is while you're in the world

Merve’s hands were up over her mouth and she was clearly trying not to cry. Her mother put her hand on her shoulder. Sea Hawk continued:

I sat on the roof and kicked off the moss
Well a few of the verses, well they've got me quite cross
But the sun's been quite kind
While I wrote this song
It's for people like you that keep it turned on

So excuse me forgetting
But these things I do
You see I've forgotten, if they're green or they're blue
Anyway the thing is, what I really mean
Yours are the sweetest eyes I've ever seen

Sea Hawk sniffed and a few tears rolled down his cheeks.

And you can tell everybody
This is the song
It may be quite simple, but now that it's done
I hope you don't mind
I hope you don't mind
That I put down in the words
How wonderful life is while you're in the world

Sea Hawk played the last chorus and wiped a few tears away with his sleeve. He stood and was about to grab his stool when Merve leapt onto the stage and enveloped him in a tight hug. She was unabashedly sobbing now and continued as Sea Hawk gently pushed her away enough to dip and kiss her. Catra couldn't help grinning at the whole display even if it was absolutely ridiculous. Unconsciously, she scanned the room and found Adora looking in her direction and smiling softly. They locked eyes and Adora inclined her head in the direction of the hotel.

Catra nodded, finished her beer, and got up as casually as she could. She even added a stretch for good measure as she turned away from the table. Perhaps she was not playing her best stealth mode, though, because she felt someone hook into one of her belt loops. She looked down to see Khyle gazing up at her with a shit-eating grin.

"Where you going, Bise?"

"Nowhere."

"Uh huh. Tell Adora I said hi."

Fulya turned around. "Say hi from me, too!"

Catra rolled her eyes. "Whatever." She slapped Khyle's hand away, headed for the edge of the tent, and made her way along the perimeter. On the way, she spied Perihan and Saliha at a table by themselves whispering with clasped hands. She considered stopping and hassling them but decided that she had more

pressing business to attend to. Namely, Adora was peeking at her from behind a column just outside the tent. When she got close, Adora dropped something on the ground and scurried off. Catra smiled and took her sweet time making her way over there, and when she arrived, she scanned the ground and found a neatly folded paper football. When she unfolded it, she saw a stick figure drawing of a flexing girl with a ponytail and cape. Around the page there appeared to be a couple more figures that she guessed were meant to represent Glimmer and Bo from their books and crowns and stars all around. Catra squinted at the page. *Did they color this with crayons?* On one side of the page was a well-adorned arrow pointing left.

Catra folded the note and put it in her pocket. A scavenger hunt it was then. She took off in the direction of the arrow. This was kind of silly, but Catra was willing to play along. Hell, anything that took her away from what was approaching the 7th hour of this wedding. More than that, she was willing to do just about anything to put a smile on Adora's face. It was something that'd been rarer as of late, ever since she'd started working on her novel.

Catra glanced down to a stone bench littered with arrows pointing her forward, so she continued on.

From what Catra had gathered, the book was to be a novelization of Adora's childhood. About 8 months or so ago, Adora had announced the project to Catra and those around them with what Catra had privately thought was an enthusiasm a touch too ardent to be altogether healthy. At first, when Adora had cheerfully started writing and showing her bits and pieces, Catra had thought that perhaps she had just been too cynical. With time, though, it became clear that Adora was struggling with it quite a bit more than she let on as the office door began shutting and locking. With time, more often than not it was at times she would traditionally be out with friends.

When she was less than forthcoming to the point that it was becoming a problem, Catra had convinced her to try talking to

someone. That had been a pain in the ass. It had taken 6 months after seeking treatment for Catra herself to even consider speaking to a therapist, though, so she'd been at least somewhat qualified to persuade her cagey-ass girlfriend to do the same. It had taken time, but Adora had eventually agreed. On top of that, Adora had been talking to her mystery sister who lived in Knoxville with her wife and kid and that was kicking up some dirt that she couldn't seem to bring herself to talk to Catra about, either. Of all people, Catra got it, but still, it was frustrating.

She took a left turn and then a right, guided by the arrows taped to the light posts.

However, the wedding had brought out another side of Adora. She was smiling and laughing and having fun like she used to. It probably helped that Glimmer and Bo were back. Their leaving, especially Glimmer's, had been harder on Adora than she had admitted. It had been hard on Catra, too, but she'd rather eat one of these paper arrows than admit it.

Catra felt a crinkle under her foot and she lifted it to find another arrow drawn on notebook paper. She looked in its direction, saw an origami crane under a lamp, and picked it up. She examined it a moment and then carefully unwrapped it. In big, capital script read the message "HI CATRA" accompanied by a doodle of what she assumed must be herself with cat ears and a tail. Catra lowered the paper and glanced around.

"Adora?"

Catra felt arms wrap around her from behind and gently push her towards some foliage and the ivy-covered stone wall behind it.

"Is this a kidnapping? Should I start praying?"

When they ducked behind the greenery and reached the wall, Catra was spun around and pressed against it with her wrists pinned above her head.

Adora shrugged. "Maybe. Why are you covered in sand?"

“They’re my pants. I can cover them in whatever I want.”

“Flawless logic.” Adora leaned down to kiss her and Catra eagerly inclined her head to meet her. Adora slotted a leg between Catra’s, lifted her off the ground, and was awarded by a surprised squeak immediately followed by a tongue brushing with her own. After a few minutes of this, Catra pulled away slightly and mumbled, “Babe, can I have one of my hands?”

“Sure.” Adora dropped one of her wrists and used her newly free hand to undo the first few buttons of Catra’s dress shirt. Meanwhile, Catra flexed her hand a few times and then reached behind her head to pull at the pins holding what was left of her bun in place. As each was plucked out, it was tossed to the ground with the faintest bit of ire. Adora was busily laying kisses along the top of her breasts when curls began falling into her eyes. She looked up.

“Aw, but your hair was so pretty like that.”

Catra whipped another pin into the bushes. “The wall’s digging the pins into my head. If you’re gonna be all spontaneous and dominant, I’m taking my hair down.”

Adora pressed a line of kisses up her neck and ran a hand through the newly-freed hair. “Fair enough. It wasn’t that spontaneous, though. I made like 30 other notes and hid them around in case you got lost. Honestly, I didn’t expect you to find me this easily.”

Catra snorted. “It was like three turns and there were arrows. The mazes on cereal boxes are harder.”

Adora bit down right under her ear and she gasped. “Is this working for you, by the way? I wanted to try something different.”

Catra grabbed the back of Adora’s neck and ground her hips down. “You’re a little talky, princess, but yeah, I’m thoroughly enjoying this.”

Adora laughed. “Let’s see how much.” With her free hand, she started fiddling with Catra’s belt buckle. She’d just gotten it undone when Catra’s pants started to buzz. Catra rolled her eyes.

“Could you get that for me?”

Adora dutifully fished the phone out of her pocket and handed it up. Catra huffed when she saw the number and bit the inside of her cheek.

“Who is it?”

“It’s that weird US scammer number again. I’m just gonna ignore it.”

Adora shook her head. “Answer it. I know it’s been bugging you. And if it’s a scammer, we can fuck with them so they don’t call back.”

Catra regarded her phone thoughtfully. “Yeah, okay. That could be fun.” Adora slid her leg back out, and Catra steadied herself against the ground. Catra opened the call and hit the icon for speakerphone.

“Hello?”

Ekaterina? Is that you?

There it was again. That creeping dread.

“Who wants to know?”

This is Janice Cavanaugh. I’m looking for Ekaterina Primov. I need to speak with her right away.

The name rang a very distant bell. She narrowed her eyes and glanced at Adora who shrugged. Perhaps it was the desperation in the woman’s voice or rank curiosity that steeled her, but in that moment, Catra made a decision.

"This is she. You've been calling me since last night. What do you want?"

Oh, thank goodness. These international numbers are so complicated. Shannon hadn't even mentioned that you left the country-

The sound of her mother's nearly-forgotten American pseudonym caught the breath in her throat. What the fuck was this about? The woman was still talking.

-always were the rebellious sort, but all the way to Turkey? How dangerous that must be!

Catra toyed nervously with one of her loose button-holes and slipped into her professional voice. "Ma'am, if you please. What is this about? I'm at a wedding, and I would like to get back to it."

Oh, I love weddings. What a lovely day for it. You really don't remember me, do you? Lord knows we saw enough of each other over the years. I was the principal at St. Matthews when you and your mother joined the congregation.

Catra blinked. "Mrs. Cavanaugh?"

There we are, dear. Say, do you remember when you gave your communion dress to your little friend Dylan and you wore his suit? I thought you both looked adorable, but your mother and Father Michael were so mad. I felt bad about punishing you, but there was nothing I could do, really.

"Their."

I'm sorry?

"Their suit. Dylan goes by they/them pronouns now. They have for a long time."

Oh, I can't keep up with all that. Though I suppose it's not all that surprising.

Catra fumbled with the buttons on her dress shirt. Adora leaned over and deftly did them up before redo-ing her belt as Mrs. Cavanaugh talked. A profound numbness had settled over Catra and she distantly wondered if this was how a deer felt in the moments before it was pummeled by an SUV.

Listen to me rambling on. You were always such an interesting girl, Ekaterina. So much potential! I always wondered what ever happened to you. After all that nasty business at CCHS – I'm friends with the vice-principal over there so I heard all about it – I have to admit that I had my doubts about you. What are you doing these days?

Catra stared at her phone and the words left her lips unbidden. "I'm a teacher. High school English."

Oh that's wonderful! Shannon must be so proud that you followed in her footsteps. You know, when it comes to you, I've never been able to get anything out of her. She's so secretive. It's funny how similar you always were. It must've been because it was just the two of you for so long, like a regular couple of Gilmore Girls.

Catra ground her teeth. "Mrs. Cavanaugh, please. While I am greatly enjoying this impromptu catch-up with my elementary school principal, I must reiterate that now is not the best time."

No need to be rude, dear. I do have a reason that I need to speak with you. It's your mother.

Catra's eyes narrowed. "What about my mother?" Adora took her arm and gently led her out of the brush and onto a nearby stone bench.

Well. Here Mrs. Cavanaugh paused, clearly growing uncomfortable. *You see, there's been an accident.*

"What kind of accident?"

That's a bit harder to say. She had an accident at home and lost a lot of blood. The doctors are saying she did it to herself, but I

know Shannon better than that. She would never do something like that. She's strong, and besides, she's too God-loving to ever consider such a sin.

"Snezhana." The name dripped off Catra's tongue like honey.

What?

"Her name is Snezhana. You know that, right? You only call her Shannon because she thinks you're too much of an uncultured hick to pronounce it right."

Excuse me?

"So my mother tried to kill herself, what a concept. When? Where is she now?"

Mrs. Cavanaugh cleared her throat and ignored the barb. *The accident occurred yesterday morning. A man came to work on the furnace and found her.*

"They're not supposed to just come in like that. Who was he, BTK?"

One might perhaps be grateful for God's miracles. Without His actions that day, your mother would likely be with Him now.

Mrs. Cavanaugh's tone was getting less friendly by the second just as Catra defrosted from her initial shock and was gearing up to shoot the messenger square between the eyes.

"So where is she?"

Methodist.

"In the psych ward, right? I've been there. It's a little bleak, at least the kiddie one is, but that should suit her just fine. Have you been to visit?"

No, not yet.

"Oh you should! With all the flowers in bloom, it'll be beautiful downtown. Too bad Snezhana won't be able to see them. Can't have windows in the rooms. Flight risk. You get it." Catra felt Adora's fingers flex between hers and realized that she'd been clinging to her with all of her strength.

Ekaterina—

"It's Catra. It's been Catra since I was 12 years old. It was Catra when you suspended me for asking questions in Religion class. It was Catra when you suspended me again for defending myself against those boys who cornered me in the bathroom saying they could 'fix me' when that rumor went around that I was a lesbian. The rumor turned out to be true, but still, 3 against 1 isn't exactly fair odds, now is it? No, it was Catra then, and it's Catra now."

Hold on—

"Mrs. Cavanaugh, with all due respect, you call me out of the blue, you cannot bear to admit to me that my mother attempted suicide, and you even seem to expect me to do something about it. Has it ever occurred to you that the reason my mother never mentions me is because we don't have the closest relationship? Would you believe that the last time we spoke was nine years ago? Hell, I wish it was longer, but it seems that time just moves too slowly sometimes, don't you think? I mean, do you know *anything* about her? I can answer that. No, you don't. If you did, I guarantee we wouldn't be speaking right now. I won't even ask how in God's name you got this number, but I applaud you for your perseverance. Very impressive. Now, please, enlighten me, what exactly do you want me to do for you?"

There was a long pause. Catra was just beginning to think that the call had dropped when there was a small voice at the other end of the line.

Ekat – Catra, I don't know what to say and I don't know what's happened between you and your mother, but I do know one

thing. You are all she has. You are all she has and she needs you. She's too proud to say it, but she needs you.

And just like that, the wind vanished from Catra's sails along with the breath in her lungs. She dropped Adora's hand and instead stared at the seconds ticking up on the phone call. She saw Adora looking at her out of the corner of her eye.

Hello? Catra? Are you there?

Catra swallowed dryly. "Yeah, I'm here. Um. Thank you for letting me know, Mrs. Cavanaugh. It was a nice catching up."

Are you coming?

"Thank you for calling."

Catra ended the call. She pocketed the phone and stared straight at the ivy in front of her. If she unfocused her eyes, she could see the frowning face of an old man in the leaves. She felt Adora wrap an arm around her shoulders. The two sat quietly, listening to the muted music from a pop song Catra vaguely recognized mixed with the drone of cicadas. After a while, they turned to each other. Adora opened her mouth to speak, but Catra grabbed her chin and pulled her in for a rough kiss. Catra released her and stood up.

"Wanna go back?" Adora blinked, took the hand offered to her, and let herself be led through the resort back to the tent. It was as if they'd never left. Merve, Fulya, Perihan, and Saliha were dancing to some Demet Akalın song. Sea Hawk was arm-wrestling someone from Merve's side while Bo cheered him on. Khyle was tossing peanuts into Lawan's mouth while Rogelio kept score. Glimmer was trying not to yell into her phone, but she was clearly furious. And, as they sat down next to her, perhaps a little drunk. She snarled something into the phone, put it on the table, and draped herself over Catra.

"Catraaa, there you are. I've missed you. Did you enjoy the surprise? I drew you."

Catra patted her on the head. She didn't have the energy to be mean. "It was great, Sparkles. You should consider a career change."

Glimmer sighed and played with one of Catra's curls. "You know, I might. This job is *killing me.* There's so much responsibility and so many stupid dumb idiots running around fucking up. And whose head is on the chopping block every single time? Mine!"

Catra sighed. "The tragedy."

"Hey." Glimmer turned to look up at her with her eyebrows knit. "Didn't you just get laid? What's with that fucking face?" Adora squirmed in her seat.

Catra looked down at her. What was there to say? "What's it like back in the states?"

Glimmer's expression turned suspicious and she sat up. "Why?"

"I don't fucking know, Sparkles. You tryna fight me for making polite conversation at a wedding?"

Glimmer laughed. "That's better. I dunno, it's the same, I guess. Boston has more witchy shops like on main roads and there are a lot more protests. When's the last time you were back? I don't think you left the entire time I was here."

Catra relaxed a little. "6 years ago? I had to renew my driver's license."

"Jesus, that's a long time."

"Yeah."

Catra gazed out at the dance floor. From what she'd learned this week, things were going well for Bo and Glimmer. Bo had easily found a job at a British International School in Boston, and the two were living in what was surely a bizarrely-furnished apartment in the shadow of the skyscraper housing the BrightMoon Group.

Catra was usually aggressively indifferent to the future ventures of anyone that dared to leave Antalya, but she was admittedly happy that Bo and Glimmer were doing well. They deserved it even if they were deserters.

It wasn't long before things began to wind down. Older relatives began complaining about their feet, children fell asleep on makeshift beds made of chairs, and everyone got tired of dancing to Sezen Aksu. Before calling it a night, the stragglers gathered around a table for the last drink of the night. Most had beer, some had soda, but all had the distinct feeling that things were now irreparably different. Catra absently played with the hem of Adora's dress under the table. Adora had been sending her concerned looks since the phone call earlier, and Catra, in turn, had been ignoring them. They'd talk about it later. Or never. Never seemed like an excellent option.

Sea Hawk cleared his throat and stood up. "Friends, may I have your attention, please?" Everyone looked up. "First of all, Merve and I would like to thank you for coming out here and celebrating with us. Some of you know, because you were there, that I met Merve outside the Waste on a night just like this one. I turned to Bo and demanded that he introduce me at once to the most beautiful woman I'd ever seen."

"Eşek, please." Merve interjected, clearly trying not to smile.

"Sorry, my love. I'll keep it short. Anyway, like the right lad he was, Bo introduced us despite never having seen her before in his life either, and thus began the most important courtship of my life. And by my side the whole time were my mates, and I'd like to thank you. To Bo and especially you, Catra, thank you for never giving up on me. You were the Maccas to my late night feed, the Milo to my milk, and, most importantly, the Patroclus to my Achilles." Bo and Catra shared an alarmed look.

"Our pleasure, man," Catra offered. Adora stifled a laugh.

“And to the rest of you, I look forward to every new memory we can make together.” He raised his soda and everyone did the same. After they drank, a few eyes, including Sea Hawk’s wandered over to Merve.

“Uh, am I also supposed to be giving a speech?”

Everyone stared. Catra smirked. “Indulge us, Mermaid.”

Merve sighed and got to her feet. “Fine. Thank you for coming to my wedding. I love some of you. Some of you are terrible. And the rest I don’t remember inviting.” Feyza snorted. “I hope you enjoyed the free food, open bar, and all-inclusive resort holiday.” Merve raised her glass and everyone followed, chuckling.

They stayed together for another couple hours, but it was clear from the soft greying of the sky over the horizon, that it was long since time to call it a night. Adora and Catra made their way to their room and when the door was shut and locked, Catra breathed out a deep sigh. She immediately stripped off her dress shirt, undershirt and pants, leaving a little puddle of sand on the floor. She wondered if she’d need to buy new ones. In the shower, she helped Adora pick the pins out of her hair and in turn Adora rubbed her shoulders under the spray. After, they crawled into one of the two provided beds. Catra was staring emptily at the ceiling, Adora’s head pillowed on her shoulder, when she heard, “Do you want to talk about it?”

“Not now. We have to go to breakfast in two hours because Merve’s a fascist.”

“Okay.” She felt Adora nuzzle into her chest and sigh.

After a while, “Hey, Adora?”

“Hmm?”

“You know I love you, right?”

Adora nodded against her. “Of course.”

“And you love me?”

A slow smile spread across Adora’s face. “I love you, Catra. I wish I had the words to tell you just how much. I’d do a song, but you and Sea Hawk already stole that and my voice is terrible.”

Catra smiled. “It’s not that bad.”

Adora snorted. “Shut up, yes it is. Can we go to sleep now?”

“Yeah. Good night.”

Adora slid off of Catra’s shoulder and pulled the other woman to her chest. Soon, the heartbeat on Catra’s face slowed down along with the breathing. Catra closed her eyes and, in a moment, was asleep.

A few hours later, Catra sat poking at an eviscerated hard-boiled egg and a half-eaten piece of toast. The sun was streaming through the high windows of the dining hall, and everyone was miserable. Gone was the joy of last night, and in its place was a malaise that only a mandatory 8 am breakfast could bring. Catra watched as the wretchedly hungover shuffled through the buffet as if taking their last meals. Bo was slumped on the table, snoring softly, while Glimmer, half her face obscured by a pair of large sunglasses, sipped at her coffee with one hand and checked her email with the other. Feyza was making a valiant effort not to vomit as she alternated sips of water with tiny bites of bread. Merve’s head was in her hands as she listened to an obscenely energetic Sea Hawk ramble on about the plans for the day ahead. Served her right.

Interestingly, Sea Hawk was not the only bright-eyed and bushy-tailed breakfast-goer this fine morning. In fact, it seemed that there was another pair that was more than thrilled to be awake and alive. Catra nudged Adora who was resting on her closed fist with her eyes closed.

“Huh? Whuh? What happened?”

“What am I looking at here?” With her fork, Catra not-so-subtly pointed to Perihan and Saliha who were practically sitting on each other’s laps while inexplicably exchanging shy glances. The tableau got even more absurd when Perihan fed Saliha a strawberry.

Adora blinked and sunk back onto her hand. “Oh. Saliha made a move last night. I swear I told you about it. It was this whole thing with flowers and sparklers and some other stuff. Looks like it went well.”

Catra took a bite of her cold toast. “Good for them.”

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Later, by the pool, Adora and Catra laid out on lounges and enjoyed their last day in Izmir. Next to Adora was a mostly-empty pitcher of mimosas that had been mostly-emptied by Glimmer who was currently floating through the water like a lifeless log. Everyone else seemed to be off doing their own thing. Catra reached down and grabbed Adora’s hand where it dangled in the space between them. Adora turned and looked at her over her sunglasses with a smile.

“Hi.”

The words that had been dancing on the tip of her tongue for hours finally pressed their way out into the world, “I have to go to the US.”

Adora squeezed her hand. “I understand.”

Catra glanced away for a moment and then back. Somehow, this one was so much harder to say. “Will you come with me?”

Adora’s smile grew wider and she took off her sunglasses completely. Catra did the same. “Of course I’ll come with you. I go where you go. All-in, remember?”

Catra smiled in spite of herself. “I remember. All-in.”

Chapter End Notes

minnoş: small or short, term of endearment [▲]
the "henna thing" is like the Turkish bachelorette party. All of the female friends and relatives gather up and get sad that the bride is going to be leaving with her husband. Everyone cries and the bride gets a hunk of henna wrapped around her palms. [▲]
halay: Here's a video. Skip around a little for the full experience. [▲]
Ayvalık is a place on the west coast of Turkey north of Izmir known for its sandwiches. It's a terrible joke that I was told to take out and I refused. [▲]
Good evening, I hope I'm not interrupting your conversation, but I couldn't help but compliment you on your beauty. Are you enjoying this wonderful wedding as much as Feyza? [▲]
We are very happy with ourselves. Seeing Merve finally get married makes us quite happy. And of course meeting beautiful and kind friends like you. [▲]
Ladies, if I didn't have something to do, I would love to make you even more happy. However, may I borrow Feyza for a few minutes? [▲]
Of course. Please go ahead. [▲]

Hiya! What a journey. Thanks again for sticking around. So, as I've alluded to everyone for the past several chapters, a sequel is in the works. Well, less a separate work, and more the second half of this. As can be guessed from the epilogue, we can expect a change of continental venue or two. That's right, Adora and Catra are going on a globe-trotting search for themselves, and I am beside myself with excitement to the point of being generally insufferable to be around. This fic has been in the works since early in the writing process for Above the Vaulted Sky, so if you've felt particularly scandalized by the lack of DT, Entrapta, Hordak, and others, know that they're exactly where they're supposed to be. As

for timeline, I'll start posting when it's finished, and, let's be real, I don't know when that is, but I am actively writing now, so take that as you will.

It's been a pleasure, everyone. Catch you later!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!